CHAPTER I.

PRELIMINARY.

SAUL'S reign is ended. David's reign has not yet actually commenced. Although David had long been the anointed king of Israel, his reign is commonly considered not to have begun till he came to Hebron, and was anointed king over the house of Judah. The monarchy in Israel had not yet become hereditary; and the saying that the king never dies, had not become a maxim of state. The intervening period between Saul's death and David's assuming the reins of government would be called an interregnum. But as our object does not require constitutional accuracy or formal precision, it will be no serious violation of historic propriety to follow up the end of the reign of Saul with the beginning of the reign of David. This will better suit the spiritual requirements of the history. The Divine government knows no interruption. It may pass through a succession of forms and degrees; but all these are connected with each other either by continuity or contiguity. The government of truth Divine is not separate, although it is distinct, from that of Divine truth. As successive states of the Divine government in the human mind, during the progress of the regenerate life, the higher is evolved from the lower by the orderly process of development, which is the progressive advancement of a being from his lowest to his highest condition of existence. What is evolved must exist in embryo in that from which it is produced. Divine truth exists in embryo in truth Divine, and Divine good in Divine truth. It is as a seed sown in the earth, which "first puts forth the blade, then the ear, after that the full corn in the ear" (Mark iv. 28). It is not to be supposed that this seed is in man by nature. The human mind consists indeed of three degrees, answering to the three heavens, the natural, the spiritual, and the celestial. These exist in embryo in every human being; and they are successively opened and perfected in those who are regenerated to the highest attainable state. The opening and perfecting of the first or natural degree is described by the reign of Saul; the second or spiritual by the reign of David; the third or celestial by the reign of Solomon. But these degrees are opened and perfected by means of the seeds of truth that are sown in the mind. For these seeds, descending as they do from the Lord through all the heavens, have in

themselves, besides the Divine truth, all the degrees of truth that exist in heaven; and it is by the opening and perfecting of these in the mind that the mind itself is opened and perfected. The blade, the ear, and the corn are thus successively produced.

What is true of the regenerate man is true in a supereminent sense and measure of the Lord Himself, as a man born into the world, but a man immeasurably transcending all other men, in being the Son of a Divine Father though of a human mother. As the son of Mary, He possessed the external coverings of the three degrees of the human mind, and these in Him, as in us, were finite; but as the Son of God, He possessed indeed the three degrees of mind answering to the three heavens, but in Him these degrees were not merely such as they are in the minds of angels and men, but such as they are in the Divine mind itself, and therefore infinite. In the Lord's paternal humanity, which was within and above His natural humanity, there was, from His birth, an infinite capacity, or a capacity for the infinite; and as these degrees were opened and perfected, according to the order of human development, the Lord's humanity became actually, as from birth it had been potentially, Divine. The Lord's glorification, like man's regeneration, commenced at His birth. The first of glorification, like the first of regeneration, consisted in acquiring and laying up, in the tender receptacles in the interiors of the mind, the remains of goodness and truth, and thus in forming the rudiments of the states which were to be developed and perfected by actual glorification. This is the descending series: first the celestial, then the spiritual, and lastly the natural. This descending series of Divine operations, both in relation to the Lord and to man, is described, in the internal series, in the history of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. The ascending series, or the development of these rudimentary states, is described in the history of Saul, David, and Solomon.

The first of these ascending states, described by the history of Saul, we have now considered, both with reference to the glorification of the Lord and the regeneration of man. Imperfectly explained the subject has necessarily been, especially as it relates to the Lord's glorification. If, at best, we can have but a general and obscure knowledge of the regeneration of man, how much more is this true of the glorification of the Lord. And yet it is highly necessary for the Christian to know something of that Divine work by which the Lord provided for the salvation of the human race. Next to the knowledge of the Lord as the only God, the knowledge of His work in the flesh is the most precious that the Scriptures reveal. It is justly maintained by Christians that the Atonement is the corner-stone of the Christian Church. The glorification of the Lord's humanity IS the Atonement. It was this which effected the reconciliation of man to God, or of the

human nature to the Divine, in the person of the Lord as the Saviour. And it is by the transforming power of the Divine humanity that men are reconciled to God, and, being reconciled, can be saved by His life. "If, when we were enemies, we were reconciled to God by the death of His Son, much more, being reconciled, we shall be saved by His life" (Rom. v. 10). The life, spiritual and eternal, which dwells in all fulness in the Lord's reconciled and glorified humanity, is that from which men have spiritual and eternal life; and that life transforms them into images of the Lord Himself. This great and blessed truth is destined to transform the whole Christian system as it now is. It sweeps away the entire scheme of substituted punishment and imputed righteousness, which forms the very essence of modern Christianity. But it is not a system of destruction and negation. It gives much more than it takes away. It gives gold for brass, and silver for iron (Isa. lx. 17). For merely natural it gives spiritual views of the justice and mercy of God. Instead of the Lord suffering in our *stead*, to satisfy the demands of Divine justice, it shows the Lord suffering for our *sake*, to satisfy the yearnings of Divine love. It presents the Incarnation in a light of marvellous clearness and transcendent beauty. It shows that God assumed human nature for the purpose of making it perfect through suffering; and having made it perfect, that He can now make men perfect, by conducting them through a life, the image of that which He himself lived upon earth. This is not the doctrine of those who teach that the Lord's work on earth consisted in showing men a perfect example. Men no doubt needed a perfect example; but they needed still more the will and the power to follow that example. These were what the glorification of humanity provided for them. The glorified humanity of the Lord is an ever-present power to prompt men to will and enable them to do of the Lord's good pleasure. It contains all the merit and righteousness which the Lord acquired by His Divine-human life upon earth. Indeed the Lord's humanity not only contains but IS merit and righteousness. By living according to the commandments a man has the law inscribed on his heart; by living according to the commandments, or rather by living the commandments themselves, the Lord became the law itself. But this is true in a wider sense than is generally understood. In its largest sense the law means the whole Word; and this the Lord fulfilled, both in the letter and the spirit, in its utmost extent and in all its degrees. Thus did He become the Word in ultimates, as, from eternity, He had been in first principles. This is the Word of which Moses prophetically and spiritually says, "The Word is very nigh unto thee, in thy mouth, and in thy heart, that thou mayest do it" (Deut. xxx. 14); and of which the Lord Himself said, "Lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end" (Matt. xxviii. 20).

In the history of David's reign we have, in the internal sense, the history of a more advanced stage of the Lord's glorification and of man's regeneration than we possess in the history of the reign of Saul. It describes, as we have said, the process by which the Lord made His humanity Divine truth, David representing the Lord as Divine truth, or, the Divine-spiritual principle in the Lord's humanity. In the secondary sense David represents the spiritual man; and the history of his reign describes that stage of the regenerate life during which man is made spiritual, or during which the spiritual degree of the mind is perfected. We do not say opened, for the opening of the spiritual mind must be understood to have been represented by the circumstance of David having been anointed king during the reign, and long before the death, of Saul. There are three different states of the natural mind in relation to the spiritual, which may be supposed to succeed each other with those who pass from death unto life. There is a state of the natural mind when the spiritual mind is shut, a state of the natural mind when the spiritual is not open and yet not shut, and a state of the natural mind when the spiritual mind is open.

We shall not attempt to follow the history of David, as describing in series the progress of the regenerate life which his reign represents; but we hope to draw from it some spiritual instruction and practical lessons that may direct and guide us in our progress through the regenerate life, as the only way to the kingdom of our Divine Sovereign.

CHAPTER II.

DAVID RECEIVES TIDINGS OF THE DEFEAT OF ISRAEL AND THE DEATH OF SAUL.

2 Samuel i. 1-16.

DAVID had not long returned from the slaughter of the Amalekites when tidings reached him of the disastrous issue of the battle of Gilboa. On the third day after his return to Ziklag a man came to him "with his clothes rent, and earth upon his head: and fell to the earth before him, and did obeisance." He had come from the camp of Israel. To David's eager inquiry how the battle went, he answered that Israel had been defeated, and that Saul and Jonathan were dead. To the question, "How knowest thou that Saul and Jonathan his son be dead?" the young man replied, "As I happened by chance upon mount Gilboa, behold, Saul leaned upon his spear; and, lo, the chariots and horsemen followed hard after him. And when he looked behind him, he saw me, and called unto me. And I answered, Here am

I. And he said unto me, Who art thou? And I answered him, I am an Amalekite. He said unto me again, Stand, I pray thee, upon me, and slay me: for anguish is come upon me, because my life is yet whole in me. So I stood upon him, and slew him, because I was sure that he could not live after that he was fallen: and I took the crown that was upon his head, and the bracelet that was on his arm, and have brought them hither unto my lord." As there is some slight difference between this account of Saul's death and that given in the previous chapter, where nothing is said of the young Amalekite, some have supposed that his tale is an invention, intended to win the favour of David, who, he seems to have believed, was to be the future king of Israel. His story does not, however, contradict the previous narrative, but may be consistently understood as supplementing it. Although Saul had fallen upon his sword, he might be still lingering in agony, and desire to have his sufferings ended. The sacred writer says nothing to throw discredit on the relation, and we may therefore accept it as true.

There is something mournful as well as significant in Saul receiving his death-wound from the hand of an Amalekite. Amalek had been his great stumbling-stone and rock of offence. His mistaken leniency to the sinners, against whom the Lord had sworn that He would have war from generation to generation, had rent from him the kingdom; and now he invites from one of the doomed race the stroke that is to deprive him at once of his life and his kingdom. In the government of God, as in His written Word, there is the law of retribution. In the Divine mind, and in the Lord's dealings with His creatures, there is nothing, in the ordinary sense, of retributive justice; but there is the eternal and immutable law of order, that good and evil return into the bosom of those who do them. Not always, however, does evil return to the bosom of the evil-doer as its eternal dwelling-place. To the repentant it returns as an avenging spirit in the way of judgment. It comes, like the Amalekite to Saul, to extinguish the last spark of the expiring fire of the corrupt selfhood. In judgment, not only in the other world but in this, all states return, like the events of life to the memory of the drowning man. As these states appear, the mind passes judgment upon them; when such as it justifies remain and such as it condemns disappear. It is true that the mind itself is not the judge of its own state. The Lord is Judge. But the Divine Judge does not call men before an outward bar, to be tried by external evidence. The bar is conscience, the judge is eternal truth, and the witness is the inward testimony of the fulfilled or violated law of life. It is therefore the Lord that judges, because it is His truth that judges in us, or by which we judge ourselves. In passing through this ordeal, in which evil is to be severed from good, the penitent sinner calls down imprecations on himself, as Saul

invited the Amalekite to slay him. For one of the truest marks of penitence for sin is self-condemnation, especially for that sin which comes home to the conscience with the most agonizing sense of guilt before God. And the more the sin itself is hated, the more is retribution felt to be deserved. But this very sense of desert turns the curse into a blessing; for like the scape-goat it carries the sin away into the wilderness. But the Amalekite not only slew Saul; he brought his crown and his bracelet to David. In ancient times kings wore a crown and an armlet in war, one as symbol of wisdom, the other of power. We have only to substitute spiritual for natural war to see in them symbols of spiritual wisdom and power as directed against evil and falsity. The crown and bracelet were providentially transferred from Saul to David, to represent the elevation of the principles they represented from the natural into the spiritual mind; and in the Lord, who was eminently represented by the kings of Israel, from truth Divine to Divine truth.

When the Amalekite had told the result of the battle and the fate of Saul, "then David took hold on his clothes, and rent them; and likewise all the men that were with him: and they mourned, and wept, and fasted until even, for Saul, and for Jonathan his son, and for the people of the Lord, and for the house of Israel; because they were fallen by the sword." The character of David here shines forth with peculiar lustre. Though now delivered from a persecuting enemy, and raised, as he must have felt, to the throne of Israel, he shows no feeling of satisfied resentment or gratified ambition, but, in evident sincerity, mourns with religious fervour, not only for the people of the Lord and the house of Israel, but for Saul himself. The several marks of sorrow which David and his men exhibited are symbolic of the affections which enter into that deeper sorrow which theirs represented. David and they that were with him taking hold of their garments and rending them, represented mourning on account of Divine truth lost, and cast away by those who were in faith separate from charity; for the regal office signified Divine truth, and the Philistines represented those who were in faith separate from charity. Mourning is grief of heart and weeping is grief of mind, or of will and understanding; and fasting is grief on account of the privation of goodness and truth, which support the life of love and faith in the Church, and in the minds of her members. The even, till which they mourned, is the end of the Church, or the end of the spiritual state of desolation, when mourning is ended. For, as we have said, every end is followed by a new beginning. When the Church perishes, a new Church is raised up in its stead; and the end of every state in the life of those who are of the spiritual Israel is succeeded by another in the ascending scale higher and better.

Another scene, in singular contrast to the mourning and weeping of David and his men over the fate of Saul and his army, now presents itself. With that sudden and apparently easy transition from tenderness to severity which, judging from Scripture, marked the Jewish character, and which is more or less characteristic of all external men, David passes from the meekness of the mourner to the zeal of the avenger. He demands of the young Amalekite, "How wast thou not afraid to stretch forth thine hand to destroy the Lord's anointed?" and calling one of the young men, he said, "Go near, and fall upon him. And he smote him that he died." The Amalekite, although he seems to be free from moral blame in ending Saul's miserable life, is yet put to death as a regicide, because it was a deadly sin to destroy the Lord's anointed. He should have known this; for, although an Amalekite, he was the son of a sojourner, called in our version a stranger, and a foreigner, living among the Israelites to learn their laws and customs. He represented one who is desirous of being instructed in the principles of the Church. One who is instructed in the truth, and yet destroys it, is guilty of sin. Therefore David says to the dying Amalekite, "Thy blood be upon thy head; for thy mouth hath testified against thee, saying, I have slain the Lord's anointed." The spiritual lesson we learn from this is, that he who, knowing the truth, destroys it, will himself be destroyed. He indeed brings destruction upon himself: his blood is upon his own head; for his mouth utters his own condemnation. "By thy words thou shalt be justified, and by thy words thou shalt be condemned."

Besides this general lesson there are some particulars that deserve our attention. It would seem as if the Amalekite had done both Saul and David a service. He killed the dying king, and brought the insignia of his royalty to his Divinely appointed successor. And yet he is slain. In the simple fact we can see this meaning: that which slays the natural is in turn slain by the spiritual. But why should this be represented in the narrative as an act of vengeance due to blood-guiltiness? The representative character of Amalek accounts for this appearance. Amalek represents falsity grounded in interior evil, which steals in upon the mind when it is suffering from the depression and feebleness produced by severe trial and temptation; like certain diseases to which the body is liable when it is in a low condition. We see this shadowed forth in the present instance. Saul had anticipated the last effects of defeat in battle, and David had but returned from the pursuit and slaughter of the Amalekites. The young man happened by chance on mount Gilboa at a time that was suitable to his own natural and representative character and to the condition of Saul. He was also behind Saul, as of old his people came behind enfeebled Israel (Deut. xxv. 18); for the falsity of interior evil

enters rather into the will, which is behind, than into the understanding, which is before. Saul looked behind him, and saw this son of Amalek; as the Lord turned and looked upon Peter (Luke xxii.), and as John turned to see the voice that spake with him (Rev. i. 12). That which enters into and affects the will causes the understanding to turn in that direction, that the intellect may perceive what the will has felt. And Saul's understanding was now opened to see the nature of the evil to which, in the hour of trial, he had weakly yielded. When the young Amalekite came to David, he came in something of the manner in which Agag came to Samuel, delicately. He came, indeed, as a friend to David, as he had seemed to be to Saul. But his representative character is the same in regard to both. This is seen even in his bringing to David the dead king's crown and bracelet. The evil, or rather the evil spirits—for evil has no abstract existence—which the Amalekites represent, insinuate themselves into the hearts of men, not only through the objects of their ambition, as these insignia of royalty might be to David, but even, in the case of spiritual men, through the spiritual principles which these insignia represent. Evil spirits, like evil men, can simulate characters not their own, and can possess themselves of the knowledges, which are but the symbols, of wisdom and honour, as the crown and bracelet were of the dignity and power of their royal owner. Through these they seek to act upon the minds of men whom they desire to seduce.

We can see a sufficient reason, on the ground of the spiritual sense, for David slaying the seemingly blameless Amalekite. Not that an act of natural injustice could be permitted for the purpose of representing a spiritual truth, or teaching a spiritual lesson. But spiritual causes lie at the root of all natural effects. And although the effect may sometimes seem different in its character from that of the cause, there is still a real relation between them, the outward seeming being all that produces the apparent want of harmony.

CHAPTER III.

DAVID'S LAMENTATION OVER SAUL AND JONATHAN.

2 Samuel i. 17-27.

DAVID'S elegy over Saul and Jonathan, considered only as the expression of his own personal sentiments and feelings, is admitted to be one of the noblest and tenderest to be found in any language. It reflects the highest credit upon David himself. Had Saul been a bosom friend we could not have expected more; had he been an

honourable rival, we should have been satisfied with less; but when we reflect that for years he had been a bitter and implacable enemy, David's lamentation over him has a moral sublimity worthy of our highest admiration, and, still more, of our faithful imitation. It is true that David speaks of Saul as the Lord's anointed, yet much of the praise he bestows upon him is for his personal qualities, although he says nothing of his general character.

In the inner sense both Saul and David are to be regarded in their representative character. In the highest sense, both are types of the Lord Himself, as King; and the Lord is King as Divine truth. When Pilate demanded of Jesus, who had said His kingdom was not of this world, "Art Thou a king then? Jesus answered, Thou sayest that I am a KING," which was a form of affirmation; and He immediately adds in explanation, "To this end was I born, and for this cause came I into the world, that I should bear witness unto the TRUTH." Both Saul and David represented the Lord as the Truth; and David, in his lamentation over Saul, bears witness to the Truth. His description of Saul is, in the spiritual sense, a description of the Truth.

When the elegy is thus understood, we can see the appropriateness and significance of that otherwise difficult and almost unintelligible exordium to it, "Also he bade them teach the children of Judah the use of the bow: behold, it is written in the book of Jasher." We need not trouble ourselves with the conjectures of commentators as to the meaning and purpose of this seemingly strange introduction. The book in which it is said to be written suggests a mysterious meaning. Jasher was a book of the ancient Church, written by those who understood the law of correspondence between spiritual and natural things, and who therefore taught spiritual truths by natural images. In the symbolic language of Scripture, which is written according to this law, a bow corresponds to doctrine. Arrows correspond to truths, but to truths opposing falsities; and truths proceed and have their power from doctrine, as arrows from the bow, or stones from the sling. But what connection is there between this lamentation over Saul and Jonathan and teaching Judah the bow? The same connection that there is between revealing truths and teaching doctrine. A religious doctrine is a conclusion from all the truths of the Word relating to one subject, as a doctrine of science is a conclusion from one class of the facts of nature. Truths are made known to men to enable them to do good and resist evil. But in order to employ truths effectually they must know them, not only singly, but in combination. The Word contains all religious truth; but the Word is not understood without doctrine. Without doctrine the mind can have but an obscure and confused notion of what the Scriptures teach. Therefore Saul and Jonathan are celebrated that Judah may learn the bow. One reason why the

Church must learn the doctrines as well as know the truths of the Word is this. The Word, as we have remarked, consists to a considerable extent of apparent truths, which, unless explained by doctrine, may be adopted and confirmed as real truths, which then become errors. Doctrine is formed from the real truths of Scripture; and these, when brought into a doctrinal form, explain its apparent truths. This distinction between truth and doctrine, and the formation of doctrine from the real truths of the Word, are taught symbolically in this Divine composition. Saul and Jonathan, as formerly explained, both represent Divine truth, such as it is in the letter of the Word, but Saul represents its apparent truths and Jonathan its real truths. In accordance with this, David speaks of Saul as wielding the sword, because the sword is the emblem of truth, and of Jonathan as wielding the bow, because the bow is an emblem of doctrine. It is Judah, too, that is to be taught the bow, because Judah represents those who are in good, as distinguished from those who are in truth, or the celestial, as distinguished from the spiritual; and the celestial desire and acquire only the real truths of the Word, which teach nothing but the doctrine of love and charity. This is the doctrine meant by the bow; so that to teach Judah the bow is to teach the doctrine of love to God and charity to man. This also is a key to the subject of the lamentation, in the spiritual sense; otherwise the introduction would have no relation to the subject. We shall see as we proceed that there is an intimate connection between what the Philistines had destroyed and what Judah was to be taught.

In David's lamentation, we are to regard Saul as the Lord's anointed, not as the frail and erring mortal that he was; as the representative of the second Adam, not as the too faithful image of the first. In the regenerate man, a corresponding distinction is to be made. Regeneration does not destroy the distinction between the spirit and the flesh, although the Christian no longer lives in the flesh, but in the spirit. The corrupt selfhood is not abolished but only subdued; and the Christian, while with the mind he serves the law of God, knows that in himself, that is, in his flesh, dwelleth no good thing (Rom. vii. 18).

David eulogizes Saul as the beauty of Israel, and both Saul and Jonathan as the mighty, as lovely and pleasant in their lives, as swifter than eagles and stronger than lions. Terrible to the enemies of Israel, the bow of Jonathan turned not back, the sword of Saul returned not empty, from the blood of the slain, from the fat of the mighty. Bountiful to his people, Saul clothed the daughters of Israel in scarlet with delights, and put on ornaments of gold upon their apparel.

Lofty as the strain of this eulogium is, its language and imagery but

faintly describe the beauty and might of Him whom Saul, as the anointed king of Israel, represented, whether we apply it to H person even when veiled in our frail humanity, or to His works of redemption and salvation, in which He overcame the enemies of His kingdom and enriched and adorned His Church with the precious gifts of His grace and truth. Saul, as the anointed king of Israel, represented the Lord as Divine truth; and the destruction of Divine truth in the Church is the general subject of the lamentation.

But it may be well to strike a lower key, and consider the lamentation as it applies to the regenerate and to the work of regeneration. These are not only images of the Lord and of His work in the flesh; but the Lord is in every regenerate man, and works out his deliverance from the evils of his nature, and brings him into newness of life, by a process similar to that by which He overcame the powers of darkness, and glorified His own humanity, and ordinated heaven, and established a spiritual Church upon earth. The Lord's work in the flesh is effected anew, in a finite measure, in every true disciple. This is the reason why the greater work is the archetype of the less, and why a description of one is, only in a different degree, a description of the other.

Truth sanctified by goodness, or a true faith anointed with the oil of love, is the beauty of Israel, because it beautifies the meek with salvation, clothing the affections of charity with the beautiful garments of wisdom and righteousness, woven of the scarlet threads of practical truth and adorned with the golden ornaments of practical goodness. Whatever graces beautify the mind, whatever virtues adorn the character, all are derived from the Lord through a living faith in Him, as our God and Saviour, and are to be admired and exalted as His gifts and as the images of His perfections. As faith animated by love is the beauty of Israel, love acting by faith is the mighty; for by the sword of truth and the bow of doctrine it overcomes what is false and evil, as opposed to that which is true and good, as principles in the understanding and the heart. The doctrine of the true Church, which is the doctrine of love and charity, is the bow that turns not back, and the truth of doctrine is the sword that returns not empty, from the blood of the slain and the fat of the mighty, or from the conflict with what is false and evil.

This is the spiritual ground of David's praise of Saul, as the Lord's anointed. It shows forth the excellence of a true and living faith, which the anointed king represented, as opposed to a false and dead faith, of which the Philistines were the types. It shows also the benefits and blessings to be derived from a true faith, when exalted to its true place in the mind, and allowed to have its due influence in the government of the ends and actions of life. This will ever be the case

with the true Israel of the Lord. It is this which marks the true disciple of Jesus as an Israelite indeed, in whom is no guile. For who are the Israel of the Lord but those who practically acknowledge Him as the King of Israel, the Anointed of Jehovah? And the Lord is practically acknowledged as the King of Israel when His laws are written in the heart and obeyed in the life; when the affections and thoughts, words and works of those who call themselves by the name of Christ, are so governed by His love and truth, that, for the Lord's sake, they do to others as they would that others should do to them. This is the law and the prophets. The Lord governs where His law rules. Where His law is exalted He is exalted, where it is fulfilled He is glorified. How beautiful must be the state and character of one who is thus brought under the hallowing influence of the Lord's Divine law of love and truth! The truth and love contained unitedly in the Divine law, are like Saul and Jonathan, who were lovely and pleasant in their lives, and in their death they were not divided. Death cannot divide those whose lives have been lovely and pleasant, whether we apply this beautiful sentiment to persons or to principles. Those who are united in that lovely connection which exists between the true and the good, and especially as they exist in the two sexes, will not be separated by death. Their union is as firm and indissoluble as that between the Lord and the soul of the true believer. "Who shall separate us from the love of Christ? shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword? As it is written, For Thy sake we are killed all the day long; we are accounted as sheep for the slaughter. Nay, in all these things we are more than conquerors through Him that loved us. For I am persuaded, that neither death, nor life, nor angels, nor principalities, nor powers, nor things present, nor things to come, nor height, nor depth, nor any other creature, shall be able to separate us from the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus our Lord" (Rom. viii. 35-39). How beautiful would the lives of Christians be if they were a faithful transcript of the spiritual law of love to the Lord, as exhibited in charity to man, which our Lord Himself revealed, when He said, "A new commandment I give unto you, that ye love one another, as I have loved you, that ye also love one another"! (John xv. 12). The command to love one another, and to love each other as ourselves, is old; but to love each other as the Lord Jesus has loved us, this is new. This is Christian love. Not ourselves, but Jesus, is the standard of love to one another. He gave Himself for us; lived for us, suffered for us, died for us. Are we willing to give ourselves for each other? But this is not only true love, it is also true faith. This faith is the beauty of Israel, and the mighty also. Faith imbued with love is beauty, love working by faith is power. Faith has no beauty but from love; love has no power but

by faith. Separate, they have neither beauty nor power; united, they have both. The religion of faith alone is religion deprived of those elements which give it all its beauty and might.

This is the evil and the calamity that David lamented in his lamentation over Saul and over Jonathan his son. The Philistines had slain the beauty of Israel upon the high places, the mighty had fallen under their instruments of violence; and those who were lovely and pleasant in their lives, and were swifter than eagles and stronger than lions, had died together in the conflict with error and evil. The destructive nature and effects of faith alone are thus expressively described. Faith in its true state is the safeguard as well as the guide of charity. But when that which should be a protection against evil and a guide in the performance of good, claims to itself all saving power, it destroys all that is vital and saving in religion. We shall see this still more clearly if we turn our attention to some of the particulars in which this is symbolically described in the pathetic lamentation of David.

"The beauty of Israel is slain upon thy high places: how are the mighty fallen!" The high places are the interior affections of the mind. These are constantly represented in Scripture by high places, especially by mountains, as here by the mountains of Gilboa. The will is the highest faculty of the mind. It is the seat of the affections. In Scripture and in popular language it is called the heart. The Divine law is said to be written in the heart when it is loved with the highest and best affections. Men are required to love God with all the heart—with the will and all its affections. Faith is also, in its highest state, placed in the heart. This is the high place of living, practical faith. "For with the heart man believeth unto righteousness" (Rom. x. 10). When the faith and the love of God are quenched in the affections, and His law is effaced from the heart, the beauty of Israel is slain upon its high places, the mighty are fallen. This is the death and the fall which David, moved by the Holy Spirit, lamented. And he exclaims, "Tell it not in Gath, publish it not in the streets of Askelon; lest the daughters of the Philistines rejoice, lest the daughters of the uncircumcised triumph." In the literal sense this is rather a rhetorical than an actual wish, since David knew that the issue of the battle must have been already published throughout the whole of Philistia. The same idea is often repeated in Scripture. God speaks and is spoken of as doing great things for Israel, that His Name may be known among the nations; and fears are expressed lest the nations hear and rejoice over the people's calamities, and regard them as evidences of the inability of their God to defend them. This idea is the basis of another and higher one. In the inner sense the nations are the evil affections and false thoughts of the natural mind,

while the Israelites are the good affections and true thoughts of the spiritual mind, or, of the natural and of the spiritual man. The natural man being opposed to the spiritual, there is war between them. The contest is to determine whether the spiritual shall rule over the natural, or the natural over the spiritual. The consequences of this contest are most momentous. If final they are eternal. There is therefore a deep spiritual reason for David's passionate lamentation over Saul, and for his exclamation, "Tell it not in Gath, publish it not in the streets of Askelon." But this reason refers to more than the victory itself. That had already been gained by the enemies of Israel. The telling of the tidings in Gath and publishing them in the streets of Askelon, and the joy and triumph of the daughters of the Philistines over the victory, is another. This we have now to consider, and this will be seen from the spiritual meaning of Gath and Askelon, and the daughters of the Philistines.

These two principal cities of the Philistines belonged at one time to the children of Israel. In the time of the judges Judah took Askelon (i. 18), and in the time of Samuel "the cities which the Philistines had taken from Israel were restored to Israel, from Ekron even unto Gath" (1 Sam. vii. 14); but they had passed into the possession of the Philistines again. These cities, therefore, now represent true doctrines of the Church falsified, like the cities from which the Israelites fled, and in which the Philistines came and dwelt. The two principal doctrines of the Word, and therefore of the true Church, are the doctrines of love to God and charity to man. These doctrines or laws of life are the conditions of salvation, because they teach the very graces that save. But when love to the Lord and charity to man are abolished as conditions of salvation, except as fulfilled by a substitute, and faith is held to be sufficient for salvation, these doctrines are falsified, and become as Askelon and Gath in the hands of the Philistines. Truths falsified, unlike simple errors, are not only aliens but enemies. They inspire the mind with hatred of the truth, and cause it to rejoice and triumph over the truth, when it seems to yield the palm of victory to the reasonings and fallacies of the natural man which have been brought against it. The Jewish Philistines in the time of our Lord, who had made the commandment of God of none effect by their tradition, which they had done by perverting the truth, rejoiced and triumphed over the destruction of the truth in the person of Him who was the Truth itself. When the two witnesses, who bore testimony to the doctrines of love to the Lord and love to man, were killed by the beast, which was the type of faith without love or works, they that dwelt on earth rejoiced over them, and made merry, and sent gifts to one another, because the two prophets tormented them that dwelt on the earth (Rev. xi. 10). To kill spiritually

means to deny, reject, destroy; but to triumph over the slain is to confirm the mind in a state of denial. This is the reason that David deprecates the tidings of Israel's defeat and the death of Saul being published in the cities of the enemy, lest the daughters of the victors should rejoice. The denial of truth is especially confirmed when the affections of the will respond to the decisions of the understanding. The affections of the will are meant by daughters; and we have here the daughters of the Philistines, who are the affection of what is false, and the daughters of the uncircumcised, who are the affection of what is evil. The confirmed denial of what is true is meant by the daughters of the Philistines rejoicing, and the confirmed rejection of what is good is meant by the daughters of the uncircumcised triumphing. That the denial of the principles of truth and goodness in the understanding may not be confirmed in the affections of the will, is the Lord's desire, as expressed in David's wish. And as His love desires so does His providence operate to prevent men confirming their hearts in a state which cuts off the hope and almost the possibility of restoration.

There are two states of mind which, while they have an affinity, and one too often leads to the other, are yet to be distinguished. One state is that in which evil is loved and practised, while a belief in its sinfulness and a secret dread of its consequences remain. The other state is that in which the conviction of sin and the dread of its consequences have been overcome, and the affections rejoice and triumph over the defeat and death of those better thoughts and feelings that gave pain and created alarm. This is a state of confirmed unbelief and impenitence. The conflict is over; the waning power of the good and true in the heart and mind has been overcome. The tidings have been told in Gath and published in the streets of Askelon, and the daughters of the Philistines rejoice, the daughters of the uncircumcised triumph. This is the state which Divine love desires to prevent, and against which Divine wisdom in all possible cases provides; and to express which David by inspiration uttered the desire, "Tell it not in Gath."

But the high places themselves on which Saul and Jonathan were slain are made the subjects of an imprecation. "Ye mountains of Gilboa, let there be no dew, neither let there be rain, upon you, nor fields of offerings: for there the shield of the mighty is vilely cast away, the shield of Saul, *as though he had* not *been* anointed with oil." The consequence of evil is often in Scripture announced in the form of a malediction. Yet God is the author of no curse, but sin entails its own curse on those who commit it. In this case the imprecation is on the scene of the slaughter, and is in harmony with the economy of the Israelitish dispensation, that place should be an image of state.

The curse on the mountains of Gilboa is a description of the state of the heart or will, which mount Gilboa represents, when the truth and love of God are therein destroyed. The dew and the rain of heaven are celestial and spiritual truth, flowing into the inmost of the mind from the Lord out of heaven, and giving refreshment and fruitfulness. And the fields of offering are the good things of love and charity that are offered up to the Lord, as the fruits of His own free and bountiful gifts that have descended upon the humble and receptive mind.

But this also describes the condition of the mind when, the heart being turned away from God, the heaven of the spiritual mind is shut, and the Lord's doctrine no longer drops upon the natural mind like rain, and His Spirit no longer distils like dew and like small rain upon the tender grass; but the mind becomes like a parched land not inhabited. When there is no spiritual love in the heart there is no saving truth in the understanding. There may be knowledge, but there is no wisdom; there may be persuasion, but there is no faith.

A special reason that there might be no dew or rain on the mountains of Gilboa was, that there the shield of the mighty had been vilely cast away, the shield of Saul, as not anointed with oil. The shield of the mighty is vilely cast away when the truth that defends good is contemned and rejected, the shield of Saul, as not anointed with oil, is cast away, when truth is treated as if it had no relation to love, or when that relation is denied.

Thus far David, in his pathetic lamentation, speaks chiefly of the death of Saul and Jonathan as regarded by the Philistines. He next comes to speak of it in relation to the Israelitish people and to himself.

David had desired that the daughters of the Philistines might not rejoice over the death of Saul; he now calls the daughters to weep for him. The daughters of Israel are the opposites of the daughters of the Philistines; they are the affections of truth. They are exhorted to mourn the destruction of truth in the Church, and to mourn by weeping, for weeping is the symbol of sorrow because truth has perished.

But to apply this to the inward state of those who are passing through the trials of the spiritual life. There are states in Christian experience which are called states of desolation, when light and hope seem to have departed, and the delight of life seems to have died away. These are times of weeping. David describes these states from his own experience; as in the sixth Psalm, "O Lord, rebuke me not in Thine anger, neither chasten me in Thy hot displeasure." Those whom the Lord loves He rebukes and chastens. But we must be not only the objects, but the subjects, of the Lord's love, before we can be chastened as children. And then the Psalmist describes his

distress under the Lord's rebuke and chastening: "I am weary with my groaning; all the night make I my bed to swim; I water my couch with my tears. Mine eye is consumed because of grief; it waxeth old because of all mine enemies." This grief is made more poignant by the remembrance of the previous state of prosperity and enjoyment, as the daughters of Israel are called upon to weep for Saul, who had clothed and adorned them. This weeping, with the state of humiliation and godly sorrow which it implies, brings the suffering soul to the Lord. "In those days, and in that time, saith the Lord, the children of Israel shall come, they and the children of Judah together, going and weeping: they shall go, and seek the Lord their God" (Jer. l. 4). To those who thus mourn, though it be in sackcloth and ashes, the Lord will give beauty for ashes, the oil of joy for mourning, and the garment of praise for the spirit of heaviness; that they may be called trees of righteousness, the planting of the Lord, that He may be glorified (Isa. lxi. 3).

It is natural that in David's lamentation over the slain on the mountains of Gilboa Jonathan should occupy a prominent place. "O Jonathan, thou wast slain in thine high places. I am distressed for thee, my brother Jonathan: very pleasant hast thou been unto me: thy love to me was wonderful, passing the love of women." Wonderful indeed was Jonathan's love for David. A worthy representative it was of love to the Lord, whom David represented, and of love for the truth which He taught. Under another view, it represented that love which is grounded in the harmony and unity which exist between the letter and the spirit of the Word; that is, between the real truth of the letter and the pure truth of the spirit; or, what is the same, between doctrine as drawn from the literal sense of the Word, and the essential principles of doctrine as contained in its spiritual sense. Combining these views we may be able to see more clearly and fully the truth and beauty of that seemingly hyperbolical tribute to Jonathan's love for David, that it surpassed the love of women.

There is one respect in which the love of man surpasses the love of woman. This has its ground in a constitutional difference in the mental character of the sexes; and, in the highest degree of the regenerate and heavenly life, it becomes actual and obvious.

The masculine soul is love covered with wisdom, and the feminine soul is wisdom covered with love. As love in the man is inmost and wisdom is outermost, his love is deeper than his wisdom; and as wisdom in the woman is inmost and love is outermost, her wisdom is deeper than her love. Masculine love is thus deeper or more interior than feminine love, as, on the other hand, feminine wisdom is deeper or more interior than masculine wisdom. Love being inmost in the man it is less perceptible, for it manifests itself in wisdom; and the wisdom of the woman is less perceptible, because it manifests itself in

love. We say therefore that the man is wisdom and that the woman is love, because these are their outward and obvious characteristics. We say also that true marriage consists in the union of feminine love with masculine wisdom, because these are the outward and obvious qualities by which they are distinguished. But there is also a deeper and more interior, although less conscious or at least less sensible, union between those who are united in true conjugal love. Besides the union of feminine love with masculine wisdom, there is a union of feminine wisdom with masculine love ; or of the internal love of the man with the internal wisdom of the woman. This twofold union is strikingly exhibited in the heavens. In the spiritual heaven, where the spiritual or lower degree of the mind is opened, the husband is wisdom and the wife is love ; but in the celestial heaven, where the celestial or highest degree of the mind is opened, the husband is love and the wife is wisdom. In these two heavens we also see the different character of masculine and feminine wisdom exemplified. Masculine wisdom, being external, is rational wisdom ; feminine wisdom, being internal, is perceptive wisdom. Therefore in the spiritual heaven the angels reason, in the celestial heavens the angels perceive. In the celestial heaven it is yea, yea, nay, nay ; in the spiritual heaven there is something of the whatsoever is more than these, which cometh of evil. We observe this distinction between masculine and feminine wisdom, or between the masculine and feminine intellect, even in this world. We observe that men reason and that women perceive. We see also that the rational wisdom of the man is not communicable to the woman, and that the perceptive wisdom of the woman is not communicable to the man. But we see the Creator's wisdom and benevolence in these distinctive characteristics of the sexes, by which two souls, that can never in anything be the same, become more perfectly one than either of them apart could ever be. In true marriage there is the union of beauty and might, mental and physical ; and this marriage exists in its perfection with the angels in heaven.

Jonathan's love for David, as being wonderful and more than the love of women, represented that love for truth and wisdom, whose type David was, which is the primary love that lies at the root of human nature, and out of which all other loves spring, even the love of women, for the woman was taken out of the man.

It would have been interesting to notice the numerous pairs of expressions that occur in this beautiful elegy, which refer to what Clowes so often points out as pervading the Word, the marriage of the good and the true, or, in the opposite sense, of the evil and the false ; but this must be left to the reader.

David concludes, " How are the mighty fallen, and the weapons of war perished ! " Fallen are the mighty when the heavenly principles

of love and charity are no longer the religion of the heart and life, and the weapons of war have perished when the truths of the Word have ceased to defend good against evil, and the conflict has ended in the extinction of spiritual life.

CHAPTER IV.

DAVID IN HEBRON ANOINTED KING OVER THE HOUSE OF JUDAH.

2 Samuel ii.

THE defeat of Israel and the death of Saul and his three sons in the battle of Jezreel, must have convinced David that the time was come when the anointing of Samuel, which had hitherto brought him nothing but trouble and anguish, would reward him for his sufferings by bringing him to the throne of Israel. He does not, however, betray any of the signs of human ambition, which most other men have manifested in similar circumstances. He does not follow the promptings of his own will, nor act on the dictates of his own judgment; nor does he ask counsel of flesh and blood; he inquires of the Lord, not whether he shall claim the vacant throne, but whether and to which of the cities of Judah he shall go up; and he is answered, "Go up unto Hebron."

Kirjath-arba, which is Hebron, had long been a distinctly representative, and had become even a sacred, place. Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob had dwelt there; and it had been appointed as a city of refuge and a Levitical city. Hebron represented the spiritual Church. One circumstance connected with its history gives it a double significance. When the Israelites came into Canaan, Hebron was possessed by the children of Anak. These were giants, and were like those who are spoken of as existing before the Flood (Gen. vi. 4). The nations of Canaan were the degenerate descendants of the people of the ancient Church, and of these the Anakim were the most corrupt; as the Nephilim, or giants, that lived immediately before the Flood, were the most corrupt of the degenerate descendants of the people of the most ancient Church. It was the fear of the sons of Anak that caused the children of Israel to wander forty years in the wilderness, and that excluded all the men from twenty years old and upwards from entering Canaan, except Caleb and Joshua (Num. xiv. 29, 30). When the spies who were sent to search the land, returned to the camp of Israel, one part of their evil report related to its gigantic inhabitants. "There we saw the giants, the sons of Anak, which come of the giants: and we were in our own sight as grasshoppers, and so we were in their

sight." When the Israelites took possession of the land of Canaan, Hebron, the district inhabited by these giants, was appropriately given to Caleb (Josh. xiv. 13), who had brought up a good report of the land, and encouraged the children of Israel to go up at once and possess it (Num. xiii. 30).

When David was divinely directed to go to Hebron, it was on account of its representative character. In Hebron had dwelt those in whom the ancient Church had fallen into its deepest state of corruption; on account of which the inhabitants of Hebron were utterly destroyed by Joshua (Josh. x. 36, 37); and there David was commanded to go, to set up his kingdom, which was to represent the Lord's spiritual Church, that Church which the Lord established when He was upon earth; for the Christian Church was the ancient Church unswathed. To represent more expressively the establishment of the Church, it is recorded that David, when he went up thither, took with him his two wives, who represented the Church, as to the internal and external affection of truth, by which the spiritual Church is distinguished. His men also did David bring up, every man with his household; these representing all the truths of the Church, each united to its own good, with their derived thoughts and affections; those who are principled therein constituting the household of faith. David's men dwelt in the cities of Hebron. Thus the doctrines of the ancient Church, which these cities represented, after being purged of their errors and corruptions, became again the habitations of spiritual truth and goodness, which David's men and their families represented.

Not long after David's settlement in Hebron, "the men of Judah came, and there they anointed David king over the house of Judah." The tribe of Judah, which was the first, was for some time the only tribe that acknowledged David as king; we can hardly say, as the successor of Saul, for the men of Judah seem to have made no claim for David's sovereignty over the whole people. Yet rightly considered, he who was king of Judah was entitled to be the sovereign of all the tribes of Israel; for he who rules the highest should rule all below. Jesus was sought and worshipped by the wise men from the east as King of the Jews, and the King of the Jews was written as an accusation over His cross; but He was acknowledged also as the King of Israel.

The kingdom began under David as it ended under Rehoboam, by being divided into two, the kingdom of Judah and the kingdom of Israel, if we may call Ish-bosheth's reign a succession, which was rather a usurpation. The kingdom belonged to the Lord, and by His command David had been anointed king long before the death of Saul. David was therefore the rightful sovereign of the one kingdom. Still there was a deeper cause for, and there is a deeper meaning in, the divided state of the people than the letter of the Word reveals.

David, we have seen, was potentially king while Saul actually reigned; as, in an early stage of the regenerate life, "we delight in the law of God after the inward man: but we see another law in our members, warring against the law of our mind, and bringing us into captivity to the law of sin which is in our members." The state is now changed. The inward man reigns actually, but the outward man is not yet wholly subject to his government. The highest or inmost thoughts and affections of the natural mind have made a voluntary submission, or rather have given their joyful consent, to the supremacy and rule of the spiritual. The men of Judah have anointed David king, confirming Samuel's act by their own, and thus reciprocating the Divine love to them in their practical love to Him. Our Lord, as the anointed of Jehovah, though never anointed as an earthly king, had the precious ointment of grateful and adoring love poured upon His head (Matt. xxvi. 7), and even upon His feet (John xii. 3); acts appropriately done to Him, and done by loving women, who represented the Church, not only in general, but in particular, as it exists in the heart, when Jesus reigns there as King and Governor.

When the men of Judah came and anointed David king, they told him of the pious act of the men of Jabesh-gilead in burying Saul; and David sent messengers to bless them, and at the same time to ask their allegiance to him, now that Saul was dead. We have already remarked upon the burial of Saul as the type of resurrection; and it was fitting that this should be introduced here, seeing that the anointed, as buried in Saul, had risen in David. For, in resurrection, that which is raised is not the same as that which is sown; the life that is taken up is not the same as that which is laid down. The old dies, the new lives. David, as the anointed, was higher than Saul.

It does not, however, appear that the men of Jabesh acknowledged David as king. For it is immediately added, "But Abner the son of Ner, captain of Saul's host, took Ish-bosheth the son of Saul, and brought him over to Mahanaim; and made him king over Gilead, and over the Ashurites, and over Jezreel, and over Ephraim, and over Benjamin, and over all Israel." Mahanaim, which was on the other side Jordan, and not far from Jabesh, was the spot where Jacob, after parting with Laban, with whom he had entered into a covenant, was met by the angels of God. "And when Jacob saw them, he said, This is God's host; and he called the name of the place Mahanaim." This name means two camps, and these two camps signify both the heavens, or both the kingdoms of the Lord, the celestial and the spiritual; and in the supreme sense, the Divine celestial and the Divine spiritual of the Lord. Although in its after-history Mahanaim seems to have verified its name, its two camps were not always the camps of God, nor were angels always the hosts that encamped

therein. Mahanaim is connected, though not in the same manner, with two kingdoms, rivals to that of David. In Mahanaim Abner set up a rival king and kingdom to those of Judah; and to Mahanaim David himself came, when he fled before Absalom, on that unnatural son rebelling against his father, and attempting to wrest the kingdom from him (xvii. 24). In Israel there were at this time, therefore, two camps, but one of them was hostile to the other.

The subject treated of in the naming of Mahanaim is, the inversion of state, in which good obtains the first place and truth takes the second. Good has now obtained the first place, for the men of Judah have anointed David king of Judah ; but truth has not yet submitted to the supremacy of good, for the rest of the tribes have not yet given David their allegiance. This is a state which has yet to be wrought out, but it is not to be effected without that internal conflict which is represented in the Word by war.

A singular and sanguinary conflict seems to have formed the commencement of the several years' war that was carried on between the house of David and the house of Saul. Abner, captain of his master's host, had gone to Gibeon, and was followed by Joab, captain of the host of David ; and they met together on the opposite sides of the pool of Gibeon. "And Abner said to Joab, Let the young men now arise, and play before us. And Joab said, Let them arise." Twelve from each side met, "and they caught every one his fellow by the head, and thrust his sword in his fellow's side ; so they fell down together : wherefore that place was called Helkath-hazzurim, which is in Gibeon." Had this encounter been the means of settling a question of right or even of might, there would have been less regret for the mutual slaughter, but it was only the initiative of a sore battle, in which David's men were victorious. We may be thankful that, as a part of Bible history, it contains another and higher meaning than that of the letter.

The pool of Gibeon, on the opposite sides of which the two little armies sat down, and across which their two leaders spoke to each other, is the type of one of those deep questions on which the men of the Church have long taken opposite sides, and over which they have proposed and accepted the challenge to decide the question by a gladiatorial display of intellectual skill. In Scripture pools signify intelligence derived from the knowledges of goodness and truth ; for pools are there taken for collected waters or lakes, and collected waters or lakes are collected knowledges by which intelligence comes. Both from its situation and from the subject of the contest between the two camps, the intelligence which the pool of Gibeon represents, is that which relates to the question, whether goodness or truth, or, what is the same, whether charity or faith has the claim to priority, and is

entitled to take the first place. Those who maintain the priority and supremacy of charity are represented by the servants of David, while those who contend for the priority and supremacy of faith are represented by the servants of the son of Saul. "It has been a subject of controversy from the most ancient times whether priority and preference are due to charity or to faith. This controversy originated in the ignorance which prevailed of old, and which prevails at this day, concerning this truth, that one has only so much of faith as he has of charity, and that in the process of regeneration charity meets faith, or what is the same thing, good meets truth, insinuating into it all its particulars, and adapting itself thereto, and thus causing truth to be faith." "Those who are in truth before they are regenerate are always such that they believe truth to be both prior and superior to good, and so it appears at that time; but when truth is conjoined to good in their minds, or when they are regenerate, they see and perceive that truth is posterior and inferior, and then good in them has the dominion over truth. But as within the Church there are more unregenerate than regenerate men, and as the unregenerate judge from appearances, it has been a matter of dispute from ancient times whether priority belongs to truth or to good. With those who were not regenerated, and also with those who were not fully regenerated, the opinion prevailed that truth is prior; for as yet they had no perception of good, and so long as there is no perception of good, they must of necessity be in shade, or in ignorance on things of this nature. But those who are regenerate, because they are in essential good, are enabled, by virtue of the intelligence derived from it, to perceive what good is, and that it is from the Lord, and that it flows in through the internal man into the external, and this continually, man being entirely ignorant of it, and that it adjoins itself to the truths of doctrine which are in the memory, consequently that good in itself is prior, although it did not before appear to be so."

These states of thought in the Church, and these stages of the regenerate life, are strikingly represented in the state of the Israelitish people at the time of this meeting between Joab and Abner, when they were divided, the tribe of Judah, which represented charity or goodness, being on one side, and the rest of the tribes, which have more relation to truth and faith, being on the other. Yet, in reference to the regenerate this is a temporary state; for even in this stage the regenerate are progressing to one in which truth in them will be subordinate to goodness, as the tribes now under Saul are being brought, though by a painful experience, to unite with Judah in acknowledging the sovereignty of David. Their submission is to be brought about by conquest; and the singular and sanguinary scene enacted in the sight of the two contending parties is the beginning of the conflict.

And very expressive also of the nature and issue of the contest, in this its first stage, are the particulars of the conflict. The contest is at first a kind of intellectual sport, as the young men were to arise and play. The intellectual character of the contest is indicated by the number of combatants on either side. There are some numbers that have relation to good and some that have relation to truth. The number twelve has especial relation to truth, and generally means all the truths that enter into and constitute the faith of the Church, like the twelve tribes of Israel and the twelve apostles of the Lord. These are the intellectual combatants that are to contend for victory. They enter into the serious play of deadly strife. The contest is short and sharp, each man seizes his fellow by the head, and plunges his sword into his side. The head has a comprehensive meaning, but, in particular, it signifies the truth which a man believes to be truth, and which he makes the truth of his faith, for with man this constitutes the head, and is meant by the head in many parts of Scripture; as in Isaiah, "The redeemed shall come to Zion with songs of joy upon their head" (Isa. xxxv. 10). As the head has relation to truth and faith, the side has relation to charity; for there, where the combatants strike, is the region of the heart, which is the seat of life, and the symbol of love, which is life. Spiritual combatants lay hold of the head and thrust at the side, when they seize the faith and strike at the love of their opponents, and thus endeavour to subdue them through both the understanding and the will. But the singularity of this conflict is, that each combatant is victor and each is vanquished. The whole of the combatants are slain, they fall down together. A complete representative this of those intellectual and spiritual conflicts in which victory and defeat are common to both sides; in which neither convinces the other, but each one believes that he wields the sword of truth, and inflicts a mortal wound upon the principles of the other. From the determined character of those who engaged in this conflict the place was called the field of strong men, to express the state of mind which such a deadly but indecisive trial of strength leaves behind it, each side equally strong in its own convictions.

But no momentous question can be allowed long to remain undecided, if the means exist by which it can be brought to a decision. The death of these combatants was the signal for a general engagement. "And there was a very sore battle that day; and Abner was beaten, and the men of Israel, before the servants of David." This preponderance of power on David's side is representative of the beginning of that inversion of state which is to end in good being actually the first in the mind's estimation, and in the government of its thoughts and affections. And this also implies the ascendancy of the spiritual over the natural; for the one state implies the other. So

far as we are naturally minded we give truth the first place and good the second, and even if we do not give truth the preference theoretically, we do it practically; and only when we have become spiritual do we give a practical supremacy to good. In every regenerate mind, therefore, the conflict takes place which is to determine whether good or truth shall be the reigning power; and only as we incline to the supremacy of goodness in our own hearts and lives does the cause of the right principle prosper and ultimately prevail.

When Abner was beaten he fled, and was pursued by a brother of Joab. As this flight and pursuit have important future consequences both to Abner and Joab, the captains of the opposing hosts, it is necessary carefully to consider it.

"There were three sons of Zeruiah there, Joab, and Abishai, and Asahel: and Asahel was as light of foot as a wild roe." Asahel pursued Abner, but Abner seems to have been nearly as light of foot as his pursuer. He not only kept in advance, but was able to look behind and warn Asahel of the danger to which he exposed himself in coming too near. "Howbeit he refused to turn aside: wherefore Abner with the hinder end of the spear smote him under the fifth rib, that the spear came out behind him; and he fell down there, and died in the same place." The three sons of Zeruiah represent, like all such combinations, the trine that makes complete unity; and as the last in every trine has reference to action, this is well represented by Asahel being light of foot. The wild roe, to whose fleetness that of Asahel is compared, expresses the character of the ultimate which he represented. In Jacob's last blessing on his sons, Naphtali is said to be a hind let loose; and he represents the delight of the natural affections after temptations, when the affections, previously bound, are restored to a state of freedom. But Asahel is compared to a roe that has never been bound, but is in the enjoyment of its original wild freedom. He, therefore, represents that activity which springs from the impetuosity of the natural affections that have not been chastened by temptation. He receives his death-stroke in an unusual way indeed, from behind Abner, and by the hinder end of his spear; but this shows his want of caution and experience, and it points out also the external means by which such a principle as that which Asahel represents may be overcome; for behind and before mean what are relatively external and internal, obscure and clear. To be thus slain would be a reproach; and the circumstance that "as many as came to the place where Asahel fell down and died stood still," may be considered to express mingled sorrow and regret that, in the warfare of the spiritual life, much zeal may be united with much indiscretion, and that a good cause may suffer loss from the well-intentioned but misdirected efforts of those who support it.

But Joab and Abishai continued the pursuit in which Asahel had failed; "and the sun went down when they were come to the hill of Ammah, that lieth before Giah by the way of the wilderness of Gibeon." In the prosecution of the same object by the two higher faculties there is some degree of the union of what is good and true, and therefore of zeal and discretion, as effected by temptation, which was wanting in Asahel; for they came to the hill Ammah, which means a beginning; that lieth before Giah, which means breaking forth (of a fountain); by the way of the wilderness of Gibeon, which spiritually signifies temptation as to truth. But when they were come thus far the sun went down. Sunset is the end of a state of clear perception, and the beginning of a state of obscure perception, in regard to love and faith. In the present instance the state of clear perception had ended before the object of pursuit had been attained; thus indicating a still undecided or indecisive state respecting the supremacy of good or of truth in the Church and kingdom of the Lord among and within men.

The state of undetermined supremacy is further described in the account which follows. The men of Benjamin, the tribe to which Saul belonged, and in whose land the combatants now were, "gathered themselves together after Abner, and became one troop, and stood on the top of an hill. Then Abner called to Joab, and said, Shall the sword devour for ever? Knowest thou not that it will be bitterness in the latter end? how long shall it be then, ere thou bid the people return from following their brethren? And Joab said, As God liveth, unless thou hadst spoken, surely then in the morning the people had gone up every one from following his brother." These leaders of the two opposite troops agreed to desist; and they returned, one to Mahanaim, the other to Hebron. They seem to have been mutually impressed with a conviction that it was unbecoming to carry on a fratricidal war to determine whether one or both the kings should reign; for this alternative seems to have entered into their calculations; and this state of indecision may be referred to that higher sphere which this condition of the two parties represents.

Still, although the question of the kingship was as yet undecided, and both the leaders agreed for the time to desist, the advantage was on the side of David. Of David's servants only nineteen had fallen besides Asahel, but of Benjamin and the men of Abner three hundred and threescore had died. These numbers express not only the extent but the nature of the loss; for three belongs to the spiritual class of numbers, and twenty to the celestial; or, to truth and good respectively. Although, therefore, both sides suffered loss, the relative strength remaining was on the side of goodness as compared with truth, or of the inner as compared with the outer man. As regards

Asahel, they buried him in the sepulchre of his father which is in Bethlehem; thus representing the rising into a new and higher life of that natural principle of which he was the expressive type.

CHAPTER V.

THE DEATH OF ABNER.

2 Samuel iii.

THE truce between Joab and Abner was but of short duration. At what time the conflict was renewed we do not learn; but the third chapter opens with the statement, "Now there was long war between the house of Saul and the house of David: but David waxed stronger and stronger, and the house of Saul waxed weaker and weaker." There were no doubt many conflicts, but they are left unrecorded. In the progress of the regenerate life there are temptation-conflicts that do not belong so much to our outward as to our inward experience. Not all are inscribed on the natural memory, but the issues of all are inscribed on the spiritual memory, the book of life, out of which all are to be judged. Our Lord was engaged during His whole life in conflicts with the powers of darkness, in which He passed alternately through states of examination and glorification; so that He waxed stronger and stronger, and the opposing power waxed weaker and weaker. Yet all that we read of in the Gospels are His temptations in the wilderness, and those in Gethsemane and on the cross. So with the Christian disciple who follows his Master and Lord. His record is on high; and to know and rejoice that his name is written in heaven, is to him more than to know and rejoice that the spirits are subject unto him. This is to know that the government of the natural is waxing weaker and weaker, and the government of the spiritual is waxing stronger and stronger; that religion is becoming more and more of the heart, and less and less of the intellect: not that religion loses any of its intellectual interest, but it is regarded, even on its intellectual side, more for the good which it leads us to do than for the truth which it requires us to believe.

The progress of this inversion of state, by which good obtains the ascendancy, is attended with an increase of the graces, or of the spiritual affections and thoughts, that enrich the mind, so far as religion comes to be a vital principle that moves the heart, still more than a system of doctrine that convinces the understanding. This is expressed in the series of events in this inspired record. Immediately after saying that David waxed and the house of Saul waned, the

sacred writer relates that "unto David were sons born in Hebron." He mentions six sons born of as many different mothers. These sons spiritually understood, are true thoughts born of good affections. They are six in number, to express the idea that true thoughts from good affections are not produced without labour and sorrow, a meaning which this number has acquired from the six days of labour that precede the Sabbath of rest, these natural days representing spiritual states through which the regenerate pass in their progress towards the heavenly state of spiritual and eternal rest.

But the true thoughts, or the spiritual perceptions of truth, which are thus born in the mind through labour and travail, which are states of spiritual conflict, become in their turn the means by which falsities and evils are resisted and overcome. Therefore children, or sons, are said to be "as arrows in the hand of a mighty man. Happy is the man that hath his quiver full of them: they shall not be ashamed, but they shall speak with the enemies in the gate" (Ps. cxxvii. 4, 5). The gate, in which are the enemies with whom the sons of youth shall speak, is the rational mind which communicates between the spiritual and the natural: and the enemies in the gate are the evils of the natural mind that resist the good of the spiritual mind in its effort to flow down into and unite the truths of the lower mind to itself. The sons that are as arrows in the hand of a mighty man, are, specifically, rational truths which have a spiritual origin; and these, when wielded by the power of internal or spiritual goodness, which is the hand of the mighty, are instrumental in removing the evils that rise up in rebellion against good, which desires to rule, only that, by establishing order, it may produce concord and happiness.

A way was now opened for the reconciliation of the two conflicting elements, and for bringing the whole under the dominion of the rightful power, which was hardly to be expected, but which is not unusual in similar, and therefore in corresponding, circumstances. Abner, who had made himself strong for the house of Saul, was accused by his master of going in to one of Saul's concubines. This would have been practically making a claim to Saul's throne, and would have represented the adulteration of the good of natural truth. This charge Abner indignantly denied; and he threatened to "translate the kingdom from the house of Saul, and to set up the throne of David over Israel and over Judah, from Dan even to Beer-sheba." In conformity with this threat, Abner "sent messengers to David, saying, Whose is the land? saying also, Make thy league with me, and, behold, my hand shall be with thee, to bring about all Israel unto thee." David accepted the offer, but attached to it a singular condition. "Thou shalt not see my face, except thou first bring Michal, Saul's daughter." David sent messengers to Ish-bosheth to demand his wife, and Ish-

bosheth sent and took her from her husband, Phaltiel, the son of Laish. There is something remarkable in these circumstances. David refuses to see Abner, who offers him a kingdom, unless he bring with him Michal, David's first wife. Yet David himself demands her of Ish-bosheth, who delivers her to Abner, and thus becomes the means of effecting his own overthrow. Ish-bosheth feared Abner, and it is evident he also feared David; and although he may not have been aware of the league that had been made between them, he must have seen the danger of sending the leader of his army to restore Michal to David in Hebron. But these circumstances were divinely ordered or permitted for higher than historical purposes. Michal was to be the medium through whom the kingdom of Saul was to be united to the kingdom of David. We do not say, by whom the house of Saul was to be united to the house of David; for, as we shall see, Michal did not effect this higher union. The daughter of Saul may not have had any direct personal influence in bringing over the tribes; but she represents the affection by which the internal and external are brought together in order that they may become one. Therefore, as Saul had taken Michal from David and given her to Phaltiel, the son of Saul took her from Phaltiel and restored her to David. Abner was the instrument, Michal was the medium. He is the truth, she is the good, by which spiritual Israel is united to Judah under the rule of David's Lord.

An affecting scene is recorded in connection with these events. When Ish-bosheth sent and took Michal from Phaltiel, "her husband went with her along weeping behind her to Bahurim." It is pleasing to find in the tender affection of Phaltiel a worthy exception to the unfeeling character of the times, which could tolerate the separation, in the easiest manner possible, of a wife from her husband. Michal had for the second time been thus disposed of; and as she loved David, she may not have felt grieved at being parted from Phaltiel. There is nothing recorded respecting Phaltiel which can account for Saul having given him Michal while she was the wife of David. We only know him as the son of Laish, the lion, a name which he may have obtained for his prowess, although he has left no memorial of his feats of strength.

Saul both gave Michal and took her away, not from love but from hatred of David, and not to aid but to injure him. Yet Saul's wrath even in this was turned to David's praise. To see his wife given to another must have added to his anguish of spirit, yet it creates no bitterness of temper towards him who had so outraged his feelings as a husband. But the time of separation must have been a time of trial for Michal as well as for David, and their reunion must have been gratifying to both; and represents the conjunction of truth in the

spiritual mind with the affection of truth in the natural mind, which serves as a medium of connection and conjunction between the spiritual and the natural.

But that which was a time of rejoicing to David was a time of sorrowing to Phaltiel. All separations are sorrowful. But they may be profitable nevertheless. If we may judge by a Hebrew sign, the husband of Michal had passed into a higher state by his union with her. When Michal was given to him he was Phalti, when separated from him he was Phaltiel. As the letter *h*, which changed Abram into Abraham, and Sarai into Sarah, was taken from the Divine name Jehovah; the letters *el*, which changed Phalti into Phaltiel, formed the Divine name El, or were taken from Elohim. Jehovah may be called the Lord's Divine-celestial name, Elohim His Divine-spiritual name. Those to whose names *el* is added, from being natural become spiritual, and those to whose names *h* has been added, from being spiritual become celestial. Those who received such names at their birth belong respectively to the spiritual and the celestial class. We mean of course representatively. But Phaltiel went on weeping after Michal till he came to Bahurim, when Abner commanded him to return. This Benjamite city, which was not far from Jerusalem, has its name from a root which signifies to prove, to choose, to love. It was the scene of transactions differing widely in character, but having one feature in common. Shimei there cursed David when flying from Absalom (xvi. 5), and there Hushai's messengers to David were concealed in a well when pursued by Absalom's men (xvii. 17). In these three instances, the only ones in which the place is mentioned, the circumstances that occurred were such as severely to try, and therefore to prove, men. David endured his trial meekly, and Phaltiel quietly submitted to the harsh mandate of the rough soldier.

Abner came to Hebron with a retinue of twenty men, and he was prepared to say to David, "I will arise and go, and will gather all Israel unto my lord the king, that they may make a league with thee, and that thou mayest reign over all that thine heart desireth. And David sent Abner away; and he went in peace." No sooner had Abner departed, than Joab returned from pursuing a troop, and laden with spoil. Hearing that Abner had been to Hebron, and that David had taken him into his favour, he came to the king, and reproached him with having sent away in peace one who had only come as a spy. Joab then sent messengers after Abner, who brought him again from the well of Sirah. "And when Abner was returned to Hebron, Joab took him aside in the gate to speak with him quietly, and smote him there under the fifth rib, that he died, for the blood of Asahel his brother." When David heard of this treacherous deed, he declared himself and his kingdom guiltless of the blood of Abner, and pronounced a

malediction on Joab and on all his father's house. Abner was buried in Hebron, and David gave him all the honours of a princely funeral. He himself followed the bier, and wept at the grave, and lamented over Abner; and said, "Died Abner as a fool dieth? Thy hands were not bound, nor thy feet put into fetters: as a man falleth before wicked men, so fellest thou. And all the people wept again over him." David fasted till the sun went down. And the king said unto his servants, "Know ye not that there is a prince and a great man fallen this day in Israel? And I am this day weak, though anointed king; and these men the sons of Zeruiah be too hard for me: the Lord shall reward the doer of evil according to his wickedness."

In order to understand the spiritual meaning of the transactions recorded in this chapter, and in some others as well, we must consider what Joab and Abner, the two leaders of the opposing forces, who play no unimportant parts in this history, represent.

In early times, the king was the leader of his army as well as the ruler of his people. One, if not the chief, object for which the Israelites desired a king was, that he might go out before them, and fight their battles. And when Samuel told the people the manner of the king that would reign over them, he spoke of his appointing captains over thousands and over fifties, but said nothing of his placing a leader over the whole army. The general of the army, therefore, when he took the place of the king, was his lieutenant in a stricter sense than an officer of the same rank is now. Both Joab and Abner were, moreover, related to the kings whom they served. Joab was the nephew of David (1 Sam. xxvi. 6), and Abner was the cousin of Saul (xiv. 47). Joab was related to David on the mother's side, Zeruiah being the sister of David; Abner was related to Saul on the father's side, Ner being the uncle of Saul.

While both of these generals were related to the kings whom they served, they yet represented principles that perform a temporary use, and are removed when that use has been performed. Abner did not long survive the reign of Saul, and Joab did not long survive the reign of David. Both of them committed the same error. Abner, on the death of Saul, took up the cause of Ish-bosheth against David; and Joab, on the death of David, took up the cause of Adonijah against Solomon. That is to say, they both adhered to the natural line, one by heredity, the other by primogeniture; one ignoring the Divine appointment of David through Samuel, the other the Divine appointment of Solomon through David. Both died a violent death. Joab killed Abner to avenge the death of Abishai, and Solomon killed Joab to avenge the death of Abner. One was slain in the gate, the other at the altar.

One other particular which broadens the basis of the spiritual sense

of the history of these two leaders, is the signification of their names. Ab, which means father, enters into both; but the termination of one name means light or a lamp, and the beginning of the other means Jehovah. Abner thus signifies father of light, and Joab means Jehovah my father; and light signifies truth, and the Divine name Jehovah signifies good.

Now there are two classes of men, one in whom the will, the other in whom the understanding, is the more active and the ruling power. This difference between Joab and Abner may be seen in their personal as well as in their typical character. Joab acts more from the deep and sometimes malignant feelings of the heart; Abner more from the dictates of the understanding. Joab is by no means deficient in intelligence, but his understanding is more under the control of his will than his will is under the control of his understanding. There is, therefore, a duplicity of character in Joab, which indicates, intellectually, more of the wisdom of the serpent than the harmlessness of the dove. Abner's character indicates more intellectual control, and more singleness of mind, perhaps also more of the harmlessness of the dove than the wisdom of the serpent.

Joab's characteristics show him to represent the rational mind not yet under the control of the spiritual. It is very significant that Joab and his brothers are always spoken of as the sons of Zeruiah, the sister of David. A sister, as we have seen from Abraham and Isaac calling their wives their sisters, signifies rational truth, or rather the affection of rational truth. The three sons of Zeruiah are the truths born of this affection; for the rational, like the spiritual and the natural, is inner, middle, and outer. This affection and its truths differ from those represented by Hagar and Ishmael, as the affection of understanding differs from the affection of knowing. The affection of rational truth is, indeed, the affection of understanding truth rationally. As, to understand is greater than to know, so much greater is its responsibility; and as it gives the faculty and the means of rising higher, so does it of sinking lower. Joab exhibits examples of both. The downward tendency in him prevails. And as he who understands the truth can profane it; so Joab, in slaying Abner without just cause and by deceit, commits the sin of profanation, and brings upon himself and upon his father's house the curse which that sin incurs, and from the blood-guiltiness of which there is no refuge, even in the sanctuary of God, and at the horns of the altar.

But Abner, what of him? He, as the servant of Saul and the supporter of Ish-bosheth, is possessed of the lower gift of knowing; therefore he is less capable of so deeply sinning, and more capable of readily repenting. It is true he turns to David because his master had offended him, but the offence shows that his master was unde-

serving of his support; therefore he turned from the false to the true.

But besides going over to David himself, he had communicated with the elders of Israel and spoken to the men of Benjamin, whom he found willing to acknowledge David as their king. It would appear from this as if the kingdom was about to be transferred, peaceably and at once, from the house of Saul to the house of David, and that Joab's jealousy alone frustrated Abner's good intention and well-devised scheme. But in the ways of God there is permission as well as provision; and this is no doubt to be regarded as the law under which both Abner and his master were taken out of the way, that the tribes of Israel might, of their own free-will and independent action, come to seek David as their king. This does not exonerate those who did the evil. God does not prompt men to sin; but neither does He forcibly restrain them. Law and conscience are the bonds of His controlling providence; and when men break these, they run into punishment, which is also permitted as a means of correction, and if possible of improvement. The evil were not withheld from compassing the death of the Lord Himself, and even the treacherous kiss of Judas was permitted to pollute the sinless lips of the Son of Man. These deeds were mourned over, and those who committed them are justly held in execration; and yet they were permitted as necessities, for the sake of the end of which they were the means—the means of effecting that death, which was to be the gate to everlasting life. Might not, on the same principle, the death of Abner, and even of Ish-bosheth, be a necessary sacrifice, though done by treacherous and bloody men, who neither desired nor intended the end to which their cruel deeds contributed? And might not these men be representative and their acts significative in that history, all whose parts were ensamples, written for our admonition? Judas was a disciple, and yet he was a traitor. Joab was David's servant, and yet he slew a confiding man, whom his master had dismissed with favour. The rational can act against as well as with the spiritual, which it is its true office to serve and obey; but even its contrary acts may become channels of usefulness.

David, however, justly mourned over Abner's death; and what is more, he made Joab himself mourn. "And David said to Joab, and to all the people that were with him, Rend your clothes, and gird you with sackcloth, and mourn before Abner." Joab's mourning may have had little sincerity to commend it, but the outward and visible act is that which represents; and the concurrent mourning of all concerned, from the king downwards, expresses the concurrent action of all the thoughts and affections of the mind in expressing godly sorrow for the commission of an ungodly deed. In the obsequies which they paid the slain hero, "king David himself followed the bier. And they buried

Abner in Hebron: and the king lifted up his voice, and wept at the grave of Abner; and all the people wept." As burial is the symbol of resurrection, Abner's being buried in Hebron tells us that the natural truth, which he represented, is raised into a spiritual state, when it has once acknowledged the sovereignty of spiritual truth, however unreal it may have been to the rational, when acting from its own views and impulses. Abner had not, it is true, carried his purpose into effect. But this he would no doubt have done had he been allowed to return to his own land. He had the will, but he was deprived of the opportunity of bringing it into action. He was not like those who have the will with the opportunity, thus showing that they have not, but only suppose they have, the performing will.

At the grave the king lamented over Abner, and said, "Died Abner as a fool dieth? Thy hands were not bound, nor thy feet put into fetters: as a man falleth before wicked men, so fellest thou." David had lamented over Saul, now he laments over Saul's general. Saul had been slain by the enemy, Abner had fallen by the hand of an ostensible friend. Neither foolish nor bound, he died as if he had been both a fool and in fetters. Wisdom and power, with the freedom to use them, are no protection against treachery. But in Scripture, a fool is not so much a weak as a worthless or wicked person; and such a one may require restraint, and even deserve death, which, we have seen, overtook Nabal. Abner was not such a one, and yet he suffered an inglorious death. But what does this lamentation of David teach us in its inner meaning? In Saul's death, David lamented the fall, in the Church, of Divine truth, which, as the anointed king of Israel, he represented. In the death of Abner he laments the fall of a primary truth, which is the same truth in a lower form and active state, as represented by Abner. Therefore David said to his servants, "Know ye not that there is a prince and a great man fallen this day in Israel?" For a prince means a primary or principal truth, which is subordinate to and rules under the highest. In espousing and maintaining the cause of Ish-bosheth, Abner became the support of Saul's house and throne. When he transferred his allegiance to David, he virtually became a support of the house and throne of David; and had he lived, he would have become so actually. Partly at least on this account, after saying of Abner, that a prince and a great man had fallen in Israel, David added, "And I am this day weak, though anointed king." But this weakness arose also, and perhaps still more, from the deed of Joab, as calculated to bring discredit on himself and his kingdom, although he had washed his hands of the guilt. "And these men the sons of Zeruiah," he concludes, "be too hard for me: the Lord shall reward the doer of evil according to his wickedness." When the inward

man fails to find support in the outward man, whether it be from want of correspondence on the part of the rational or the natural, he is, in that state, as David was in that day, weak, though anointed king. Faith imbued with love may be the ruling principle in the inward man; but the inward man is but weak, and feels his own weakness, whenever the outward man refuses to act in harmony with him, much more when he acts against him. For the outward man is not, strictly speaking, an agent, but a reagent; he does not act but reacts; for all the power of acting comes from within. But the outward man can react against, as well as with, the inward man; he can use the power with which he is continually supplied to work his own will instead of that of his master. It is the same with man himself in relation to the Lord. Man is not, strictly speaking, an agent but a reagent. The Lord is the only agent throughout this universe; all created things and beings are but reagents. Yet man, although he has all his power, as he has his life, from God, can react against Him. He can use his God-given power to do his own will, instead of the Divine will. He has rationality and liberty, without which he would not be human, and the existence of these implies the power of judging and choosing, and therefore of acting, as if the power were his own, as it virtually, though not actually, is.

It seems remarkable that David should so bitterly complain that the sons of Zeruiah were too hard for him, and yet show no intention or even desire to remove them from a position they had misused. It may be thought they were too powerful to lose as friends and encounter as enemies. The higher reason is, that the sons of Zeruiah had a representative use to perform. That rationality which they represented is not to be rejected, even when it reacts against the higher perceptions of the mind, until the stage of the regenerate life to which it belongs is completed, and the state is perfected. When good takes the place of truth, when Solomon reigns instead of David, its end will have come. Then JEHOVAH will reward the doer of evil according to his wickedness. Not the anointed but the anointer is he who rewards such wickedness; not the Divine truth but the Divine good is that which removes such capability from the sphere of mental activity and bodily action. Now, the inversion of state is only going on. When that is completed, and good reigns, it will cast out all that offends.

CHAPTER VI.

THE DEATH OF ISH-BOSHETH.

2 Samuel iv.

IT is not surprising that "when Saul's son heard that Abner was dead in Hebron, his hands were feeble, and all the Israelites were troubled." It would appear from this that Ish-bosheth was not aware that the captain of his army had made a league with David, to bring all Israel under his rule. Adversity brought effects, not unusual in rude and warlike nations, in the affairs and fortunes of Ish-bosheth ; it shook the stability of his kingdom, and raised up unscrupulous and deadly enemies against him in his own camp. Two brothers, that were captains of bands, Baanah and Rechab, went, and came about the heat of the day to the house of Ish-bosheth, who lay on his bed in his bedchamber ; and they slew him, and cut off his head. This they brought unto David at Hebron, and said to the king, "Behold the head of Ish-bosheth the son of Saul thine enemy, which sought thy life ; and the Lord hath avenged my lord the king this day of Saul, and of his seed." Instead of commending or rewarding them, David ordered them to be slain ; and the young men who slew them cut off their hands and their feet, and hanged them over the post of Hebron. But they took the head of Ish-bosheth, and buried it in the sepulchre of Abner in Hebron.

It is always painful to read of the sufferings and fate of the unfortunate, especially when brought upon them by those whom "their former bounty fed." But history records too many instances of this to make it a matter of surprise, as it is of regret. Yet even here we are to recognise a permissive Providence. The Creator of all worlds is this Disposer of all events. His presence and power, which are necessary to the subsistence and order of all things, and without which this glorious universe would resolve itself into chaos, are equally necessary to preserve and ordinate the moral world. Unless the providence of the Lord over the states and concerns of men were as minute as the beautiful analogy suggests, that the very hairs of their head are all numbered, and that a sparrow falls not to the ground without their Father in heaven, the moral world would fall into utter confusion and ruin. True it is that the Divine will is not done in all the actions of men ; yet that will is ever active, working out, through the human mind and in human affairs, the greatest possible amount of good and measure of happiness for each one and for the whole of the human race. The Divine

is present in the minutest particulars of human thought and affection, influencing where it cannot inspire, controlling where it cannot guide; while all angels and spirits are employed as agents, and men and circumstances are brought to act as far as possible, in furtherance of the one purpose of the Divine Father, in the creation and government of the world, to make men holy and thence happy. A Being who is eternal must have eternal ends in view. Therefore much of human experience in this world is permitted for the sake of life in the world to come.

In sacred history, where we see as much of the dark, with more of the bright side of human nature than in the histories of the world, we find it placed in the light of Divine truth, and thus in the light of Divine and not merely of human judgment. In Scripture the actions and experience of men are not recorded for information merely or even chiefly, but for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness, that the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works. But besides all the doctrine and instruction that can be drawn from the sacred history, as history, we can now, by the law of spiritual interpretation, see in it a higher doctrine and purer instruction, enabling us to drink at the upper as well as the nether springs of revealed truth.

In the historical events of this part of the Word we see, especially, in the character and conduct of the two barbarous brothers, the character and operations of the unregenerate natural mind, both as to will and understanding. Their cruel deed exemplifies as well as represents the character of the natural man. One of the characteristics of natural-minded men is their instability. They are the people who change with circumstances. Having no inward principle to guide them, they go with the stream, and can be as zealous in destroying, as they had been in preserving, the idol of their worship. When the will and understanding are united in the pursuit of a selfish object, no deed is too dark, no means too unscrupulous. The two Benjamites went into the house of Ish-bosheth as though they would fetch wheat—as though they were pursuing good when they were hasting to do evil, seeking to promote life when they were eager to destroy it. Ish-bosheth "lay on his bed in his bedchamber, and they smote him, and slew him, and beheaded him, and took his head, and gat them away through the plain all night." When evil and falsehood penetrate into the interior of the human mind, where life reposes, or seeks repose, after the toils and anxieties of its active state, they take that life away, so far as it has been the life of goodness and truth; and severing the inner from the outer part of that which they have already slain, they get them away with it through the plain in the darkness of night. This plain is in the mind itself, and the night is a state of the

mind. Plains, in Scripture, signify planes in the mind. These two words in our language have the same origin, and express nearly the same idea, but the idea, and not merely the word, forms the ground of the meaning. "With man there are two planes, on which the celestial and spiritual principles from the Lord are founded. One is interior, the other is exterior. The planes themselves are conscience. The interior plane, or interior conscience, is where genuine goodness and truth are, for goodness and truth flowing in from the Lord constitute its active power. The exterior plane is the exterior conscience, and is where justice and equity, in the proper sense, are, for what is just and equitable, moral and civil, which also flow in, constitute its active power. There is also an outermost plane, which appears as conscience, but is not conscience. It does what is equitable and just for the sake of self and the world, or for the sake of self-honour or reputation, of worldly possessions, and through fear of the law." This last plane is that which exists in the minds of the wicked. It is the plain through which those represented by Baanah and Rechab pass in the night, when darkness is sought to cover deeds of darkness, and hide it even from themselves.

David, to whom the slayers of Ish-bosheth presented his head, as an offering intended to secure his favour, shows the true nobility which marked his conduct on other similar occasions, when his interest would have prompted him to act a less generous part. He said to them, "When one told me, saying, Behold, Saul is dead, thinking to have brought good tidings, I took hold of him, and slew him in Ziklag, who thought that I would have given him a reward for his tidings: how much more, when wicked men have slain a righteous person in his own house upon his bed? Shall I not therefore now require his blood of your hand, and take you away from the earth? And David commanded his young men, and they slew them, and cut off their hands and their feet, and hanged them up over the pool in Hebron. But they took the head of Ish-bosheth, and buried it in the sepulchre of Abner in Hebron." Those mutilations which were practised so much by ancient nations, when recorded in the Word are representative of the effects of evil. The hands and the feet, as the members by which the power of the body operates, or by which, roughly speaking, we work and walk, correspond to the ultimate powers of the mind by which the will and the understanding act. When the evil are such that "the act of violence is in their hands, and their feet run to evil, and they make haste to shed innocent blood" (Isa. lix. 6, 7), they lose the power of doing good. We see in this the judgment of Divine truth, which returns the evil done upon the evil-doer, according to the eternal law of retribution, that as a man sows so also shall he reap.

CHAPTER VII.

DAVID IS ANOINTED KING OVER ISRAEL, AND GOES UP AGAINST JERUSALEM.

2 *Samuel* v. 1-5.

ISH-BOSHETH reigned two years; but it was not till five years after his death that David was anointed king over Israel. What government prevailed among the eleven tribes between the death of Saul's son and the commencement of David's reign, we do not learn. It would probably resemble that which existed during the time of the judges, when there was no king in Israel, and every man did that which was right in his own eyes. The tribes had no doubt come to feel the necessity of a more stringent rule. They came to David of their own accord. It is indeed remarkable that David seems to have taken no measures to bring the eleven tribes under his dominion. It was no doubt right that they should come and offer him their voluntary homage. The Lord came to establish a kingdom, but He never employed force to bring men into it. He requires the free reciprocation of His love; for only in freedom can men be ruled to their advantage.

When the tribes of Israel came to David they said, "Behold, we are thy bone and thy flesh. Also in time past, when Saul was king over us, thou wast he that leddest out and broughtest in Israel: and the Lord said to thee, Thou shalt feed My people Israel, and thou shalt be a captain over Israel. So all the elders of Israel came to the king to Hebron; and king David made a league with them in Hebron before the Lord: and they anointed David king over Israel." This is an accurate description of the Lord Jesus. He is our bone and our flesh, in being clothed with humanity, which, though glorified in Him, is not less akin to us. Nay, it is nearer to us than it was when yet unglorified. For that humanity in which all the fulness of the Godhead dwells, is life itself, and enters as a living principle into all that is human in us: nay, it is the origin of all that is truly human in human minds; for no one is truly man but he in whom is an image of the Divine man. It is no less accurate a description of David's Lord that He feeds His people, and is a captain over them. He leads them to the green pastures and beside the still waters, and defends them against, and even prepares a table before them in the presence of, their enemies.

The league which the Lord makes with His people is the agreement

which rests upon conditions—conditions of support and protection on His part, and of fidelity and obedience on theirs. This league is made before Jehovah, when the Church acknowledges the Divinity of the Lord in His Humanity. And the Church anoints the Lord King over Israel, when the love she has received from the Lord is returned to Him again, and there is reciprocal conjunction between the Lord and His people.

When all Israel had thus voluntarily placed themselves under the rule of David, and formed one united kingdom under one king, a new capital was to be provided by the king more suitable to his enlarged dominions.

Jerusalem was inhabited by the Jebusites, one of the seven nations of Canaan that were devoted to the sword. In the division of the land it fell to the lot of Benjamin (Josh. xviii. 28). The king of Jerusalem was one of the five kings who fought against Joshua on that memorable day when the sun stood still (Josh. x. 5). So powerful were the Jebusites, the inhabitants of Jerusalem, aided no doubt by the strength of the place, that neither the children of Judah nor the children of Benjamin could drive them out, but the Jebusites dwelt with them "unto this day" (Josh. xv. 63; Judges i. 21). The reduction of the stronghold of the Jebusites was reserved for David, nor did he attempt it till backed by the whole force of Israel. And when the king went up against Jerusalem, the Jebusites, as we shall see, felt so perfectly secure, that they mocked at the very idea of his seriously attempting to force his way into their impregnable fortress. In all this there is of course a higher meaning. It is, in one of its applications, part of a large and comprehensive subject, and one of the mysteries of the kingdom that could only have been known by what may be called a revelation.

The whole history of the Israelites, from the time of Moses to the reign of Solomon, is, in the internal sense, a history of the Lord's work of redemption, in regard to its effects in the spiritual world. There, we know, judgment is effected, and a new heaven is formed, preparatory to the establishment of a new Church upon earth. The plagues of Egypt, by which the Israelites were separated from the Egyptians, describe the process and progress of judgment, by which the good were severed from the evil in the world of spirits. The Red Sea signifies that hell into which the wicked, who were represented by the Egyptians, were cast, and through which the righteous, represented by the Israelites, passed in safety. The forty years' journey through the wilderness describes the temptations through which the redeemed passed before they could enter heaven. And this reveals a most important fact relating to those who had lived in the world from the fall of the celestial Church to the time of the Lord's Advent. It is the common belief of Christians, that there was no salvation for the fallen

race of man but through Jesus Christ; and that His atonement included past sins as well as future offences. But the important question is, How was this effected? We know the common opinion. Christ, it is held, suffered for the sins of all men from the time of the Fall; and those "who died in faith, not having received the promises, but having seen them afar off," were saved, "being justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus: whom God hath set forth to be a propitiation through faith in His blood, to declare His righteousness for the remission of sins that are past" (Rom. iii. 24, 25). We share in the common belief in the efficacy of our Lord's redemption. We believe, however, that sins can only be remitted by being removed. And it is a vital question, how the sins committed before the Lord's coming could be removed by what the Lord did and suffered in the flesh.

The work of salvation consists of two parts, reformation and regeneration. All who are reformed in the world are ultimately saved; for those who in the natural world have shunned evils as sins can be imbued with good in the spiritual world. Before the Lord's coming men could be reformed in the world, but they could not be regenerated. Regeneration cannot be effected without temptation. And until the Lord had conquered hell and glorified His humanity, no one could undergo temptation; therefore none were admitted into a trial in which none could have stood. Yet without regeneration there is no salvation, therefore no heaven. How then was the salvation of those who died in faith provided for? All who had passed through the first stage of the new life, and were thus capable of passing through the second, were reserved in the intermediate state, or world of spirits, until the Lord's coming. And when the Lord had overcome hell and glorified His humanity, then could the faithful in the world of spirits pass through the corresponding process, and be regenerated as He had been glorified. He being perfected through suffering could succour them that were tempted (Heb. iii. 18). The temptations which the faithful underwent in the middle state, were represented by the trials which the children of Israel endured in the middle region between Egypt and Canaan, the waste and howling wilderness. And by this means they realized the promise, and had remission of sins that were past. They had been carried in the womb; now they were born—born from above although with trouble and anguish. For the Church, as the mother of the faithful, had been in that state described by the prophet: "The children are come to the birth, and there is not strength to bring forth" (Isa. xxxvii. 3). The faithful, new-born, were prepared to enter into heaven, as the Israelites, after their weary pilgrimage, were to enter into the Promised Land.

Regarding Canaan as the type of heaven, the eternal home of the

faithful, there is one important circumstance connected with it, which seems to make it anything but an image of that place where the wicked cease from troubling and the weary are at rest. It is inhabited by wicked nations, which have to be driven out before Israel can find it a quiet habitation. But this otherwise inexplicable circumstance is explained in the Writings, and in such a way as to make the whole history of Israel a consistent and continuous history of the great work of human redemption. "Before the Lord's coming into the world, that region of heaven to which the spiritual were afterwards raised, was occupied by evil spirits and genii; for before the Lord's coming, a great part of them roamed at large, and infested the good, especially the spiritual, who were in the lower earth; but after the Lord's coming they were all thrust down into their hells, and that region was delivered, and given for an inheritance to those of the spiritual Church." These were like the imaginary heavens spoken of in connection with the Lord's Second Advent, and which were abolished by the judgment which then took place.

When we know that the evil spirits and genii who occupied that region of heaven which was afterwards given as an eternal inheritance to the spiritual, were represented by the nations of Canaan, we can see the reason why none of them were completely conquered by Joshua, by the Judges, or even by Saul, but that their final and complete overthrow or subjugation should be reserved for David, who especially represented the Lord as Divine truth, and who, as such, conquered death and hell, and went and preached to the spirits in prison, delivering men on earth and the faithful in Hades from the captivity in which they had for ages been held by the powers of darkness.

David is now leading Israel, as the Lord led the faithful, to take the kingdom of heaven by force. But the account of this we reserve for another chapter.

CHAPTER VIII.

DAVID TAKES THE STRONGHOLD OF ZION.

2 Samuel v. 6-10.

As the capital of the kingdom is now to be transferred from Hebron to Jerusalem, a few remarks on this may be offered. Hebron was nearer to the borders of Canaan than Jerusalem; and represented a more exterior part of that region of heaven which was given to the spiritual; and also the Church in a less interior state. The removal

of the kingdom from Hebron to Jerusalem represented therefore the exaltation of the spiritual in the other life, and of the Lord's love and truth in the mind, by which their dominion becomes more perfect and extensive.

In the first as in the second seat of David's kingdom there is a duality, which is expressive of that distinction which was represented by Jerusalem and Zion. It is sometimes spoken of as Kirjath-Arba, which is Hebron. And Kirjath-Arba and Hebron, like Jerusalem and Zion, signify the two principles of truth and good which unitedly enter into the kingdom and government of the Lord, whether they are grounded essentially in love to Him, or in love to the neighbour. We sometimes indeed speak of the government of truth and the government of good, as expressive of the two kingdoms of the Lord; but we do not mean truth or good separate, but united. That principle which is most active gives its character to the mind. In some minds truth is more active than good, in others good is more active than truth. Yet in every regenerate mind, truth acts from good, or good by truth. And this constitutes the difference between the spiritual and celestial man, church, and heaven.

Jerusalem and Zion, like Arba, which is Hebron, were in the possession of the native inhabitants of Canaan when the children of Israel entered to take their inheritance. Hebron, we have seen, was in possession of the sons of Anak; and in the distribution of the land it was given to Caleb, in fulfilment of a promise which had been given him by Moses forty-five years before, that he should receive all the land on which his feet had trodden, when he went with others to spy Canaan, because he had wholly followed the Lord his God. Caleb and Joshua were the only two of those who left Egypt that entered the Holy Land, the only two who saw the beginning and the end of that eventful history that commenced with the exodus of the Israelites from Egypt, and ended with their settlement in Canaan. And these two men represented those two principles—goodness and truth—which, amidst all the changes which the mind and life experience, continue to exist, and finally prevail. These enter into and are present in all states, and form them into one, by connecting the first with the last, the beginning with the end. They therefore represent also the new will and the new understanding, which are acquired during the progress of the regenerate life.

David may be considered the Joshua of the regal period of the Israelitish history; and to him was reserved the more arduous work of wresting Jerusalem and Zion from the hands of the Jebusites.

Some difficulty has been experienced in regard to the circumstance of the blind and the lame being intrusted with the defence of the stronghold of Zion, and of David offering a reward, or making it a matter of peculiar merit and importance, to smite the lame and the blind.

Although the literal sense of the Word is written for the sake of the spiritual sense, and in some instances is made to yield to it, yet there is no wisdom in creating difficulties where none exist, and the simplest will generally be found the truest and most satisfactory way of explaining such difficulties as the Scriptures, like human writings, sometimes present. The most reasonable view of the matter appears to be, that the place was so strongly fortified, as well as so greatly favoured by nature, that the Jebusites in derision intrusted its defence to the lame and blind, and taunted David with his inability to wrest it even from their feeble hands. There is no reason to suppose that when the Jebusites perceived the nature of the enemy they had to contend with, they left the fate of their city in the hands of those they had derisively placed upon its walls. They no doubt brought their whole strength to bear upon their besiegers, and found its utmost efforts unavailing.

But whatever view may be taken of the precise meaning of the singular circumstance of the inhabitants of Jerusalem affecting to intrust the defence of their city to the most helpless members of their community, the internal spiritual sense remains the same: the fact itself is sufficient for our guidance.

The lame and the blind are the evils and falsities of our own hearts and understandings. In Scripture, where diseases of the body signify diseases of the mind, lameness, which implies partial or entire inability to walk or to work, signifies a debilitated or perverse state of the will, which prevents one from living a useful life; and blindness, because the eyes correspond to the understanding, signifies ignorance or error —which is either unintentional or wilful mental blindness.

If we consider this subject as relating to the work of human regeneration, Zion and Jerusalem, in the hands of the Jebusites, will be seen to represent the will and understanding not yet delivered from the power of evil desires and false persuasions. In David we see a type, in the highest sense, of the Lord as the Deliverer and Saviour, by whose omnipotent arm the enemies of the heart and mind are overcome, and who establishes His kingdom where that of Satan once had been. But whether we speak of the Lord or of His Divine love and truth it is the same: for the Lord is Love itself and Truth itself; and He is present in His love and truth in the minds of men, but cannot be present, as a saving power, out of or without them. Whether therefore we speak of the Lord and His power, or of His truth and its power, within us, it is the same; and in this sense and way we may consider the Lord's representative, David, in the present circumstances. The truth of the Lord has now, we may consider, laid siege to the highest thoughts and affections of the mind, the most powerful stronghold of the evils and falsities of our hereditary nature; and in the particulars of the Divine record we may find some instructive lessons as

to the nature and results of the contest. The lame and the blind are represented as the great obstacles to the reduction and possession of the city by David; and the king himself regards them as such, since he exhorts the people to get up to the gutter and smite them.

The Jebusites, as one of the seven nations who were devoted to destruction, represented one of the primary or essential evils and falsities with which no league can be made. They were like the seven devils of the New Testament which must be cast out to effect perfect purification, and like the seven spirits more wicked than himself with which the evil spirit that has gone out of a man returns, and by which the last state of that man becomes worse than his first. We are not indeed to understand that the number of such destructive evils is seven; the number seven is employed to denote the quality rather than the quantity of evils that are essentially destructive of the spiritual life, and which are therefore themselves to be cast out or destroyed. For the number seven, in its favourable sense, is expressive of what is holy, and in its opposite sense, of what is profane. Whatever is evil and false may indeed be said to be profane, and therefore the seven nations and seven evil spirits comprehend all evils and falsities. Yet there are evils and false principles which are not essentially so in relation to those who are in them, when they are the fruit of ignorance, or the indirect but unintentional results of an imperfect or erroneous faith. Such evils are not essentially profane, nor absolutely destructive of spiritual life; and these were represented by the remote nations whom the children of Israel were permitted to spare and make tributaries. The Jebusites, under their more favourable representative character, signify a false principle in which there is something of truth; and for this reason they were long permitted to remain in Jerusalem, and were never entirely expelled. In one respect the presence of some redeeming quality in that which is nevertheless essentially wrong is the means of its preservation, since evil does not appear so evil when it can present a good side, nor does falsity appear so false when it can show something of truth. The magicians of Egypt were able to deceive by simulating the miracles of Moses, so long as these miracles represented states in which there was a mixture of evil and good, as of truth and falsity; but as soon as Moses came to perform wonders which represented states of evil and falsity alone, the power of the magicians ceased. Those who are well disposed cannot be deceived and led by mere evil and falsity, but they can be seduced by those which can put on some appearance of goodness and truth.

But the Jebusites intrusted the defence of the city to their lame and blind, because these were unable to offer any serious resistance. They must therefore have represented something less essentially

opposed to the Israelites than the men of war who might have been opposed to David and his men, and who stood behind them ready to put forth their power if the necessities of the case should require it. The Lord said to the Jews, "If ye were blind, ye should have no sin: but now ye say, We see; therefore your sin remaineth." Blindness, when it signifies ignorance, is not sinful; lameness, when it signifies the want, but not the abuse of power, is not criminal. But when these are assumed, or when, as in the present instance, the blind and the lame are put forward in derision or for deception, then is the criminality greater than where there is no confession of sin, no show of humility or of impotence. The lame and the blind are therefore spoken of as being hated of David's soul, as well as pointed out for destruction. Yet it is to be observed that not these alone are mentioned as the objects of his hate and hostility. For David says, "Whosoever getteth up to the gutter, and smiteth the Jebusites, and the lame and the blind, that are hated," evidently combining them in his mind, as the enemies against whom his hatred and power were to be directed. It is added, indeed, as if these feeble opponents were the special objects of his dislike, that the Israelites therefore said, "The blind and the lame shall not come into the house." But there is some obscurity about this passage, that leaves room to doubt whether it lends any countenance to this idea. In the margin of our Bibles it is rendered differently, so as to put this expression into the mouth of the lame and blind themselves: "Because they had said, even the lame and the blind, He shall not come into the house." There is something unaccountable in the idea of the Israelites declaring, for this is not spoken by David alone, that the lame and blind should not come into the house, unless we suppose this to have been a decree made at a future period. For then there was no house of the Lord in Jerusalem. The tabernacle was not set up there till several years afterwards; nor is there any reason to suppose that any of the Jebusites would be permitted to come into the house of the Lord.

After David had taken the stronghold of Zion, he dwelt in the fort and called it the city of David, and built round about from Millo and inward. This stronghold of error had become the city of truth; and had acquired a "new name" expressive of its new quality. And what was possessed needed to be defended. The building round about from Millo and inward was no doubt the beginning at least of those magnificent edifices, both for defence and enjoyment, which afterwards called forth the Psalmist's praises of this "joy of the whole earth." "Walk about Zion, and go round about her: tell the towers thereof. Mark ye well her bulwarks, consider her palaces" (Ps. xlviii. 12, 13). The attainment of a state of holiness, and the preservation of that state when attained, are objects that should be combined in our religious life.

David had now entered on a new career, attended, as all spiritual progress is, with hindrances and trials, which are but the permitted means of calling forth mental energy, and increasing humility and trust. "David went on, and grew great, and the Lord God of hosts was with him." Those who go on in the way of truth and grow in the love of goodness have the God of love and truth with them, nay, in them; for it is He that enables them both to will and to do of His good pleasure. The Lord of hosts is with them in their spiritual conflicts. The armies that He leads forth for the aid of the faithful, are His angelic hosts and the truths of His Word. These ever act together. They are the instruments by which the Lord opposes the hosts of the enemy. These opposing hosts are in our own hearts and minds. There is the conflict, there is the victory, which cannot fail to be obtained when the Lord God of hosts is with us.

One result of David's success and greatness was that Hiram, king of Tyre, sent messengers to him with materials and workmen, and they built David a house. Hiram, who afterwards did so much to aid Solomon in the building of the temple, represented those who possess the knowledge of goodness and truth, and who thus supply the means and intelligence for building up in the mind a habitation for the Lord. David's house was such a habitation, not, indeed, like the temple, which was a type, not only of the regenerate mind, as a temple of the Holy Spirit, both of the Divine humanity of the Lord, as the temple of His Divinity; his house was a type of the mind when the Lord's truth finds in it a fixed abode. "David [therefore] perceived that the Lord had established him king over Israel, and that He had exalted his kingdom for His people Israel's sake." This stage in David's progress represents the establishment of spiritual truth as a governing principle in the regenerate mind. The spiritual state is not yet perfected; but the spiritual principle has obtained so firm a hold on the affections, that it gives the mind a joyful sense of stability and therefore of power.

Distinct though not apart from this spiritual view of the subject, David expresses an enlightened view of the purpose for which kings reign. The Lord had exalted David's kingdom for His people Israel's sake. This is the principle of the Divine government. The Lord governs for His people's sake. He desires that His kingdom should be exalted in the hearts of men, that He may rule them for their own good. He has no view to His own glory separate from their happiness.

Another result of the prosperous condition of David's kingdom is one that, naturally considered, is not so pleasing to reflect upon. "David took him more concubines and wives out of Jerusalem, after he was come from Hebron: and there were yet sons and daughters born to David." Spiritually, these additions mean an increase of

the affections of truth and goodness, and the sons and daughters born are the virtues that are produced by them. The names of the wives are not given; but the names of the sons born to David in Jerusalem are mentioned. As natural births mean spiritual births, the sons of David, like the sons of Jacob, have a representative character, and their names have a spiritual meaning. The order of their birth is also descriptive of the order in which the qualities they represent come into existence. It would perhaps be difficult accurately to explain the nature and order of the spiritual births which these sons of David represent. And yet the Divine record affords the means of forming some conception of what is involved in these successive births. Hebrew names have a meaning, although we cannot always be certain what their exact meaning is. And as, in Scripture, names are significative as well as persons and things, they serve as the means of interpretation. Let us see whether the signification of the names given to the eleven sons of David born in Jerusalem does not suggest some idea of a series of qualities that enrich the mind in the progress of the regenerate life. Shammuah, signifies hearing; Shobab, brought back (from enemies); Nathan, given (by God); Solomon, peaceable; Ibhar, whom He (God) elects; Elishua, God the rich; Nepheg, shoot, bud; Japhia, illustrious; Elishama, my God will hear, or hearken; Eliada, whom God knows, *i.e.* acknowledges and cares for; Eliphalet, God of salvation. The series begins with hearing and ends with salvation. But there is a connection of the whole, which we may attempt to trace.

The first son is named from hearing; and hearing is faith in the will, as seeing is faith in the understanding. Faith in the will, or obedience to the truth, delivers the Christian disciple from the power of his enemies, which are the evils of his own heart. So far as evil is removed, the Lord gives good, or, what is the same, charity. And when good is united to truth, or charity to faith, the Christian comes into a peaceable state, or receives of the Lord's peace. Then is he numbered with the elect; for the elect are those whom the Lord has chosen, because they have chosen Him as their teacher and guide. When the disciple has chosen the good part, he becomes rich in God, being enriched with the treasures of wisdom and knowledge; with the fear of the Lord: that is wisdom. A new state of development now begins. When the life of love flows into the mind from the Lord, as heat from the sun into a tree, it causes it to bud, and to put forth shoots. Next the buds unfold themselves in a garb of foliage, and the tree puts forth its blossoms as the promised wealth of harvest; and this is the spiritual state of being illustrious, for blossoms signify intelligence, and fruit the works of righteousness. These two states are not the beginning of the new life; for the regenerate man must, like a tree,

have attained some degree of maturity before he can have the power of reproduction. But what connection is there between this last state and that which is expressed by God hearing? A blessed and fruitful state of the Church is described by Hosea in these words: "It shall come to pass in that day, I will hear, saith the Lord, I will hear the heavens and they shall hear the earth; and the earth shall hear the corn, and the wine, and the oil; and they shall hear Jezreel. And I will sow her unto me in the earth" (ii. 21-23). The Lord hears us when all things of the mind from the highest to the lowest correspond, each answering to the other, and all in a state of agreement with Him. There are two different acts of hearing. We hear the Lord when we receive His truth into our will; He hears us when our will is in agreement with His truth. The first is reception, the second is reciprocation. When the Lord hears us, He knows us, and we also know Him. "I know My sheep, and am known of Mine. My sheep hear My voice, and I know them, and they follow Me: and I give unto them eternal life; and they shall never perish, neither shall any man pluck them out of My hand." Then truly may the Christian say, God my salvation!

There is some similarity between these eleven sons of David and the last eleven sons of Jacob.

The name of the first of these sons of David has the same signification as that of the second son of Jacob, and he has the same spiritual meaning. Reuben was Jacob's first-born, and he was named from seeing; Simeon was his second son, and he was named from hearing. The understanding sees truth, the will hears it. Now regeneration does not begin actually till truth enters the will, that is, till Simeon is born. David's sons born in Hebron were six in number, and the number six has relation to truth, and to states of truth. His sons born in Hebron may be considered, relatively to those born in Jerusalem, as Reuben was to the other sons of Jacob. It is deserving of remark that, like Reuben, some of David's first sons misconducted themselves. Amnon ravished his sister Tamar, Absalom rebelled against his father David, and Adonijah rebelled against his brother Solomon. All three died a violent death, as the result directly or remotely of their crimes. Reuben and Absalom committed the same sin: each went up unto his father's couch.

So far we may consider the sons of David and the sons of Jacob to have a relative signification. As natural signify spiritual births, the same general fact is represented by them all, differing according to the state of mind and stage of the new life in each case.

David's prosperity did not secure him against trial. Regeneration is to a considerable extent a succession of states of alternate trial and triumph, of tribulation and repose. "When the Philistines heard that they had anointed David king over Israel, all the Philistines came up

to seek David." So formidable was this array that David again betook himself to the hold. The Philistines also came and spread themselves in the valley of Rephaim, or of the giants. But David, encouraged by the Lord his God, went up against them, and defeated them. A second invasion by the same foes was followed by the same result; and David "smote the Philistines from Geba until thou come to Gazer."

Having already considered several of Israel's conflicts with the Philistines, we can the more readily leave these without particular explanation. Not that they are unimportant; but they can be more easily understood from those which have been already explained. Other events, and of a different character, claim their share of our attention.

CHAPTER IX.

THE ARK OF GOD BROUGHT INTO THE HOLY CITY.

2 Samuel vi.

THE ark of God was the most sacred of all the sacred things of the Israelitish Church. It was the consecrated receptacle of the two tables of stone, on which the ten commandments were engraven by the finger of God. That law was called the law of the covenant, because the keeping of its precepts was the condition on which rested all the promises of God to His people. That condition still remains. "If thou wilt enter into life keep the commandments." There is, however, one difference. We must keep them in the spirit as well as in the letter. But as the obligation is increased, so is the blessing of obedience enhanced. If we have a spiritual law, we have also as a reward a spiritual inheritance. As the law of God is to be engraven on our hearts, so is the kingdom of God to be within us. With the Christian "the kingdom of God is not meat and drink; but righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost." When this kingdom is set up in the heart, the Christian has his inheritance in himself; and it remains as a treasure in heaven that waxeth not old. It remains sure amidst all outward changes.

This interest that we have in the law makes everything relating to it, or related of it, interesting to us. Those treasured histories of the Old Testament respecting the ark of God, how interesting do they become to us when we know that all the singular and often affecting circumstances related of it happened for ensamples, and are written for our admonition!

In the history of the journey through the wilderness we read of the

law being delivered amidst the thunders of Sinai, and directions given for the construction of the ark, wherein the tables on which it was written were to be placed. The ark was to be of shittim wood, overlaid with pure gold within and without, to teach us that the laws of heaven have their immediate dwelling-place in the good of love, free from selfishness and self-righteousness, the heart inwardly acknowledging no merit but that of the Lord, from whom all righteousness comes. Over the ark was the mercy-seat, also of pure gold, and on the mercy-seat were the two cherubims, between which God was to meet and commune with Moses, and through him with the people. The ten commandments are a Divine summary of our duties to God and to our neighbour, and therefore contain the whole duty of man as a religious being. For this reason our Lord, while He enforced the keeping of the commandments as a condition of eternal life, raised them above the low standard of Jewish morality. He taught that the first of all the commandments is, Thou shalt love the Lord thy God above all things, and that the second is like unto it, Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself; and declared that upon these two commandments hang all the law and the prophets. Love to God and love to man, which all the commandments teach and on which they are all fulfilled, are the two cherubim that were over the mercy-seat that covered the ark containing the Divine law. The Lord meets with His people where love to God and love to man are united; and their union rests upon purity of heart and holiness of life, as the mercy-seat and the cherubim rested upon the ark of the testimony. The ark, thus containing the law and surmounted by the cherubim, was placed in the inmost of the tabernacle, to remind us that the Divine law is to be placed in the inmost of the heart and mind.

The ark henceforward became the centre round which the Levites congregated and the congregation encamped. It was carried before them in their journeyings, and returned with them into their rest. It divided the Jordan and overthrew the walls of Jericho. For when the Divine law is in the heart, it has power to remove all obstacles that self-love and love of the world offer to our progress in the spiritual life.

But a time came when the children of Israel no longer possessed the ark as a means of protection and blessing. Under the priesthood of Eli there was war with the Philistines, and Israel was overcome. In their distress and perplexity the elders caused the ark to be brought into the camp, and Israel shouted with a great shout, so that the earth rang again. But this was not the shout of holy trust and confidence in God. Their priestly leaders were shamelessly corrupt, and they themselves had apostatized to the worship of Ashtaroth, the queen of heaven, a name and title of the moon, as Baal was of the sun. There can be no real confidence in God when there

is iniquity in the midst, such as was now the case with the children of Israel. In their next encounter with the Philistines, the Israelites were smitten, and the ark of God was taken. The ark was carried as a trophy into the country of the Philistines. But if the presence of evil in the good hinders the very ark of God from protecting or delivering them, what must its effect be upon the evil themselves? It is the means of their destruction. "This is the condemnation, that light is come into the world, and men loved darkness rather than light, because their deeds were evil." And it may be said of the tables of the law, as it is said of the Lord Himself, who was that very law, "whosoever shall fall on this stone shall be broken: but on whomsoever it shall fall, it will grind him to powder." The ark soon showed its power against its unbelieving possessors. Dagon fell down in pieces before it. The inhabitants of Ashdod were destroyed and smitten with disease. The diviners were called, and advised that the ark should be sent with an offering back into the land of Israel. Two milch kine were tied to a cart, on which the ark, and the coffer containing the golden mice and images of their emerods, were placed; and the kine took the straight way to Beth-shemesh, a city of Judah. This was no doubt done in accordance with the law of correspondence, the remains of which still continued among the Philistines. The ark was placed upon a new cart, because a new cart signifies doctrine undefiled by evil and falsity; the cart was drawn by milch kine on which no yoke had come, because they signified good natural affections which have not been brought under servitude to false persuasions. The kine spontaneously took the way to Beth-shemesh, to indicate that uncorrupted natural affection inclines to the truth which leads to spiritual goodness, or goodness having a spiritual origin. The men of Beth-shemesh clave the wood of the cart, and offered up the kine a burnt-offering unto the Lord; for this act implied the dedication to the Lord of the true thoughts and good affections of the natural mind, by which they become spiritual and saving.

But the men of Beth-shemesh themselves brought evil upon many of the people by an act of irreverence of which they were guilty. They looked into the ark, and the Lord smote of the people fifty thousand and threescore and ten men. Such an act seems in itself but a venial sin, and under a spiritual dispensation might not be regarded as a sin at all. But that to which the men of Beth-shemesh belonged was a representative Church, in which everything was typical. An act done from an idly curious or with a profane eye, an act which, with the deepest reverence, could be lawful for none but for the priest only, brought upon them a destruction which, like the act itself, was representative. To seek to penetrate into the inmost of the Holy Word, and see its hidden wisdom, with an understanding

unsanctified by the Spirit of truth, and a heart uninfluenced by the love of good, is destructive of spiritual life.

Terrified by this destruction, the Beth-shemites sent to the men of Kirjath-jearim, who came and fetched the ark, and brought it into the house of Abinadab in the hill, and sanctified Eleazar his son to keep the ark of the Lord. "And it came to pass, while the ark abode in Kirjath-jearim, that the time was long; for it was twenty years: and all the house of Israel lamented after the Lord." There the ark remained till the time of David. One of the first acts of his reign was to bring it up out of its obscure place in Gibeah, and set it in his place, in the midst of the tabernacle he had pitched for it in Jerusalem. The account of this translation of the ark is that which we are now to consider.

David, with thirty thousand of the chosen men of Israel, went to bring up the ark of God from the house of Abinadab. When they had placed it upon a new cart, they set out with it, accompanied by two sons of Abinadab, Uzzah and Ahio, playing upon all manner of instruments. When, however, they came to Nachon's threshing-floor, the oxen shook the ark, and Uzzah put forth his hand and took hold of it: and for this rash act, the Lord's anger was kindled against him, and He smote him there, that he died by the ark. David's fear for the Lord was so great, that instead of removing the ark to his own city, he carried it aside into the house of Obed-edom the Gittite, where it remained for three months. Hearing that the Lord had blessed the house of Obed-edom because of the ark, he brought it up with great sacrificings and rejoicings to the city of David.

This removal of the ark by successive stages, or from one place to another, is representative of the successive elevation of the Divine law of love and truth in the mind, which takes place during the progress of the regenerate life. Three places are mentioned in which the ark rested. The first two were its temporary abode, the last was its fixed and proper dwelling-place. These three places, and the resting of the ark in them, and its removal from one to the other, represented the three states through which the regenerate pass in their upward progress to the kingdom of heaven. For every one who is fully regenerated is first natural, afterwards spiritual, and lastly celestial. To express it more strictly, man is regenerated first as to the natural degree of his mind, then as to the spiritual, and finally as to the celestial. And these degrees of the mind are signified by the house of Abinadab, the house of Obed-edom, and the city of David. In this view of the subject the account of the removal of the ark to its final resting-place in Zion describes representatively the work of regeneration from its beginning to its end, in those who attain to the highest degree of religious perfection. It may seem therefore to have but little interest

for any others than those who have reached this elevated state. There is, however, in every particular stage a resemblance of the whole. And in this way the relation may be applied by every one to his own state. The ark of God, as a symbol of the Divine law of love and charity, experiences a progressive elevation in every regenerate mind analogous to that which it has in those who reach the purest condition of celestial life. The Divine law, in every regenerate one, is successively raised out of the memory into the understanding, and out of the understanding into the will. The first two are but the temporary abode of the law, the will is its final and permanent dwelling-place. The imperfectness of the previous state is marked by the act of Uzzah. His putting forth his hand to prevent the ark from falling to the ground, points to that state of the mind when man acts under the influence of the feeling or persuasion that he is able to keep the law by his own power, or support or vindicate it by his own wisdom.

The removal of the ark by successive stages representing the successive elevation of the Divine law in the regenerate mind, there are some particulars of the history respecting it which deserve our attention.

David and those who were with him played before the Lord while removing the ark both from its first and from its second resting-place. As music is expressive of affection, the various instruments mentioned signify the various affections of the mind, the harmonious delights of which produce that which may be called the music of the soul—the sense of peace with God and goodwill to men. This is the true music of the spheres, and fills heaven itself with sweetest harmony. The instruments on which they played on their way from the house of Abinadab signified the gladness of the mind resulting from the natural and spiritual affections of truth. The dancing of David, with the sound of a trumpet, on their way from the house of Obed-edom to Zion, signified joy of heart resulting from the affections of spiritual and celestial good.

While on the way to Zion, and after he brought the ark into it, David sacrificed to the Lord, to represent the dedication to Him of all the principles and faculties of the mind, this being true worship. He blessed the people, and dealt among the whole multitude of Israel, as well to the women as men, to every one a cake of bread, and a good piece of flesh, and a flagon of wine. The people, the multitude of Israel, represented the common affections—the women the affections of good, the men the affections of truth. The bread, flesh, and wine given them are the spiritual and celestial good and truth, by which, as their proper food, they are sustained and delighted. But when these general feasts are spoken of, the mutual satisfaction and delight of all the affections of the mind are understood. Satisfaction and joy that

fill the whole mind are the feast of the soul, and that which was represented by the feasts of which we read so often in the Sacred Word.

The introduction of the ark into Zion after all its wanderings in the wilderness, its capture by the Philistines, its abode in the houses of Abinadab and Obed-edom, was no doubt the greatest and most joyous event connected with that sacred symbol that took place previous to its introduction into the temple of Solomon. Representing the completed work of regeneration, the event is fraught with matter of the most important significance. And although we may not be able to enter into it as a subject which is realized in our own experience as a whole, yet it may have found its fulfilment in some particulars of our spiritual life. Every single truth, as a part of the Divine law, is an image of the whole; and every single truth that passes out of the memory into the understanding, and out of the understanding into the will, and again from the will into act, performs a circle that is an image of the greater. And every truth that thus completes the circle of life becomes a part of our eternal inheritance. It has attained its place in the inmost of the mind, and will, if we remain faithful, continue there for ever.

In the highest sense this event represents the completed work of the Lord's glorification, as the origin and pattern of our regeneration. And in connecting these two in our minds, we may find more abundant reason for rejoicing. Connected together as cause and effect, the one sheds light upon the other, for in the higher we see the lower in its cause and pattern, in the lower we see the higher in its effect and image. To that Divine work in the Lord we trace every saving work that can be effected in ourselves. And when we reflect that the Lord came into the world, and went down into Egypt, and passed through the temptations of the wilderness, and overthrew the works of the devil, and finally entered into His glory, only that He might deliver us from bondage, and lead us to victory, and raise us into spiritual power and happiness, we must indeed be desirous to connect these works together, not only in our reflections but in our experience. As subjects in which we have a deep interest, we may profitably enter into them with the earnest and jubilant feelings which the records and images of them are intended to express and inspire. The entrance of the ark of God into the city of David is generally, and we have no doubt justly, considered to be the theme of that sublime psalm which the Church usually chants in celebrating the Lord's ascension. The 24th Psalm is written in the responsive form, and is supposed to have been sung when the holy ark arrived at the gates of the Holy City, David and the multitude without, and the priests, the Levites, and the people within, singing in responsive strains, "Lift up your heads, O

ye gates; and be ye lift up, ye everlasting doors; and the King of glory shall come in. Who is this King of glory? The Lord strong and mighty, the Lord mighty in battle. Lift up your heads, O ye gates; even lift them up, ye everlasting doors; and the King of glory shall come in. Who is this King of glory? The Lord of hosts, He is the King of glory."

Looking at the Lord in His ascension as one who has gone before us—as that one who, having been lifted up from the earth, will draw all men unto Him, we may make a practical application of the subject in the responsive words of the same psalm. "Who shall ascend into the hill of the Lord? or who shall stand in His holy place? He that hath clean hands, and a pure heart; who hath not lifted up his soul unto vanity, nor sworn deceitfully. He shall receive the blessing from the Lord, and righteousness from the God of his salvation."

When David had concluded the service in the tabernacle which he had set up for the sacred ark, he went to bless his household. But he met with a singularly unkind reception. "Michal the daughter of Saul came out to meet David, and said, How glorious was the king of Israel to day, who uncovered himself to day in the eyes of the handmaids of his servants, as one of the vain fellows shamelessly uncovereth himself!" This reproachful speech drew from David the only severe expressions he ever addressed to any one of the house of Saul. "David said unto Michal, It was before the Lord, which chose me before thy father, and before all his house, to appoint me ruler over the people of the Lord, over Israel: therefore will I play before the Lord. And I will yet be more vile than thus, and will be base in mine own sight: and of the maid-servants which thou hast spoken of, of them shall I be had in honour." In speaking of Michal, I have said that she represented rather a natural than a spiritual affection. She seems to have had little sympathy with David in his holy work of bringing up the ark, and raising the law into its rightful position, though not into its final dwelling-place. So far as Michal represents the Church, she represents it in its Judaizing rather than in its Christian aspect, like those early disciples who wished to unite the law and the gospel, by placing the Jewish ceremonials on a level with Christian rites, making the law of ordinances as necessary for salvation as the law of life. The natural affection, however firmly it may adhere to the law, does not delight in it; and it was to the gestures expressive of delight that Michal objected in David's conduct. Especially does the natural affection object to see the spiritual uncovered, which was the highest of David's offences against dignity and propriety in the eyes of his wife. The conduct of Michal is no doubt to be understood as having brought a Divine judgment upon her. She had no child to the day of her death. This implies, when spiritually regarded, that between

David and Michal there was no true marriage. "Children are an heritage of the Lord: and the fruit of the womb is His reward" (Ps. cxxvii. 3). When spiritually He makes women childless, it is because there is a want of harmony between the natural mind and the spiritual, whose union is necessary to give birth to the virtues of the religious life. When natural affection is not in unison with spiritual truth, there can be no such union between them as to make the life fruitful. And if that state of affection remains, Michal, who might have been a joyful mother of children, shall have no child till the day of her death.

CHAPTER X.

DAVID DESIRES BUT IS FORBIDDEN TO BUILD A HOUSE FOR THE ARK OF THE LORD TO DWELL IN.

2 Samuel vii.

THE scene which the sacred historian now presents to us is the peaceful one of David sitting in his house with Nathan the prophet. The Lord had given him rest round about from all his enemies. Regarding the glory of God more than his own splendour, he says to Nathan, "See now, I dwell in an house of cedar, and the ark of God dwelleth within curtains." It would be a very low idea of this sentiment to transfer it literally to ourselves, and regard it as a reproof of our own not uncommon practice, of surrounding ourselves with elegance and comfort, and leaving the house of God with but scant provision of either. But if we did apply his words in this way, we should receive but small encouragement from the sequel of David's zealous plea for the honour of his God. The prophet, indeed, sympathized with David's sentiment, and entered warmly into his idea. "Nathan said to the king, Go, do all that is in thine heart; for the Lord is with thee." But both prophet and king had resolved without asking counsel of Him whom they desired to honour. "It came to pass that night, that the word of the Lord came unto Nathan, saying, Go and tell My servant David, Thus saith the Lord, Shalt thou build Me an house for Me to dwell in?" Since the Lord brought the children of Israel out of Egypt, He had walked in a tent and in a tabernacle, and had asked none of the tribes or judges, "Why build ye not Me an house of cedar?" He had taken David from the sheepcote to make him a ruler over His people Israel; He had been with him withersoever he went; He had cut off all his enemies; He had made him a great name. Moreover, He would appoint a place for His people Israel, which they would dwell in, and move no more, neither be afflicted any

more by the children of wickedness: He would also build David a house. Notwithstanding all this, not he, but his son that should reign after him would build a house for the Lord to dwell in.

In all that the Lord says to Nathan, no reason is given why the temple was not to be built by David but by Solomon. The reason is made known when the temple is about to be built. Here we may say that, as the temple represented the glorified humanity, it was to be built by the king by whom that humanity was represented. Our principal object here is to notice some of the particulars of the present narrative.

If David represented the Lord, how are we to understand his ignorance of the Divine will in regard to the building of a house to His name? In the Gospel history there is the appearance, at least, of the Lord being ignorant of some things. We need not stop to consider the instances in which the Lord marvels, and makes inquiries. He who needed not that any should testify of man, for He knew what was in man, and who gave so many evidences of knowing persons and events at a distance, could not be really ignorant of persons and circumstances near at hand. There is, however, one instance in which the Lord Himself makes confession of His ignorance. Of His own second coming He says, "Of that day and that hour knoweth no man, no, not the angels who are in heaven, neither the Son, but the Father" (Mark xiii. 32). We might take this statement in all its literalness, if Jesus were a mere man, or even the first created intelligence. But if we admit His Divinity, it is impossible to understand it in its merely literal sense. For even if we believed Him to be a Divine person distinct from His Father, it could make no difference, since the Three Persons of the Godhead have all equal Divinity. But when we understand the distinction in the Godhead to be that of Essentials, we can see the ground of our Lord's declaration. The Father is the Divine love, the Son is the Divine wisdom. Now the first Christian Church or dispensation is called the kingdom of the Son, and the second is called the kingdom of the Father. Thus St. Paul speaks of the end, when the Son shall deliver up the kingdom to the Father; when the Son also Himself shall be subject to the Father, that God may be all in all (1 Cor. xv. 28). This is commonly explained as relating to what is called the Lord's mediatorial kingdom, which the Son is to resign at the end of the world, when His intercession for sinners shall no more be required. But what of the Son being subject to the Father? There is a dogmatic answer, but it is unnecessary to consider it. Thankful we may be that we are delivered from all this perplexity. Clear and beautiful is the truth, that the kingdom of the Son is the Church and the member of the Church as governed by Divine wisdom or truth, and that the kingdom of the

Father is the Church and the member of the Church as governed by Divine love. The kingdom of the Son must of necessity precede the kingdom of the Father. Truth must reign till all things are put under its feet; till all rebellious thoughts and affections are subdued, and made subject to Christ. But when all enemies, or all enmities, are put under the power of the truth of God, then His truth gives up the kingdom to His love, which enters on its peaceful reign. Even truth itself becomes subject to love; for faith becomes secondary and subordinate to charity, truth to goodness, the understanding to the will. Love is the fulfilling of the law. Against love there is no law. He who has love is not under the law. The law has done its work. It has put all things under its feet; and it has resigned the kingdom to love, and is itself subject to its beneficent rule.

How plain is the analogy in this case to the reign of David and that of Solomon. David was a man of war; Solomon was a man of peace. Yet Solomon owed his peaceful reign to the warlike reign of David. The Lord put all the enemies of Israel under David's feet; and when all the enemies of Israel were conquered, a reign of peace followed as its natural sequence. But all this does not reveal the cause or explain the fact of the Son not knowing the day and hour of visitation and of His future coming; or David's mistaken zeal for the Lord's house. The Lord's ignorance of the day and hour of His coming was not absolute but relative. Nothing could be hid from His infinite wisdom; but His wisdom does not reveal His love except to those who receive it. Time is the symbol of state. A state of love is unknown to those who are in a state of truth. Every state reveals itself to those who enter it. In a lower state we may know that a higher exists; but what that state is in itself, we can only know by experience. We know that the reign of law is to be followed by the reign of love, but what that love is, love only knows and can reveal. We may, like David, desire and even attempt to anticipate it; but the Divine command is, to refrain. A new birth is to take place before this work can be performed, this new house built. "When thy days be fulfilled, and thou shalt sleep with thy fathers, I will set up thy seed after thee, which shall proceed out of thy bowels, and I will establish his kingdom. He shall build an house for My name, and I will stablish the throne of his kingdom for ever." The two kingdoms, the spiritual and the celestial, of which heaven consists, and which were also represented by the kingdom of David and Solomon, are so distinct, that the wisdom of the angels of the higher kingdom transcends the apprehension of the angels of the lower; nor can any enter into celestial wisdom until they attain the celestial state. The new name in the white stone no man knoweth save he that receiveth it.

Such is the Divine mode of teaching us that every state of life or

stage of regeneration has its own duties, its own work, and its own kind and measure of knowledge. And as it is with individuals, so it is with dispensations. One passes into another, and yet so distinct are they in character, that one can neither know nor do what belongs to the state and uses of its successor.

When Nathan delivered the Divine message to David, then went in king David, and sat before the Lord ; and, with profound humility and deep gratitude, poured out his heart before Him. Adoring the Lord God, besides whom there is no God, who had redeemed Israel for Himself, from the nations and their gods, he praises Him for the good which He had spoken concerning His servant, and for His gracious promise that He would establish his house for ever.

Whether we regard David as a type of the Saviour or of the saint, and his prayer as expressive of the Lord's aspirations to the Father or of the saint's pious adorations of his Saviour, we may learn a great lesson. The states of humiliation through which the Lord passed during the days in which He carried our frail nature, teach us lessons of profound wisdom. They tell us, so far as we can comprehend them, what the Lord endured and did for our sake, and also what we must endure and do for His : with this important difference, that all He did was for our benefit, while all we are required to do is for our own. For His sake, indeed, our works, both of passion and of action, must be done, for the end sanctifies the deed. Our works are good only when the Lord is in them as their end and cause, when His love prompts and His wisdom guides us. Self-abnegation must lie at the root of our self-denial as well as of our active duties. For it is possible to practise self-denial for the sake of self, as well as do good deeds for the sake of reward. Self-abnegation is a high state to attain, and can only be reached by patience and perseverance. But not only have we the example of our blessed Lord before us, we have His Spirit with us—that of which it is said, " The Holy Spirit was not yet given ; because that Jesus was not yet glorified" (John vii. 39). The Spirit of Jesus differs from the Spirit of Jehovah. The Spirit of Jehovah was rather a creative than a regenerative Spirit. The Spirit of Jesus is the Spirit and power of all that He accomplished in the world; it is the Spirit of Jehovah in His Divine humanity, and it therefore conveys to those who receive it the power to become, by regeneration, images of what the Lord has become by glorification.

CHAPTER XI.

NATIONS OUT OF CANAAN CONQUERED AND MADE TRIBUTARY.

2 Samuel viii.

THE rest which the Lord had given David from all his enemies round about he did not long enjoy. About two years after he had taken Jerusalem we find him engaged in war with several different nations. The first of these are the irrepressible Philistines, whom David subdues, and from whom he takes Metheg-ammah, an important town in Gath, which, from its commanding position, was called the bridle of the mother city. A blow was thus struck at the metropolis of Philistia. Like one of the heads of the Apocalyptic beast, it was wounded to death, but like it also its death-wound was healed; for although subdued, the Philistines were not yet wholly vanquished.

After recording this subjugation of the Philistines, the chapter is occupied in relating the wars which David carried into some of the nations beyond the borders of Canaan, which he not only conquered but made tributary. And this leads us to consider a distinction which the Israelites were commanded to make between the Canaanitish nations and those whose countries bordered upon Canaan, but were separate from it.

The seven nations inhabiting Canaan were to be utterly destroyed, but the nations beyond Canaan, unless they resisted, were only to be subdued and made tributary. In Deuteronomy (chap. xx.) this is clearly stated: "When thou comest nigh unto a city to fight against it, then proclaim peace unto it. And it shall be, if it make thee answer of peace, and open unto thee, then it shall be, that all the people that is found therein shall be tributaries unto thee, and they shall serve thee. . . . Thus shalt thou do unto all the cities which are very far off from thee, which are not of the cities of these nations. But of the cities of these people, which the Lord thy God doth give thee for an inheritance, thou shalt save alive nothing that breatheth."

The nations of Canaan represented evil loves and false persuasions that are essentially opposed to everything good and true, and which can neither be reconciled nor made subservient to right principles. But the nations out of Canaan represented affections and persuasions that are indeed remote from goodness and truth, but are not essentially opposed to them, and can therefore be made tributary to them, and serve them. On this interesting and important subject the Writings throw a clear light, as the following quotation will show. Though the

author's remarks refer directly to another subject, they are quite applicable to this.

"Evils with man are of various kinds; there are evils with which good cannot be mixed, and there are evils with which good can be mixed; the case is the same with falsities; and unless it was so, it would be impossible for any man to be regenerated. The evils and falsities with which goods and truths cannot be mixed, are such as are contrary to love to God and to love towards our neighbour. For example; if any one loves himself in preference to others, and under the influence of that love studies to excel others in moral and civil life, in scientifics and doctrinals, and to be exalted to dignities and likewise to opulence above others, and yet acknowledges and adores God, performs from his heart duties towards his neighbour, and does from conscience what is just and equitable, the evil of that self-love is such as to admit good and truth to be mixed with it; for it is the evil which is proper to man, and is hereditarily born with him; and suddenly to take it away from him would be to extinguish the fire of his first life. But if any one love himself in preference to others, and under the influence of that love despises others in comparison with himself, hates those who do not honour, and, as it were, adore him, and therefore feels the delight of hatred in revenge and cruelty, the evil of his love is such as not to admit of good and truth being mixed with it, for they are contraries. Again: if any one believe himself to be pure from sins, and cleansed like a person cleansed of filth by washing in water, when he has once done the work of repentance, and discharged the duties which he has imposed upon himself by repentance, or after confession has been told by his confessor that he is so cleansed, or after he has been a partaker of the Holy Supper; in case such a one lives a new life, in the affection of what is good and true, this false principle is such as to admit of good being mixed with it; but in case he lives a worldly and carnal life, as heretofore, the false is then such as not to admit of good being mixed with it. So again; he who believes that man is saved by virtue of believing what is good, and not by virtue of willing what is good, and nevertheless wills what is good, and in consequence thereof does what is good, this false principle is such as to admit of good and truth being adjoined to it; but not so in case he does not will and thence do what is good. Again, if any one be ignorant that man rises again after death, and in consequence thereof does not believe in the resurrection, or if he be acquainted with the resurrection, and still doubts and almost denies it, and yet lives in truth and good, this false principle also is such as to be admissive of good and truth being mixed with it; but if such a person lives in what is false and evil, the false in this case is admissive of no such mixture, because of contrariety, and the false destroys the true, and the evil the

good. Further, pretence and cunning, which have good for their end, whether it be the good of the neighbour, or of a man's country, or of the Church, are prudence, and the evils thereto admixed may be mixed with good from and for the sake of the end proposed; but pretence and cunning, which have evil for their end, are not prudence, but are artifice and deceit, with which good can in no wise be conjoined, for deceit, which has evil for its end, induces an infernal principle in all things in man, and places evil in the midst, and rejects good to the circumference, which order is essentially infernal. The case is similar in numberless other instances. That there are evils and falsities, to which goods and truths can be adjoined, may appear from the fact, that there are so many diverse dogmas and doctrinals, several of which are altogether heretical, and yet in every one of them salvation is attainable; and also from this, that among the Gentiles who are out of the Church, there is likewise a Church of the Lord, and that although they are in false persuasions, still such as live a life of charity are saved, which could not possibly be the case, unless there were evils which can be mixed with goods, and falsities which can be mixed with truths. Evils which are mixed with goods, and falsities with truths, are wonderfully arranged in order by the Lord, for they are not conjoined, still less are they united, but they are adjoined and applied, and this in such a sort, that goods with truths are in the midst, as in a centre, whilst such evils and falsities are by gradations as the circuits or circumferences, in consequence of which the latter are illustrated by the former, and are variegated like black and white by the light proceeding from the midst or centre. This is heavenly order."

The nations whom David subdued at this time were the Moabites, the Syrians, and the Edomites. David garrisoned their cities, and they became his servants. Two of them are mentioned as having brought gifts, but the other was no doubt also made tributary. Besides these gifts, which were compulsory, the king of Hamath sent him vessels of gold and silver and brass. These did David "dedicate unto the Lord, with the silver and gold that he had dedicated of all nations which he subdued; of Syria, and of Moab, and of the children of Ammon, and of the Philistines, and of Amalek, and of the spoil of Hadadezer, son of Rehob, king of Zobah." The reduction of these nations to a state of vassalage, is a type of the subjection of the natural man to the authority of the spiritual; and the dedication of their gifts or their spoil to the Lord, is representative of the sanctification of the possessions of the natural man, by devoting to spiritual uses and eternal ends what had hitherto been employed for natural uses and temporal ends. As the silver and gold, of which the Israelites spoiled the Egyptians, came to be dedicated to the Lord in the construction

and adorning of the tabernacle, the treasures which David obtained from the nations helped to adorn and enrich the temple. But as both the tabernacle and the temple represented, not only the Lord's Humanity, but His Church, and not the general Church only, but the Church as built up and established in the individual mind, we learn from this turning of the spoils and gifts of the nations from profane to sacred uses, the duty of turning all our natural acquisitions, whether they be intellectual or material, into means for promoting the glory of God. This does not imply that they are to be devoted to what are commonly called religious purposes, but that they are to be brought under the government of religious principles, and so employed as to promote the glory of God, by ministering to the best interests of ourselves, and of our neighbour. That which is made to serve the love and truth of God in us, is, in the best sense, dedicated to the Lord, for it is applied to uses that build us up into temples of His presence.

The gifts themselves are various; but they are spoken of, in the present case, as consisting of gold, silver, and brass; and these, as sent by the king of Hamath, were in the form of vessels. We have had occasion, more than once, to speak of these receptacles as symbols of what we have called scientifics, that is to say, facts, as distinguished from the conclusions we draw from them, or the wisdom they teach us. Every one recognises the difference between knowledge and wisdom. But we have a better instance in the difference between science and religion. Nor do we need to confine ourselves in this case to natural science. A man may be eminent in religious science and yet have no religion. In regard to natural science, we know that it can be a means of confirming men either in the belief or in the denial of a creative Intelligence. By the believer "the invisible things of Him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are made, even His eternal power and Godhead" (Rom. i. 20). To the unbeliever, invisible things are assumed to have no existence, and the visible are considered to account for their own existence, and to show that they are able to take care of themselves. It is essential that men should not be forced to believe, therefore God does not reveal Himself to sense, but to reason. It is a less evil to disbelieve from choice than it would be to believe from compulsion. Natural science, therefore, leaves men free. But it does not leave them blameless. That is to say, scientific denial is deeper and more deadly than simple negation. Science creates neither belief nor unbelief, but it confirms the mind more deeply in either. The more deeply the natural man penetrates into the secrets of nature the nearer he believes he is to the origin of life. What he calls the origin of life the spiritual man calls its beginning, the origin of which is in Him who is Life itself, from whom all things are and

live. Scientifics, in fact, are vessels, which men may replenish either from the true vine or from the vine of Sodom and the clusters of Gomorrah, and out of which they may drink either to the true God or to idols—the molten images of their self-love or the graven images of their self-intelligence.

But, on this subject, we must let the light of Revelation in upon ourselves. There, if we have entered on the regenerate life, we shall see what is here described representatively in the history of the Israelites. We shall see the spiritual mind and the natural mind in their true character. In the natural mind we shall find evils that are in their very nature opposed to spiritual truth and goodness; while there are others, some of which may be called infirmities, which can be brought under subjection to spiritual principles, and be made to serve some useful spiritual purpose, the acquirements of the natural man contributing to the perfection of the spiritual. Let us see, then, what these different nations represent.

Moab, the first of these nations that David subdued, was descended from Lot's son by his eldest daughter. In treating of the Ammonites, the descendants of the son of Lot's younger daughter, who were the first to feel Saul's kingly power, we have seen that Moab and Ammon represented the profanation of goodness and truth. Yet they did not represent that degree of profanation which is unpardonable, because unremovable. A Moabite or an Ammonite was not absolutely excluded from the congregation of Israel, but was not allowed to enter until the tenth generation (Deut. xxiii. 3), which implies that the profanation they represented did not necessarily destroy all remains of goodness and truth, but might leave a rudiment, from which a new and spiritual state could be commenced. David's treatment of the Moabites on this occasion teaches something of the same kind. They were subdued and severely treated, but not exterminated. "He smote Moab, and measured them with a line, casting them down to the ground; even with two lines measured he to put to death, and with one full line to keep alive." Dreadful work! And yet apologists tell us, and no doubt tell us truly, that the treatment of the Moabites, as compared with that of conquered nations in those times, was humane. By the law of nations, and even by the law of Moses, the whole of the Moabites had forfeited their lives by their opposition or resistance; and David showed his clemency by saving some. It reminds us of the Calvinistic vindication of the character of God in the decree of election. The whole race by their sins had incurred the sentence of eternal damnation, and God showed His mercy by saving a few. The truth is, the Jews were a barbarous race, and enjoyed the delight of all barbarous nations in shedding blood. They were not chosen because they were better than other nations, but because they were

better adapted to perform a use which concerned the welfare of the human race. Their great use in the Divine economy was to receive and preserve the oracles of God, and to keep alive, however imperfectly, the faith and worship of the one true God. Their barbarism made them fit instruments for rooting out hopelessly corrupt nations, and their facile piety made them the means of keeping the embers of religion from altogether dying out. They served therefore to preserve the spiritual connection between heaven and earth, on which the salvation and even the preservation of the human race depends; and they could perform acts which represented higher things than they either thought or intended.

Regarding David's treatment of the Moabites, there is some difficulty in understanding the nature of the operation by which the fate of the vanquished was decided. German critics make the text to mean, that David subdued Moab, and then made the whole people lie down on the ground, and measured them with a measuring-line, destining two measures to death, and one measure to life. In other words, instead of exterminating the whole brood, he decimated them, as it were, by a kind of lot, and left it to apparent chance whether any given Moabites were to be slain, or spared. Josephus, however (Jewish Wars, vii. 5), has not so taken it; possibly he was willing to spare David's humanity. Just as the Chronicles omit this incident. On the other hand J. D. Michaelis, in his treatise on the Mosaic Law, declares that David was much more merciful than the Mosaic Law if he only killed two-thirds of them.

Whatever the precise nature of the operation may have been, the general conclusion seems to be, that two-thirds were in this way devoted to death, and one-third kept alive. Whatever obscurity there may be respecting the application of the measuring-line and its results, the terms are sufficiently precise to enable us to see the spiritual lesson intended to be conveyed by the circumstances. To measure is to ascertain or estimate the quality of a thing. A mystic man with a measuring-line measured the temple (Ezek. xl.), and also Jerusalem (Zech. ii. 2), and John was commanded to measure the temple of God and them that worship therein (Rev. xi. 1); in all which cases, to measure evidently means to discover, or rather to show, the quality or state of the Church. The measuring-line applied to the spiritual Moabites is not, therefore, a measure merely to decide their fate, but a measure to ascertain or express their character. With two lines David measured to put to death, and with one full line, literally, with the fulness of the line, to keep alive. All the Moabites were cast down upon the ground, to represent, that those who live profanely are all equally natural and earthly; but they were measured with different lines, to show that they are not all equally guilty; that even with them

"there is a sin unto death, and there is a sin not unto death" (1 John v. 16, 17). Those who were measured with two lines typified those who live profanely from the will with the full consent of the understanding; while those who were measured with one line represented those who live profanely from one of these two active powers of the mind, but not from both. This subject may be illustrated by one of the laws of Moses. One of the rules of evidence laid down in the Mosaic code was this: "At the mouth of two witnesses, or three witnesses, shall he that is worthy of death be put to death; but at the mouth of one witness he shall not be put to death" (Deut. xvii. 6). This law, spiritually interpreted, teaches this important, and at the same time hopeful truth. When the will and the understanding, or when the will, the understanding, and the outward life, bear united witness against us; at the mouth of these two or three witnesses, we bring upon ourselves the sentence of eternal death. But when one of these only witnesses against us, we, of the Divine mercy, are kept alive. Some sin from natural depravity, hardly knowing what sin is and what are its consequences; some sin from education and habit, as those who have been brought up to crime, as skilled workmen in a not dishonourable but rather dangerous trade. It is not to be supposed that either of these is in a state of innocence. But they come within this saving condition: Natural depravity of the will may not have deeply corrupted the understanding, and misdirection of the understanding may not have deeply corrupted the will. Indeed, we can hardly speak of will and understanding with respect to such persons; for will is nothing without understanding, and understanding is nothing without will. Such persons form a kind of fictitious will and understanding in a lower region of the mind, leaving the true faculties to a great extent undeveloped, and the capacity of being reformed and regenerated, though seriously injured, yet not undestroyed. This is not, of course, the case with all even of the criminal class; but it is no doubt true of some. Indeed, the Moabite, in the better aspect of his character, represents one possessed of some natural goodness, which makes him the easy dupe of the designing, to whom he has not the courage to say no.

There are, however, others besides such characters, to whom, as spiritual Moabites, these lines may be applied. The law which required at least two witnesses to put to death, was delivered with immediate reference to the man or the woman who "hath gone and served other gods, and worshipped them, either the sun, or moon, or any of the host of heaven." Scripture does not say that Moab worshipped the heavenly bodies, unless the Moabitish god Chemosh, who is said to have been worshipped under the form of a black star, may be considered to belong to the host of heaven; but the Mosaic

law included all kinds of idolatry. And the worship of God was an exalted virtue and idolatry a deep crime, because the idea of God enters into all our worship, which comprehensively means all our religion. In profane worship there may be the concurrence of the will and the understanding; or one may be involved without the other. A gross idolater may be sincerely devout. While his understanding is corrupted, his heart may be sound. He will be measured by one full line to be kept alive. When the heart is idolatrous as well as the understanding, then will the false worshipper be measured by two lines to be put to death. But there is an inward as well as an outward idolatry. Yet even here the line of life may be found to apply. Only when the concurrent testimony of the two inward witnesses is against the idolater, will he be measured with two lines to be put to death. A hopeful doctrine this when we apply it to others; a solemn one when we apply it to ourselves.

After Moab, David "smote Hadadezer, the son of Rehob, king of Zobah, as he went to recover his border at the river Euphrates." From him David took many thousand chariots, and horsemen, and footmen. And when the Syrians of Damascus came to succour Hadadezer, David slew of the Syrians twenty-two thousand. Zobah was in Syria, so that here was one and the principal of the Syrian princes supporting another. Syria, in its best days, when the second ancient or Hebrew Church was there, signified the knowledge of good, as Syria of rivers signified the knowledge of truth. In the time of Abraham, when he was called out of Ur of the Chaldees, which was in Syria, it had sunk into idolatry, and had therefore corrupted the truth which it once possessed. Syria is thus the intellectual principle, answering to Moab, which has relation to the will. The intellectual character of the Syrians is indicated by their chariots and horsemen, which are symbols of doctrine and intelligence, false it may be.

When David had subdued and made tributary the Syrians of Zobah and Damascus, a third Syrian king, Toi, sent his son to bless David, because he had fought against Hadadezer, and smitten him, because that Hadadezer had wars with Toi. Wars take place in the rational mind itself, which Syria, under one view, signifies, as when one intellectual nation conflicts with another. We have seen that one evil may serve to hold another in check, but cannot remove it. Neither the rational nor the natural mind has the power to reform itself. This can only be done by the spiritual mind. So David ended the wars between the two Syrian kings; and, while he forced one into submission, led the other to send a friendly message with rich gifts.

One other nation David subdued. "He put garrisons in Edom; throughout all Edom put he garrisons, and all they of Edom became his servants." The Edomites, the descendants of Esau, had, like the

other nations, degenerated. Therefore, from representing the good of the natural mind, they had come to represent the natural mind under the influence of self-love, which rejects all truth. In putting garrisons throughout all Edom, and making all Edom become his servants, David represented the power and operation of the spiritual mind in placing under the control of spiritual truth all the natural affections that powerfully influence the mind in favour of self as a ruling principle. For those garrisons of the king's forces in the conquered nations around Canaan symbolize the presence of the spiritual mind in the natural by means of truths, which exercise a controlling power over those thoughts and feelings which are inimical to, but not destructive of, the life of love and truth in the soul. Yet this is not a permanent state. The thoughts and feelings which at first are restrained must finally be brought into a friendly relation with the ruling principle of the mind, or be removed. And so we find in the prophets predictions of the ultimate renewal or destruction of the nations generally that David conquered. Here, at least, we have, in the conquests of David, a representative history of a Divine work that is constantly going on in the minds of those who are being regenerated, and a promise of the time when all nations shall serve the Lord, and bring their gifts and offerings to Him as the King of kings and Lord of lords.

CHAPTER XII.

DAVID CHERISHES JONATHAN'S SON.

2 Samuel ix.

DAVID, having subdued his enemies, began to make inquiry after his friends. True to the generous sentiment which he had constantly manifested towards him who had been, almost from first to last, his deadly enemy, "David said, Is there yet any that is left of the house of Saul, that I may show him kindness for Jonathan's sake?" That this inquiry should not have been made until fifteen years after the death of Saul is assumed to have been because not till then could David feel sure that his kingdom was securely established. It seems singular, however, that David should have been ignorant of the very existence of one in whom, had he known of him, he must have felt the liveliest interest, and to whom he had bound himself by a solemn covenant to show kindness. One reason of this may have been, that the descendant of Saul, whom he now discovered, lived in retirement, perhaps in seclusion, lest, as some suppose, he might be treated as a possible rival to the throne. Yet there is some difficulty even here;

for David's noble conduct on the death both of Saul and of Ish-bosheth, with the tolerance, at least, which he had hitherto manifested towards Saul's sons, might have inspired confidence in his clemency if not in his friendship. There are, however, deeper reasons than any that the circumstances themselves suggest for no one of the house of Saul having been discovered till this time. The sequence of events in sacred history represents the sequence of states in the regenerate life. And evil is to be subdued before good can be attained or brought into manifest existence.

Ziba, a servant of Saul, being brought into David's presence and interrogated respecting Saul's family, answered, "Jonathan hath yet a son, which is lame on his feet." When fetched from the house of Machir, in Lo-debar, which was in Gilead, on the other side Jordan, where he had been long and no doubt lovingly cherished, Mephibosheth fell on his face before David, and he did reverence. And David said unto him, "Fear not: for I will surely show thee kindness for Jonathan thy father's sake, and will restore thee all the land of Saul thy father; and thou shalt eat bread at my table continually."

This son of Jonathan we have had occasion to speak of once before. In the fourth chapter we read that he was five years old when the tidings came of Saul and Jonathan out of Jezreel, and his nurse took him up and fled; and it came to pass as she made haste to flee, that he fell, and he became lame.

The origin of Mephibosheth's lameness, which had some influence on his fortunes, and has something to do with his representative character, has an interest for us, which invites us to consider it.

In the Scriptures a nurse, as one who nourishes and suckles an infant, properly signifies one who nourishes innocence with the milk of the Word, which is the good of truth. Of this spiritual nourishment, which unites the qualities and virtues of goodness and truth, milk is a beautiful emblem; for it is at once food and drink, and contains all the elements required for the support and growth of the body, in all its constituent parts. Its provision is a striking instance of the wise beneficence of that Being who created and sustains us; as His Holy Word is of His love in so mercifully providing for the nourishment and growth of our souls. It is not, therefore, by a figure of speech, but by an exact and beautiful analogy, that the nourishers of the Church are called her nursing fathers and nursing mothers, and that the Church herself is spoken of as the nursing mother of her children. "Rejoice ye with Jerusalem, and be glad with her, all ye that love her: rejoice for joy with her, all ye that mourn for her: that ye may suck, and be satisfied with the breasts of her consolations; that ye may milk out, and be delighted with the abundance of her glory" (Isa. lxvi. 10, 11).

But a nurse has another function besides that of suckling the

children. She takes care of them after they are weaned. And, although children were suckled to a comparatively advanced age in olden times, yet such we may suppose was the office which the nurse held when she fled with her young charge after the fatal battle of Jezreel; as it was that of Rebekah's nurse, when she accompanied her young mistress, on leaving her father's house to become the wife of Isaac; and of whom we have the honourable memorial, that when she died, they buried her under an oak, which was called the oak of weeping (Gen. xxxv. 8). But even while a nurse is suckling a child she contributes to the nourishment and growth of his mind as well as of his body. This is mental nursing, and is represented by physical nursing, which it accompanies.

In mental growth there are two different elements that are nourished and, for a time, grow up together. All infants are born in a state of innocence; and the proper function of those who nurse the mind is to nourish and support that infantile innocence. But while all infants are born in a state of innocence, they are also born with hereditary inclinations to evil, that is, with the natural inclination to love themselves and the world inordinately, or with what may be called ambition and covetousness. However carefully the young may be nurtured, these natural inclinations will increase and strengthen. They are the tares that grow up together with the wheat. We cannot pluck them up, nor would it be wise in us to do so if we could. To the human wisdom that would attempt it, Divine wisdom has said, "Nay; lest while ye gather up the tares, ye root up also the wheat with them. Let both grow together until the harvest: and in the time of harvest I will say to the reapers, Gather ye together first the tares, and bind them in bundles to burn them: but gather the wheat into My barn" (Matt. xiii. 29, 30). Not till man comes under the regenerating influence of the Lord's Spirit can this separation be effected, and then angels, not men, are the reapers. When this change of state comes, then, where there was the natural ambition to be great and be envied by others, there is the spiritual principle, "He that would be greatest among you let him be your servant;" and where natural covetousness grew there is the heavenly plant of the Father's planting, "Covet the best gifts."

Until the human being can acquire and act from these higher and purer motives, he must act from the lower and grosser. All that can be done and ought to be attempted, is to bring the higher, as they acquire strength, to bear upon the lower, so as to moderate them by their influence. But to attempt to root out all hereditary inclinations that have regard to self and the world, which inspire them, to root out, for instance, youthful emulation, would be equally vain and mischievous. Rather should such inclinations be nursed, by being

supplied with their proper food, and directed, as far as possible, in their exercise, to useful results.

In the more interior sense, in which persons represent principles, a nurse means hereditary evil itself. "Thus hereditary evil yields the young nourishment, until they are able to judge for themselves, and then, if they are regenerated, they are led by the Lord into a state of new infancy, and at length into celestial wisdom, thus into true infancy, or into innocence, for true infancy or innocence dwells in wisdom. The difference is, that the innocence of infancy is without and hereditary evil within, but the innocence of wisdom is within and hereditary evil without. Hence it is that hereditary evil performs as it were the part of a nurse, from first infancy up to the age of new infancy. Hence it is that a nurse signifies hereditary evil, and also the insinuation of innocence through the celestial spiritual principle."

Such a nurse was represented by Rebekah's nurse, and such a nurse was represented by her who fled with the young son of Jonathan, who, by falling in her panic-stricken flight, became lame in both his feet.

What, in the spirit of its meaning, is this lameness? and why should it have happened to the son of Jonathan? The feet are important members of the human body. They are so often spoken of in Scripture in a religious sense, and their analogy is so plain, that no one can mistake their general meaning. "I turned my feet unto Thy testimonies. I refrained my feet from every evil way. Thy Word is a lamp unto my feet" (Ps. cxix. 59, 101, 105). To walk in the Lord's truth (Ps. lxxxvi. 11); to walk in His paths (Isa. ii. 3); is it life according to the teaching of His Word, and thus in the path of righteousness.

Lameness is also spoken of in a religious sense. "Lift up the hands which hang down, and the feeble knees; and make straight paths for your feet, lest that which is lame be turned out of the way" (Heb. xii. 12, 13). One of the blessings promised by the Lord's coming was that the lame man should leap as an hart (Isa. xxxv. 6); and although this was literally fulfilled, yet both the prediction and the act have a spiritual meaning. Lameness is either partial or complete; on one side or on both. Our Lord said, "If thy hand or thy foot offend thee, cut them off, and cast them from thee: it is better for thee to enter into life halt or maimed, rather than having two hands or two feet to be cast into everlasting fire" (Matt. xviii. 8). The hand and the foot are, in this instance, offending members; and from a similar statement it would appear, that it was the right hand or foot that was to be rejected (v. 30). Divine wisdom must have had a meaning in this symbolic teaching. The right and the left sides and members of the human body correspond to what may be called the two sides of the human mind and character, the moral and the intellectual. The right corresponds to the moral

side, the left to the intellectual. How beautifully instructive the Lord's teaching is! Not the intellectual error but the moral evil is to be cut off and cast from us. Not that error is a matter of indifference, but all serious error has a moral ground, and when that ground is removed, root and branch, the error withers away. But the feet of Mephibosheth, which were lame, do not mean evil and error, but goodness and truth. His lameness was an accident and a misfortune, and represented the loss both of moral and intellectual power, so as to be unable to walk in the ways of truth and goodness.

After the death of the king and his three sons, Mephibosheth, as the son of Jonathan, was the natural representative of the house of Saul. But the battle of Jezreel ended Saul's temporary kingdom, and commenced the enduring kingdom of David. This is described in the Divine promise given to David respecting Solomon: "My mercy shall not depart away from him, as I took it from Saul, whom I put away before thee. And thine house and thy kingdom shall be established for ever before thee: thy throne shall be established for ever" (2 Sam. vii. 15, 16). All the power of the house of Saul was now, therefore, departed from it, and transferred to the house of David. Mephibosheth, in his state of physical lameness and impotence, represented the house of Saul in its powerless condition. But this accidental and natural analogy is itself representative; and must be viewed in other than natural light before it can disclose its true Scriptural meaning. For only in the light of God can we see the light of His Word.

Saul, we have seen, represented truth Divine. In its widest sense this includes all Divine truth as received by finite minds, in heaven and in the Church, and even as it was in the mind of the Lord Himself, in the earlier period of His life on earth, while He was making His humanity truth Divine. In a less extended sense, Saul represented truth Divine such as this in the letter of the Word, and specifically the apparent truths of the letter, Jonathan representing its real truths. Jonathan's son now represented both. The letter of the Word consists, of necessity, in a great measure of apparent truths. Everything that comes from God into nature must put on nature. The human soul cannot live and act in the natural world without a natural body. Revelation cannot come from God into the natural world but by clothing itself with a natural sense, adapted to the understandings of men. The letter of the Word is, in the truest sense, a body, in which its spirit dwells, analogous to our own body, as the dwelling-place of the soul. All that in the Word concerns love to the Lord constitutes the heart, all that relates to faith in the Lord forms the lungs, or the spirit. These are the two vital principles which pervade and animate the whole Word, and on which all its truths depend. The highest of

these truths, those which relate to God, are the head; secondary truths, which relate to the neighbour, are the trunk; and the moral precepts and laws of duty are the hands and the feet. When all these parts are preserved in their order, connection, and integrity, the Church herself has a sound mind in a sound body. But this is far from being always the case. When the Lord was in the world, He declared to the leaders of the Jewish Church, that they had made the commandment of God of none effect by their tradition (Matt. xv. 6), and that they taught for doctrines the commandments of men (Mark vii. 7). With them the moral and intellectual power of the Word was gone. They neither walked in the truth nor in the good of religion; they neither performed their duties to God nor to man; they neither practised sincerity nor integrity; they devoured widows' houses and for a pretence made long prayers (Matt. xxiii. 14). The foundations were removed, and the kingdom of God among men was threatened with dissolution. In truth, the kingdom as it had been established among the Jews, provisional and temporary as it was, like that of Saul, had come to its end, when a new foundation was to be laid, and an everlasting kingdom established, which was typified by that of David. "Behold, I lay in Zion for a foundation a stone, a tried stone, a precious corner-stone, a sure foundation" (Isa. xxviii. 16). "I will raise unto David a righteous Branch, and a King shall reign and prosper, and shall execute judgment and justice in the earth" (Jer. xxiii. 5). "Of the increase of His government and peace there shall be no end, upon the throne of David, and upon His kingdom, to order it, and to establish it with judgment and with justice from henceforth even for ever" (Isa. ix. 7).

There is a profound significance in the Lord being called a foundation and a foundation-stone. The Church on earth is the foundation of the Church in heaven, the literal sense of the Word is the foundation of its spiritual sense, the religious virtues are the foundation of the religious graces. The higher rest upon the lower, unsupported by which they are unsubstantial and evanescent. At the time of the Incarnation all these foundations had given way. The Lord came into the world to lay these foundations anew, and to lay them in such a way that they should never be moved. He laid them deep and sure in the human nature He assumed and glorified. For, in truth, all these foundations exist in man, and have no existence out of him. The Church on earth has no abstract existence. Nor does it exist in creeds and formularies. It has no actual existence but in the hearts and lives of men. This is equally true of the Word itself. As a book it is a mere dead letter. Only when its truths are received into the understanding and hearts of man, as principles and laws of life, has it any actual existence as a power on earth. The religious graces, as

love to God and love to man, have no abstract existence, nor can they exist in the mind alone; they have no positive existence but in the virtues of a religious life. When these ultimates are wanting, or exist only in a perverted form, the Church and religion, and even the Word itself, as received in the human mind, is as a house built upon the sand, or as a man without the power to walk. This is the condition of truth Divine as represented by the son of Jonathan, who was lame in both his feet.

But David took this child of misfortune under his care and protection, as David's Lord took our infirmities and carried our sorrows; so that He, as the Word made flesh, became the Word as flesh had made it, perverted and enfeebled. For what do we understand by the Word being made flesh? That He clothed Himself with a fleshly body? He assumed human nature, not merely a human body. And man's nature is human from his having the capacity of knowing and doing the will of God. Yet even this does not, strictly speaking, constitute humanity, but is only the capacity of becoming human. Humanity consists in knowing and doing the will of God. It is this that makes man human. The Lord took upon Him human nature, but He took it, as it had become through sin, maimed and distorted. "His visage was so marred more than any man, and His form more than the sons of men" (Isa. lii. 14). That only mars and deforms humanity which mars and deforms that which constitutes humanity.

But the Lord took humanity marred and deformed, that He might restore it to more than its original beauty of visage and perfection of form. He made humanity, not only as it is in its greatest possible perfection in men and angels, a form of truth, but He made it the Truth itself in form. This is glorification, and that for which the Lord prayed when He said, "Father, glorify Thou Me with Thine own self with the glory which I had with Thee before the world was" (John xvii. 5). The Lord restored and glorified His humanity in two ways, one external, the other internal. Knowledges, especially the truths of His Word, entered from without, and the life of His indwelling Divinity entered from within; as Mephibosheth had restored to him all the land of Saul, and was fed continually at the king's table. Our Lord pointed out this distinction regarding Himself. His disciples were gone away into the city to buy food, and on their return, when they pressed Him to eat, He told them that He had meat to eat that they knew not of (John iv. 32).

Mephibosheth, who represented the Lord's frail humanity, as truth Divine, was not indeed restored to soundness; for the account of his better fortunes closes with the words, "So Mephibosheth dwelt in Jerusalem: for he did eat continually at the king's table; and was lame on both his feet." But although not restored himself, he was restored in his

son ; for he "had a young son whose name was Micha." And so far as we can rely on the meaning of names, those, in this instance, of parent and child have a happy significance ; for the father's name means "Exterminating the idol," and the son's, "Who is like unto the Lord?"

CHAPTER XIII.

DAVID'S ILL-REQUITED FRIENDSHIP FOR THE KING OF THE AMMONITES.

2 Samuel x.

GREAT events sometimes arise out of trifling circumstances, and bloody wars have been undertaken to redress some small wrong or revenge some slight or fancied insult. "The beginning of strife is as when one letteth out water," says Solomon (Prov. xvii. 14). Or it is like the cloud no bigger than a man's hand, which was quickly followed by a heaven black with clouds and wind, and a great rain (1 Kings xviii. 44, 45). The whole cloud material was there, though invisible ; and a slight electric change was all that was needed to produce a storm. So is it often in our public wars and private contentions. The warlike and contentious spirit is there, and little suffices to let it loose, so as to deluge fields with blood and spread and perpetuate discord among men. But the interest and honour of nations must be maintained, and men must stand upon their personal rights. By all means. But in our times, and with the nations and people of Christendom, let it be on Christian principles. Those who lived in less enlightened ages, and under a less perfect religious dispensation, must be judged by a lower standard.

This chapter of the Book of Samuel gives an exemplification of serious consequences resulting from an apparently slight offence. The king of the children of Ammon died ; and David said, "I will show kindness unto Hanun the son of Nahash, as his father showed kindness unto me. And David sent to comfort him by the hand of his servants for his father." The princes of the Ammonites persuaded the new king that David must have an interested motive in this ambassage. "Wherefore Hanun took David's servants, and shaved off the one half of their beards, and cut off their garments in the middle, even to their buttocks, and sent them away." As the men were greatly ashamed, the king said, "Tarry at Jericho until your beards be grown, and then return." The result of this insult was war, first with the Ammonites, aided by the Syrians, in which they were defeated, and next with the Syrians themselves, in which David slew the men of

seven hundred chariots, and forty thousand horsemen, and reduced them to servitude.

There is no account elsewhere of Nahash, the king of Ammon, showing kindness to David. This Nahash is supposed to be the son of the Ammonitish king who, forty years earlier, besieged Jabesh-gilead, which was relieved by Saul. Though an hereditary enemy of Israel, he might show kindness to David, as did Achish, king of the Philistines, while Saul was their common enemy. David, in his prosperity, desired to return to the son the kindness that the father had showed him in his adversity. But why should David desire to cultivate friendly relations with the king of the Ammonites? The children of Ammon were of the nations with whom the children of Israel might make peace, representing, as one of those remote from Canaan, what could be subordinated to right principles. David might, therefore, lawfully send to Hanun a message of condolence on the death of his father. But there was now on the throne of Ammon a king that knew not David, whom his princes easily persuaded to distrust and insult. The treatment to which the king subjected David's messengers was, according to the ideas of the times, most ignominious. Those messengers were no doubt men of rank, whose flowing beards and rich and ample apparel reflected the dignity and grandeur of the court to which they belonged and the king they represented, and were intended to show honour to those to whom they came. To have refused their message, would have been discourteous and unfriendly, but besides this, to send them away with half of their beards shaved off and their garments cut so as to shamefully expose their persons, was certainly a wanton insult and great indignity. Our principal concern is to understand what it means and what instruction it affords.

The hair in general and the beard in particular, and the garments, are so often spoken of in Scripture in what is called a figurative sense, that it is not necessary to show that they have a symbolic meaning. We need only to consider what their meaning is.

It would be an interesting inquiry, why the Creator has given a natural covering to animals, which he has denied to, or but sparingly bestowed on man. Without attempting to discuss so large a subject, a few remarks upon it may be ventured. One of the fathers of the Development theory, while believing that Nature has done all else for man, cannot help thinking that we must recognise the hand of God in this. According to this admission, man's peculiar condition in this respect is at least evidence of design. This we need not stop to consider. We do not so much desire to know its economical purpose, as to ascertain its secondary cause, and thence its meaning. First of all, it implies, because it necessitates, the existence in man of a reasoning

power. The being who is thus circumstanced, and has to provide what his condition requires, must see the connection between end and means, and between cause and effect. May not that mental power which sees the bodily need and exerts itself to supply it, have had some share, as a secondary cause, in producing it? All creatures are the organized forms of their own nature. They are made for the life they are intended to lead. Their whole structure, even to the hair, and feathers, and scales with which they are covered, is a development of their nature, and an adaptation to their mode of life. The animal soul clothes itself with an animal body, in every particular its own image, and therefore its own instrument. This is equally true of man. The human soul clothes itself with a human body, because this is its form, its image, its instrument. But there is this important difference between an animal and a man. An animal is born with all the knowledge which its nature requires. Man is born only with the faculty of acquiring knowledge, not with any undeveloped fund of knowledge, yet with the inflowing light of discernment. Animals are born with clothed minds, and as a consequence they are born with clothed bodies. They neither sow nor reap, nor toil nor spin to feed and clothe their bodies, because neither labour nor skill is required of them to feed and clothe their minds. The Creator has given man a naked body because He has given him an unclothed mind. Man has, by study and labour, to acquire knowledge, and clothe his mind with ideas; and as a consequence, he has to acquire the materials and form them into garments for his body. In brief, the clothing of animals grows out of their bodies because their knowledge grows out of their minds. Man has to acquire and put raiment on his body, because he has to acquire and put garments on his mind. It is on this ground that there is an analogy between the knowledge that clothes the mind and the garments that clothe the body.

Yet the human body is not left without a natural covering entirely. The head in all, and the lower part of the face in man, have a covering for beauty and glory. This, too, has its origin in correspondence. The celestial degree of the mind, to which the head corresponds, is in its nature and activity spontaneous. The men of the celestial Church did not, and the celestial angels do not, like the spiritual, lay up their truths in the memory and their garments in the wardrobe, and put them on as occasion requires. The celestials apply the truths they acquire immediately to the life. There is an important difference, however, between the hair of the head and the beard. The hair of the head comes by birth, the beard comes with manhood. And as the period of manhood is that in which reason asserts its power and assumes its sway, and as man, by the exercise of his reason, passes from knowledge into intelligence, therefore the beard is the emblem

of intelligence, as indeed the face is of the rational mind, out of which it grows.

As knowledge is to the mind what clothing is to the body, this is the Scripture meaning of garments. But that to which they correspond is the knowledge of Divine and spiritual things, or, truth as the vesture of goodness. As the hair and the garments serve a similar use, they have a similar meaning. There is this difference: the hair corresponds to that truth which celestial goodness puts forth, and garments correspond to those truths which spiritual goodness puts on; one comes by immediate, the other by mediate influx, or, one comes from within, the other from without.

One more particular respecting the hair and the garments. As a covering for the body they answer to the ultimate truths of the mind, in which its inward principles terminate, and which preserve them in their integrity and connection. So that when those ultimate truths are removed, the effects on the mind are like those which the removal of the hair and garments would have on the body. Besides being exposed to injuries, the vital heat would be dissipated, and disease would in all probability speedily bring its existence to a close. So with the mind.

Hanun did not, however, denude David's messengers entirely of their hair and garments. His purpose was not so much to injure as to insult, to express contempt for the king of Israel, and cast ridicule upon his servants. The Ammonitish king and his advisers were like those who not only refuse to receive the messengers of the King of kings, the prophets and evangelists, but who heap up contempt and ridicule upon them. Their mode of manifesting their contempt is very significant. They shaved off half the men's beards and cut their garments in the middle. In its evil sense, to halve is to divide, to divide is to dissipate, and to dissipate is to destroy. The act of king Hanun represents, therefore, a state of antagonism to Divine and spiritual truth of a very decided and hopeless kind. Simple denial of revealed religion, deeply mistaken though it is, may be sincere, and resolved upon after serious reflection. But when denial not only refuses to listen to the message of peace and goodwill, but treats the messengers with contempt and ridicule, unbelief is not only intellectual but moral denial. It is like the treatment to which the Lord Himself was subjected in the Prætorium, when, with daring derision, they took off His own garments and dressed Him in a purple robe, and put a crown upon His head and a reed in His hand, and saluted Him with, Hail, King of the Jews! Another representative act of those who crucified the Lord more formally resembles that of Hanun to the messengers of David, and has a similar meaning. The soldiers parted the Lord's garment. They did not indeed divide it in two but four parts; but

four has often the same meaning as two, the multiples of numbers having the same general meaning as the roots. The Lord's outer garment, which was the one the soldiers divided, represented, in relation to Him as the Word, the literal sense of the Word, which contains, supports, and preserves its Divine and spiritual senses; and when that is rent and divided, it is practically destroyed; and the higher truths which express themselves through the lower, though, like the Lord's seamless garment, preserved entire, are disposed of by the providential decision of the lot, so as to save it from division and profanation. For profanation is one of the evils represented by division, and is one of the evils represented by the Ammonites. But how do the evil divide the truth? Not as the workman, who has shown himself approved unto God, rightly divides the Word of truth (2 Tim. ii. 15), giving to every one according to his capacity. The division of truth by the evil is not the apposition, but the opposition, of truth to truth, and especially of truth and goodness. But how can one truth be brought into conflict with another truth? With the letter of Scripture this can be done, and often is done, by placing its apparent truths in opposition to its real truths, which produces a seeming contradiction. Some also who reject the Word of God, do so, partly at least, on the ground that its tendency, if not its teaching, is immoral, and that its human authors, besides whom they acknowledge no other, under the guise of doing men service, seek only to seduce and enslave them; just as the princes of the children of Ammon suggested to Hanun their lord, "Thinkest thou that David doth honour thy father, that he hath sent comforters unto thee? hath not David rather sent his servants unto thee, to search the city, and to spy out, and to overthrow it?" The Ammonites, we have said, represented those who profane truth—those who maintain, not only that the truths of the Scriptures are divided against themselves, but that they are hostile to goodness, because they lead men to neglect their true interests in this world in order to secure an imaginary happiness in a world which has no existence.

It is true there is a deeper kind of profanation than this, which is committed by those who first believe the truth and then deny it. This arises, not from a change of mind only, but from a change of heart. No one who has really believed the truth of God can reject it unless his faith has been undermined by evil. Yet we must draw a distinction between the truth as it is revealed in the Word of God, and as it is represented to be in human creeds. These forms of faith may be matter of belief and afterwards of denial, without the truth itself being absolutely rejected.

But there are the victims as well as the subjects of this unbelief to be considered, the messengers of David as well as the princes of

Hanun. Viewed abstractly, these represented the truths themselves which the spiritual Ammonites profane, the prophets and apostles as present with us in their writings. But the messengers of David represent also those who acknowledge the truth, which the prophets and apostles have written, those who are in the faith of the truth, and belong to the Lord's kingdom. How do these suffer injury from those represented by the Ammonites? and how is the injury to be repaired?

Two circumstances recorded in the earlier part of the Hebrew Scriptures will help us to understand the nature of the injury sustained by David's servants. When Joseph's brethren sold him to the Ishmeelites, they stripped him of his coat, which they made use of to deceive their father and conceal their own wickedness. When Joseph fled in horror from the enticements of his mistress, she caught hold of and retained his garment, which she employed as evidence against him, so that he was cast into prison. The spiritual meaning of these circumstances is this. When the faithful are deprived of ultimate truth, they are left unprotected; and that which was given as a defence is even turned in the hands of their enemies into a testimony against them. How is this? Those who are opposed to the truth of Scripture seize on the apparent truths of the letter, and employ them to invalidate its real truths, and thus to prove what is false to be true, and what is good to be evil; as Joseph's enemies did in regard to him. It is a cause of great distress to the faithful to see what they hold sacred thus profaned, by men seizing and mutilating the ultimate truths of the Word, to show that the teaching of the Holy Book is neither true nor good. And not the least dangerous enemies of revealed truth are some of its professed friends, whose laboured criticisms and materialistic systems of interpretation tend to degrade the Word to the level of a common writing, composed by men with views as different as were those of the times in which they lived. This, it is true, affects only the letter of the Word. But the letter of the Word is the clothing of its spirit. And when that is marred and severed from its spirit, which is the Spirit of God, it has breathed into it the spirit of man, which is that of its human interpreter.

But in the Scriptures these oppositions of the false to the true and the evil to the good are, in the spiritual sense, descriptive of oppositions in the mind itself, as inward trials of faith and love. In the mind of the spiritual man, or of him who is becoming spiritual, doubts and difficulties arise on those very points and questions, which the natural man settles either by an easy or elaborate negation. There is no solid and settled faith without intellectual conflict, no deep and abiding love without moral temptations. The Egyptian and the Philistine, the Moabite and the Ammonite have all to be encountered and overcome in the errors and evils which they represent. The Ammonitish

principle assails us when we are tempted to doubt the Divinity and spirituality of the Word, on the ground covered by the question, How can that be, in its essence, Divine and spiritual, which, in its form, is, in many instances, so human as to be inconsistent and contradictory, and so natural as to be concerned with the affairs of this world only? These are doubts to which the young Christian is perhaps most liable. He looks at the Word more with the eye of science than with that of spiritual discernment. It is but right that he should. By all means let him bring his scientific faculty and knowledge to bear upon the Scriptures. But let him not trust to these alone. There is, however, a time, or rather a state, in the experience of every earnest inquirer, even when he inquires in an affirmative spirit, when these doubts are so prominent and so powerful as seemingly to deprive him of half his faith. It is a favourable sign if, in this state of mind, which seems to be forced upon him, he feels distressed and ashamed. There is the sure ground of hope in such a state of mind. It prepares it for hearing and following the counsel that will repair the temporary loss he has suffered, and restore him to a more perfect spiritual faith. The counsel to such tempted ones is that given by David to his insulted messengers: "Tarry at Jericho until your beards be grown, and then return."

Jericho was the first city to which the children came after they had crossed the Jordan and entered the Promised Land. As in passing through the Jordan the Israelites received a second baptism, the first being that unto Moses in the cloud and in the sea (1 Cor. x. 2), these two answering to the baptism of John and that of Jesus; and as those who pass through baptism are to be instructed in the truth of Jesus and to enter on a new life, instruction in new and higher truths, and a new life in accordance with them, were represented by Jericho. What, then, are the truths instruction in which are the requisite means for restoring to the intellect the intelligence and power of faith?

To those whose scientific faculty and knowledge have brought them into distrustful doubt, there is a science which will resolve all scientific doubt, because it enters into and enlightens all science. The science of Correspondence is the science of sciences. Creation was framed, and the Word of God was written, according to the law of correspondence. This explains the nature of the connection which exists between God the Creator and His works, and between God the Revealer and His revelation. It explains the nature of the connection which exists between the works of God and His Word, and between the different parts of these with each other. Correspondence is the universal bond that holds all things in connection and in harmony with God and with each other. We all acknowledge the intimate connection that exists between the words and works of men. If a man

is perfectly sincere, his words and his works are but two different modes of expressing his mind. His will and understanding are manifested equally in both ; and each might be translated into the other. Few seem to think that there is as perfect a connection or correspondence between the words and the works of God. Yet this must absolutely be the case. The correspondence between Creation and Revelation being perfect, we should regard them both in the same way. If we look at the works of God only sensually and superficially, we see many things under an appearance which is widely different from, and sometimes opposite to, the reality. Where would have been the science of astronomy if men had never looked up into the heavens with any other eye but that of sense? Where would have been the science of geology if men had never looked deeper than the surface of the earth? On the same ground, where would true theology be if men looked no deeper into the book of God than the letter? Besides these and other intellectual considerations that counteract the influence of negative reasoning from science, there is a moral consideration of the very highest importance in the settlement of doubts. "If any man will do His will, he shall know of the doctrine, whether it be of God" (John vii. 17). "He that is of God heareth God's words" (viii. 47). These are among the lessons we have to learn for the strengthening of our faith, in a state of trial such as that represented by the sufferings of the messengers of the king of Israel to the king of the Ammonites.

Although David must have felt keenly the insult that had been offered him by Hanun, he does not appear to have meditated any swift revenge. The Ammonites were the first to move ; and in doing so, they perhaps only anticipated what they knew must happen. "When the children of Ammon saw that they stank before David, the children of Ammon sent and hired the Syrians of Beth-rehob, and the Syrians of Zoba, twenty thousand footmen, and of king Maacah a thousand men, and of Ish-tob twelve thousand men." Against these combined forces David sent Joab, who defeated them, and returned to Jerusalem. But the Syrians gathered themselves together again. "And Hadarezer sent, and brought out the Syrians that were beyond the river : and they came to Helam." There David himself at the head of the Israelitish army met them, and slew the men of seven hundred chariots and forty thousand horsemen. Then "all the kings that were servants to Hadarezer made peace with Israel, and served them. So the Syrians feared to help the children of Ammon any more."

It would occupy too much space to enter into the particulars of this narrative. We have recently seen David engaged in war with several of the Syrian nations, whom he conquered and made tributary. But the same spiritual evil, like the same natural enemy, is not always,

when once defeated, entirely subdued. Old evils enter into new combinations, and call up others to strengthen their forces. For there is a confederacy between things evil as there is a connection or confederacy between things good. David speaks of this in the Psalms: "Thine enemies make a tumult: . . . they are confederate against Thee: the tabernacles of Edom, and the Ishmaelites; of Moab, and the Hagarenes; Gebal, and Ammon, and Amalek; the Philistines with the inhabitants of Tyre; Assur also is joined with them; they have holpen the children of Lot" (lxxxiii. 2, 5-8). Almost all the nations which have appeared in the historical part of the Word on which we have been engaged, are introduced here, and they are all confederate against God, to help the children of Lot, as the Syrians are here. But not only do evils and falsities become confederate among themselves, but evil becomes confederate with good and falsity with truth. "Syria is confederate with Ephraim," is recorded of a time in the Jewish history which represented the Church in the last stage of its decline, and is therefore followed by the Divine promise, "Behold, a virgin shall conceive, and bear a son" (Isa. vii. 2, 14). The mixture of principles in their nature opposite is the worst kind of profanation. But even in these times, and in the worst states of temptation, the faithful have an unfailing support and guide, sufficient, if they but trust and follow Him, to overcome all the power of the enemy, and to break up the confederacy so far, at least, as that the Syrians shall fear to help the children of Ammon any more.

CHAPTER XIV.

DAVID'S GREAT SIN.

2 Samuel xi.

IT is impossible long to peruse the record of human transactions without having cause to mourn over the frailty of human nature. History, both sacred and secular, is, to a considerable extent, a record of the vices and follies of mankind. It was meet that the Book which reveals the origin of evil and the fall of man, should trace the evil through its devious course, and exhibit the consequences of the fall in the darker doings of corrupt humanity. However painful these may be to our better feelings, and indelicate some of them may seem to our conventional sentiments, they are all capable of producing beneficial effects, when rightly contemplated. The purpose of Revelation, in recording such transactions, is to place crime before us, not only as evil, but as sin; to point it out, not only as a breach of the laws of man,

but as a violation of the laws of God; to show us that the Lord has placed our secret sins in the light of His countenance; and that the sinner, though he may be above the reach of human authority, shall not escape the judgment of a righteous God.

A striking exemplification of this is given in the case of David in the double crime he committed in the matter of Bathsheba.

There are some reflections that can hardly fail to arise in our minds in reading the narrative of David's sins, and which it may be necessary to consider before proceeding to speak of its more interior sense.

It may not be necessary to employ much time in meeting the not uncommon objection, How, viewing such conduct, can David have been called a man after God's own heart? It is abundantly proved that this could not have been affirmed of him in regard to his personal, but his official and representative character; for it is not the man but the function that represents. This is evident from David's own treatment of Saul, whom he regarded and treated as the Lord's anointed.

There is another and still more serious difficulty. How could David, in such acts as those of which he had been guilty, represent the Lord, or even the regenerate man? The fact, which has been already stated, must be kept in mind, that evil actions committed by representative men represent, in the Lord and in the regenerate, not acts but temptations. Nor are they to be understood as temptations to commit those very acts of which David and others were guilty; but temptations which have a much deeper ground, and go much more to the root of evil, which grows up and branches out into the numerous forms of sin that men commit. All evil has its primary root in self-love, which is the opposite of love to God. Love to God is the root of all goodness, for even love to the neighbour grows out of love to God. And these two loves comprehend all goodness, for on them hang all the law and the prophets. In like manner the love of the world grows out of the love of self; and these two loves comprehend all that is opposed to goodness, for all evils are opposed to the law and the prophets. As love to God thus comprehends all religion, the love of self comprehends all irreligion; as the one includes all righteousness, the other includes all unrighteousness. What the apostle calls sins of the flesh have their root in self-love as truly as any other sins. Self-love is at the root of whatever we do to gratify our own desires without regard to the welfare and happiness of others. And what can be more greedily and basely selfish than to gratify the lust of the flesh at the expense of all that is most precious to a human being upon earth, not to speak of the effects which are spiritual and may be eternal?

It is in this way we are to look at sin and at temptation. Christian temptation is not simply that which comes from external objects,

exciting our desires and alluring us to sinful acts. These no doubt are temptations. But real spiritual temptations may be endured without externally exciting causes, if causes they can be called, for they are rather the occasions than the causes of sin. The causes, as well as the ends, are within us. Unless these are removed, sin is never put away; the axe is never laid at the root of the tree; we are content to try to lop off the branches. Temptation goes to the root of evil, to the end and the cause; and not until we endure and overcome such temptations are we in the true way of being perfected by suffering. The Lord took upon Him all our hereditary evils, which had their root in His maternal humanity. That root descended, so to speak, into the lowest hell, from which, through that hereditary root, His deepest and direst temptations came, and in overcoming which He carried His redeeming power to the very root of evil and to the lowest depths of Satan; so that He is now able to succour them that are tempted, however severe their temptations may be.

In the transaction we have been considering, David committed the two greatest crimes of which a man can be guilty, and they must therefore have represented the Lord's deepest temptations. To see the true nature of the two evils he committed, and so to understand something of the depth of the temptations they represented, we must inquire into their spiritual origin. And this we cannot better ascertain than in the Writings of the Church:—

"The origin of love truly conjugal is the love of the Lord towards the Church, whence the Lord is called in the Word the Bridegroom, and the Church the bride and wife. From this marriage the Church is a Church, both in general and in particular; and the Church in particular is the man in whom the Church is. Hence it is evident that the conjunction of the Lord with the man of the Church is the very origin of true conjugal love. How that conjunction is the origin of this love shall be explained. The conjunction of the Lord with the man of the Church is the conjunction of goodness and truth. From the Lord is goodness, and with man is truth. Hence the conjunction is called the heavenly marriage, from which exists love truly conjugal between married partners who are in the conjunction of goodness and truth from the Lord. Hence it is first evident that love truly conjugal is from the Lord alone, and with those who are in the conjunction of goodness and truth from Him. Now since the origin of conjugal love is the marriage of goodness and truth, which is heaven, it is manifest that the origin of the love of adultery is the marriage of evil and falsity, which in its essence is hell. Heaven is marriage, because all who are in the heavens are in the marriage of goodness and truth; and hell is adultery, because all who are in the hells are in the marriage of evil and falsity. Hence it follows that marriage and adultery are

as opposite to each other as heaven and hell. The love of marriage corresponds to the love of the supreme heaven, which is love to the Lord from the Lord, and the love of adultery corresponds to the love of the lowest hell. The reason why the love of marriage is so holy and celestial is that it commences from the Lord Himself in the inmost parts of man, and descends according to order to the ultimate parts of the body, and thereby fills the whole man with celestial love, and induces in him a form of Divine love, which form is the form of heaven, and is an image of the Lord. But the love of adultery commences from the ultimate parts of man, and from an impure lascivious fire there, and thence, contrary to order, penetrates towards the interiors, always into man's selfhood, which is nothing but evil, and induces therein a form of hell, which is an image of the devil.

"The good works of chastity which concern married partners are, spiritual and celestial loves, intelligence and wisdom, innocence and peace, power and protection against the hells. The evils consequent upon adulteries are opposite to these. Instead of spiritual and celestial loves are infernal and diabolical loves; instead of intelligence and wisdom there are insanities and follies; instead of innocence and peace are deceit and no peace; instead of power and protection against hell are demons themselves, and the hells; and instead of beauty there is deformity. . . . Adulteries correspond to the adulterations and defilements of goodness and truth." So far respecting David's violation of one commandment. What is involved in his violation of the other?

"In the spiritual celestial sense, Thou shalt not kill, means, Thou shalt not take away from man the faith and love of God, and thereby his spiritual life, this being homicide itself; for by virtue of this life man is man, the life of the body serving thereto as the instrumental cause serves the principal cause. From this spiritual homicide moral homicide is derived, wherefore he who is in the one is also in the other; for he who wills to take away man's spiritual life, is in hatred against him if he cannot take it away, for he hates his faith and love, and thus the man himself. Spiritual homicide, which is that of faith and love; moral homicide, which is that of fame and honour; and natural homicide, which is that of the body, are consequent in a series, one from the other, as cause and effect. Since all who are in hell are in hatred against the Lord, and thence in hatred against heaven, for they are against goodness and truth, therefore hell is the very homicide or murderer itself, whence homicide or murder proceeds. The reason is this: man is man from the Lord through the reception of goodness and truth, wherefore to destroy goodness and truth is to destroy what constitutes humanity itself, thus to kill the man."

But there is this to be taken into consideration in regard to David's

sins. The principles which have been stated are absolutely true in themselves, but the guilt attaching to those who act against them is in proportion to the moral and spiritual light they enjoy. Under the Jewish dispensation men did not see the sinfulness of such violations of the law so clearly as Christians do. Indeed polygamy, which the law sanctioned, and in which they lived, was inconsistent with the true idea of marriage, and therefore with a clear conception of the sinfulness of violating its sanctity; and comparatively little value was then set on human life, because they had but an obscure notion of the soul and of its eternal existence. To us who live under a higher dispensation, to which the true nature and the sanctity of marriage, and the true nature of the soul and of the future life, have been so fully made known, the lessons which these sins teach are most solemn.

We see from the teaching of the Writings how holy marriage is, and how great is the sin of those who violate its sanctity; how precious the soul of man is, and how sinful it is to destroy its spiritual life. The violation of what is most holy and the destruction of what is most precious lie at the root of David's two sins. The two spiritual evils are most destructive of the Church, as the two natural evils are of human society. They are the evils in which the spirits of darkness are most deeply involved; and are the most directly and deeply opposed to the love of God and man, in which the angels of heaven are principled, and which they embody most perfectly in the sanctity of marriage, and in the intense love of the human soul, which makes them all ministering spirits, and inspires them with joy over every sinner that repents. In short, heaven and hell are opposed to each other as life and death, purity and impurity.

Now the Lord in His temptations had the angels with Him although He took nothing from them; because, as His maternal humanity brought Him into connection with all the hells, His Paternal humanity brought Him into connection with all the heavens; so that while the Lord as the Redeemer was conquering the hells, He was at the same time and in the same degree ordinating the heavens; and in this way establishing the equilibrium between heaven and hell, on which the spiritual freedom of the human race, because of the human will, depends. But as hell could not be subdued, so heaven could not be ordinated, without conflict. The angels of heaven as well as the spirits of hell retain the selfhood, or proprium, which is the ground of their conscious existence as individual human beings. This in its very nature is opposed to the Divine, but only in the way that the centrifugal force of the planets is opposed to the centripetal or attractive force of the sun. If the planets had not the tendency to fly off from the sun as their centre they would fall into it, and could therefore have no individual separate existence; and if the sun did not

attract them, they would fly off into space, and be lost or destroyed. So comparatively with God and man. God, as man's Creator, has given him a selfhood, as the ground of his individuality, which, from its very nature, tends outwards, away from the Author of his existence and Fountain of his life; but his Creator exerts an attractive force which is equal to the contrary force exerted by the creature. This applies when man is in a state of order. For, unlike the planet, man has free-will, and can overcome the attractive force of Divine love, and wander away into the spiritual region of darkness and death. That region is hell; for hell is nothing more than wilful separation from God, and determined opposition to Him, and to all that is with Him, therefore to His kingdom on earth and in heaven. Angels are with the Lord, and yet their selfhood is against Him. In this is grounded the singular fact that, in the great work of redemption, the Lord was tempted even by the angels, nay, that the severest of His temptations were from that source. And this, in the highest sense, is involved in David's temptation in the matter of Bathsheba.

But in effecting redemption the Lord had a work to perform in His Church on earth as well as in His Church in heaven. Redemption included among its immediate objects the establishment of a Church on earth, as the basis of the Church in heaven, and as the means of saving souls, and thus supplying heaven with inhabitants. And in the internal sense it is to this that the history of David and Bathsheba relates.

Bathsheba was the wife of Uriah the Hittite. "The Hittites were among the better sort of inhabitants of the land of Canaan, as may appear from the circumstance that Abraham dwelt among them, and afterwards Isaac and Jacob, and were also buried there; and they behaved themselves with piety and modesty towards Abraham, as is manifest from Genesis xxiii. Hence it is that this people, as a well-disposed nation, represented the spiritual Church. But it came to pass with them, as with the rest of the nations who composed the ancient Church, that in process of time they declined from charity or the good of faith, and hence they afterwards signified the false principle of the Church, as in Ezekiel xvi. 3, 45 (where Jerusalem is reproached with her father having been an Amorite and her mother a Hittite). Still the Hittites were among the more honourable, as may appear from the consideration that Hittites were attendant on David, as Ahimelech (1 Sam. xxvi. 6), and Uriah (2 Sam. xi. 3), whose wife was Bathsheba, of whom David had Solomon." But the circumstance that has more particular relation to the present subject is the burial of Sarah, Abraham's wife, in the land of the Hittites, who were the children of Heth. Sarah died in Hebron, which we have seen represented the spiritual Church; and there Abraham buried her in the field of Ephron.

"And the field, and the cave that is therein, were made sure unto Abraham for a possession of a burying-place by the son of Heth." Sarah represented the Church, and burial signifies resurrection. Abraham burying Sarah among the children of Heth, was representative of the Lord raising up a Church among the Gentiles, when the former Church had expired. This Church was also represented by Bathsheba, the wife of Uriah the Hittite. It may be difficult to see how a criminal connection can represent anything that is good. And yet we know there are in Scripture things evil that are types of things good, and things false that are types of things true. This seeming inconsistency originates in the circumstance that evil is the perversion of good, and falsity is the perversion of truth; and when the perversion is removed the good and the truth remain. Evil and falsity have no original or independent existence. Evil is nothing without reference to good, falsity is nothing without reference to truth. If there had been no such thing as good, there could have been no such thing as evil; if there had been no such thing as truth, there would have been no such thing as error or falsity. On this ground the connection between Lot and his daughters had a good as well as a bad representation; so had that between Judah and his daughter-in-law Tamar, through whom, as afterwards through the harlot Rahab, came the seed royal, and finally the Messiah. Although, naturally, this tells us that on the Lord was made to rest, by hereditary transmission, the iniquity of us all; yet, spiritually, the Lord's progenitors represented the remains of goodness and truth, of all kinds and degrees, which the Lord acquired from His birth upwards. David's first connection with Bathsheba represented the conjunction which existed between the Lord and the Gentiles before the Church, in its true sense, was established amongst them. The universal Church has, indeed, in all times and under all dispensations, included the Gentiles, since it includes all who are in the good of their religion, whatever that religion may be. But Gentile good, though not false, is spurious, because it is good unenlightened and unpurified, like the good of childhood. Yet that good, like the good of childhood, is very beautiful to look upon, as Bathsheba was; and although it is not pure, it desires purity, and employs such means of purification as the Gentiles possess, or as the Church may indirectly supply, as the woman was washing herself when David from the roof of his house beheld her. The conjunction of the Lord with the Gentiles, when the Church was established among them, was represented by the connection that existed between David and Bathsheba when she became his wife, the marriage of the Lord and the Church being the result of the union of goodness and truth; for Gentile good becomes Christian good when it is enlightened and purified by, and united to, Christian truth. The

fruits of these two dissimilar conjunctions were represented by the child born, whom the Lord smote that he died, and by Solomon the wise, who succeeded David on the throne. All good is from the Lord; but good from the Lord is not genuine good in us unless it is united to truth, and the fruit of such good has not true spiritual life in it. When good is united to truth, then, from this union, which is the heavenly marriage, the fruit of wisdom and righteousness is produced.

Such is a general view of the spiritual meaning of this inspired record, which, while it stands as a great moral and religious warning, teaches a high spiritual truth.

As all evil is, as far as possible, turned by Divine providence to some substantial good, this evil has produced some results that may be profitable to the Church in all future times. To David's crime we owe the penitential psalm, through which the prostrate sinner breathes the very language of a broken and contrite heart; and which assuredly shows the royal sinner's repentance to have been sincere and deep. One should never read the account of David's crime without reading also the utterance of his contrition. It would do much to temper the severity of our judgment respecting him, and to diffuse over our minds a feeling of reverential awe in the presence of Him who alone can give us power to resist temptation as well as grant us pardon for our sins. The fifty-first psalm is so perfectly full of the beauties of holiness, and they are linked together in such perfect harmony, that it seems like doing violence to the whole to part them asunder.

Another benefit the Church has received from David's sin is that beautiful lesson of active piety and wise resignation which he displayed, one during the illness, the other at the death, of his child. "The Lord struck the child that Uriah's wife bare unto David, and it was very sick. David therefore besought God for the child; and David fasted, and went in, and lay all night upon the earth." On the seventh day the child died, and his servants feared to tell him that the child was dead, concluding that, as he refused all comfort while the child was yet alive, he would vex himself much more on hearing of his death. But David acted a wiser and more consistent part. When David perceived from his servants' whisperings what they feared to tell, he rose from the earth, and anointed himself, and changed his apparel, and came into the house of the Lord, and worshipped: then he came to his own house; and when he required, they set bread before him, and he did eat. When his servants remarked on this strange conduct, he said, "While the child was yet alive, I fasted and wept; for I said, Who can tell whether God will be gracious to me, that the child may live? But now he is dead, wherefore should I fast? can I bring him back again? I shall go to him, but he shall not return to me." This is conduct which Christians would do well to imitate, and

the reasons on which it was grounded Christians would do wisely to adopt as their own. Under David's circumstances, earnest prayer and pious resignation are equally dutiful and perfectly consistent. While there is hope we may send up the prayer of faith. Yet even in this prayer there should be resignation, whether unuttered or expressed, as in the words of the Lord Himself, "nevertheless, not as I will, but as Thou wilt." When the issue is no longer uncertain, what should be our course but meek and quiet submission? It is hard to part with the objects of our love, who are a part of ourselves and of our very life. But wherefore should we afflict our souls? We cannot bring one of them back. And we can say with more enlightened views of life and immortality, and with a brighter hope than David had, "I shall go to him, but he shall not return to me."

CHAPTER XV.

GOD'S MESSAGE AND NATHAN'S PARABLE.

2 Samuel xii.

IT is not perhaps desirable to enter into the particulars of this painful history, the bare mention of which is sufficient to rend our hearts, and impel us, like the lepers of old, to cry, Unclean, unclean. For the moral leprous spot, which broke out in this representative man, is exhibited in Scripture, not only to warn us against such uncleanness, but to remind us that we all inherit the propensity to which he yielded in temptation. We will consider David's double crime as so expressively described in the parable of Nathan, when that prophet was sent by the Lord to reprove David for his sin, and pronounce the judgment of Divine justice against him. The exposition has appeared elsewhere, but this is the place it originally occupied.

David had now accomplished his object. Bathsheba had become his wife. This was more than he originally intended. But this result of his sinful indulgence had been forced upon him by the self-denial of a faithful servant, who had forfeited his life to his continency. Whether David's conscience was entirely at ease we know not. He had added iniquity to his sin. But he had done it secretly. No one knew of his dark device but Joab. And he was too faithful a representative of the rational faculty, which easily becomes the servile instrument of an overmastering passion. Had David's crime been generally known, he might have been pricked by the stings of that social or conventional conscience which we call shame. But as it was hid from men, David seems to have felt as if his were hid in his own

heart. But there was an eye, that eye to which all things lie open, that was ever upon him, and that looked through him, in the motions of his criminal passion, and in the schemings of his fertile brain. "The thing that David had done displeased the Lord. And the Lord sent Nathan unto David." The presence of Nathan did not call David's sin to his remembrance, and it was not the prophet's purpose to charge him directly with it. He adopted a more prudent course, and one that was eminently successful, not only of convicting but convincing the king of his guilt.

The kings of Israel, like those of most other nations of that period, were the judges as well as the rulers of their people. The prophet availed himself of this circumstance to perform his important but delicate mission with the greatest certainty of success. He appeared in the presence of the Israelitish monarch as a claimant for justice to an injured Israelite. Addressing the royal judge, he took up his parable, and said, "There were two men in one city; the one rich, and the other poor. The rich man had exceeding many flocks and herds: but the poor man had nothing, save one little ewe lamb, which he had bought and nourished up: and it grew up together with him, and with his children; it did eat of his own meat, and drank of his own cup, and lay in his bosom, and was unto him as a daughter. And there came a traveller unto the rich man, and he spared to take of his own flock and of his own herd, to dress for the wayfaring man; but took the poor man's lamb, and dressed it for the man that was come to him." On hearing the recital of this heartless act of cruelty and oppression, David's anger was greatly kindled against the man, and he said to Nathan, "As the Lord liveth, the man that hath done this thing shall surely die: and he shall restore the lamb fourfold, because he did this thing, and because he had no pity." By this righteous decree the first object of the prophet was attained. The royal judge had admitted the justice of the poor man's cause, and had pronounced sentence against his rich oppressor. While David's zeal for justice and his generous indignation against the rich man were yet hot, the prophet, with the authority and power of a messenger from the Judge of all the earth, pronounced in his ears the awful words, "THOU art the man. Thus saith the Lord God of Israel, I anointed thee king over Israel, and I delivered thee out of the hand of Saul; and I gave thee thy master's house, and thy master's wives into thy bosom, and gave thee the house of Israel and of Judah. Wherefore hast thou despised the commandment of the Lord, to do evil in His sight? Thou hast killed Uriah with the sword, and taken his wife to be thy wife."

No case could more strikingly point the moral delivered in the writings of the Apostle, "He that judgeth another judges himself when he doeth the same things."

All men have a perception of abstract justice. In some it may be clearer than in others, but in none is it entirely wanting. In a certain sense, and to a certain extent, the Divine law is still written on the human mind, though unhappily not now upon the human heart; and written too with the finger of God; for He is the Author of every perception which the mind has of right and wrong, of justice and injustice. And not only has every one a perception of abstract justice, but he is able, almost unerringly, to apply it for the regulation of his own conduct. By the power of reflex judgment he can see that, in condemning any evil in another, he condemns that evil in himself. The same power enables him to apply a still more comprehensive law, the law of equity, "Whatsoever ye would that men should do to you, do ye even so to them." This, it is true, is not only a natural but a revealed law: it is "the law and the prophets." But the laws of nature and of revelation are in harmony; for the same God is the Author of both. Were man in a state of nature, by which we mean a state of order, such as that in which he was created, he would have the law of his nature, which is the law of God, written in his heart, and would require no outward revelation. But having departed from his original state, the law, which he had effaced from the table of his heart, was written for his use upon tables of stone. And even now, by the united operation of the Lord's Spirit from within, and of His written law from without, every man of sound mind has the power of discerning between right and wrong, and of applying the law of equity, both in judging and in acting. But in the practical part, how often and gravely do we fail! Clearly as we can see justice in the abstract, our passions and prejudices seriously warp our judgment in its application, making us lynx-eyed in detecting others' faults, but strangely blind to our own, and greatly indisposing us to do to others as we would that others should do to us.

Strikingly and painfully was this exemplified in the case of David, when, in the name of the God of justice, he pronounced the decree of death and restitution against the rich man who had deprived his poor neighbour of his one ewe lamb, while he himself was stained with the crimes of adultery and murder, for which he had made no restitution either to God or man.

We cannot plead, in behalf of the Israelitish king, that, while he knew the moral law, he had not the means of acquiring the moral principle. At the time his judgment and his actions were so much at variance, he recognised the moral law as the law of God. Nor can we, on the other hand, plead that he only fell through the weakness of sinful flesh, and that his sin was but a momentary spot on the purity of his saintly character. At the same time, in judging of David's sin, we must not forget that he lived under a dispensation far more obscure

than that of the Gospel. We enjoy a clearer light; but its demands upon us are proportionately greater. Under the Christian dispensation, "Whosoever looketh on a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart;" and "Whosoever is angry with his brother without a cause shall be in danger of the judgment," having made one step towards the crime of murder. Such being the case, we have reason to tremble in the presence of the holy prophet when he pleads for judgment; and even when our zeal for justice leads us to condemn another, we may only have to listen to the voice of the Eternal Truth to hear the words pronounced in our internal ear—"Thou art the man."

But the spiritual sense reveals the origin both of the evil prohibited by the law, and of the intention condemned by the Gospel.

Marriage is at once an effect and a type of the heavenly marriage of goodness and truth, or of love and faith. In this marriage the man represents truth and the wife good. To violate the good which any truth of religion teaches is the spiritual evil which David's first sin represented. But as his first sin led to the second, so does the violation of good lead to the falsification and destruction of its truth. When we have done violence to any good of religion, its truth rises up in our thoughts, and haunts us with visions of a coming judgment. It is Uriah, whom we have spoiled of his best treasure—the poor man, whose ewe lamb we have torn from his bosom, and dressed to satisfy our wandering lusts and depraved appetites. Our first endeavour is to draw the truth over to the evil side; but it consents not, and lies like sin at our door, filling us with alarm and apprehension. But when the truth will not consent, it must be made to yield; and so it is perverted and falsified, and thus practically destroyed. This is the history of every spiritual-moral declension. First the will corrupts the good, and then the understanding falsifies and destroys the truth. The falsification and consequent practical destruction of the truth is especially represented by the second criminal act of David. For Nathan lays particular stress on the fact, not simply that David had slain Uriah, but that he had slain him with the sword of the children of Ammon. Moab and Ammon were the two sons of Lot by his daughters, and represented, as the Moabites and Ammonites did after them, the profaning of goodness and truth. We are spiritually guilty of David's crime in killing Uriah, when we put such a false construction upon any truth as to destroy its real meaning and practical utility, and so remove it as an obstacle to selfish or sensual indulgence.

When the reproving voice of truth is hushed into silence, the troubled mind finds peace; but it is the peace which is no peace—the stillness of corruption, the calm of spiritual deadness. Happy is it if the conscience, though silenced, is not seared. It may yet be awakened

by the voice of the Eternal Truth, speaking to it through its sense of right. So it was with David. When the grave had closed over Uriah, and Bathsheba was in the king's palace, David sat upon the throne of judgment, with a conscience stifled, if not at rest. But when the Lord's prophet turned upon the guilty judge the sword of justice, which he had raised over one less guilty than himself, it entered into his soul, piercing even to the dividing asunder of soul and spirit, and proving a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart. Smitten with a sense of sin, he sat, a conscience-stricken and a humbled man, uttering before the man of God, and in the presence of his assembled court, the unreserved confession, "I have sinned against the Lord."

David's ready confession received as ready a forgiveness: "Nathan said unto David, The Lord also hath put away thy sin; thou shalt not die."

It may seem at variance with strict justice that so serious a sin should have met with so ready a forgiveness. But it is in strict accordance with the Scripture law upon the subject. In both Testaments pardon is promised on repentance. If David's repentance was sincere, his sin could not consistently remain unpardoned. At the same time we are to reflect that David's punishment, repentance, and forgiveness were natural and temporal, while those of the Christian are spiritual and eternal. Christian forgiveness can only, therefore, be secured by Christian repentance.

But while repentance never fails to receive forgiveness, sin, once committed, entails certain consequences on him who commits it. Although David's life was spared, he did not escape unscathed. Having slain Uriah with the sword, the sword was never to depart from his house; having divided the house of another, his own house was to be divided; having taken his neighbour's wife, his own wives were to be given to his neighbour; having sinned secretly, he was to be punished in kind openly; and having given great occasion to the enemies of the Lord to blaspheme, the child that was born to him was to die.

The law of retaliation, which forms the ground of this judgment, had its origin in the law of equity—"Do to others as ye would that others should do to you." In heaven, and among the heavenly minded, this law is only known as the rule for measuring out good to one another; but when it descends into the lower world, and among natural men in whom heavenly order is inverted, it becomes the rule for measuring out evil, "An eye for an eye, and a tooth for a tooth." Still it is the same Divine law, being the law of providence in the one case, and the law of permission in the other. When God permits the employment of the law of retaliation, it is to teach us that every evil has within itself its own punishment, and that every evil act ultimately returns on the head of him who commits it. In the present instance

we are instructed that, even when sins have been confessed and forgiven, the evil condition of mind in which they have originated cannot be corrected, and the mind restored to a right state, without conflict with the very evils from which our sins have proceeded. We are not to suppose that repentance and forgiveness wipe our sins at once and for ever away. Repentance turns our faces Zionwards ; but in our journey to the holy city we have to encounter the very evils that have led us away from its gates ; and unless we overcome them, we can never gain that place of security and peace. The life of the spiritual man is one of conflict ; the sword never departs from his house ; the foes against whom he has to contend are those of his own household—the evils of his own heart ; the sin he has committed in secret is to return upon him openly, and the fruit of sin itself is to die.

We may humbly trust that the purer principles of Christianity and the grace of its Divine Author will preserve us from sinning after the similitude of David's transgression. Yet the contemplation of his transgression is profitable. We inherit the same nature, and are of like passions, and are exposed to the same temptations, as the Israelitish king. Do we not, then, need to regard his sin as a warning? But we need to be warned against more than the deeds themselves which he committed. Impurity of thought and intention is the unclean sin in its beginning, and to cherish is to commit. Anger and revenge are more than the seeds of murder : they are the branches of the evil tree that bears the deadly fruit. These we have to learn, from David's double crime, to shun. But we may learn from it to look still deeper into our hearts and minds. We may see both evils in their first origin in the violation of any spiritual principle of good whatever, and in perverting the truth that teaches, guards, and defends it. Knowing that every part of the Holy Word is divinely inspired, and is given for correction, for reproof, for instruction in righteousness, let us remember the end for which it is given—that the man of God may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works.

CHAPTER XVI.

AMNON AND TAMAR.

2 *Samuel* xiii.

THE Sacred Scriptures have some characteristics which can hardly fail to impress any candid mind with the conviction that they are the Word of God and not the word of man. They have evidently been written for the purpose of teaching great truths and inculcating high

principles, with a total absence of even the appearance of being trimmed to meet the views of human expediency. In recording the lives of those who profess to be the servants or the friends of God, deeds that tarnish the character, and actions that shed lustre upon it, are recorded with the same openness and fidelity; and those who occupy the highest stations or exercise the holiest functions, are treated with the same impartial judgment that is meted out to the meanest and obscurest in the land. In such cases human expediency would have suggested either a total suppression or great modification of the facts, on the ground that the misdeeds of religious men bring discredit on the cause with which they are connected. God has a tender regard for the honour of His Church and kingdom; but this does not prevent Him from exposing the misdeeds, or bringing to light the secret sins, of those who belong to them. David, for instance, is blamed, not only for having committed a grievous sin, but for having given occasion to the enemies of the Lord to blaspheme; but this does not prevent a public exposure of his secret crime. It has been remarked how faithfully the Evangelists chronicle events, even when their own failings and faults are to be recorded. Human policy inclines men to act differently. God blames, but does not conceal, the sins of His people. The Church may not be disinclined to censure the evils of her children, but she is disposed to hide them from the eyes of the world. Concealment sometimes even puts on the semblance of charity. Charity does not indeed delight in exposing the sins of others; but neither does she desire to conceal them merely to prevent a public scandal.

Another characteristic of the Scriptures which supports their claim to be the Word of God is this. They show no false delicacy. They speak of impure actions in a becoming manner; but they do not smooth them over so as to take away their true repulsiveness. The fact that the Scriptures mention them at all is considered by some as an offence against modesty. To treat impure subjects, or even to speak of them, in such a manner as to pander to a prurient feeling, is in itself impure; but when the truth is told for the sake of good as an end, the end justifies the means, and makes that pure which in itself is impure. "To the pure all things are pure."

The case of Amnon and Tamar stands alone in the page of Divine Revelation. The case may be briefly stated, and we shall do this as far as possible in the words of Scripture. "Absalom the son of David had a fair sister, whose name was Tamar; and Amnon the son of David loved her." It was against the law of Moses for a man to marry his sister, the daughter of his father or the daughter of his mother (Lev. xviii. 9). Amnon's was therefore an unlawful passion; and the sequel shows it was as impure as it was criminal. But

"Amnon was so vexed, that he fell sick for his sister Tamar; for she was a virgin; and Amnon thought it hard for him to do any thing to her." There was as yet something of honour in Amnon's passion. But he yielded to evil counsel. His cousin Jonadab, a very subtil man, saw his leanness, and having extracted from him his secret, gave him the advice which he acted upon. Amnon lay down on his bed and made himself sick, and when the king came to see him, he prayed that his sister Tamar might come, and make him a couple of cakes in his sight, that he might eat them at her hand. When he had allured the unsuspecting maiden into his chamber, where she brought the cakes for him to eat, "he took hold of her, and said unto her, Come lie with me, my sister." She remonstrated and eloquently pleaded against the threatened violation of her virgin purity. "Howbeit he would not hearken unto her voice: but, being stronger than she, forced her, and lay with her." "As the nightingale in Hesiod sung in vain to the ravenous hawk, so Tamar said all her words to a deaf man, who was wholly under the power of his furious lust, and was regardless of God and man."

But this was not the consummation of his crime, though the sequel was its not unnatural consequence. "Then Amnon hated her exceedingly; so that the hatred wherewith he hated her was greater than the love wherewith he had loved her. And Amnon said unto her, Arise, be gone." Tamar again remonstrated against this second cruelty as being greater than the first, but he would not hearken to her. Thrust out by his servants, "Tamar put ashes on her head, and rent her garment of divers colours that was on her, and laid her hand on her head, and went on crying." But Absalom her brother comforted her. "So Tamar remained desolate in her brother Absalom's house."

The recurrence of a case like that of Amnon and Tamar is not much to be feared, and therefore need not be greatly guarded against. But the passion in which it originated is common to all men, and the form it took in Amnon was not an unnatural but only an unrestrained development; and it is no doubt recorded in Scripture to show us, by an extreme case, what evil the desire, when ungoverned and unhallowed, may produce. The sinful indulgence of the sexual passion, which unhappily is not uncommon, is fraught with such ruinous consequences, especially to that half of the human family on whose unstained purity the moral beauty of social and domestic life so greatly depends, that a strong sense of duty overcomes any scruples of conventional delicacy there may be against treating of the subject. We cannot perhaps do better, in drawing attention to Amnon's sin, than to show the difference there is, in some essential respects, between love and passion.

The first and most essential difference between them is, that love is a human affection and passion is an animal desire. Both of them

exist in man, but one belongs to his human nature, the other to his animal nature. Man is human by virtue of what he enjoys above what animals possess. In common with the inferior creatures he inherits all the natural desires and appetites, and among them those which draw the sexes to each other. But besides the animal nature man has a rational soul; and it is this which makes him human. Strictly speaking, the rational soul, as inherited by birth, is rather the faculty of becoming human than humanity itself. Humanity, as we have had occasion to remark, consists of goodness and truth, or love and wisdom, which are the principles of human life, and which make man truly human, because truly rational. Now passion is an affection of the animal nature, and love is an affection of the rational soul. Passion is therefore a natural affection, and desires only natural gratification; while love is a rational affection, and desires rational satisfactions and enjoyments. Nay, love, in its best state, is spiritual and celestial, and aspires after a spiritual and eternal union.

Notwithstanding the possession of a rational soul, man may remain natural and sensual. He may live so much in his animal nature, that his rational faculty may remain comparatively undeveloped. He may therefore be more an animal than a man. The main difference between a sensual man and an animal is, that the animal follows its desires, uninfluenced by any higher end, and undirected by any higher law, than those which the Creator has inscribed upon its nature. Man may combine other motives, such as worldly advantage, rank, dignity; and may be outwardly ruled by the laws of his country and of social life, or by the love of reputation. There is, on the other hand, this difference between a sensual man and an animal. The animal never employs force or cunningly devised schemes to gratify its sexual desire, but man employs both, so that his human faculties, when perverted, make him more dangerous and viler than a beast.

The present historical circumstance affords an instance of a passion so strong as to consume the body, and yet be merely natural, a proof that the ardency of a passion is no test of its purity. The character of an affection is determined by the state and condition of the man. With the sensual man love is sensual even as it is in the mind; with the spiritual man love is spiritual even as it is in the body. It is the merit and advantage of religion, that it enters into the inmost of the mind, and creates a motive higher than the world and more enduring than time; and that it permeates and purifies and sanctifies all the affections, passions, and appetites of man's nature.

The second difference between love and passion is, that love is orderly, and passion is disorderly. Order is prescribed by laws. We do not here refer so much to the laws of man as to the laws of God. From a merely natural point of view laws seem to be simply limitations

and restraints; and some natural men have held that the only difference between marriage and free love is, that one is artificial and the other is natural. If man, like the animal, had the law inscribed on his nature, he would need no outward rules. As this is not the case, he requires to be made acquainted with what is necessary for his guidance in the order and conduct of life. To a rational man law is not so much a restraint as a direction. The law does not restrain him, he restrains himself by the law, and walks in it as the divinely appointed means of order, which leads to happiness. It is necessary for our welfare and happiness that our natural appetites and passions should be restrained and kept in order. The greatest misfortune that could overtake us would be to abolish all law, and leave our natural man to do as wished. And yet there is a time and state when law can be dispensed with; and that is when the law has done its work by reducing all unruly things to subjection and bringing all right things into order; when love takes the place of law; for love is the fulfilling of the law (Rom. xiii. 10). Amnon's was a disorderly love. There are instances indeed in the early parts of Scripture of marriage between what were afterwards made prohibited degrees. Abraham and Sarah were brother and sister, being, like Amnon and Tamar, children of the same father, but not of the same mother. But arrangements that are suitable to a simpler state of society and purer state of life, are not always safe and proper in what is called a more advanced state of civilization, in which life is more artificial.

A third difference between love and passion is, that love is a principle, passion is an impulse. Passion has a view to its own gratification, without having any regard for the honour, welfare, or happiness of the object to whom it is directed. Love has respect to them all. No more clear and unmistakable characteristic of love, as distinguished from passion, is its delicate sense of propriety, its scrupulous regard for the honour and purity of its object. Love does not extinguish passion, but it quells its unruly motions, and brings it into compliance with the dictates of honour, and the sentiments of admiration and esteem. So far from desiring or meditating anything that could, in the smallest degree, injure the object loved, it becomes her guardian and protector. No desire is so debasing as mere passion; no affection is so ennobling as true love.

Lastly, love, as distinguished from passion, is constant. Amnon, when his passion was gratified, hated Tamar, so that the hatred wherewith he hated her was greater than the love wherewith he loved her. Sensual love may not in all cases change its character so suddenly and completely as his, but its tendency is to pass off into indifference or loathing. Inherently it is not the love of another but the love of self. And that hatred which Amnon exhibited lies within

such a passion from the beginning. The love of self is the hatred of others. And that very passion which seems like love is hate, because it seeks its own in the ruin of another. And this its hidden nature comes, in some instances, to be its outward and obvious character. But whether it takes this outward visible form or not, unscrupulous passion is in its essence hatred. Love is constant, because it is founded, not on the love of self, but on the love of another. It rests on esteem and on inmost confiding friendship. It is the love of character more than of person, therefore of inward more than of outward beauty. Love thus lies within passion as a diamond in its matrix; and the union which it desires is essentially a union of soul with soul and of mind with mind, without which outward union and passional gratification are mean and inhuman. Love, as distinguished from passion, is therefore not only constant, but increases in all the qualities that produce constancy. Union formed by love becomes more perfect, and the more perfect the more enduring. Indeed the union of two souls, formed by true conjugal love, survives the death of the material body, and cohabitation increases in constancy, happiness, and delight through eternity.

We may remark, in conclusion, that the principles of the Christian religion, as restored and exalted in the Writings of the New Church, afford just ground of confidence that those who adopt them in heart and life will be preserved from every form of Amnon's sin, as well as from sin in every other form. The light that now shines forth from the sacred page of Divine Revelation, exhibits so clearly the hidden springs of human action and the root and radicles of sin, and shows us how certainly we may detect the evil in ourselves, that the teaching of the New Church affords a powerful protection against the specious grounds on which deviation from the strict line of religious virtue is often presented and urged upon us both from within and from without. On the particular subject of the relation of the sexes, the teaching of the New Church is highly instructive and eminently practical, and so exalts our ideas of the purity and sanctity of conjuga love, that every true member of the Church must regard chastity as the tenderest part of the moral sense, and that he who offends against it touches the very apple of the eye.

The sin of Amnon has some relation, as it has some family likeness, to the sin of David, which it immediately follows in the series of the history, if we except David's terrible treatment of the conquered Ammonites. The Divine record seems as if intended by its Author to reveal the effects, in their worst forms, of ungoverned and unsanctified passion. But these evils spring from spiritual causes, which they therefore represent. On this subject it may be sufficient to say that "in the Word, in the internal sense, adulteries signify

adulterations of good, and whoredoms, falsifications of truth; but the filthy conjunctions which, in Leviticus (xviii. 6-24), are called the prohibited degrees, signify various kinds of profanation." As the state of the Church at the time of its end, when the Lord was in the world, is here represented, these are the evils which had come to prevail in it, and which He by temptation-conflicts overcame and removed. The pure truth and good of the Word, and, as a consequence, the faith and love of the Church, had become so corrupted that hardly anything of pure and undefiled religion remained. These the Lord came to restore. But, in order to remove the corruption, He had to contend against it still more in its inward invisible essence than in its outward visible form. He reproved the corruptions of the Jews, and through them of the world, and taught that lust is adultery and hatred murder; but He also had to endure the temptations of the wilderness, the agony of the garden, and the shame of the cross, because men had ceased to resist the devil, or to be agonized by sin, or to crucify the lusts of the flesh.

There is another aspect in which this painful case is to be regarded. Once erect and beautiful as the palm-tree, whose name she bears, but now bowed down under the insupportable weight of her unspeakable wrongs, the many-coloured garment of her maidenhood rent, and sitting desolate in sackcloth, Tamar is the very image of the affection for goodness and truth shamefully polluted and vilely cast away by the unhallowed lust of falsehood and evil.

King's daughters represented the affections of goodness and truth, and the garment of divers colours which they wore was the emblem of truth as the vesture of goodness in its virgin purity. Truth is like light, which is so often used in Scripture as its emblem, as when God is said to clothe Himself with light as with a garment. Like light, truth consists of divers colours, and can be divided into them. Pure truth exists only in the Divine mind; the finite mind sees only the appearances of truth, and these are the colours into which the pure truth of God is refracted when it enters the minds of angels and men. Tamar's garment of divers colours is the truth of God as variously received and perceived by the members of the Church. The rending of her garment was thus a representative sign, that when the good of the Church is violated, its truth is rent in pieces, as the Lord's garment was at the time of the crucifixion. If, when good is destroyed or profaned, the truth were to remain, it would deceive, because it would be an appearance behind which there was no reality, a garment that would cover iniquity and give it the appearance of righteousness, or that would, as in the present case, conceal the violence which the good of the Church has suffered at the hand of sinful man. Tamar, when she rent her garment, put ashes, and laid her hand, upon her head,

which indicated that when good is profaned, not only is truth divided and destroyed, but all true intelligence is lost; and she went on weeping, as a sign of mourning in bitterness of spirit over the desolate state of the Church.

According to the law of Moses Amnon's life was forfeited (Lev. xviii. 9, 29). David was very wroth, yet Amnon escaped unpunished. But Absalom, though he spake unto his brother Amnon neither good nor bad, determined to avenge his sister's wrongs; and the stroke came though it was long delayed. "It came to pass after two full years, that Absalom had sheepshearers in Baal-hazor, which is beside Ephraim: and Absalom invited all the king's sons." Wealth in those days consisted chiefly in flocks and herds; and sheepshearing was an honourable occupation, not beneath the dignity of princes. Sheep-shearing signifies the performance of use, and the fleece of the sheep the good of charity. But the place where this sheepshearing took place indicates the character of the use to which it was to be applied. Ephraim represented the intellectual principle of the Church, and the city of Ephraim, which is here meant, and which was in the tribe of Judah, not far from Jerusalem, signified the doctrine of the Church, while Baal-hazor, which means a fenced place, a castle, signifies reasoning by which her doctrine is confirmed. Absalom's position, which he assumed and no doubt justified to himself, was near and partly within the doctrine of the Church upon the subject, for the law awarded death to Amnon's crime, but it was against the law for him, of his own will, to inflict the punishment. Amnon's death was merited, but the act that deprived him of his life was lawless. But lawlessness characterized Absalom's subsequent conduct, and finally proved his ruin. Yet there is in this act a permissive and overruling Providence. Where legal justice sleeps, it is in certain conditions well that natural justice should rise up and redress a flagrant wrong. Natural justice is, however, a dangerous power, and is inconsistent with orderly and stable government. It rests on private feelings and interests, and is wanting in the dispassionate and impartial judgment that belongs to a tribunal which is based on general principles and regards the public good. But Amnon has fallen under a stroke that he had not unjustly drawn down upon himself. He who had dishonoured a sister has been slain by a brother. And these unnatural deeds may be regarded as counterparts of each other, and as teaching the solemn lesson that one evil produces another of a kindred nature, turning even domestic love into hatred and virtue into vice, and bringing upon the soul certain destruction.

CHAPTER XVII.

THE WIDOW OF TEKOAH'S PARABLE AND ABSALOM'S RETURN.

2 Samuel xiv.

ABSALOM, when he had slain Amnon, fled, and went to Talmai king of Geshur, who was his grandfather; he being the son of Maacah, the daughter of Talmai, one of David's wives (iii. 3). Absalom was like an offending child who seeks refuge from a father's severity in a mother's tenderness. In this Syrian kingdom he remained three years. Being himself a Syrian by maternal descent, he no doubt, during the period of his abode in Geshur, strengthened this hereditary side of his character, which he so conspicuously displayed after his return to Judea. For Syria, while it represented the knowledge of spiritual things, represented also that knowledge perverted; as the sons of the East, which the Syrians are sometimes called, were wise men, but were also among those of whom it is said, "Thy wisdom and thy knowledge, it hath perverted thee" (Isa. xlvii. 10).

David's love of Absalom gradually overcame his displeasure. "The soul of king David longed to go forth unto Absalom: for he was comforted concerning Amnon, seeing he was dead." When Joab perceived that the king's heart was towards Absalom, he employed his ingenuity to obtain the king's consent to Absalom's return without directly proposing it. He "sent to Tekoah, and fetched thence a wise woman, and said unto her, I pray thee, feign thyself to be a mourner, and put on now mourning apparel, and anoint not thyself with oil, but be as a woman that had a long time mourned for the dead: and come to the king, and speak on this manner unto him. So Joab put the words in her mouth."

The parable which Joab put into the mouth of the woman of Tekoah, though not equal either in its subject or its object to the parable of Nathan the prophet, was well adapted to the purpose it was intended to serve. Attired as a widow who had long mourned for the dead, she came to implore the help of the king. "Thy handmaid had two sons, and they two strove together in the field, and there was none to part them, but the one smote the other, and slew him. And, behold, the whole family is risen against thine handmaid, and they said, Deliver him that smote his brother, that we may kill him, for the life of his brother whom he slew; and we will destroy the heir also: and so they shall quench my coal which is left, and shall not leave to my husband neither name nor remainder upon the earth." The king desired her

to return to her house, and he would give charge concerning her. This was not sufficient for the suppliant's purpose. She led the king on, till he made the solemn declaration, "As the Lord liveth, there shall not one hair of thy son fall to the earth." Then she disclosed her purpose, and applied her parable, not indeed with the overpowering directness and authority of the prophet, as the man and messenger of God, but with a freedom and boldness that bespoke the consciousness of being upheld by a power greater than her own. "Wherefore then," she demands, "hast thou thought such a thing against the people of God? For the king doth speak this thing as one which is faulty, in that the king doth not fetch home again his banished." After alluding to the case of the manslayer, for whom God had appointed a city of refuge, and devised means that his banished be not expelled from him, she concludes with saying, "The word of my lord the king shall now be comfortable: for as an angel of God, so is my lord the king to discern good and bad: therefore the Lord thy God will be with thee."

But the king had discerned more than the wise woman suspected. He saw not merely what was the purpose of the parable, but who was its real author. "The king answered and said unto the woman, Hide not from me, I pray thee, the thing that I shall ask thee. Is not the hand of Joab with thee in all this?" In confessing the truth, the woman makes it the means of paying an Oriental compliment to the king, as being "wise, according to the wisdom of an angel of God, to know all things that are in the earth."

Although this scheme for obtaining the king's consent to the return of Absalom was of human contrivance, the circumstances, in virtue of their forming part of an inspired record, have a Divine and spiritual meaning.

In Joab we see here, as in the case of Uriah, the pliant instrument of the king's will, as the reasoning faculty he represents can be of the human will. Joab perceived that the heart of the king was toward Absalom. But the wise woman of Tekoah was Joab's instrument. She did not devise, but her woman's wit was relied on for the effective execution of a plan which might require much more than clever acting. As women's perceptions are keener than their reasonings are powerful, they have more resources for sudden emergency than men have; and the woman of Tekoah showed herself to be, in this respect, equal to the occasion. She is not, however, alone in her reputation for wisdom. A little further on in this history, we shall meet with another wise woman whose quick perception and decision of character were the means of saving a city from destruction at the hand of Joab himself.

There is not much in the Word to guide us as to any connection that existed between the wise woman and Tekoah. This city is mentioned twice in the prophets. Amos was a herdsman of Tekoah

when he was called to the prophetic office (i. 1); and Jeremiah speaks of it. "O ye children of Benjamin, gather yourselves to flee out of the midst of Jerusalem, and blow the trumpet in Tekoah, and set up a sign of fire in Beth-haccerem: for evil appeareth out of the north, and great destruction" (vi. 1). "The subject here treated of is the devastation of the Church as to truth and good, because it is against Zion and Jerusalem, for Zion signifies the good of the Church and Jerusalem its truth; and as the sons of Benjamin signify the conjunction of goodness and truth, they are commanded to assemble themselves out of the midst of Jerusalem, to blow the trumpet in Tekoah, and kindle a fire in Beth-haccerem (or the house of the vineyard). To blow the trumpet signifies combat, by virtue of truths derived from good, against that Church, the house of the vineyard signifying that Church itself, and to kindle a fire upon it signifies the destruction of the same by evil loves. The north, from which the evil appears, signifies the falsity of evil, and the great destruction the dissipation of goodness and truth." Tekoah and Beth-haccerem were near each other, and not far from Jerusalem; and it is evident, from the trumpet blown in the one and a sign of fire set up in the other, that they have reference to the two principles of truth and goodness in the Church; for truth is the trumpet that sounds the alarm, and good is the sign of fire, and is that which the fire of evil love destroys. When Amos was among the herdsmen of Tekoah he was called by the Lord to raise a warning voice to backsliding Israel; and he speaks of the Lord's word through him by this same figure: "Shall a trumpet be blown in the city, and the people not be afraid?" (ii. 6.) Tekoah, therefore, as mentioned by the prophets, is that truth which comes with the voice of warning and expostulation. The voice, in the case we are now considering, is that of a woman, although the words she utters are those of a man. The parable, which was designed to win the king's consent, must, it is true, be put into a woman's mouth; but, for a higher reason, it was meet that the expostulation and appeal should be uttered by a woman's voice; for the king himself desired what he was to be asked to grant; and one who was the type of affection was the suitable medium of appealing to the heart. Yet the king, when his affection had been secured, saw through the artifice, he saw that the voice was indeed the widow's voice, but that the words were the words of Joab. As in the case of Jacob, when clothed in Esau's garments, good was without and truth was within. It was under the semblance of good that truth attained its object.

The parable itself was simple; and though the main incident was true, the circumstances connected with it were not. It was true that one brother slew the other, but it was not true that they strove together in the field, and that there was none to part them. This part

of the parable was not based upon the law of Moses, for no case of this kind occurs in the civil code. The law treats of accidental and of wilful homicide. For him who killed his neighbour ignorantly, whom he hated not in time past, a city of refuge was provided; but for him who hated his neighbour, and lay in wait for him, and rose up against him, and smote him mortally that he died, there was no escape (Deut. xix.). It is evident that in the time of David the law of Moses was not, at least in all cases, strictly enforced. And this may be regarded as indicating the state of the Church at the time our Lord was in the world, when the law was in a great measure set aside; and when, in consequence, the Lord's mercy was exercised, not against the law, but without it. For at the end of the Church, the people are in a great measure in the state of the servant that knew not his lord's will, and committed things worthy of stripes, and who was therefore beaten with few (Luke xii. 48). The Lord is mercy itself. He is the lord in the parable who forgave his servant ten thousand talents because he asked him. But answers to prayer and forgiveness of sins are not always represented in Scripture as so directly or easily obtained as in the parable of the indebted servant. In the parable of the unjust judge we are taught the necessity of persistent prayer, and encouraged confidently to hope that, however long delayed, an answer of peace will come at last. The Divine mercy, though in itself spontaneous and unbounded, is hindered and limited in its exercise by the unfitness of sinners to receive and use it. And he who obtains mercy in the forgiveness of his sins, may forfeit that mercy by being himself unmerciful, as did the forgiven servant when he refused to forgive a fellow-servant, who owed him an hundred pence (Matt. xviii. 23-35). So we find Absalom, after he had obtained his father's forgiveness, rebelling against him. Here, however, we have only to consider the forgiveness. For this there was a desire on both sides. Both the king and Absalom desired reconciliation. But means were required to bring it about. And this is always the case whether it is indicated or not. However simple and direct the action of the mind may seem, there are many different powers called into activity in even the simplest mental operation; just as in the body every movement calls innumerable parts into action. In all cases of reconciliation and conjunction there must be reconciling and conjoining mediums. And the operation may seem to begin with them. The rational faculty, for instance, is so constituted that it has the power of looking upward and downward, upward to heaven and downward to the world, upward to what is spiritual and downward to what is natural; or, what is the same, the rational is able to look inward and outward, inward to the inner man and outward to the outer man, and to mediate between them, so as to reconcile and unite them.

Joab's mediation through the widow was successful. "The king said unto Joab, Behold now, I have done this thing: go therefore, bring the young man Absalom again." Joab fell to the ground on his face, and bowed himself, and thanked the king, representing the submission of the rational to the spiritual; and then he arose and went to Geshur, and brought Absalom to Jerusalem, representing the influx of the spiritual through the rational into the natural, by which the natural is elevated into a spiritual state. But reconciliation and conjunction were not yet complete. "The king said, Let him turn to his own house, and let him not see my face." The face represents the interior of the mind, as the back represents its exterior. Hence so much is said of the Lord's face, as expressive of the inmost and hidden nature of God, which no man can see and live, and which yet may be seen as brought forth to view in the Divine Humanity, which veils the glory of the Essential Divinity; and hence Moses, who desired to see the Divine Glory, was not permitted to see the Lord's face, but only His back parts. In this state of incomplete reconciliation Absalom remained two full years, that number which is so often mentioned when a state representative of conjunction, or one ready for conjunction, is treated of. "Therefore Absalom sent for Joab, to have sent him to the king." But Joab, though sent for three times, refused to come; and was only induced to comply by Absalom's servants setting Joab's field of barley on fire. A full state of truth does not of itself bring the rational over to the natural; but when the fire of natural love, as zeal, invades the good of the rational mind, which is from a natural origin, and is in connection with natural good, as Joab's field was near Absalom's field, or place, then is the effect produced. "Joab came to the king, and told him: and when he had called for Absalom, he came to the king, and bowed himself on his face to the ground before the king: and the king kissed Absalom." Thus the son humbled himself before his father, and his father gave him the kiss of love, the symbol of reconciliation and conjunction.

CHAPTER XVIII.

THE REBELLION OF ABSALOM.

2 Samuel xv. 1-9.

WHEN, after David had procured the death of Uriah, and taken Bathsheba to be his wife, the prophet was sent by the Lord to reprove the king and pronounce judgment against him, one of the consequences of his sin was declared to be, that the Lord would raise up

evil against him out of his own house. This was amply verified in the rebellion of Absalom. That prince, as we have seen, had slain his brother Amnon, and fled to Geshur, where he remained three years. On being, by the indulgence of his father, permitted to return to Jerusalem, and afterwards admitted into his favour, he, by his condescension and apparent and professed desire to care for their concerns and judge in their disputes, stole the hearts of the people. This was but a means to effect his end, which was to seize the throne of his father. And having on a false pretence obtained leave to go to Hebron, he sent spies through all Israel, who declared him king. War was now made by this ambitious and unnatural son against his father; and a battle was fought between the army of David and that of Absalom in the wood of Ephraim. The arms of the king prevailed: and Absalom himself, carried by his mule under the thick boughs of a great oak, was caught by his head, his hair getting entangled in its branches; and, the mule passing from under him, he was left suspended between heaven and earth, where he was slain by Joab thrusting three arrows through his heart.

This portion of sacred history, one of the most painful that the Word contains, and one of the most dreadful that history records, has its moral, and should be read with a feeling of deep humiliation. It exhibits one of the worst phases of our degenerate nature, and holds up a solemn warning both to parents and children, to guard against the neglect or violation of those laws Divinely delivered and enjoined for the prevention of evils destructive of domestic as well as of public order, peace, and happiness.

But this historical relation contains still deeper lessons in virtue of its spiritual or internal meaning, a meaning which it contains in common with every part of the Divine Word, as the result of its inspiration. Were we to consider it in that inmost sense, in which the Word relates to the Lord as the Word Incarnate, we should find that the present circumstance points to some one of the Lord's deepest temptations. David was a type of the Lord in human nature, while engaged in the work of redemption, a work which He effected by admitting temptations from the whole powers of darkness, and combating against them from His own inherent power. And those temptations were admitted through the hereditary evils of his maternal humanity, which the tempting powers endeavoured to excite into hostility or rebellion against the will of the Father, or of the Divinity that dwelt within Him. In the Lord indeed there could be no actual evil, which alone is sin, although there was a will which He inherited from His human mother contrary to the will which He inherited from His Divine Father; but that will He ever held in submission to the Divine will, as expressed in His words, "Not My will, but Thine be done." The rebellion of Absalom

represented, therefore, in respect to the Lord, only a temptation to evil, but not evil itself, since He never sinned either by consent or act. In human beings, however, evil does not always end with the temptation to commit it. Every one is more or less guilty of actual evil, and is thereby a sinner. Those, indeed, who have begun to follow the Lord in the regenerate life, must be understood to successfully resist temptation, though not every temptation, nor everything in any one, since no one who yields in all can be a true follower of Him who never yielded in any. When any one overcomes a temptation, the evil which gave it admission is weakened or removed, and order and peace are more or less completely restored. In these temptations, a man's foes are often, in a peculiar sense, they of his own house- his own cherished evil desires and false thoughts being the enemies that rise up against him, and the nearer these are to the centre of his life, the deeper the temptation, the severer the trial.

The rebellion of Absalom is a fit symbol of some of those temptations and trials ; and the defeat and death of that unnatural son a fit emblem of their removal.

While this application of the subject presents itself when viewed from the side of the victor, it admits of another application when regarded from that of the vanquished : and it is on this side that we propose to contemplate the circumstance of Absalom's death.

We may consider him as, in the most obvious sense, representing one who is inspired with the love of dominion. The love of dominion, for its own sake, is the love of self in one of its deepest and most dangerous forms. When that lust obtains complete ascendancy in the heart, it allows nothing to stand between it and its object. It quenches the warmest affections, and breaks asunder the strongest ties. It is the Lucifer that seeks to exalt its throne above the stars of heaven, and to aspire to unlimited authority.

But there is another and greater evil than ambition, however towering, which the rebellion of Absalom represented. To see what this evil is, we must inquire more particularly into his representative character than it has been hitherto thought necessary to do. We have to consider his parentage. He was the son of David by Maachah, daughter of Talmai king of Geshur.

In the highest sense kings represented the Lord, their wives represented the Church, and their sons and daughters those who are born of the Lord as a father and of the Church as a mother. As there is but one Lord, there can be but one Church, as the Lord's bride and wife. Yet David and Solomon, who were eminent types of the Lord, had many wives and concubines. In what respect did these represent the Church? If the Church on earth were one and undivided, the union of the Lord and His Church could only be represented by a

marriage of one husband with one wife. This is true of the purely celestial Church, to which the Lord is related as a Husband in His priestly character; and to represent the absolute unity of this Church, a priest was not allowed to have more than one wife, and that wife must have been married a virgin. In the spiritual Church, even in its celestial state—for there is a celestial of the spiritual, as there is a spiritual of the celestial—the case is different. The spiritual Church, like the celestial, is one before the Lord, but before men it is many and even diverse. The Church universal consists of numerous general and particular churches, both within and beyond the pale of the visible Church, where the Word is known and the Lord is acknowledged; as in our day, in Christendom and in Heathendom. The reason of this difference of the Church, as seen by the Lord and by men, is this. The Lord looks at the Church in respect to its goodness and love, and men look at the Church in respect to its truth and faith; or, as the Lord Himself expresses it, man looketh on the outward appearance (literally, on the eyes), but the Lord looketh upon the heart. The celestial Church is one in itself, and the spiritual Church is one in the Lord's sight, because good, which is the celestial principle, is one, but truth, which is the spiritual principle, is manifold. This difference is expressed even with regard to the Lord Himself, in the two Divine names by which He is chiefly designated. Jehovah, which is His Divine celestial name, is singular, but Elohim, which is His Divine spiritual name, is plural. Good, which is the celestial principle, is one, but truth, which is the spiritual principle, is manifold. And in this we see one of the wonders of Divine mercy. Good is the saving grace, and good is one; but the one good can be given under various forms of truth, or under various modes of faith; and thus can the Lord save those of every religion, in which a God is acknowledged, and evil is condemned as sin against Him, and good is required to be loved for His sake. On this interesting subject the Writings shed a clear light. Take an example. The author is treating of the family of Nahor, the brother of Abram, by his wife Milcah and his concubine Rumah; where Nahor and Milcah signify the good and truth among a certain class of Gentiles. He says, "That the Gentiles are in possession of truths may appear from many considerations. For it is well known that the Gentiles of old were in wisdom and intelligence, in that they acknowledged one God, and wrote concerning Him with much sanctity. They acknowledged also the immortality of the soul, and a life after death, and likewise the happy state of the good and the unhappy state of the wicked. Their laws, moreover, were grounded in the commandments of the Decalogue—that God is to be worshipped, that parents are to be honoured, that murder, theft, and adultery are crimes which ought not to be committed, and that it is sinful to covet

what belongs to others. Nor were they content to practise these things in externals only, but insisted on their internal observance. The case is the same at this day. The well-disposed Gentiles in all parts of the earth discourse on these subjects better than Christians, nor do they discourse only, but live accordingly. These and various truths are in possession of the Gentiles, and join themselves with the good which they have from the Lord. In consequence of this conjunction, they are in a state of receiving still more truths, because one truth acknowledges another, and they easily enter into consociation, there being connections and relationships of truths. Hence it is that they who have been principled in good in the world easily receive the truths of faith in the other life. Things false with such persons do not join themselves with good; they only apply themselves, but so as to be easily separable from them. Falsities which are joined remain; but those which are only applied are separated, and they are separated when the truths of faith are learned and imbibed; for every truth of faith removes and separates what is false, insomuch that at length what is false shuns and hates what is true."

Now Absalom's mother belonged to one of those Gentile nations which were in possession of truths. The daughter of the king of Geshur, she was a Syrian. In Syria the ancient Church and afterwards the Hebrew Church had their principal home. Abram, who was a Syrian, was, as a remnant of this second ancient Church, called out of his country and from his father's house, to be the father of the representative Church, named after Israel; for every Church is first formed from that which has come to its end, as the Christian Church had its commencement with those whom the Lord called out of the expiring Jewish Church. The king's wives, who were of several different nations, represented, as we shall have occasion, in treating of Solomon's numerous wives and concubines, to show, the one universal Church as consisting of numerous general and particular churches, both within and beyond the pale of the visible Church. Maachah therefore represented the Church among the Gentiles, such as were those who at that time lived in Geshur in Syria. Even after it became Gentile, Syria represented the knowledge of goodness and truth, because from ancient times such knowledge was preserved there, as appears from that possessed by Balaam. Absalom, therefore, as the son of Maachah, represented the truth, or knowledge of the truth, as it had descended from the Ancient and Hebrew Church, and even as it exists now in some of the more enlightened Gentile nations. The Hebrew Church, from which Syrian knowledge had been proximately derived, was far more spiritual in its character than the Church established among the Israelites.

This representative character of Absalom may be seen in the parti-

culars recorded respecting his personal gifts and address. "In all Israel there was none to be so much praised as Absalom for his beauty: from the sole of his foot even to the crown of his head there was no blemish in him. And when he polled his head, (for it was at every year's end that he polled it: because the hair was heavy on him, therefore he polled it:) he weighed the hair of his head at two hundred shekels after the king's weight." This beauty of person and unblemished perfectness of form represented the externals—the representatives and significatives of the ancient Church. "The ancients had representatives and significatives of things celestial and spiritual pertaining to the Lord's kingdom, thus to the Lord Himself. Those who understood them were called wise, and in reality were wise; for by means of them they were enabled to converse with spirits and angels, inasmuch as angelic discourse, which is incomprehensible to man, as being spiritual and celestial, when it is conveyed down to man, who is in a natural sphere, falls into representatives and significatives such as exist in the Word; and hence it is that the Word is a holy code or volume. And as the ancients were in the representatives and significatives of the Lord's kingdom, in which nothing but celestial and spiritual love prevails, they had also doctrinals which treated solely of love to God and charity to the neighbour; by virtue of which they were called wise." And then the marvellous growth of hair, whose very weight made an annual polling necessary, when that which was removed weighed two hundred shekels. Hair signifies what is natural belonging to man. Ezekiel, in treating of the new temple, says of the priests, who were to minister in it, that they shall not shave their head, nor suffer their locks to grow long; they shall only poll their heads (xliv. 20). The subject treated of under the emblem of the New Temple is the New Church. Not to shave the head or suffer the locks to grow long, but to poll the head, spiritually means that the external or natural man is not to be rejected, but is to be accommodated, so that he may be in agreement with and subordinate to the spiritual, and both to the Divine. In the other world, "those who have been rational, that is, spiritual men, with whom the natural has been rightly subordinate, appear with graceful hair; yea, in the other life it may be known from the hair what every one's quality as to the natural man is." The polling of his head every year, and the hair polled weighing two hundred shekels, represented the keeping of the natural man in subordination to the spiritual in every state of the regenerate life, and in conformity with the laws of spiritual goodness and truth.

Absalom's professions were as noble and his manners as fascinating as his person was beautiful. By taking an interest in the people's concerns, and desiring that he were made judge in the land, that he might do every man justice, and by returning great humility with

greater condescension, he stole the hearts of the men of Israel. All this is quite consistent with spirituality of character, and is indeed one of its true manifestations and legitimate results, assuming it to be sincere.

One other circumstance is accounted for by Absalom's representative character. David's love for Absalom was singularly tender. When the king sent forth his generals with the army against him, he commanded them, saying, "Deal gently for my sake with the young man, even with Absalom," and when he heard he was slain, we know in what pathetic language he lamented his death. The Lord's love for His spiritual Church, and for that spiritual truth which was nearer to His own Divine truth than was that received by the Israelitish Church, His desire for its preservation, and His sorrow over its fall and judgment, may be seen represented in the conduct of David respecting Absalom. And under this view we must regard the personal beauty and other good qualities of Absalom abstractedly from the moral state they for a time concealed. For under his personal beauty and faultless form there lay great depravity of heart and duplicity of mind, representing how the best gifts may be perversely applied to the worst of purposes, and thus profaned and utterly destroyed. This we shall see exemplified.

"It came to pass after forty years, that Absalom said unto the king, I pray thee, let me go and pay my vow, which I vowed unto the Lord, in Hebron." He professed he had vowed, when at Geshur in Syria, that if the Lord should bring him to Jerusalem, then he would serve the Lord. Hebron, we have seen, represented the spiritual Church. Where David had been anointed king of Judah, his son now proceeds in order to undermine and overturn his father's kingdom. The forty years, after which this came to pass, are believed to date from the time that David was anointed king by Samuel. Forty is the Scripture number for temptation. It was after Jesus had been forty days in the wilderness tempted of the devil that His three great temptations began. The trial which David was now to endure was the greatest he had yet experienced. Not his own familiar friend, who did eat his bread, but his own son, who had derived his existence from him, was to lift up his heel against him. This is truly the case of a man's foes being those of his own house; the son against the father, to be followed by the father against the son. When Nathan declared to David the word of the Lord, "Behold, I will raise up evil against thee out of thine own house," what does this mean when understood of Him whom David represented? The Lord's own house is heaven and the Church. The words of Jehovah by Nathan must, therefore, in the highest sense, refer to trials and temptations which the Redeemer was to endure from evil brought to bear upon Him by or through those of His own

house, the members of His own family, who can have been no other than those who belonged to His Church in heaven and on earth. Understood of the Lord, of whom David was a type, whom does this rebel son, and what does his rebellion, represent? In Christian literature there is a fabled rebel angel, who drew to his standard the disaffected of the heavenly host, and made war against Him who was both his Father and his King, with the unfilial and mad intention of driving Him from His throne and reigning in His stead. Every great error is the perversion of some great truth. The unperverted truth is this. The rebel angel is, in one aspect, the angelic proprium or selfhood, and his rebellion is the excitement of this selfhood against the Lord in His great work of redemption. A conscious and open rebellion among the angels is an impossibility. It would be not only the extreme of wickedness, but the extreme of folly. But that the selfhood of the angelic host should, under certain circumstances, be excited into activity, is conceivable. The hostility of the Church on earth was conscious and open. In considering the subject in relation to the Lord and His Redemption, we must not forget that an important part of His Divine work and experience was in connection with those in the intermediate region of the spiritual world, where all judgment takes place. At the period of the Incarnation a judgment was effected there on all who had remained in the world of spirits from the time of Noah, or the beginning of the ancient Church. And to the state of judgment on these the Lord referred when He said, "I beheld Satan as lightning fall from heaven." There were the prisoners of hope whose deliverance the Lord effected by redemption, and there were the foes He made His footstool. This could not be accomplished without temptation and conflict. In the Church on earth, too, there was rebellion and warfare. Among the Lord's apostles there was one that betrayed Him, and that one represented the Jewish Church. Even among the Gentiles there was enmity, though not of the same malignity, and the Gentiles had their representative in Pilate. The changed economy in the government of the Lord's universal kingdom which the Incarnation involved, is sufficient to account for an uprising of the human selfhood in all His dominions during the performance of the Divine work, in which the Lord spiritually "measured the waters in the hollow of His hand, and meted out heaven with a span, and comprehended the dust of the earth in a measure, and weighed the mountains in scales, and the hills in a balance;" or, when the Lord brought into order or reduced to obedience all things in His spiritual dominions, restoring the balance or equilibrium between heaven and hell, good and evil, spiritual and natural, a balance which had been disturbed and was wellnigh lost.

But we must not pursue the subject in this high sense. It is

sufficient to know that it has reference to the Lord, and treats of His experience as a man of sorrows and acquainted with grief.

The circumstances connected with this rebellion and the death of Absalom will form the subject of another chapter.

CHAPTER XIX.

DAVID'S FLIGHT.

2 Samuel xv. 10.

IT is singular how easily men are deceived by specious appearances and seduced by flattering appeals to their vanity or self-love. David had won renown by great deeds, Absalom's fame rested on fair speeches, and yet the hearts of the men of Israel were alienated from the man who had made their kingdom great among the nations, and given to one who had done nothing to make it illustrious, but whose present act could not fail to bring upon it deserved reproach. But Absalom stole the hearts of the people. Although in the letter this may express nothing more than that he won them, in the spirit it expresses something very different. In the spiritual sense the men of Israel represent not only the members, but the principles, of the Church, the truths which form its faith and practice. The heart of a truth is the good that it contains; for good is the essence of which truth is the form. Truth without good is the same as faith without love. Spiritually to steal the hearts of the men of Israel, is to rob truth of its goodness, and make it subservient to our own selfish purposes. When we steal from truth its heart of goodness, we implant in it the heart of evil, because we animate it with our own self-love. The spies sent out are the false principles that put on the semblance of persuasive truths, and the trumpet-sound that is to be the sign of a commencing reign is the self-glorification that seeks to exalt itself above all the truths of the Church and above the Truth itself.

But Absalom sent for Ahithophel, David's counsellor, from his city, even from Giloh, while he offered sacrifice. It seems unaccountable that he whose counsel, when he counselled in those days, was as if a man had inquired at the oracles of God, should have joined Absalom's cause, even although there had been better grounds of hope for its success. It is a Jewish opinion that Ahithophel was Bathsheba's grandsire, and that he espoused Absalom's cause to avenge the wrong David had done her. There is no great probability in this having been his motive, even supposing the relationship, since Bathsheba was now in great honour, and her son Solomon was to be the heir

to David's throne. The reason for his identifying himself with a morally bad and doubtful cause, was most likely that which a man of worldly wisdom would have for engaging in such an enterprise, that he must profit largely by success. With all his wisdom he seems to have been a worldly man, and the wisdom of such is foolishness with God, as his name, which means brother of folly, implies, and as his wisdom turned out to be. For while his counsel to Absalom, though in itself wicked, is called good, as being favourable to Absalom's cause, it was defeated by the counsel of Hushai, who had been providentially led to be a countervailing power to Ahithophel, "For the Lord had appointed to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel, to the intent that the Lord might bring evil upon Absalom." Here then was the wisdom of the world defeated by the wisdom of God, which these two counsellors respectively represent.

But another and very affecting spectacle is presented to us in the history of this conspiracy, which we find "was strong; for the people increased continually with Absalom." A messenger came to David, saying, "The hearts of the men of Israel are after Absalom. And David said unto all his servants that were with him at Jerusalem, Arise, and let us flee; for we shall not else escape from Absalom: make speed to depart, lest he overtake us suddenly, and bring evil upon us, and smite the city with the edge of the sword." David on this occasion seems to display less of the strong man than in other parts of his chequered history. But such a trial as this might well depress and unnerve him; and trials that are spiritually like his have of necessity the tendency to make men feel their own weakness. This part of the history of David has some considerable outward resemblance to that of the Lord Himself. The king with his weeping people passed over the brook Kidron; "and David went up by the ascent of mount Olivet, and wept as he went up, and had his head covered, and he went barefoot: and all the people that was with him covered every man his head, and they went up, weeping as they went up." Jesus, after telling His disciples of His departure, when sorrow filled their hearts, left Jerusalem, and went to the mount of Olives, over the dark Cedron into Gethsemane, to undergo His great temptation, and to be afterwards betrayed into the hands of His enemies by Judas, who, like the traitor Ahithophel, went and hanged himself. Nor is there an outward resemblance only, but there is, if we thought well to pursue it, an inward correspondence also. The outward results, indeed, were different. But in our Lord's case the counsel of His betrayer was defeated in the Lord's resurrection, which was a greater deliverance than that which David experienced. But there was something in David's experience that resembled that of his Lord. When David came to Bahurim, "thence came out a man of

the family of the house of Saul, whose name was Shimei, the son of Gera: he came forth, and cursed still as he came. And he cast stones at David, and at all the servants of king David: and all the people and all the mighty men were on his right hand and on his left. And thus said Shimei when he cursed, Come out, come out, thou bloody man, and thou man of Belial: the Lord hath returned upon thee all the blood of the house of Saul, in whose stead thou hast reigned; and the Lord hath delivered the kingdom into the hand of Absalom thy son: and, behold, thou art taken in thy mischief, because thou art a bloody man." Our Lord endured the reproaches of His enemies, and their violence against Him was still greater than that which Shimei showed against David. And in this case we see a shadow of the Lord's forbearance in David's meekness under the brutal conduct of this man. When Abishai desired that the king would allow him to take off Shimei's head, he said, "So let him curse, because the Lord hath said unto him, Curse David. . . . Behold, my son, which came forth of my bowels, seeketh my life: how much more now may this Benjamite do it? . . . It may be that the Lord will look on mine affliction, and that the Lord will requite me good for his cursing this day." This humiliation of David, like that of our Lord, was no doubt the means of his exaltation.

And as it was with them so is it with us. Our endurance is the means and even the measure of our exaltation. We must, it is true, suffer in the right spirit. The promise is to those who are persecuted for righteousness' sake; theirs only is the kingdom of heaven. It is possible for us to suffer for the sake of reward, which is for the sake of ourselves, and not for the Lord's sake. David no doubt had the grace of humility under suffering, but he did not always show in prosperity the same meek spirit that he exhibited in adversity, and notably in the case of Shimei. But we know that he belonged to a race and age in which great humility, like devout sanctity, could be felt intensely yet superficially. We must cultivate these and other religious conditions as abiding states, and not merely as transient feelings, much less as mere outward forms. We must rend our hearts and not our garments, we must shed the tears of penitence and not merely of sadness; we must cover the head and make bare the feet, by feeling as well as confessing that, in ourselves, there is nothing true and nothing good, that our sins are as a thick covering that shuts out from our minds the light and influence of heaven, and that makes our lives of the earth earthy.

One of the uses of adversity, whether temporal or spiritual, is to induce a state of humility, in which the Christian sees and feels his own nothingness, and his distance from Him who is all, and to deepen his sense of dependence upon that Being who is the Author of all his true light and joy.

The application of the historical events we are now considering to the Lord, and to those who are of His household, is made evident to us from the writings of David himself. The third Psalm is inscribed "a psalm of David, when he fled from Absalom his son." And we learn from the "Internal sense of the prophets and psalms," that this inspired composition is concerning the Lord when He was in temptation and subjugated the hells, and then was in a state of humiliation, and prayed to the Father. Psalm lv. is generally understood by commentators to relate to the same event; and Ahithophel's treason is supposed to be that over which David mourns where he says, "It was not an enemy that reproached me; then I could have borne it: neither was it he that hated me that did magnify himself against me; then I would have hid myself from him: but it was thou, a man mine equal, my guide, and mine acquaintance. We took sweet counsel together, and walked unto the house of God in company." Whether or not the psalm can be applied wholly to the circumstances of the present history, the description of the faithless friend is one that entered into the Lord's experience, not merely in the treason of Judas, but in that which it represented, the defection and enmity of His church. And it forms part of the experience of His disciples. It is possible that those with whom we, as disciples, may have taken sweet counsel, and walked unto the house of God in company, may cease to be friends and even become enemies, or, on the other hand, that we may become enemies to them. But there is another way in which this is realized. The counsellor which we have in our own understanding may fail us in our utmost need. And so far as it has been natural it must and will fail us in states of trial, which are permitted to show us on what a frail reed we have been leaning. But the trial, which discovers to us on what a staff of a broken reed we have trusted, and which may have pierced the hand that leaned upon it, brings to our hand another and better support; as David in losing one counsellor had another divinely directed to supply his place. And it was when David had come to the top of Olivet, where he worshipped God, that, behold, Hushai the Archite came to meet him with his coat rent, and earth upon his head. When the afflicted soul worships God from love, or from the highest affections of the heart, light and comfort come from Him who only can give help in time of trouble.

By David's direction Hushai returned to Jerusalem, where Absalom had now established himself, and, feigning himself a friend and follower, was received into Absalom's favour. David had prayed the Lord to turn the counsel of Ahithophel into foolishness; and he now evidently regarded the appearance of this Archite as an answer to his prayer, for he saw in Hushai the means by which the object of his

petition might be accomplished. An opportunity soon occurred of serving the king by defeating the counsel of Ahithophel. By the advice of this clever but unscrupulous counsellor, Absalom had, in the sight of all Israel, gone in unto his father's concubines, and by this profane act consummated his iniquity, and made it representative of the sin, in its worst form, of spiritual adultery, which is the profanation of spiritual goodness. This was the fulfilment of the Lord's judgment on David delivered by Nathan: "I will take thy wives before thine eyes, and give them unto thy neighbour, and he shall lie with thy wives in the sight of this sun. For thou didst it secretly: but I will do this thing before all Israel, and before the sun." This is a terrible exemplification of the law of life declared by our Lord, and to which the evil as well as the good are subject: "There is nothing covered, that shall not be revealed; neither hid, that shall not be known. Therefore whatsoever ye have spoken in darkness shall be heard in the light; and that which ye have spoken in the ear in closets shall be proclaimed upon the house-tops" (Luke xii. 2, 3). Innocence and truth, however hid in the inner man from the eyes of others, will come forth; and evil and falsehood, however carefully concealed, will be ultimately manifested. Evils were sometimes committed and punished in descending generations, because these represented the offspring of the will and understanding, which are affections and thoughts; and these in their turn give birth to words and acts.

In giving this evil advice Ahithophel was successful, for the iniquity of Absalom was not yet full. But here his power for evil ended. He advised immediate action against David, and offered, with twelve thousand men, to go himself in pursuit of the king, while he and the people that followed him were weary. His sudden appearance would strike terror into them; the people would flee: he would smite David only, and all the people would be brought to Absalom, and would be in peace. This saying pleased Absalom well, and all the elders of Israel. But Absalom wished also to hear the opinion of Hushai. He represented to Absalom that his father and his men were mighty men, and were chafed in their minds, as a bear robbed of her whelps in the field; that as a man of war David would not lodge with the people, but would be hid somewhere. He therefore counselled that all Israel should be gathered from Dan even to Beer-sheba, that Absalom should go to battle in his own person, and, with an overwhelming force, light upon him as dew falleth on the ground, so that of him and of all the men that were with him they should not leave so much as one. The counsel of Hushai prevailed. "For the Lord had appointed to defeat the good counsel of Ahithophel, to the intent that the Lord might bring evil upon Absalom."

When David fled from Jerusalem he was followed by Zadok and the

Levites, bearing the ark of the covenant of God; and they set down the ark; and Abiathar went up, until all the people had done passing out of the city. A ceremonial this like that which was commanded and observed when the people passed over Jordan into the Promised Land. Here as there, though the circumstances were so different, the ark had a solemnizing and sanctifying influence. It was a sign that the Divine presence was with the king and his people; for it represented the Lord as the Divine Law. But David desired the priest to carry back the ark of God into the city; expressing a pious resignation to the Divine will, whether it might please the Lord to bestow His favour upon him, and bring him again, and show him both the ark and his habitation, or to say, I have no delight in thee. "The king said also unto Zadok the priest, Art not thou a seer? return unto the city in peace, and your two sons with you, Ahimaaz thy son, and Jonathan the son of Abiathar. See, I will tarry in the plain of the wilderness, until there come word from you to certify me." David's heart is in Jerusalem, and there the ark of the covenant between him and his God should retire, to dwell securely in the inmost of his affections, while, as to the outer man, he tarries in the plain of the wilderness of trial and temptation.

And the time has now come when the priest is to convey to David word that is to certify him as to the state of affairs in relation to himself and his kingdom. Hushai, whom David had instructed to send him everything he could hear, communicated to the two priests the counsel that Ahithophel and he had given to Absalom, and desired them to send quickly, and tell David, saying, "Lodge not this night in the plains of the wilderness, but speedily pass over; lest the king be swallowed up, and all the people that are with him." The two sons of the priests stayed by En-rogel, the fuller's fountain, whose name is expressive of purifying trial; for "who shall stand when the Lord appeareth? for He is like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' sope" (Mal. iii. 2). They were to carry the tidings, but they might not be seen in the city; and a wench went and told them; and they went and told king David. The circle which had commenced from David was now complete, and had returned to him again. Yet this circle was in danger of being rendered incomplete and ineffective. Jonathan and Ahimaaz were discovered before they could reach the king; but they found a man friendly to their cause in Bahurim, who concealed them in a well, over whose mouth the woman spread a covering with ground corn thereon, so that when Absalom's servants came in search of them they could not be found, especially as, like Rahab, she not only concealed the pursued, but misdirected their pursuers. The truth was hid from them; and they believed the false to be true, as the evil are prone to do. The evil, indeed, create the falsity which they believe; for although in the Scripture narrative the concealment and the false

report are from others, it is the state of the evil that creates it. It is like the appearance which the letter of Scripture presents, that God hides His truth from the wise and deceives the false prophets (Matt. xi. 25 ; Ezek. xiv. 9). The truth is concealed from those who would apply it to an evil use ; and they are permitted to be in false persuasions, as less injurious to them than to believe the truths, while it diminishes their power of doing evil to the good.

The mission for conveying tidings to the king, which was now secured, owed its success in a great measure to the courage and wisdom of two women. They represent affections, which are links of connection between the intellectual principles that enter into the circle of order, which begins and ends in Him who is the First and the Last in all things, the least as well as the greatest.

When the two messengers were released from their place of concealment, they went and told king David ; and in accordance with the advice they were commissioned to give, "David arose, and all the people that were with him, and they passed over Jordan : by the morning light there lacked not one of them that was not gone over Jordan." Although now out of Canaan itself, David and the people were not out of the Israelitish possessions; for the place to which they went belonged to the tribe of Gad. Mahanaim has been already mentioned as signifying two camps, Jacob having so named it as the place where the angels of God met him. Here David and the people found those who were to them as ministering angels. All their wants were supplied, and their smallest comforts attended to ; "for they said, The people is hungry, and weary, and thirsty, in the wilderness." Those gifts brought to David are, spiritually understood, the offerings which the faithful present to the Lord, as it is recorded of the pious women who were of the Lord's disciples, that they ministered unto Him of their substance (Luke viii. 3) ; and, in a lower sense, are the ministrations of the natural to the spiritual mind. These consist of the things that sustain and nourish the mind, knowledge and science, goodness and truth, charity and faith, affection and delight. These are the means of satisfying the wants of the soul after suffering hunger, weariness, and thirst in the wilderness of trial and temptation.

David and the people that were with him have gone over Jordan, Absalom passed over Jordan also, he and all the men of Israel with him. The fate of the kingdom of Israel was therefore to be decided on the other side Jordan, in that part of the Holy Land which represented the natural mind or the external man, which is the scene of all such conflicts.

CHAPTER XX.

THE DEFEAT AND DEATH OF ABSALOM.

2 Samuel xviii.

THE relation of parent and child, and the sympathy and love that naturally exist between them, are convincing evidences of the wisdom and beneficence of the Creator. All creatures are inspired with the love of their offspring. We can see a reason for it, since it would be impossible for the animal kingdom in general and for the human race in particular to exist without it. But can we not trace or assign it to some cause? Is it a natural development, or is it the result or design, or does it originate in the attributes of the Creator Himself? Is there not in the Divine nature something answering to this most essential element of human nature? The teaching of the New Church traces it to the Divine Love itself, in which creation had its origin. There are three things that constitute the essence of Divine Love, to love others who are out of, or without Himself, to desire to be one with them, and to make them happy from Himself. As man was created from this Love, so also was he created for it. The sphere emanating from this Love pervades the universe, and affects every one according to his state. This sphere more immediately affects parents, inspiring them with a tender love towards their offspring, and with a desire to be one with them, and to make them happy. It affects also the evil as well as the good. This universal sphere affects in a peculiar manner those who receive the love of God, as all do who believe in God and love their neighbour, the charity which reigns with them being an image of that love. The love of children for their parents is the reflex of parental love. For it may be said of human paternal love as it is of Divine Fatherly Love, "Herein is love, not that we loved God, but that He loved us." The love of children for their parents is as necessary as the love of parents for their children. Without love there can be no true honour, without honour there can be no true obedience, and without obedience there can be no order and improvement, and without all there can be no domestic happiness. Parents are seldom deficient in love, however much they may be in wisdom to direct it. Children are more liable to come short, partly, no doubt, from injudicious training, of which we find some very serious cases in Scripture, and partly from the general imperfection of fallen human nature, and the impatience of restraint which is natural to the young. In the Scriptures, therefore, we find the inculcation of filial, much more than

of parental duty; while one of the ten commandments is, "Honour thy father and thy mother." One of the acts which St. Paul enumerates as the sign of a reprobate mind is disobedience to parents (Rom. i. 30).

When we consider the origin of parental and of filial love, we must see that persistent opposition to a parent's will, and, as in the case of Absalom, open rebellion against a parent's personal and kingly authority, is to disregard the dictates, not only of the best natural affection, but of the highest spiritual affection also. Such conduct is not only rebellion against the authority and government of the earthly father, but of the heavenly Father also; not only against the temporal but of the eternal King. The lesser evil contains the greater. For the Divine command, to honour father and mother, comprehends the higher command to honour the Lord and His kingdom. And the violation of this higher command is the spiritual evil which the rebellion of Absalom represented.

When David found himself compelled to meet his rebellious son in deadly strife, he numbered the people that were with him, and set captains of thousands and captains of hundreds over them. Moreover he formed the whole army into three divisions, which he placed under the command of Joab, Abishai, and Ittai the Gittite. This spiritually means a Divine arrangement in heavenly order of all the principles of goodness and truth in the spiritual mind, to meet the opposing principles of evil and falsity in the natural mind. All spiritual conflict resolves itself into this. We can indeed consider the opposite principles as existing separately in different minds, or either of them as predominating over the other in the same mind. But all spiritual conflict is mental conflict, and the final result is the judgment of truth for or against a man, according as he has acted in agreement with or in opposition to its laws and teaching.

When David had appointed the leaders of his army, he said to the people, "I will surely go forth with you myself also. But the people answered, Thou shalt not go forth: for if we flee away, they will not care for us; neither if half of us die, will they care for us: but now thou art worth ten thousand of us: therefore now it is better that thou succour us out of the city." It was the great object in ancient warfare to kill or capture the king in battle. But there is another reason for us why it was expedient for David not to go forth personally into the conflict. It is better in certain circumstances that the ruling principle should not come out into open conflict with that which is opposed to it. Moses determined the fate, and even the progress of the battle which Israel fought with Amalek, not by going out with the army, but by standing on the top of a hill, and holding up the rod of God in his hands. David, it is true, proposed himself to go with the people, and such is the will of the Lord, and of the Truth, in which He is present

with us in our spiritual conflicts. And He is with us, even when He does not go forth into the battle. The people's request showed the value they placed on the king's life. And their estimation of the value of the king's life, in comparison of the value of their own, is expressive of that state of mind when the leading and governing principle of religion is esteemed as above all price, compared with its subordinate and common truths. In religion men often contend about matters of secondary importance, and seem little concerned for essential principles; nay, they sometimes sacrifice the essential to the secondary, or even to the formal, either by magnifying the worth of secondary things, or contending for matters of faith to the destruction of charity, or exalting ritual to the degradation of piety. The people, when they went forth to battle, did not think that, by denying themselves of the king's presence, they were depriving themselves of his aid. They expected he would succour them out of the city. It is not always by the outward and open, but by the inward and hidden operation of the ruling principle that the victory is gained. David's spirit went forth with the people. And yet although it was the spirit of victory, it was also the spirit of salvation, even of him whom his army had gone to oppose. For his command to the three commanders was, "Deal gently for my sake with the young man, even with Absalom."

The battle that took place between the two contending armies in this unnatural civil war is, like Scripture battles generally, very briefly related, for, with the exception of the main incident, we cannot say it is described. "The people went out into the field against Israel: and the battle was in the wood of Ephraim." We may conclude from this that it was chiefly the men of the tribes of Israel who had adhered to the house of Saul that joined Absalom, while those who remained faithful to David were chiefly of the tribe of Judah. The wood of Ephraim, in which the battle took place, was not in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim, which was in the centre of Palestine, but was near Mahanaim, thus on the other side of Jordan. Appropriately it was in that region of Israel's inheritance which represented the external man, where man's evils reside and where conflict with them takes place. The wood of Ephraim also is characteristically representative of the immediate scene of the battle. For although the wood of Ephraim was not in the territory of the tribe of that name, it has the same meaning as if it had, with this difference, that in the Holy Land means in the inner man, and out of the Holy Land means in the outer man. Ephraim signifies the intellectual principle of the natural or sensual part of the mind.

In this wood "the people of Israel were slain before the servants of David, and there was there a great slaughter that day of twenty thousand men. For the battle was there scattered over the face of all the

country : and the wood devoured more people that day than the sword devoured." The number slain is expressive of the nature rather than the extent of destruction. A great slaughter means a destruction of good rather than of truth ; and the number slain implies that the result of the conflict was, on the side of the vanquished, the extinction of spiritual life, even to the remains of goodness and truth. This is especially the result of the evil of profanation, which the sin of Absalom represented, and which, we shall see, is further indicated by the singular cause and manner of his death.

"Absalom rode upon a mule, and the mule went under the thick boughs of a great oak, and his head caught hold of the oak, and he was taken up between the heaven and the earth ; and the mule that was under him went away."

Under the Israelitish and Jewish dispensation, kings and their sons rode upon mules, and judges and their sons rode upon asses ; and indeed kings rode upon she-mules, and their sons upon he-mules ; and judges rode upon she-asses, and their sons upon he-asses. And this was for the sake of the inner sense of Divine inspiration. For as animals signify affections, the female signifies the affection of goodness and the male the affection of truth : and this is the distinction which exists actually and representatively between a father and a son. But taking animals in the general sense as denoting affections, the mule signifies the affection of rational truth, and the ass the affection of natural or scientific truth.

There are three animals useful to man which are frequently mentioned in the Scriptures : the horse, the mule, and the ass ; and they correspond to the three kinds or degrees of the affections and perception of truth : spiritual, rational, and natural ; or what may be called intelligence, reason, and knowledge. From this also the mule derives its signification ; because the rational perception of truth is produced from the union of the spiritual and natural perception of truth : the rational faculty being itself the result of the conjunction of inward discernment and outward knowledge.

In the Scriptures the horse, the mule, and the ass are frequently mentioned in such a way as to show that they have a meaning beyond that of the letter. The armies of heaven, and even the Lord Himself, are described in the Book of Revelation as riding on white horses, where it must be plain that a spiritual meaning must be contained in that of the letter. And when we regard the horse as the symbol of intelligence, or understanding, the description becomes truly significant ; since it is by the understanding of the pure or spiritual truths of the Word that the Lord and His kingdom are brought near to us : and this sense of the passage is rendered still more evident when we reflect that the Lord is there called "the Word of God."

The Lord also when He was in the world rode into Jerusalem on an ass and the colt the foal of an ass, to represent that He had obtained dominion over all the natural and rational principles of the human nature He assumed in the world; and by means of which He comes to His Church, as the Judge and King. And to show His judicial and regal authority, He entered the temple and cast out the money-changers and all who bought and sold within its sacred precincts.

But the mule upon which Absalom rode is not to be regarded as representing the rational faculty and its affection and perception in a state of order and of useful activity, but perverted and applied to an evil purpose. In the abstract sense the mule represents rational truth, which can be either used or abused, preserved or perverted. And when that which is in itself good and true and useful is perverted, it becomes evil and false and injurious. And what faculty is more easily perverted than reason—what power may be more perversely employed? Is not the rejection of religion and of revelation, and even the denial of God Himself, done in every instance in the name of reason? And not only is religion denied, but falsified, under the authority of the same plastic faculty. Whenever indeed the natural will is allowed to lead, the reason is easily made to follow; for there are always abundant reasons for the confirmation of what any one has a desire to believe or an interest in believing. Nor is the agency of this faculty employed only in matters of faith or of opinion. Whatever we ardently desire to do or to possess, we employ our reason to accomplish or acquire; and so far is this the case, reason may be made the instrument of unscrupulously ministering to the blind impulses of the will.

When the rational faculty becomes thus perverse, it leads into and confirms what is opposite to goodness and truth; and involves the mind in the mazes of error, and leads away into all evil. The tendency of perverse rationality to the errors and evils that destroy, is described in the succeeding incidents—the mule's carrying Absalom under the thick boughs of a great oak, and his head being caught in the branches. In Scripture a wood or forest signifies the natural mind, especially when it is in a comparatively uncultivated state; as a garden signifies the rational mind, highly cultivated and adorned with the graces of love and truth. The battle between the armies of David and Absalom was in the wood of Ephraim; for Ephraim signifies the intellectual principle of the Church, and the wood of Ephraim denotes the understanding of the natural mind, or the natural understanding. Therefore it was that more of Absalom's army were destroyed by the wood than by the sword; denoting that, in corresponding circumstances, the greatest destruction is the result of the fallacies in the natural understanding itself. Absalom himself was

also therefore overcome and led to destruction by the same means; and in his case the particular cause is mentioned: "he was carried under the thick boughs of a great oak." The oak-tree signifies the most general kind of the perception of truth which the natural understanding acquires. The thick boughs mentioned here and in other instances, include the idea of what is intertwisted or tangled; and this is always expressive of the spiritual idea of what is involved or obscure, such as is all knowledge when seen only through the fallacious eye of sense. When spiritual things are apprehended only by the senses, or when they are believed only so far as they can be apprehended sensuously, they become entangled in the appearances which arise from the fallacies of the senses; and these fallacies are properly signified by the thick boughs or entangled branches of the oak. In this sense they are frequently mentioned in Scripture. In Isaiah ix. 18: "Wickedness burneth as the fire: it shall devour the briers and thorns, and shall kindle in the thickets [or intertwistings] of the forest, and they shall mount up like the lifting up of smoke." Fire which catcheth at thorns and kindles in the entangled branches of the forest is self-love; for errors and fallacies are ever ready to favour evil affections. In the 31st of Ezekiel the meaning of thick or intertwisted boughs is still more obvious: "Behold, the Assyrian was a cedar in Lebanon with fair branches, and with a shadowing shroud, and of an high stature; and his top was among the thick [or intertwisted] boughs. . . . Therefore his height was exalted above all the trees of the field, and his boughs were multiplied. . . . Therefore thus saith the Lord God; Because thou hast lifted up thyself in height, and he hath shot up his top among the thick boughs, and his heart is lifted up in his height; I have therefore delivered him into the hand of the mighty one of the heathen."

Throughout the Word Assyria signifies the rational mind; and in the present case that mind perverted: the Assyrian is therefore described as a tree having intertwisted branches, to indicate the tendency of natural reason to become entangled in the delusive appearances which the senses present, when they alone are consulted on the nature of spiritual things. When any one follows the teachings of his senses, and pursues only sensual pleasures and worldly dominion, he is like Absalom in the wood of Ephraim, overshadowed and bewildered, and is carried he knows not whither to his own destruction. Absalom was caught by the head in the thick boughs of the oak. The head of the body signifies the interiors of the mind; and the mind becomes interiorly under the influence and power of sensuous reasonings, when these are directed by an evil heart. But we are to understand that Absalom was caught by the hair, and thus by the head. And the hair signifies what is external. The hair of the head signifies the ultimate

of man's will and understanding. It was from this that Samson's strength lay in his hair; for spiritual power is in the outward manifestation of inward principles. Absalom's hair is particularly mentioned, as we have seen, in chapter xiv.; and besides his abundant locks, his person is said to have been more praised for beauty than any other in Israel. Considered simply as a king's son, Absalom represented one of the primary truths which are derived from, and have respect to, the Divine Truth in heaven and the Church; and the beauty of his person and the abundance of his hair have respect to the beauty and gracefulness which are the natural attributes of such truths in their own proper form. But when spiritual principles are perverted, and applied to evil purposes, the outward beauty may indeed be retained and cultivated, because it is a means of deceiving those who look only upon, and judge by, the outward appearance; but it is no longer a true index of the inward state of the mind. The same evil may exist in spiritual as in natural life, and in the things of the mind as in those of the body. Personal beauty and gracefulness of manners must always command admiration, as everything beautiful and graceful deservedly does with those who are right minded; but no right-minded person will accept the outward forms of grace and beauty for those higher qualities—the grace and beauty of the mind, which they were designed by the Creator to embody and represent. When the outward beauty of holiness is all that exists in any one, it may indeed deceive the ignorant or unguarded into an unwise admiration of the man, as many of the Israelitish people no doubt were deceived and seduced by the beauty and blandishments of Absalom; but there is one part of their conduct which the true Israelite will never imitate—their being led by their fascination into an act of rebellion. One of the points of his personal beauty was the immediate cause of Absalom's destruction. That hair which grew so luxuriantly was the immediate occasion of his death. Absalom, when his head caught hold of the oak, being "taken up between the heaven and the earth," and the mule that was under him going away, presents a singularly striking ensample of that state of profanation which his conduct represented. This state and its consequences are minutely described in the Writings. There are several degrees of profanation. We will speak only of two.

Those who practically separate faith from charity divide the mind into two parts. By the truths of the Word they turn themselves to heaven, and by evils of life they turn themselves towards hell, so that they halt between them. By means of thought concerning God, and concerning heaven and eternal life, they have some degree of conjunction with heaven, but only by obscure thought, and not by the affection of charity, for this they have not: wherefore by the affection of self-love and the love of the world, they are conjoined to hell. Hence

it may appear that they are between heaven and hell, inasmuch as they look with their eyes towards heaven, while with their hearts they are inclined towards hell. To do this is to profane, and the lot of profaners in the other life is of all others the worst.

Those who have been guilty of profanation are signified by the lukewarm, who are neither cold nor hot (Rev. iii. 6), and their separation from the Lord is meant by their being spued out of His mouth. And to be thus separated from the Lord is to be neither in heaven nor in hell, but in a place apart, deprived of human life, where there are mere phantasies. The reason of this is that they mixed truths with falsities and goods with evils, thus holy things with things profane, to such an extent that they cannot be separated. And as the profanator cannot be prepared either for heaven or for hell, the whole of his rational life is rooted out, and only the ultimates of life remain, which when separated from the inward life are mere phantasies.

But Absalom, though suspended between heaven and earth, was yet alive. A certain man told Joab that he saw Absalom hanged in an oak. And Joab "took three darts in his hand, and thrust them through the heart of Absalom, while he was yet alive in the midst of the oak. And ten young men that bare Joab's armour compassed about and smote Absalom, and slew him." In this Joab acted in opposition to the injunction of the king, not in forgetfulness, for the man who told him repeated the king's command, as a reason for not killing Absalom himself. The king's wish and Joab's act, as contrary to each other, exemplifies, or at least represents, two opposite principles of judgment, the principles of good and truth. Good raises all to heaven; truth condemns all to hell. This finds its expression in the theological doctrine of a conflict in the Divine mind between mercy and justice, on which is grounded the tenet of substitutional satisfaction. The opposite tendency and judgment of goodness and truth are not in the Divine but in the human mind. Goodness and truth are one in God and ever act in perfect unity. In the human mind they may be divided. Good may exist without truth, and truth may exist without good. All who are in good, even if it be without truth, are saved, but all who are in truth without good are lost. The truth which men have condemns them. Truth may be called the knowledge of goodness. The Lord, as the Truth, is the great Teacher, all whose lessons have goodness for their end. But if the lessons of truth do not terminate in goodness, but are neglected, and especially if they are perverted, as all knowledge may be, to an evil end, then truth condemns the soul to hell. In all such cases it is not the Lord who condemns, but the words which He has spoken. The evil are, therefore, practically their own judges; they carry the law of their condemnation in themselves. Yet while the Lord's truth as a judge condemns, His love as a father yearns for

the safety, and mourns over the loss of His children. The royal father's passionate grief over the death of his rebellious son, was but an imperfect type of the sorrowing love of Him who wept over the profligate city while He pronounced its doom, and who sent up in His agony a prayer for those who were nailing Him to the cross. "O my son Absalom, my son, my son Absalom! would God I had died for thee, O Absalom, my son, my son!" What David desired to have done, David's Lord did. He died for His rebellious children. Not in their stead did the Lord die for them, but not the less to save them from death. Moses and Paul expressed a desire to die for their rebellious brethren, as David did for his rebellious son; and this was the only way in which they could express it. But this is not the Divine way, nor is it consistent with Divine order. When Moses prayed to be blotted out of the Lord's book rather than that his people should not be forgiven, the Lord gave this answer to his prayer, "Whosoever hath sinned against Me, him will I blot out of My book." Infinite love and mercy cannot save the guilty, but infinite wisdom has found out a way by which sinners may turn from their wickedness and live.

CHAPTER XXI.

DAVID'S RETURN TO JERUSALEM.

2 Samuel xix.

SEVERAL incidents are recorded to have taken place after the death of Absalom, which are interesting and instructive, but some of which must be passed over and others briefly noticed.

After Absalom was slain David still remained at Mahanaim; and there was strife among the people throughout all the tribes of Israel, saying, "The king saved us out of the hand of our enemies, and he delivered us out of the hand of the Philistines; and now he is fled out of the land for Absalom. And Absalom, whom we anointed king over us, is dead in battle. Now therefore why speak ye not a word of bringing the king back?" There is no appearance of any of the effects that, in modern times, follow a rebellion, of bringing the leading rebels, at least, to account for their conduct. The people, who had anointed Absalom king over them, now that he is dead, return to their allegiance to their legitimate sovereign, and contend among themselves which of the tribes shall be the first to bring him back. The idea and the movement originated, apparently, with the people themselves. Yet David desired to return to Jerusalem, though he did not express his desire till "the speech of all Israel had come to the king, even to his

house." This is like the Lord's way of dealing with His people. Their duty is known to them, and they are left to discharge it, or to return, if they have departed from it. The Divine will is that the people should think and act as of themselves. The Lord says to the rebellious, "Turn unto Me, and I will turn unto you." And yet it is the Lord who turns the sinner and backslider to Himself. His Spirit is ever striving with the wicked, but its influence is internal and secret, that men may have the power, if they have the will, to return to Him who has saved them out of the hand of their enemies in His work of redemption, and it may be, to some extent, in the work of regeneration. When they freely turn to the Lord, then the Lord turns to them. David, when the people of Israel moved, "sent to Zadok and to Abiathar the priests, saying, Speak unto the elders of Judah, saying, Why are ye the last to bring the king back to his house? Ye are my brethren, ye are my bones and my flesh: wherefore then are ye the last to bring back the king?" Here the word proceeds from the king through the priests to Judah; as the Lord operates upon His Church and people through the highest affections of love in the heart into the principles of good in the will, that these may meet and unite with the perceptions of truth in the understanding. David's speech through the priests "bowed the heart of all the men of Judah, even as the heart of one man; so that they sent this word unto the king, Return thou, and all thy servants."

The king, when this word came to him, was on the other side Jordan, whither he had fled to escape the power of Absalom, and where he had been compelled to meet him as an enemy. In the trials and temptations of the spiritual life there are experiences analogous to this. In the rebellious motions in our own minds, which consist in subordinate affections seeking to usurp the dominion exercised by the principle they should obey, there is for a time a seeming state of inverted order, a state in which, to speak in the language of the present history, the king is driven from his throne, and one who ought both to love and obey him, takes his place, and claims to rule. All Christians have experiences of states in which doubt has seemed to have taken the place of faith and distrust of confidence, and even when spiritual love seems to yield to the claims of natural affection. These are, to the tried soul, states of tribulation, the issue of which, if faithful to his God and to himself, is, to bring the Christian back to the Salem from which he has been driven, with greater power and security than he had previously enjoyed; even as the Lord, our pattern, both in our trials and our triumphs, was driven into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil, and, after He had overcome, returned in the power of the Spirit into Galilee. In the highest sense, these trials and triumphs of David are types of those of the Son of Man.

In returning to Jerusalem David was met by the men of Judah, who had come to Gilgal to conduct the king over Jordan. David re-entered the Holy Land as the Israelites had entered it, by making the passage of the Jordan; but the circumstances were now changed. To allow the children to pass into Canaan, Jordan was divided, so that they walked on the bed of the river, but David passed over the river itself, in what is called a ferry-boat. The first passage was grander and more imposing, and was, like the passage of the Red Sea, effected by means of a miracle. But David's passage over Jordan represented spiritual progression in a higher state. Their passage of the Jordan represented a state of trial, his represented a state of triumph. Gilgal was the first place where the children of Israel halted, when they came up from the wilderness into the Holy Land, and where, by a painful rite, they rolled away the reproach of Egypt; it was the last halting-place of the children of Judah, when they came down from Jerusalem with rejoicing, to meet their king. That which is first in the progress of the spiritual life is also the last. Obedience is the first and lowest service and the last and highest virtue; but the first obedience comes from a sense of duty, the last springs from a feeling of love. So with all the other elements of religion. All have a first state which is natural, and a last state which is spiritual. There is a truth that leads to good and a truth that is derived from good. There is a faith that leads to charity and a faith that is derived from charity. These are the Jericho and the Gilgal that change their character while they retain their name; and which have their analogues in the ladder of Jacob, on which he saw the angels of God ascending and descending, the lowest step being the first to those who went up from earth to heaven, and the last to those who came down from heaven to earth.

Unlike the children of Israel, who on their entrance into the land of Canaan were met by enemies, and whose progress through it was a continued warfare, David was received by admiring friends, and he went up with the tribes of his people, who vied with each other in doing him honour, and no doubt made a triumphal entry into Jerusalem.

Among those who came to Gilgal with the men of Judah to meet the king was one who had been a bitter and insulting enemy, now come as a humble suppliant for mercy. Shimei, who, when David was in adversity, cast stones and dust at him and cursed him as a bloody man, "hasted and came down with the men of Judah to meet king David," and threw himself at the king's feet, confessing that he had done perversely, not faintly boasting of his prompt zeal to hail the king's return: "I am come the first this day of all the house of Joseph to go down to meet my lord the king." Shimei was a Benjamite. As the last son of Jacob and brother of Joseph, both the children of Rachel, Benjamin, and the tribe which sprung from him, hold a

conspicuous place among the persons and principles that constitute the Church and kingdom of the Lord. Benjamin represents those who are in the truth of good, or what is the same, those who are in the faith of charity. When the principles which form this state are perverted, we have the character so shamefully exemplified and so plainly represented in the conduct of Shimei, when he cursed the king in the day of his trouble. False and evil, faithless and uncharitable, the pervert acts, as this Benjamite confesses he had acted perversely. Yet such is the clemency of Him against whom such characters direct their hostility, that confession and supplication never fail to receive forgiveness, even though those who are pardoned be like the servant in the parable, whose lord forgave him ten thousand talents, simply because he asked him, but who the next hour refused to remit to his fellow-servant a debt of an hundred pence. These acts of clemency express the Lord's boundless love and forgiving mercy, but they do not always express a state of forgiven sin in those who receive them. So long, indeed, as, like Shimei and the unmerciful servant, they do not themselves violate the law of forgiveness, or break the covenant into which they have openly or tacitly entered, they are safe ; but the moment they who have obtained mercy cease to be merciful, or those who have sinned transgress the law under which they live in safeguard, they forfeit all they had obtained, and learn by bitter experience that only the merciful obtain mercy, and that the soul that sinneth it shall die. Shimei's repentance, as we shall see, was too much like that of the unforgiving servant. He acknowledged his sin and asked for clemency, and he was forgiven. There was indeed an accusing spirit in the person of Joab's brother, who looked upon Shimei's offence with the pitiless eye of truth, and deprecated the pardon of one who had cursed the Lord's anointed, but David rebuked him, as one of the sons of Zeruiah with whom he had nothing to do in such matters, and gave the answer, worthy of a king and noble in a conqueror, "Shall there any man be put to death this day in Israel? for do not I know that I am this day king over Israel?" David now knew better than before this terrible ordeal that his throne was established. His trials, even of this character, are not yet ended ; but every trial that the faithful undergo leaves its own conviction of increased stability in truth and righteousness.

Another man of a different character came down to meet the king. "Mephibosheth the son of Saul came down to meet the king, and had neither dressed his feet, nor trimmed his beard, nor washed his clothes, from the day the king departed until the day he came again in peace." Being asked, "Wherefore wentest not thou with me, Mephibosheth?" he answered that his servant had deceived and slandered him. In chapter xvi. we read, when David in his flight was a little past the top

of Mount Olivet, Ziba the servant of Mephibosheth met him with a couple of asses laden with provisions. Being asked where was his master's son, he said, "Behold, he abideth at Jerusalem: for he said, To day shall the house of Israel restore me the kingdom of my father. Then said the king to Ziba, Behold, thine are all that pertained to Mephibosheth." Jonathan's son expresses himself in the highest terms of the king's wisdom, and his kindness to him; whose father's house were but dead men before the king. "And the king said unto him, Why speakest thou any more of thy matters? I have said, Thou and Ziba divide the land. And Mephibosheth said unto the king, Yea, let him take all, forasmuch as my lord the king is come again in peace unto his own house." Those who judge of sacred history by the ordinary standard, have considered David's treatment of Jonathan's son to be censurable. And certainly there is a seeming inconsistency in David's easy and complete forgiveness of Shimei's confessed sin, and his leaving uncensured Ziba's cruel and unacknowledged falsehood; and in leaving his maligned master's wrong unredressed, except the restoration to him of the half of the land of which Ziba had defrauded him. But there is some deeper reason than appears on the surface. Ziba, though the servant of Jonathan's son, adhered to David, and ministered to him, in his adversity, when appearances were so much against his interests that even his wise counsellor forsook him. It is possible also that, when Mephibosheth's explanation came, David did not receive it with undoubting confidence. His indifference can hardly be otherwise accounted for, although his partial rectification of the judgment which gave Ziba all, seems an admission that some adjustment was needed. With Mephibosheth, as with himself, the servant gained a temporary ascendancy over the master, as the external sometimes does over the internal; and when this is the case, the laws of order are not adhered to, since the natural man has desires and interests of his own, so that even in his service rendered to the Lord he has a view to the recompense of reward. But David did between Ziba and his master what is right in such a case, he united their interests and established a balance between them, by dividing between them the land, of which they became joint possessors. The master's self-denying exclamation, "Yea, let him take all," is the disclaiming of all merit; the return of the king in peace to his own house, or the restoration of the peaceful rule of the Lord's truth in the mind, and eminently in the will, being the highest reward which the inner man desires.

One other of those who came to meet the king was Barzillai, the Gileadite, who was one of the three who had so liberally supplied the wants of David, and the people that followed him, at Mahanaim. As forming part of the Israelitish possessions, and thus a part of the Holy Land in an extended sense, but a boundary, as when the breadth of

the land is said to be from Gilead even to Dan (Deut. xxxiv. 1), Gilead signifies the first good, which is that of things pertaining to the bodily senses; for it is into the good or the pleasurable enjoyment of these that man who is regenerated is first initiated. Yet, under another aspect, and in relation to a more advanced state of the regenerate life, as when it becomes the heritage of Ephraim (Zech. x. 10), it signifies the good of charity. Barzillai is here represented as having reached that higher state of life when the good or pleasurable enjoyment of the bodily senses has passed away, or rather, when it has passed into that higher good, which is the pleasurable enjoyment of mental things, to which the first corresponds and is designed to lead. When Barzillai came and passed over Jordan with the king, and David invited him to go with him to Jerusalem, where he would feed him, he said, "I am this day fourscore years old: and can I discern between good and evil? can thy servant taste what I eat or what I drink? can I hear any more the voice of singing men and singing women?" Here is a state described in which the means have accomplished their end, and are no more needed. The pleasurable enjoyment of the senses is one of the wise as well as beneficent provisions of the Creator. Men sometimes speak of them as hindrances to the reception and enjoyment of spiritual things. And no doubt when they become the sole or superior good of life they are. But considered in regard to the young, the pleasures of sense are the proper enjoyments of life. And the senses are the avenues through which they acquire their information as well as their pleasures. The senses of touch, of taste, of smell, of sound, of sight, how marvellously are they adapted to the outer world of matter in which we live, and to the inner world of mind, to which they minister! While the things of the world give us numberless sensuous pleasures, they supply us with numberless ideas. And yet those with which nature supplies us are but the food of the natural mind, which is designed to prepare us for a nobler and more satisfying means of life. Nothing can satisfy the immortal mind but that which is spiritual and eternal. When these have obtained their true place in our estimation, the world and the things of it, though they may have lost neither their charm nor their use, are no longer the chief good. A higher good, a more refined and enduring pleasure, has taken the place of the lower; the means have given way to the end. When the spiritual and the eternal become ends, life is in its true order. Things temporal and eternal are harmonized. True religion is a reconciler of all created things, whether they be things of earth or things of heaven. The grand harmony is that which is established between the different faculties of the mind itself, the will and the understanding. This harmony was Barzillai's age, fourscore, like four, and four like two, being expressive of this

harmony and union. When all the powers of the mind are harmonized and united, that which constitutes true old age has arrived; whether old in years, if one is old in state, such a one is old in the spiritual and Scripture sense of the word. Sense has become subordinate to mind. And this is second, that is spiritual, childhood. The innocence of ignorance has become the innocence of wisdom. Sense has done its good and useful work, and has yielded up its sway to the matured perceptive and affectional faculties of the mind.

Barzillai pleaded his many infirmities for asking permission, after he should have passed with the king over Jordan, to turn back, that he might die in his own city, and be buried in the grave of his father and of his mother. To die is spiritually to live again, and to be buried is to rise again: to die in his own city is to live the higher life of his own native doctrine, and to be buried in his parents' grave is to enter into the higher life of his hereditary faith and love, and to enter into consociation with kindred souls who are in the same degree of the heavenly life. However highly perfected one may be in the religious life, he can only enter into and enjoy that one of the three heavens which corresponds to the degree which has been opened in his own mind. The Lord desires, indeed, that all should rise into the highest state, and ascend into the highest heaven, and partake with him of the highest good and bliss, but happiness, even in heaven, can only be found in that one of the many mansions of our Father's house whose amplitude or smallness answers to our capacity of reception and enjoyment. Barzillai is a Gileadite, and a Gileadite he must live and die. But although he lives in the outer circle of the Holy Land, he has a warm heart and a liberal hand. He is happier in his own city and with his own humbler fare than he would be in Jerusalem and at the king's table. Yet, although he may not go up, Chimham may go. The son has not, like the father, closed his account with the world. He has not come into that singleness of heart and mind which no longer needs to discern and choose between good and evil. He can taste what he eats and drinks, he can hear the voice of singing men and women. His mental like his bodily senses are still active; they have a clear perception of the good and the true, as the meat and drink of the soul, and of the harmony of the affections for them, which is the soul's concord of sweet sounds. He is still capable of increasing in knowledge and growing in wisdom. He will not be a burden to the king. The king kisses Barzillai and blesses him. With the kiss of love and the blessing of peace, he returns unto his own place, waiting patiently, as one whose state is full, until his change came. Chimham goes up with the king, and he becomes great, so that a habitation, or city, is called by his name (Jer. xli. 17). Those whose nature answers to Chimham's name, who have a "great desire" for higher, that is,

for heavenly things; and who can say with the Psalmist, "O God, Thou art my God; early will I seek Thee; my soul thirsteth for Thee, my flesh longeth for Thee," will receive Chimham's reward, not only in finding a habitation in the heavenly Canaan, but in receiving the blessing bestowed by the king in his dying charge to Solomon on the sons of Barzillai: "Let them be of those that eat at thy table: for so they came to me when I fled because of Absalom thy brother" (1 Kings ii. 7).

CHAPTER XXII.

THE REVOLT OF ISRAEL UNDER SHEBA.

2 Samuel xx.

THE king was conducted from Gilgal by all the people of Judah and half the people of Israel, and all the men of Israel came to the king, and said, "Why have our brethren the men of Judah stolen thee away, and have brought the king, and his household, and all David's men with him, over Jordan?" This gave rise to a contention between the tribes concerned, the men of Judah urging that the king was near of kin to them, and the men of Israel maintaining that they had ten parts in the king. This is the great contention between the members of the Lord's household, which was as early as Cain and Abel, and as late as the twelve apostles, whether goodness or truth, or charity and faith, is entitled to pre-eminence, and has more interest in the king and a better claim to his favour. In the present case, as in many others before and since, the difference was not settled. We only read that the words of the men of Judah were fiercer than the words of the men of Israel. If the men of the Church could only see that charity and faith are both excellent, and both necessary to the existence of true religion, they might agree to live and work harmoniously together. Love or charity is, indeed, nearer of kin to the king, when David is king, but truth or faith has ten parts in him, not only because the truths of faith are numerous, but because they are the ten words which, as the laws of justice and judgment, are the habitation of the throne of God.

The unsettled contention between these two divisions of the people resulted in a revolt. "There happened to be there a man of Belial, whose name was Sheba, the son of Bichri, a Benjamite: and he blew a trumpet, and said, We have no part in David, neither have we inheritance in the son of Jesse: every man to his tents, O Israel. So every man of Israel went up from after David, and followed Sheba the son of Bichri: but the men of Judah clave unto their king, from Jordan even to Jerusalem." This contention among the tribes, like that

among the apostles, took place by the way, as the king went up from Gilgal, and the malcontents left the king to follow Sheba.

When the king came to Jerusalem, his first act was to shut up the ten women, his concubines, whom he had left to keep the house, and they lived in widowhood till the day of their death. These were the unfortunate women we read of in Absalom's rebellion. Now that they were defiled, though not by their own fault, and were as things profaned, they must be separated; since good profaned cannot be united to truth, which itself would be profaned by such an alliance.

David then commissioned Amasa to assemble the men of Judah within three days, which is, spiritually, to combine the principles of good according to the laws of truth. But Amasa failing to appear at the appointed time, the king commanded Abishai to take his lord's servants and pursue after Sheba, and there went after him Joab's men, and the Cherethites, and the Pelethites, and all the mighty men.

And here an event is recorded which we must pause to consider.

When they went forth and were at the great stone which is in Gibeon, Amasa went before them. And Joab, under the pretence of friendship, took Amasa by the beard with his right hand and kissed him, while with his left he thrust his sword into his body. Joab had killed Abner, the captain of Saul's army, who adhered to Ish-bosheth, and now he slays Amasa, who had led the army of Absalom, but only when they had been received into favour by David. Naturally considered, it was, of course, jealousy in one case and revenge in the other that led Joab to commit these crimes. But they were the crimes which finally rose up in judgment against him, and condemned him, although they were not the immediate cause of his death. He was accused by David of slaying deceitfully two men more righteous than himself, who had given him no just cause of offence. Of course we are to regard the subject in its spiritual sense. And if we see in Joab a type of that rationality which partakes more of the natural mind than of the spiritual, we may perceive the reason of Joab's conduct both to David and to those whom David favoured to the prejudice of Joab's interests and authority.

Amasa, like Joab, was a nephew of David's, being the son of his sister Abigail, as Joab was of his sister Zeruiah. In chapter xvii. 25, Amasa's father, Ithra, is said to have been an Israelite, but in 1 Chronicles ii. 17, he is called an Egyptian. How are we to account for this discrepancy? If one statement is wrong, it is more likely to be that in Samuel; for it is not usual to intimate that a man of Israel is an Israelite. But it seems possible that both statements may be true. Ithra may have been an Ishmaelite by descent and an Israelite by adoption. We find in the same chapter of Chronicles in which Ithra, or Jether, is called an Ishmaelite, the account of a man of Israel, who

had no son, giving his daughter, an heiress, to an Egyptian servant, who became, by marriage, a member of the commonwealth of Israel, and whose children and descendants were enrolled as belonging to the tribe of Judah. We cannot, perhaps, infer much from the name, which was borne by several pure Israelites, but the first instance in which it occurs is as the name of a foreigner, Jethro, the priest of Midian and father-in-law of Moses. Considering Ithra to have been a re-born Ishmaelite, his son must have inherited the nature of the wild-ass man of the desert, refined and elevated by the purer and nobler blood of Isaac. The younger of two sisters, also, has generally the higher signification, as Rachel the younger sister of Leah, and Mary the younger sister of Martha. So also their sons, as Joseph and Benjamin. The principle which Amasa represented was also more comprehensive than that of which Joab was the type. The two separate streams in which the blood of Abraham had flowed for centuries met and mingled in the blood of Amasa. He must therefore have represented the rational in a broader and even higher sense than as represented by Joab; the rational, which is distinguished into internal, external, and middle, being capable both of particular and general advancement.

Amasa, who had supported the rebellion of Absalom, was appointed by David to suppress the insurrection of Sheba; a characteristic of that faculty which can act either in separating or in uniting the spiritual mind and the natural, according as it sides with the one or the other. It can be converted from the negative to the affirmative side, and be as powerful in supporting a cause as it formerly was in opposing it, even when the cause is that of God and religion.

Amasa was sent to assemble the men of Judah within three days; but he tarried longer than the set time; and David, fearing that Sheba's insurrection might do him more harm than Absalom's rebellion, despatched Abishai with all the king's servants that were in Jerusalem in pursuit. Joab with his men followed. Meantime Amasa returned, and seems to have been sent to join Abishai. And when they were at the great stone which is in Gibeon, Amasa went before them. Joab, simulating friendship, went up to Amasa, and took him by the beard with his right hand to kiss him, while with the left he thrust his sword into his side and killed him. This may be regarded as an act of revenge, and, like the murder of Abner, was intended to remove a dangerous rival out of the way. But there is in other minds the spirit from which these acts proceeded. There is a conflict of spiritual as well as of natural interests. The Lord's own disciples contended among themselves which should be greatest in His kingdom. The contention among the disciples represented a contention which takes place in the mind of every disciple among the principles which the twelve represented. There is a contention whether, for

instance, charity, faith, or works shall be greatest, and shall rule over the others. Joab had hitherto been the greatest in the kingdom of David; and he retained his ascendancy to the last; for we find him, after the death of Amasa, at the head of the army again, even although the king evidently wished to supersede him. And so it is in our religious experience. We desire to place the truths by which we oppose our spiritual adversaries under a more perfect leadership; so that there is a conflict within a conflict. While there is a conflict between motive and act, there may be a conflict between motive and motive; a conflict between the spirit and the flesh, and a conflict at the same time within the spirit itself, which grieves that it is not right with God. Nor does this conflict end till the state of the religious life itself passes into one purer and higher. Some of David's aspirations are only realized in Solomon. It is well that these things are in the heart. The Lord will bring to pass all the desires of the faithful; but the times and the seasons are in His hand.

One of Joab's evil qualities was duplicity. He was like those who attempt to serve God and Mammon. With Joab it was himself and the king. The slaying of his own rival first and the slaughter of the king's enemies next. With the dexter hand of simulated goodness he took Amasa by the beard to give him the kiss of brotherly love, while with the sinister hand of concealed self-interest he slew him with the sword of falsehood, for the truth is turned into falsehood by those who use it falsely. Yet Joab, though not commissioned to engage in suppressing the insurrection, seems to have taken the place of Amasa, and assumed the chief command. For one of Joab's men said, "He that favoureth Joab, and he that is for David, let him go after Joab." And "all the people went on after Joab, to pursue after Sheba the son of Bichri."

It is rather remarkable that after the defeat and death of Absalom, and indeed out of it, there should arise an attempt to divide, if not to overturn, the kingdom of David. But we need not be greatly surprised if we reflect that want of harmony between the understanding and the will is a condition of mind incident to all stages of the regenerate life till that work is completed; for the establishment of harmony and union between these two faculties is the new birth itself. Conflict between will and understanding is also conflict between good and truth, and between charity and faith. Not that there is or can be any conflict between these two, as they are in themselves. True faith can never be opposed to true charity. It is only in the human mind that they can come into conflict; for there only can one be made to contemn the other. The Christian moralist may contemn faith, and the Christian believer may contemn charity. The more common error is to claim supremacy or independence for faith. This claim was repre-

sented by the revolt of Sheba the son of Bichri, in which he was joined by the tribes of Israel, as opposed to the tribe of Judah, which adhered to David. This is a heresy which owes its origin to evil, or to the absence of goodness. This is expressly mentioned in the present case, for Sheba was a man of Belial. If the radical meaning of the word were applied to the heresy, it would exactly describe its nature; for while a life of charity is a useful life, a life of faith without charity, or of truth without goodness, is a "useless" one, and a useless life is liable to become a wicked and sinful one, which the word, when applied to any one, generally signifies.

Pursued by Joab, Sheba took refuge in Abel, a city belonging to the tribe of Manasseh. There is nothing particular recorded of this city except in this instance; and that is highly creditable to it. It had become proverbial for wisdom, so much so, that "they were wont to speak in old time, saying, They shall surely ask counsel at Abel: and so they ended the matter." When Joab came to Abel he cast up a bank against it, and all the people that were with Joab battered the wall, to throw it down. A peaceful city is converted into a theatre of war. A city is the emblem of doctrine. Manasseh, the eldest son of Joseph, represented the new will, as Ephraim, his younger son, represented the new understanding; and the tribes descended from them had a similar meaning. But there is something connected with the formation of the new will that throws light upon the case we are now considering. "Manasseh signifies forgetfulness, thus, in the spiritual sense, removal, namely, the removal of evils, as well actual as hereditary; for when these are removed the new will arises; for the new will exists by the influx of good from the Lord. This influx is continual with man, but evils, actual and hereditary, hinder and oppose reception; wherefore on their removal the new will comes into existence. That the new will is thus formed appears manifest with those who are in misfortune, misery, and disease; for whereas on such occasions there is a removal of self-love and the love of the world, from which all evils flow, at such times a man thinks well of God and of his neighbour; he is also in like manner well disposed in will towards his neighbour in temptations, which are spiritual griefs, and thus interior miseries and desperations. By these more especially the removal of evils is effected; and after evils are removed celestial good from the Lord flows in, whence comes the new will in the natural mind, which in the representative sense is Manasseh."

We have here, then, an exemplification of this state. There are evil, misfortune, misery; temptations, which are spiritual griefs, and desperations. The disturbing elements have been drawn from many of the tribes, from Manasseh as well as the others, and now they find shelter behind the walls of one of her cities. The name of this city is

not the same as that of Adam's second son, whom Cain slew. Abel signifies mourning. We find it in Abel-mizraim, which received its name from the great mourning at the floor of Atad, where Joseph and his company rested when he went up to bury his father in Canaan. The name was also given to the great stone on which the Israelites set down the ark of the Lord, when it was brought out of the country of the Philistines, to express, we may suppose, the lamentation of the people, because the Lord had smitten above fifty thousand of the men of Beth-shemesh for having looked into the ark (1 Sam. vi. 14-19). To distinguish the Abel of the present chapter from others, it is called Abel of Beth-maachah, the whole signifying the mourning of the house of oppression. The state and condition of the city were such as its name expressed. It was like a mind oppressed by the presence of evils, both active and hereditary, within, and pressed upon by the demands of truth and duty from without. The walls that surround and defend a city are like the truths of the literal sense of the Word that serve as the defence of doctrinal principles. As the outworks of a principle, they are the first to be assailed; and when they can no longer defend, the principle itself must give way. When resistance is continued, the consequence of being overcome is like that which attended the conquest of resisting cities, when all were put to the sword. When evil predominates in the mind, the result of determined opposition to the truth is, that good and evil perish together, they are involved in one common ruin. The state of the mind is not determined by the relative amount of good or evil it contains, as if one could be weighed in a balance against the other. The ruling principle determines the character of the mind, whatever its secondary and accidental qualities may be. Sheba and no doubt many of his followers had made or forced their way into the city of Abel, and may have found others there who favoured their cause. They seem to have formed a strong party, else the inhabitants would have gladly opened their gates to Joab. It is not unlikely that many of the men leaned to Sheba's side; but the city was saved by a wise woman. "Then cried a wise woman out of the city, Hear, hear; say, I pray you, unto Joab, Come near hither, that I may speak with thee." When she had obtained the ear of Joab, after reminding him of the proverbial wisdom of the people of Abel, she said, "I am one of them that are peaceable and faithful in Israel: thou seekest to destroy a city and a mother in Israel: why wilt thou swallow up the inheritance of the Lord?" When Joab had assured her it was far from his wish to swallow up or destroy, and that he would depart on their delivering up Sheba, the woman said unto Joab, "Behold, his head shall be thrown to thee over the wall. Then the woman went unto all the people in her wisdom. And they cut off the head of Sheba the son of Bichri, and cast it out to Joab. And he

blew a trumpet, and they retired from the city, every man to his tent. And Joab returned to Jerusalem unto the king."

The perceptive wisdom of women is more rapid in its operation and more certain in its conclusion than the reasoning intelligence of men. Their wisdom is the highest logic, although it is not syllogistic, which all right reasoning is said to be. It is the logic of good sense, because it is true thinking from right feeling. Such is the wisdom of every good woman; and such was the wise woman of Abel. Her wisdom was the truth of goodness. The decisions of that truth are Yea and Amen, from which there is no appeal, because none is felt to be necessary. Those who are in doubt, or with whom there is a difference between the will and the understanding, and who yet sincerely desire to have their doubts removed and their differences settled, need only to ask counsel at Abel, and the matter will be ended. "Blessed are they that mourn, for they shall be comforted." "The just shall live by his faith." These are among the means by which the mind is quieted and its conflicting faculties are reconciled.

The wise woman had no hesitation in promising to Joab that the head of Sheba should be thrown to him over the wall. And when she went to the people in her wisdom she seems to have had no difficulty in persuading or convincing them of what was right for them to do. "Wisdom is justified of all her children." Beheading Sheba was cutting off the head of the insurrection. Principles may be thus destroyed as well as persons. Principles are as the head which rules, and on which the rest of the parts depend, and when the ruling element is separated from the dependent parts the whole falls to the ground. The head of Sheba, after being cut off, was thrown over the wall. It was like a principle that is cast out from the mind, and is thus rejected and repudiated. This in the case of Sheba satisfied Joab, who returned to Jerusalem unto the king.

Thus ended the rebellion; and the order which followed, as the result of peace, is expressed by the concluding statement respecting David's affairs, and his ministers, from Joab, who was over all the land of Israel, to Ira the Jairite, who was a chief ruler about David.

CHAPTER XXIII.

SEVEN MEN OF THE SONS OF SAUL GIVEN UP TO THE GIBEONITES.

2 Samuel xxi.

THERE is a painful interest in many portions of the Old Testament, where war and bloodshed enter so largely into the sacred history, and

where the Divine Being Himself is not unfrequently represented as seeking satisfaction in the death of His creatures. Yet these are the parts of Scripture that require our most careful attention. The appearance they present of cruelty or injustice, and of undue severity on the part of the Infinite, if left without satisfactory explanation, has a tendency to diminish our reverence both for the Scriptures and their Divine Author. But when we reflect that such difficulties not only admit of a satisfactory solution, but afford useful spiritual instruction, we have a double inducement for making them the subjects of reflection.

Under a religious dispensation in which the states of the Church were exhibited in their effects in outward nature, a famine that continued for three years, year after year, could not fail to excite in the mind of every pious Israelite a fear, if not a conviction, that some unknown and unacknowledged evil reigned amongst the people. Under such an impression David inquired of the Lord; and he received for answer, "It is for Saul, and for his bloody house, because he slew the Gibeonites." The tragic sequel, the death of seven of Saul's house, and the burial of their bones with those of Saul and Jonathan, are represented as having removed the cause of the famine; for "after that God was intreated for the land."

There are several reflections which this relation suggests.

In the first place, God did not make known by immediate revelation the consequences that must ensue if the crime of Saul were not followed by suitable atonement; but He allowed the famine to fall as a scourge upon the people, and to continue, till they themselves should search out the cause. Of this mode of dealing with His people there are many instances recorded in the Scriptures. And these are no doubt designed to instruct us in the nature of a part of the Divine economy of which we ourselves are the subjects.

The Lord has revealed His will and given us laws, for our instruction and direction in the life of righteousness. If we violate any of those laws, or do what we know to be contrary to the Divine will, the revealed Word assures us that we cannot be forgiven but by repentance and amendment. And if the evil is not removed, its consequences must of necessity fall upon us, that we may be led to self-examination before God, in order to trace the effect up to its cause, and seek His direction and aid for its removal. In many things also we can only be taught by experience. Not that there are any circumstances in which we are left without sufficient direction to walk in the right way. But such is the human will of fallen man, that it cannot be subdued without tasting of the bitter fruits of sinful indulgence. And as man is to be led in freedom, both to resist evil and to do good, he is left to

act freely; and on this ground the Lord teaches him through his experience freely to forsake the path of sin, when he has neglected to obey the truth as revealed.

In the second place, the crime of Saul is not visited on him nor on Israel during his time, but on his descendants and on the people in the time of David. In the Israelitish Church, in which all things were representative, guilt is often punished on others than those by whom it is immediately committed. The iniquity of the fathers is visited upon the sons. In the Divine view Israel was considered to be one, and, spiritually, Israel represents one man. The men of Israel represented the principles of the mind of this one man, and the periods of the Israelitish history represented the stages of the regenerate life. The crimes that were punished on the descendants of those who committed them represented those evils that are not checked in their beginning or interrupted in their progress, but are allowed to run their course till they have reached a crisis, which ends either in death or restoration. An evil that exists in the will may not be seen or arrested there, but may branch out into the affections and thoughts, or even into the words and actions, before it be successfully opposed. And the affections and thoughts, in relation to the will and understanding, are as children in relation to parents; and are represented by them in the Scriptures. The derivation of evil in the will into the affections, and of falsity in the understanding into the thoughts, is spiritually signified by the declaration in the decalogue, that the Lord visits the iniquities of the fathers upon the children unto the third and fourth generation of them that hate Him. Three and four do not mean simply a series, but one number has relation to the understanding and its falsity, the other to the will and its evil. And these principles, when rooted in the will and understanding of the mind, branch out into the affections and thoughts. It is in this more ulterior form that they are, in many cases, first discovered, and that they are brought to judgment. This would appear to be the reason that, in the present instance, the descendants of Saul were punished for his sin, and that there is no previous record of the sin itself as committed by that king. The famine was for Saul, because he slew the Gibeonites. But this is the first time that that crime is mentioned. Nothing is said in the history of Saul of his having destroyed any of that people. So, in our experience, there are evils that are only brought to our remembrance and consciousness as sins long after they have been committed; and evils may have had a deadly activity in the will that have only been truly seen and condemned when they have descended into the thoughts of the understanding.

The crime of Saul which was visited by famine upon the people and death on the seven men of his sons requires our attention. The

singular history of the introduction of the Gibeonites into the congregation is well known and must be familiar to every reader of the Bible. When Joshua entered as a conqueror into the Promised Land, this section of the Hivites, and here called a remnant of the Amorites, "did work wilily, and went and made as if they had been ambassadors, and took old sacks upon their asses, and wine-bottles, old, and rent, and bound up; and old shoes and clouted upon their feet, and old garments upon them; and all their provision was dry and mouldy. And they went to Joshua unto the camp of Gilgal, and said, We be come from a far country: now therefore make ye a league with us." So "Joshua made peace with them, and made a league with them to let them live; and the princes of the congregation sware unto them." When the fraud was discovered, although the oath could not be broken, Joshua said unto them, "Now therefore ye are cursed, and there shall none of you be freed from being bondmen, and hewers of wood and drawers of water for the house of my God." The oath with which the covenant was confirmed was thenceforward to be held inviolate. Saul was the first and the only one who broke that sacred engagement, although there is no record of when or how the engagement was broken. And an act which set at nought a solemn compact, and was visited by such serious consequences, must represent an evil of a very serious character.

Of the seven nations of Canaan devoted to utter destruction, two were partially received into connection with the Israelitish people—the Hivites by covenant, the Jebusites by sufferance. This partial exception was made in their case, because the Hivites represented idolatry in which there is something good, and the Jebusites idolatry in which there is something true. In relation to those who are being regenerated, whom these seven nations represented so far as regards all the corrupt principles which make up the life of the natural mind as it is hereditarily, the connection of the congregation of Israel with a remnant of two of these nations represented the preservation of every good natural affection and thought, or of every natural good and truth in the mind, and its conjunction with the spiritual good and truth acquired by actual regeneration. Everything is preserved and regenerated that is capable of being bent into conformity with any good end, and that can be made to render any real spiritual service, however lowly or limited. The external character of the good which the Hivites represented, and the external character of the service they were capable of rendering, was represented by their being made hewers of wood and drawers of water to the house of the Lord, this service indicating a cultivation of the knowledge of good and truth, not for their own sake, but as a matter of duty, as a labour, not of love but of service. Yet this service is useful and necessary, and when performed faithfully, is

to be received as a use rendered to the Lord and His kingdom; and, like many of the lower uses of religion, forms a means by which the higher uses are preserved in their activity. To destroy these principles, therefore, would be to destroy the use which a beneficent Providence has appointed them to perform; but to destroy them, as Saul sought to do, after a solemn covenant had been made with them, is to seek to dissolve their conjunction with the principles of the spiritual mind, and to deprive both of the mutual use and stability which conjunction secures.

This was the sin which brought a famine for three years upon the land, denoting the privation of the means of supporting the spiritual life, when such a violation of faith and integrity is attempted, though not fully carried into effect.

The death of seven of the men of the sons of Saul represented the removal of the evils and falsities derived from that original and ruling principle in which the crime originated. Although this remedy was demanded by the Gibeonites, it appears to have been approved, and even required, by the Lord Himself. But this does not teach us that the Lord punishes the sins of the fathers upon the children in a spiritual manner; but only that order itself produces, and the Lord provides, the judgment of justice against evil, either in its beginning or in some of its derivations. Painful in a natural point of view as the present relation is to our feelings, it is no doubt intended to impress us with the conviction that the spiritual result of evil, of which it is the symbol, is still more harrowing to the spiritual affections. These natural sorrows have an end, and time itself exhausts them; but those which are spiritual, if not corrective, endure for ever.

Connected with this historical circumstance there is a touching incident recorded in the conduct of Rizpah, the concubine of Saul, and mother of two of the sons who were put to death. She spread sackcloth upon the rock, from the beginning of harvest till water dropped upon them out of heaven, and suffered neither the birds of the air to rest upon them by day, nor the beasts of the field by night. In this we may recognise the unwearied watchfulness and extreme tenderness of womanly affection, especially when that affection is exalted into maternal love. Infamy cannot destroy it, misfortune greatly exalts it; and when all others' hearts are cold or careless, there is one at least that remains warm and watchful by day and by night. In this beautiful instance of feminine and maternal love we see the symbol of inward spiritual affection in its desire and its care to preserve the principles of the Church from being destroyed by falsities and evils. For both Saul and his sons represented the principles of the Church, although in their states of opposition to the Lord's cause they represented those principles perverted. Such is the representation of the men of

the sons of Saul in the present instance. The principles of the Church are perverted when our own evil life, or our own evil ends, enter into them and rule them. When, as in the case of Saul's sons, the evil life is destroyed or removed, the principles themselves are holy, and become filled with a new and higher life. As holy things, they are to be preserved by the watchfulness of the spiritual affections from the devouring tendency of the natural lusts and passions, which, like birds and beasts of prey, are ever ready to consume whatever is good and true in the mind. The watching of Rizpah is said to have been continued from harvest till water dropped upon them out of heaven. Harvest in the Word signifies the completion of a state, the time of consummation and decision, when there is an end and a separation; the harvest being gathered in, the wheat is stored up in the garner, the tares are burned in the fire. But when, after the labours and the drought of harvest, the rain drops out of heaven, when truth descends from the heaven of the inner man, and falls, like a refreshing shower or the gentle dew, upon the outer man, a new state begins, and the days of mourning are ended—the sackcloth spread upon the rock ceases to be the couch of the holy watcher. The pious care of Rizpah is told unto David, and David completes the object of her care and solicitude by gathering the bones of the seven men, with those of Saul and Jonathan, and burying them in the sepulchre of Kish. After that God is intreated for the land. In Scripture burial signifies resurrection; for while men bury the body, angels welcome the spirit into the eternal world. In the view of angels death and burial have nothing sad or destructive in them. They see only the immortal soul entering into a new and higher life; and in the spiritual, which is the angelic, sense of the Divine Word, life and immortality take the place that death and burial occupy in the letter. The burial of the bones of Saul and his sons by David represented the rising into higher and purer life of the Divine truths of the Church, after being purified from the perversion to which they had been subjected. This is effected by the Lord, of whom David was an eminent type. They were buried in the land of Benjamin, in the sepulchre of Kish, the father of Saul; for the land of Benjamin is the intellectual mind, and the sepulchre of Saul's father, Kish, is the life of love or goodness.

When we view the subject in the light of the spiritual sense we can see our way to a satisfactory solution of the difficulties presented in the simple historical sense, and at the same time draw from it instruction for our guidance in the life of righteousness.

When the evils that obstruct the operation of the Divine mercy and truth are removed from our souls, the sunshine of heaven falls with its blessed influence upon them, and serenity and joy are restored. Our souls become barren when they are turned away from the Lord;

but when we turn to Him with the whole heart, and enter into new life, God is intreated for us—He is favourable; and in His favour is life. Of course we do not mean that any change takes place in the Divine mind. Such is presented in the appearances of the letter. The spiritual sense teaches us that the change is in man. The Divine Being is ever favourable, ever kind, but His favour and kindness are turned away by the sins of His creatures, and flow in abundance into the human heart when men are willing and obedient.

When we find ourselves without the inward consolation and outward fruitfulness of the heavenly life, we should examine ourselves to discover the cause. And having made the discovery, we should put away the evil of our doings from before the eyes of the Lord, and the light of the Divine countenance will shed joy over our inward life and render our outward life fruitful in all good works.

CHAPTER XXIV.

DAVID'S SONG OF THANKSGIVING.

2 Samuel xxii.

AFTER the life of tribulation and conflict which David had passed through, with its perils and deliverances, it is only what might be expected from the piety of his character that he should pour out his soul to God in a song of thanksgiving. We have had occasion to notice some of these beautiful compositions, in which he expresses his trust in the Lord in times of trial, and His gratitude to Him for deliverance from trouble. This song is more general in its character than any of the others; and is one of the noblest and sweetest of the numerous effusions of his pious spirit, influenced as it was by the Spirit of the Lord.

This song bears some resemblance to that which Moses sang after the deliverance from Egypt; and we may preface the explanation by what our great commentator has said on the subject of sacred songs in treating of that which was sung by that other representative man on the borders of the Red Sea. "To sing a song signifies to glorify; and thus a song signifies glorification. In the ancient Church, and afterwards in the Jewish, songs were prophetic, and treated of the Lord, especially of His coming into the world, and destroying the diabolical crew, and delivering the faithful from their assaults. And as the prophetics of songs contained such things in the internal sense, they hence signified the glorification of the Lord, that is, the celebration of Him from gladness of heart; for gladness of heart is especially

expressed by a song, since in a song gladness breaks forth as it were spontaneously into sound. Hence it is that Jehovah, that is, the Lord, in song is called a Hero, a Man of War, the God of Armies, the Conqueror, Strength, a Defence, a Shield, Salvation. And the diabolical crew which was destroyed is called the enemy which was smitten, swallowed up, overwhelmed, cast into hell. Those who knew nothing of the internal sense formerly believed that such worldly things were meant as worldly enemies, combats, victories, overthrows, and overwhelmings, of which the songs in the external sense treat. But those who knew that those prophetics involved heavenly and Divine things, and that the heavenly and Divine were represented in the worldly, knew that these prophetics treated of the condemnation of the unbelieving, and the salvation of the believing, by the Lord when He should come into the world. And those who knew this to be the case, and reflected on it, and were influenced by it, were affected with internal gladness; but the former only with external gladness. The angels also who were attendant on man were at the same time, on such occasions, in the glorification of the Lord. Hence those who sang and those who heard the songs experienced heavenly gladness from the holy and blessed principles which flowed in from heaven, in which gladness they seemed to themselves as if taken up into heaven. Such an effect had the songs of the Church among the ancients. Such an effect might they have also at this day; for the spiritual angels are especially affected by songs that relate to the Lord, to His kingdom, and to the Church. That the songs of the Church had such an effect was not only in consequence of their giving activity to gladness of heart, and its breaking forth from the interior even to the extreme fibres of the body, and exciting them with a glad and at the same time a holy tremor, but also because the glorification of the Lord in the heavens is effected by numerous choirs singing in concert. Hence also angelic speech is harmonious, falling into numbers. Hence the glorification of the Lord among the ancients who belonged to the Church was performed by songs, and psalms, and musical instruments of various kinds; for the ancients who belonged to the Church derived surpassing joy from the recollection of the Lord's coming, and of the salvation of the human race by Him."

With a few slight differences this song is the same as the eighteenth Psalm. It might have been sufficient to refer the reader to Clowes and Hiller on the Psalms, where the explanatory passages scattered throughout the Writings are brought together. But as David's spirit was refreshed after his many and severe trials by raising his thoughts and affections to God, so may the reader who has followed with us the course of David's history, and has seen so much of war and bloodshed, feel his spirit tranquillized by joining David in his pious aspirations.

In his fragmentary notes known as "Adversaria," our author, after leaving twenty chapters of the Second Book of Samuel unnoticed, enters into a minute explanation of David's song; minute, we mean, not in explaining every word, but in taking every verse, and saying something in the way of explanation upon it. The explanation itself is, to use the artist's phrase, rather a study than a finished work. Yet as the studies of the great masters are highly prized, as enabling us to trace the development of their ideas, this study of our great Master Expositor may be interesting and not a little instructive. We therefore offer a translation of this sacred song. In some instances the explanation is supplemented by remarks, or by extracts from the author's published works, which are distinguished from the words of the "Adversaria" by a dash. Some few of the renderings may be considered partly as conjectural readings, the original being elliptical even to obscurity, and one is omitted as being founded on an accidental misreading of, we suppose, Schmidius' Latin version of the Hebrew.

(1.) The song of David when he was delivered out of the hand of his enemies.

That David uttered this word inspired by the Spirit of God-Messiah is clear: thus the Spirit speaks, not David, as also appears from chap. xxiii. 2. And because the Spirit speaks, it is not David who is understood, but in the more internal sense the faithful, and in the inmost sense those who trust and love God-Messiah, and in the supreme sense God-Messiah Himself. Such is the intention of the Holy Spirit wherever He speaks through David. Of this any one may be assured, particularly from vers. 21-27, where he treats of justice, cleanness of hands, integrity, holiness; although he says elsewhere that in himself no one is pure, but altogether profane and unjust.

"The Lord is my rock, and my fortress, and my deliverer; the God of my rock; in Him will I trust: He is my shield, and the horn of my salvation, my high tower, and my refuge, my Saviour; Thou savest me from violence" (vers. 2, 3). These are names which all signify God-Messiah, for He is everywhere called a mountain, and stone, and rock, and bulwark—for He alone fights —as well as holy, and the horn of salvation.—The Lord is a rock, as the omnipotent; a fortress, a high tower, a shield, as a protector; a horn of salvation, a Saviour, as He who saves from the violence of Satan and sin.

"I will call on the Lord, who is worthy to be praised: so shall I be saved from mine enemies" (ver. 4). Spiritual enemies are understood; the Spirit means no other.

"When the waves of death compassed me, the floods of ungodly men made me afraid; the sorrows of hell compassed me about; the snares of death prevented me" (vers. 5, 6). The horde of the devil,

who is the enemy, is likened to the waves of death and the floods of Belial (ungodly men), because they are spirits, who in like manner rush in in troops. Hence come temptations, for they rush in in an inexpressible manner, by persuading, reviling; hence they are called the sorrows of hell and the snares of death; continually they persuade him whom they assault, craftily, most cunningly, nay, they are suffered in temptations to affect man, but they are snares or cords of death.

"In my distress I called upon the Lord, and cried to my God: and He did hear my voice out of His temple, and my cry did enter into His ears" (ver. 7). Spiritual distress is here described. But in God-Messiah is the only refuge; out of His temple, that is, out of heaven, through the angels, comes a supplication (or cry), which, the more intense it is, is the more compared to a cry, for a cry is an effect, as is known, in accordance with the degree of intensity of the spirit.

"Then the earth shook and trembled; the foundations of heaven moved and shook, because He was wroth" (ver. 8). Here is described vengeance upon the enemies, which is not inflicted by God-Messiah, although it is ascribed to Him, but is given to others, who rush in. Anger is described, that it will descend in order to the ultimate. Thus all that is above is moved, as is the case in man whilst the mind is in anger; whatever is below, too, and the ultimates in the body, are moved; there they act together. Here it is said, the earth trembled, the foundations of the heavens shook and were moved. Evil spirits are in the lowest parts, namely, in the place where the body is, and the natural mind respectively to the higher mind; wherefore they tremble.

"There went up a smoke out of His nostrils, and fire out of His mouth devoured: coals were kindled by it" (ver. 9). Anger is likened to smoke, and fire, thus to live coals, as in mount Sinai and elsewhere. —It is not meant that smoke and devouring fire come out from the Lord, because He has no anger; but it is so said, because the Lord appears such to those who are in the falsity of evil. Smoke denotes falsity, and the flame of it anger; for the falsity of evil in the intellect is as smoke, and anger is the flame of kindled smoke.

"He bowed the heavens also, and came down; and darkness was under His feet" (ver. 10). In like manner darkness, for it is as a very dark cloud, because it is then night to the evil.—Jehovah bowing the heavens and coming down signifies the visitation which precedes the last judgment; darkness under His feet signifies falsities of evil in lower things; by this is effected an exploration of the quality of spirits, and also a separation of the good from the evil. The Lord also bowed the heavens and came down at the time of the Incarnation when the heavens co-operated with Him, and darkness was under His

feet, when He assumed our fallen humanity. Darkness also is the literal sense of the Word.

"And He rode upon a cherub, and did fly: and He was seen upon the wings of the wind" (ver. 11). Upon a cherub; because cherubs are those who descend, and who execute commands. On the wings of the wind is the same, for angels are called wings of the wind.—The Lord's riding upon a cherub signifies His Divine Providence, and His flying signifies His Omnipresence in the spiritual world, and His being seen upon the wings of the wind signifies His Omnipresence in the natural world.

"And He made darkness pavilions round about Him, dark waters, and thick clouds of the skies" (ver. 12). Darkness is as pavilions round about Him. Also binding of waters, and clouds, which amounts to the same, but with some difference of meaning.—This treats of the coming and presence of the Lord in the Word. Darkness and clouds are the literal sense. Still Divine truth such as it is in heaven is within the literal sense, therefore darkness is called a pavilion round about Him.

"Through the brightness before Him were coals of fire kindled" (ver. 13). There is brightness, which is the truth; thence coals are kindled; for [the spirits] chastise by means of the truth.—The darkness mentioned in the previous verse meaning the literal sense of the Word, the brightness here is the spiritual sense. In relation to the righteous, the darkness of the letter comes before the brightness of the spirit; and they know the Lord after the flesh before they know Him according to the spirit. The affections are kindled by the fire of the Lord's love.

"The Lord thundered from heaven, and the Most High uttered His voice" (ver. 14). He thundered out of heaven. Thunders are thus the effects of anger; they follow in the clouds; thence [He] is called the Thunderer, from terror.—In respect to the Lord Himself His thunder is His Divine love and His lightning is His Divine truth, which affect the good and the evil in opposite ways, as explained in the next verse.

"And He sent out arrows, and scattered them; lightning, and discomfited them" (ver. 15). These are spiritual weapons, namely, truths and goodnesses; they are weapons of torment because they wounded the innocent one. Lightning is that light which thus comes, by which they are confounded.—Thunders are here expressed by thundering out of heaven and by giving forth a voice, and lightnings by arrows; and both these signify Divine truths, and the flash their light; which truths, as they vivify and enlighten the good, terrify and blind the evil, which is understood by sending forth arrows and scattering them, and lightning and discomfiting them, for the wicked cannot endure Divine

truths or any light from heaven, wherefore at their presence they flee away.

"And the channels of the sea appeared, the foundations of the world were discovered, at the rebuking of the Lord, at the blast of the breath of His nostrils" (ver. 16). That these will strike to the lowest hell, thus to the ultimate, is here described, the channels of the sea and the foundations of the earth being the lowest hell; for of hell there are degrees, on account of the rebuking, namely, the voice, or what that here signifies, the lightning, the thunder, of the truth. From the blast of the breath of His nostrils, the blast of the breath of the nostrils is life, which penetrates thus with that glow to the lowest parts.

"He sent from above, He took me; He drew me out of many waters" (ver. 17). Here is described, that man, nay, spirits are drawn forth out of hell, and this by God-Messiah, who draws man out from the damnation of many sins, that is, from many waters; He took him out of the deep, because from hell; man is rescued from the enemy, or the devil, who is too strong for him, thus from them that hate him, for the impious horde regard with deadly hatred the sons of God-Messiah, who are here represented by David.

"They prevented me in the day of my calamity; but the Lord was my stay" (ver. 19). They prevented me in the day of my calamity, namely, they desired to destroy me, but God-Messiah was my stay, as above, vers. 2, 3.—The day of calamity is a weak state as to the faith of truth; the Lord being a stay signifies ability in such case.

"He brought me forth also into a large place: He delivered me, because He delighted in me" (ver. 20). He brought me forth into a large [broad] place, into a heavenly plain, from the pit, from hell, because He delighted in me, that is, God-Messiah delighted in His sons. Here those things which are God-Messiah's are applied to those things in heaven and earth which are in God-Messiah. These [expressions] can in no wise be applicable to David, according to his own confession and various acts of his life, for he was exceedingly unrighteous. Because now those things which are in God-Messiah are applied or imputed, these words treat concerning Him alone, namely, that Jehovah delights in His Son alone, as was said in the mount, when He was glorified: these in like manner; for God-Messiah alone is Righteousness and clean.

"For I have kept the ways of the Lord, and have not wickedly departed from my God" (ver. 22). He alone kept the ways of Jehovah, that is, the Law in its complex; for He fulfilled all the law, internal and external, as well as all that the law involves, namely, what is involved by the sacrifices, and worship, etc. etc.: thus He alone

became Righteousness, and yet He prayed for those that hated Him, which David was never wont to do.

"For all His judgments were before me: and as for His statutes, I did not depart from them" (ver. 23). This is now confirmed by these words.—Judgments are Divine truths, according to which men ought to live. Statutes are the external things of the Word, such as rituals; and those things which are representative and significative of the internal sense are the laws of worship.

"I was also upright before Him, and have kept myself from mine iniquity" (ver. 24). In like manner, [as in the previous verse.] Mine iniquity is man's iniquity, but it reads, "he took care that he should not act wickedly," as the other translator renders it. In Him was no iniquity.

"Therefore the Lord hath recompensed me according to my righteousness; according to my cleanness in His eyesight" (ver. 25). These words in like manner as before, but with a difference.—By fulfilling the whole law in all its degrees the Lord became Righteousness itself; and He alone had merit in His righteousness, because He fulfilled the law by His own power, whereas all the power which men have of doing good is derived from the Lord alone, and to Him all the merit of human righteousness is due.

"With the merciful Thou wilt show Thyself merciful, and with the upright man Thou wilt show Thyself upright" (ver. 26). That imputation of righteousness or holiness is understood, is manifest from these words, namely, with the holy Thou art holy, with the perfect Thou art perfect. Only God-Messiah is holy and perfect.

"With the pure Thou wilt show Thyself pure; and with the froward Thou wilt show Thyself unsavoury" (ver. 27). With the pure, pure, in like manner. That righteousness may be imputed there must be a conflict, wherefore it is said, With the perverse Thou contendest.—This and the previous verse teach a most important truth. The Lord appears to every one according to his state. Mercy itself and purity itself, the perfect One appears to imperfect men, and especially to evil spirits, as He is reflected in their own states of heart and mind. For however men may think of the Lord doctrinally, they necessarily think of Him practically from their own states.

"And the afflicted people Thou wilt save: but Thine eyes are upon the haughty, that Thou mayest bring them down" (ver. 28). Thus, Thou savest the afflicted, namely, in the conflicts. But the haughty Thou castest down; the lowly only He raiseth up: thus the lofty one is opposed to the afflicted, or the lowly, who lies in the dust.

"For Thou art my lamp, O Lord: and the Lord will lighten my darkness" (ver. 29). Thus He enlightens the understanding, for the understanding is never enlightened but after a conflict; thus is dis-

persed the darkness, or the falsities. But the darkness clings to the mind because cupidities and guilt do so; these continually induce falsities, which God dispels.

"For by Thee I have run through a troop: by my God have I leaped over a wall" (ver. 30). Thus he shall conquer, which is to run through a troop, and he will go over a wall, which they attack, as above, for within or without amounts to the same: for the impious think they stand in their fortified city.

"As for God, His way is perfect; the word of the Lord is tried: He is a buckler to all them that trust in Him" (ver. 31). After man has been justified, this now follows, for God-Messiah then defends man and spirit, wherefore it is here now said, "as for God," that is, God-Messiah. He is called the way, integrity, the tried word of Jehovah, which clearly signifies God-Messiah, who is the Word of Jehovah, and tried, as is well known. A buckler to all who have faith, that is, who trust in Him.

"For who is God, save the Lord? and who is a rock, save our God?" (ver. 32.) That Jehovah alone is God: thus God-Messiah, in whom is the fulness of the Godhead; for through Him, that is, by Him, all things are made, who alone is a rock, as above.

"God is my strength and power: and He maketh my way perfect" (ver. 33). In like manner a refuge, and power, as above. He will make man's way perfect, will lead man in the way of truth, which is the perfect way, which He will prepare.

"He maketh my feet like hinds' feet: and setteth me upon my high places" (ver. 34). Swiftness is here treated of, that He will speedily prepare the way. Feet are the way in which they walk. Upon my high places, namely, upon the sphere in me, which is above the rational mind, which is the high place in man, when it gives him understanding of the true and the good.

"He teacheth my hands to war; so that a bow of steel [brass] is broken by mine arms" (ver. 35). He teacheth to war, how he shall smite his enemies, or overcome them. He submitteth the brazen bow to my arms, that is, gives me to understand the natural truths which are the brazen bow. Arms are the powers of understanding; these are the strength of a man, and are called arms.

"Thou hast also given me the shield of Thy salvation: and Thy gentleness hath made me great" (ver. 36). The shield of salvation is saving faith. Thy afflicting makes me great, namely, affliction makes those who have faith great—thus to afflict is also said of the Messiah, that He makes man great.

"Thou hast enlarged my steps under me; so that my feet [ankles] did not slip" (ver. 37).—To enlarge, literally, to make broad, the steps is to bring the life, meant by the feet, into conformity with the truth,

which is meant by breadth. The ankles, like the feet, correspond to the natural and sensual part of the mind; hence the ankles not slipping signifies that the natural mind is supported.

"I have pursued mine enemies, and destroyed them: and turned not again until I had consumed them. And I have consumed them, and wounded them, that they could not arise: yea, they are fallen under my feet" (vers. 38, 39). These things follow when man has acquired faith; then he pursues his enemies until he has consumed them.—The Lord pursued His enemies when, in His conflicts with the powers of darkness, He continued to resist and fight against them until they were overcome. The powers of darkness are in the continual effort to rise up and acquire dominion over heaven, yea, over the Lord Himself; but the Lord so completely subdued them under His power that His foes were made His footstool. In relation to man the Lord's foes are the thoughts and affections of the natural mind, which are in the continual endeavour to rise against the thoughts and affections of the spiritual mind, until the Lord has brought them into subordination to the power of His Divine truth and goodness.

"For Thou hast girded me with strength to battle: them that rose up against me hast Thou subdued under me. Thou hast also given me the necks of mine enemies, that I might destroy them that hate me" (vers. 40, 41). The like, for strength here is faith, with which he is girded, and with which he lays low, *i.e.* subdues his spiritual enemies.

"They looked, but there was none to save; even unto the Lord, but He answered them not. Then did I beat them as small as the dust of the earth, I did stamp them as the mire of the street, and did spread them abroad" (vers. 42, 43). How his enemies are treated of, how they are subdued, namely, that none shall save them, that they shall be as the dust, which is trodden as the mire, etc.—It may seem singular that the enemies of the Messiah or of man should cry unto the Lord for help; but we find in the Gospel evil spirits both acknowledging the Lord's power and praying Him to grant them what they knew He only was able to give them. When about to be cast out of one possessed, the spirits prayed Jesus that He would not send them forth into the deep.

"Thou also hast delivered me from the strivings of my people, Thou hast kept me to be head of the heathen: a people which I knew not shall serve me" (ver. 44). Because it is faith that effects all this, here those things are set forth in which there is no faith, but there is doubt. Thus He shall deliver me from the strivings of my people, from the doubts which bring forth strivings and heresies. "Thou shalt keep me to be head of the heathen." Thus it is faith which he will keep; in the inner, the inmost, and the supreme sense the head of

the heathen is God-Messiah. The people whom he knew not, is all that which confirms faith, which are things intellectual, etc., these shall serve and consent.

"Strangers shall submit themselves unto me: as soon as they hear, they shall be obedient unto me" (ver. 45). These words in like manner, for they are called sons of the stranger which shall fawn upon me, for they consent and obey; for those things are servile, in comparison with faith.

"Strangers shall fade away, and they shall be afraid out of their close places" (ver. 46). Here are other sons of the stranger, namely those who possess truths without applying them; they guard their treasures without enjoying them; these shall quake, for from them they shall see spiritual celestial truths: this now is "out of their close places," where they guard those things.

"The Lord liveth; and blessed be my rock; and exalted be the God of the rock of my salvation" (ver. 47). Now again he calls upon God-Messiah, as in the beginning so in the end, because of the first and the last, as is usual in Divine songs, just as in our Lord's Prayer. "The Lord liveth" is a solemn expression, implying that Jehovah-God alone is Life. God-Messiah alone is a Rock, as above. And God is the rock of salvation, *i.e.* of faith. He is the rock of salvation.

"It is God that avengeth me, and that bringeth down the people under me" (ver. 48). He alone it is who defends man from injuries, and punishes the evil, [whom He prostrates,] for He alone it is who does this; faith indeed [effects this,] but He alone gives faith.

"And that bringeth me forth from mine enemies: Thou also hast lifted me up on high above them that rose up against me: Thou hast delivered me from the violent man" (ver. 49). The things which were stated in the beginning are here taken up again, as is customary in songs. At length the deliverance is set forth. The enemies are, as above, the devil's horde. The man of violence is the devil.

"Therefore I will give thanks unto Thee, O Lord, among the heathen, and I will sing praises unto Thy name" (ver. 50). Hence now confession or thanksgiving. That it shall be among the heathen, signifies various things, which see elsewhere; for Thy name shall be sung among the heathen, those who confess.

"He is the tower of salvation for His king: and showeth mercy to His anointed, unto David, and to his seed for evermore" (ver. 51). Who magnifies the salvation of His King; namely, Jehovah the Father, who praises His King's, *i.e.*, His Son's, righteousness and merits. And showeth mercy to His anointed, unto David, *i.e.* unto God-Messiah, for when He suffered He cried out concerning the mercy of Jehovah the Father, that He had forsaken Him. The Son Himself is the Anointed of Jehovah; and is King David. And His seed is all who

have faith in Him. Furthermore, by king, anointed, and David are understood those who are called the sons of the King, thus kings. Seed is applied to them, when God-Messiah is understood by David. But seed is applied to faith and to those things which belong to faith, when the King's sons [are meant] by David; but when [seed] is applied proximately to David, it is those who will reign after him. These [will endure] for an age, *i.e.* for a time, as is manifest from the signification of an age wherever it occurs. But in the inner sense [and] the inmost, an age signifies eternity, as also elsewhere. That the kingdom will be everlasting, of David, see above, 2 Sam. vii. 13, 16, where those words also are explained.

CHAPTER XXV.

THE LAST WORDS OF DAVID.

2 *Samuel* xxiii. 1-6.

THE last words of David are evidently prophetic. The language bears a striking resemblance to that of Balaam, when he took up his parable, and blessed the children of Israel, whom Balak had brought him to curse. "And he took up his parable, and said, Balaam the son of Beor hath said, and the man whose eyes are open hath said: he hath said, which heard the words of God, and knew the knowledge of the Most High, which saw the vision of the Almighty, falling into a trance, but having his eyes open: I shall see him, but not now: I shall behold him, but not nigh: there shall come a Star out of Jacob, and a Sceptre shall rise out of Israel, and shall smite the corners of Moab, and destroy all the children of Sheth. And Edom shall be a possession, Seir also shall be a possession for his enemies; and Israel shall do valiantly. Out of Jacob shall come he that shall have dominion, and shall destroy him that remaineth of the city." The similarity of the language shows that both spoke under an immediate inspiration from the Most High; and this alone is sufficient to convince us that the words of the Psalmist are prophetic as well as those of the Soothsayer. This is indeed obvious from the subject of David's utterance, as well as from his declaration, that the Spirit of the Lord spake by him. There is one part of his parable which might be understood in reference to himself, where he says, or rather where the Spirit says, "He that ruleth over men must be just, ruling in the fear of God;" but what follows cannot certainly be considered as applicable to any merely human being. It evidently refers to the Lord, who was about to come into the world; nor is this in any degree inconsistent with those facts which appear to

relate to David and his house; for David himself was a representative of the Lord, as was also Solomon, and every other king of Israel and Judah.

Seeing then that David is here speaking from the Spirit of God concerning the glory of the Messiah and of His kingdom, we proceed to consider the import of his inspired enunciations.

To take this prophecy under its most general view, it declares the two universal objects and effects of the Lord's advent, the establishment of a covenant with the faithful, or the bringing of them into a more intimate connection with Himself, and the subjugation and removal of those who had overturned His kingdom in the world.

The Church is meant by the house of David; for the Church is the Lord's house; and the everlasting covenant to be established with it has reference to the conjunction which the Lord's Incarnation was to effect between Himself and His people. By the sons of Belial are to be understood especially the powers of darkness; therefore not wicked men only but evil spirits, by whose influence and machinations the Church of the Lord had been perverted and destroyed. The subjugation of the powers of hell is described by the sons of Belial being thrust away as thorns, and utterly burned with fire. And that this could not be effected by the Lord in His pure unclothed Divinity, but required human nature as a covering and an instrument, is indicated in what is said of the sons of Belial, that they cannot be taken with hands, but that the man that shall touch them must be fenced with iron and the staff of a spear. The humanity of the Lord was a medium of communication between Himself and His children, and an instrumental power by which He opposed the enemies of His Church and kingdom. The Lord was the Word made flesh—clothed with humanity; the Divine truth of which is meant by the iron, and the Divine goodness by the staff of a spear, in accordance with which another part of Scripture speaks of the Lord ruling the nations with a rod of iron, because iron signifies natural truth.

Besides, but in harmony with, this universal sense of the prophecy, there is a particular meaning, which lies concealed in every portion of it. In the 4th verse it is said, "He shall be as the light of the morning, when the sun riseth, even a morning without clouds; as the tender grass springing out of the earth by clear shining after rain."

In their general sense these Divine words relate to the Lord at His coming into the world, when, as the Sun of Righteousness, He arose on a benighted world with healing in His wings, and removed the cloud that had rested for ages upon the tabernacle and concealed its inner glories, and rent the veil of types and shadows, and shed the light of truth immediately from Himself; and thus commenced the new day of spiritual enlightenment and of true and living faith. But in

the particular sense, they relate to the coming of the Lord, by His Spirit and His Word, to the minds of the penitent, when His light and love are shed abroad in their hearts, when the darkness of ignorance and error is removed, when a new day of truth and goodness dawns on the mind; and the signs of a new life, as the tender grass, are beginning to appear.

These are blessings set before us under the figure of the morning without clouds. But they are to be considered as the results of the spiritual dominion and government of the Lord, which are spoken of in the previous verse, where it is said, "He that ruleth over men must be just, ruling in the fear of God." The Lord, as the Ruler of men, is indeed infinitely just in Himself; but He rules His people in justice, when His justice rules in them as well as over them. For the Lord's government is different in different minds; some He governs by justice, some by judgment, or some by love, and some by fear, some by goodness, some by truth. The Divine government in its origin is the same, it is the government of infinite love by infinite wisdom; but its aspect is changed according to the different and varying states of men. When the Lord is spoken of as ruling in justice, the government of His Divine goodness is especially meant, and it is intended to describe the nature and quality of His dominion in the hearts of men. When the Divine goodness rules, it rules in the fear of God, not the slavish fear of God as an avenger, but the holy fear which is in all true love, a fear to injure and offend the object loved.

It is such love and fear of the just God that makes His coming to the mind as the light of the morning, when the sun ariseth, even a morning without clouds.

The morning is an emblem of peace and serenity of mind, when Divine truth sheds its mild light in the mind, and gives it a sense of that heavenly beauty and harmony which the light of Divine truth discloses. Morning, in Scripture, is peculiarly emblematical of an interior state of spiritual peace—a peace which arises not so much from the absence of outward troubles, as from the tranquillized state of inward feelings. Regeneration begins in tranquillity—like the dawn of day and the infancy of life. It is neither effected at once, nor does it advance in one continued series. It consists of a succession of distinct as well as of continuous states; and each particular state is an image of the whole. The life of the soul progresses in a way correspondently with that of the body. It has its birth, and its alternations of activity and rest, of wakefulness and repose. States also, like times, are formed and measured by particular revolutions. Every state has its morning, its noon, its evening, and its night. And it is by these grateful and beneficent vicissitudes that the powers of the mind are at once refreshed and invigorated, delighted and improved. States and their progressions are likewise produced from a cause analogous

to that which produces periods and progressions of time. It is the sun, indeed, which produces the day, and distinguishes the day from the night; and it is the difference of the sun's altitude which makes the times of the day. But it is the revolution of the earth which causes all these changes, the sun shining in perpetual splendour, and making, so far as depends on him, perpetual day. It is the same with the Lord and His moral creation. In God there is no change, no variableness, neither shadow of turning: He is the same yesterday, to-day, and for ever: His Sun shines with unchanging and impartial light on all the children of men. The absence of that light cannot be produced from its source, any more than darkness can be produced by the sun; it arises solely from its subjects averting themselves from it, and excluding its influence from their hearts and understandings. Moral or spiritual darkness is caused entirely by self coming between the soul and God—by the selfhood of man standing between the Lord and the faculties which He has given for the perception and reception of His light and life. And as spiritual darkness is caused by the interposition of man's corrupt selfhood, agreeably to the declaration of Scripture, "Your sins have separated between you and your God, and your iniquities have hid His face from you;" so every degree of obscurity arises from the activity of the human selfhood. However highly regenerated man may be, his selfhood can never be entirely neutralized, much less abolished. Even the heavens are not clean in the Lord's sight; for as the man is in the angel, the angel is not free from the imperfections of the man.

If, then, the selfhood of man is the ground and cause of all spiritual darkness and obscurity, the degree of obscurity will be such as is the degree of its activity. When it is in its greatest activity it is night, when in its least activity it is morning; and as it increases in activity, the day advances towards evening and night again. With the regenerate, as with the angels, there is never real darkness; for although they experience a state that may be called night, it is such night as that in which, though the sun is absent, its light remains; and that twilight is but an agreeable obscurity which gives repose and refreshment to the mind, and enables it to enter upon a new day with recruited powers and enlarged capacities, and gives zest to the enjoyments and energy to the duties which belong to it.

The morning of the spiritual state is that which is treated of in the last words of David. And it is said that the Lord shall be as the morning, when the sun riseth, a morning without clouds. The Lord is the Sun whose rising gives birth to the morning; because His rising is His exaltation in the affections of the heart, which gives Him an ascendancy in the mind, and thus gives Him the influence and control over it, which result in the diffusion of light and peace over the whole inward

man. The many exhortations to exalt the Lord have all reference to the exalting of Him in the heart. Nor are we to suppose that we can practically exalt Him in any other way. We exalt the Lord practically when we exalt His love and wisdom, His goodness and truth, His justice and judgment, in our understandings and hearts. When His love and wisdom are exalted, the Lord is exalted; when they dwell in us, the Lord dwells in us; for the Divine Being can only dwell in that which is His own, or in what is from Himself. Justice and judgment are the habitation of His throne in the lowly and contrite heart, as well as in the mansions of eternity. These form His habitation in the mind, and in them only can He be exalted.

But how are the principles of justice and judgment to be exalted? By shunning and abhorring whatever is contrary to them. The Lord cannot be exalted by a mere devotional act or by mental excitement. The foundations of His "habitation" must be laid in humility and self-abasement, and the graces which enter into its formation must each rest on self-denial. The idea of exalting God before we have humbled self is vain, and the labour must be fruitless. It is from this practical error that there is so little of the true exaltation of God in the Church and in the lives of its members. Where are the evidences, the fruits of such exaltation? When God is truly exalted in the mind, the virtues which proceed from Him will be prominent in the life—there will be meekness, gentleness, kindness, forbearance, and all those virtues which bespeak an equal if not a greater regard for the feelings and the welfare of others than for our own. These are the true effects of the Lord's exaltation, or of man's true humiliation; for the one cannot exist without the other. It is mocking for the proud or the self-righteous to speak of exalting God. Those who consider themselves better and more righteous than others, have acquired but little knowledge of themselves, and less knowledge of God. This knowledge has the certain effect of making us think lowly of ourselves, and highly of others in comparison; being the very opposite of the practice of the world, where there is an unhappy readiness to offend and to take offence, to injure and to revenge an injury.

If we can ever hope to experience the dawn of a morning without clouds, we must subdue those evil passions which becloud and agitate the mind, and prevent the truth and love of God from giving light and peace. This is our peculiar duty; for if we deny ourselves of evil, God will implant goodness; for He waits to be gracious, and He must ever wait till the ungracious things of our selfhood are removed by active resistance and obedience.

Until evil is resisted in the inward life, and desisted from in the outward conduct, from a sense of duty to God, no good thing can be implanted even in the inner life. But after this has been effected,

there is another important and blessed work to be effected. The good insinuated into the inner man by the Lord during our practical fidelity to Him, is to be brought down into the outer man; the good of the affections and thoughts is to be made the good of the works and words of the outward life and conversation. These are the tender grass springing out of the earth by clear shining after rain. Here we have a beautiful instance of the system of analogy that runs through the whole Word of God. Heaven is emblematical of the spiritual mind, and the earth is emblematical of the natural mind. Truth, like rain, descends from the heaven of the spiritual mind and falls upon the earth of the natural mind, and makes it fruitful. We read of the heaven being shut up, when there is no rain; for the spiritual mind is actually closed by evil, when no heavenly truth can descend to the natural mind below, so that there is spiritual drought and famine. We read again the Divine promise, that if we bring our offering to the Lord, He will open the windows of heaven and pour us out a blessing, that there shall not be room enough to receive it.

But there is sunshine as well as rain needed to make the earth fruitful. So must there be love as well as truth to make the life fruitful in righteousness. The tender grass grows out of the earth by clear shining after rain. How true is this spiritually. Truth is most necessary and useful for our growth in goodness. But without love truth would be as fruitless as rain without sunshine. It is the clear shining of love after the rain of truth has watered the good ground of an honest heart, that causes growth and fructification in the life.

It is the same in our relation to each other as it is in the mind itself. It is not sufficient that in our intercourse with each other we are truthful, we need also to be loving. Truth, precious as it is, existing or dispensed by itself, is cold and unproductive of the good of which it is capable, as a power working under the influence of love. What would the state of childhood be if we gave the young mind truth but gave the young heart no love? Is not the sunshine of love as necessary for the growth of the young life as the rain of truth? So with our friendships. So with our spiritual brotherhood. Truth is one of the essential elements of real usefulness in all the relations of life, but love is the uniting principle. To speak the truth in love is the perfection of teaching and of admonishing. Above all, therefore, the religious teacher must be a man of love as well as of truth. He must be faithful in teaching the truth and enforcing its lessons, but unless he give the clear shining of love after the rain of truth, he will fail to produce the good which should be aimed at as the ultimate result of his sacred office. How beautifully were these two united in the teaching and example of our great Teacher, our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ.

CHAPTER XXVI.

DAVID'S MIGHTY MEN: THREE BRING HIM WATER FROM THE WELL OF BETHLEHEM.

2 Samuel xxiii. 8-29.

THE feats of the leaders of David's army form the principal topic of the remaining part of the 23rd chapter, and occupy a conspicuous place in the 21st. Their extraordinary valour and prowess were not unworthy of those who led on the hosts of him who was the dread of the enemies of Israel.

So long as war shall continue, these qualities will be prized, and their chivalrous exercise will command admiration. And justly so. War, though a great evil, is, as yet, an unavoidable one. Wars may be regarded as the eruptions of the moral volcanoes which relieve the internal fires that produce them, which diminish and will finally exhaust them, so far as they require a visible outlet. As thousands of extinct volcanoes on our globe attest the diminution of the cause that produced them, and give a certain promise of the gradual and complete extinction of the whole; so war, once the almost natural result of the collision of the tribes and nations of the earth, is gradually becoming less wide in its extent, less ferocious in its character, and less frequent in its occurrence. The internal fire of the lust of wealth and power, with the cruelty and revenge which that lust inspires, has now fewer outlets. And although these may be in themselves extremely formidable and in action truly terrible, yet is the evil of war, though more concentrated, greatly moderated; and humanity and religion, as they obtain ascendancy over men, will convince them that peace and goodwill are the only true means of securing national as well as individual prosperity and happiness.

The wars and warriors of the Scriptures are, however, designed to lead us to the contemplation of far other subjects than national strife and personal deeds of martial glory. They are designed to lead us to a consideration of those inward strivings, those conflicts between the principles of spiritual light and darkness, which constitute the warfare of the spiritual life. In considering these we do not exclude the indirect consideration of natural wars. Men war against each other because they do not war against themselves. The ultimate fate of war itself is to be decided, not on the battle-field, but in the human mind. Within us is the world of causes, without us is the world of effects. So far as men conquer evil and establish the empire of good

in themselves, they will cease to war against each other. As they become the subjects of the kingdom of Jesus Christ they will desire and strive to overcome the world in themselves, that they may be unworldly in their conduct towards each other. The Author of Christianity, who was the pattern of the Christian life and character, exemplified this in His own person, both in His inward experience and in His outward life. He came into the world for the purpose of overcoming the world and bringing it under obedience and into harmony with Himself. But how did He seek to effect this great object? Not by outward physical war, but by inward spiritual conflict. He resisted and overcame the world in Himself. At the same time, and by the same acts, He subdued the kingdom of darkness, which prompts us through our worldly-mindedness to deeds of aggression against our fellow-creatures. While the Saviour was thus engaged in an inward strife with the principles of fallen humanity, which He in mercy assumed for the redemption and salvation of mankind, His life was one of purest love and beneficence. His warfare was within, mercy and peace marked the progress of His life without. As this was the character of the true Christ, it is also the character of true Christians. "In this world," said our Lord to His disciples, "ye shall have tribulation; but be of good cheer, I have overcome the world." The world which the Lord overcame is that which the disciple is to conquer—the world in himself, with all its principalities and powers.

As this warfare is spiritual, so are the instruments and agents by which it is to be carried on. It is not to be engaged in with carnal weapons, but by the sword of the Spirit, which is the Word of God; nor is this sanctified and powerful instrument to be wielded by mighty men, but by mighty principles. The principles in which such extraordinary power resides are those of love and truth, in their various forms of goodness, meekness, humility, patience, sincerity, simplicity, integrity, prudence, but clothed with zeal for the accomplishment of great objects or the performance of great deeds. By these and their kindred qualities the Lord effects our deliverance from the power of our spiritual foes, those of our own household. For we have the Philistine, and the Egyptian, and even the wild beast in our own natural understandings and hearts—we have the spurious intelligence, the false science, and the savage lusts and appetites that spring up in our minds spontaneously, and find in our hereditary nature their native and congenial home. That pride of personal wisdom, too, which has an overweening confidence in its own power, without the wisdom and power of God, is the giant principle, the parent of self-reliance, whatever shape it may assume. The thoughts that obtrude themselves into our minds, inspiring them with the

notion that the objects and ends of life may be attained by mere human wisdom and skill, and leading us to suppose that meekness of heart and lowliness of mind are only other names for feebleness of purpose and lack of intelligence—these are the Rephaim and the Anakim, in whose sight the true Israel are as grasshoppers.

It was in the valley of Rephaim that the troop of the Philistines had pitched when the circumstance took place which is here narrated. The relation carries us back to the beginning of the reign of David, the circumstance having taken place soon after the tribes had anointed him king over Israel. In the 5th chapter, at the 17th verse, we read that "when the Philistines heard that they had anointed David king over Israel, all the Philistines came up to seek David; and David heard of it, and went down to the hold. The Philistines also came and spread themselves in the valley of Rephaim."

The cave of Adullam is celebrated as having afforded David shelter and concealment when, at a still earlier period of his history, he fled from the face of Saul, an incident which was considered in its place. It describes a state of deep temptation and of great mental suffering, so well expressed by David himself in the 142nd Psalm: "I looked on my right hand, and beheld, but there was no man that would know me: refuge failed me; no man cared for my soul." In the present instance David was pressed by another enemy. The Philistines who had slain Saul now sought to destroy his successor. David was compelled to seek refuge in the hold; and the hosts of the enemy were spread out in the valley of the giants, and their garrison was at Bethlehem, not far from Adullam. Though now surrounded and watched by a powerful enemy, David was not in that condition in which "no man cared for his soul." The people of Israel were on his side; "and three of the thirty chief went down, and came to David in the harvest time unto the cave of Adullam." Shut up in the hold at that season when no shower falls in Palestine, when the ground is parched and the streams are dried up, David, in the extremity of his suffering from burning thirst, called to remembrance the cool refreshing spring of which he had so often drunk, and exclaimed, "Oh that one would give me drink of the water of the well of Bethlehem, which is by the gate!" Almost every one has had some slight experience of the intolerable nature of extreme thirst, and of the longing it produces for that most delicious, and, one might almost say, that most precious of all the natural gifts of God's bounty to His creatures, the cool and limpid water-spring. But this has its analogy in the experience of mental thirst, the desire not merely for knowledge but for truth, which is almost as universally felt as the thirst for water, and the defect or want of which, where the desire is ardent, is not less intolerable. In no sound mind is the desire for knowledge entirely wanting, although the

knowledge desired may be extremely various in different minds. There is a love of knowledge common to all minds in this state, and there is particular love of knowledge which has for its end the attainment of special objects. The man of science makes a special pursuit of scientific knowledge, the lawyer of legal knowledge, the physician of medical knowledge, and every other one that which relates to his function, and even the evil-doer cultivates the knowledge which promises him the means of success in evil. In all these cases the desire of knowledge is in particular instances not less ardent and distressing than the thirst for water. How does the philosopher, attempting the solution of some profound problem, thirst for the knowledge that may enable him to accomplish his purpose, and with unwearied toil dig deep into the mount of science, in hopes that the well-spring may burst forth to satisfy the desires of his longing mind. Still more intense perhaps is the desire for knowledge when some beloved object is far away in the midst of danger and imminent death —exposed to the perils of war or of travel, in the burning sands of Africa or in the ice-bound regions of the pole.

If mental thirst or the love of natural knowledge is thus intense, still more must be the desire of spiritual knowledge, which may be called the thirst of the soul. If the nature and ardency of the desire increase with the excellency of the object, religious desire must be the highest and intensest of all. If it is not felt to be so, it must be because we do not so ardently desire the solution of the religious problem, or the pursuit of the religious life, or the realization of the religious hope. If we truly prize life and immortality, we cannot but desire the knowledge which brings them to light; and any obstacle that comes between us and the knowledge we desire, that cuts off the communication between the soul and the water of life, will produce a sense of severe privation, and bring the soul into a state of deep distress and suffering. The spiritual knowledge of which we now speak is not that which may be called the science of religion—a knowledge of the doctrines of the Bible. It is that which is felt to come immediately home to us as beings who know that we stand between life and death, and in whom the fear of eternal death and the love of eternal life have been truly awakened. It is not your men of mere religious science, but those of religious life, that feel this thirst of the soul. Men may indeed thirst for the water of science, but that is entirely different from thirst for the water of life. The water of science is desired as the means of imparting a pleasurable sensation to the mind, but the water of life is desired as the means of securing spiritual existence to the soul. The want of the one is only the absence of pleasure, the want of the other is the absence of happiness and eternal life. Temptation arising from the defect or want of Divine truth is only experienced by

those who have entered on the life of truth, and to whom therefore truth is the means of life. Such a temptation did our Lord experience in the passion of the Cross. He of whom David was a type, and whose conflicts, trials, and sufferings were shadowed forth by those of the king of Israel, was then pressed upon by the whole power of the enemy, the kingdom of darkness. In that temptation despair for the salvation of the human race, which was the end He had in view in coming into the world, and for which He suffered and died, fell upon the Saviour; and the ardency of His desire for the salvation and happiness of His creatures produced in the suffering humanity its analogous state. When the Lord said, "I thirst," He expressed the agonizing desire of His holy mind infinitely more than the raging thirst of His body. His thirst was eminently the desire for eternal life, and for securing the means of attaining it; but it was for the eternal life of others, not His own. His thirst was also for the water of life; for His desire was to be filled as to His humanity with that living truth which was equally necessary to His overcoming in temptation, and to His becoming a fountain of living water to His famishing children. Nor is the water of the well of Bethlehem without its typical significance in reference to the Lord and His people. Bethlehem literally signifies "the house of bread;" and here it is to be regarded as the house of water also. Bethlehem, the place of the Lord's birth, may be understood to point to Him as the bread of life, in whom is the fountain of the water of life.

In reference to the Christian disciple in his states of trial and temptation, when there is a famine, not of natural bread or water, but of the hearing of the Word of God, longing for the water of the well of Bethlehem is expressive of the desire of the soul to drink of the living water of the fountain which has been opened up for us in the house of David —the living truth proceeding from the love of God in His Divine Humanity. The well of which David desired to drink was beside, literally in, the gate of Bethlehem; a gate being introductory; from which the Lord calls Himself the door, His Humanity being the medium through which there is access to His eternal Divinity, the Humanity itself being the immediate fountain or well of water from which men draw their supplies.

David's longing for the water of the well of Bethlehem was not without its effect, though the final result was not that which his friends intended. Three of the thirty mighty men of David, hearing the words of the king, "brake through the host of the Philistines, and drew water out of the well of Bethlehem, that was by the gate, and took it, and brought it to David: nevertheless he would not drink thereof, but poured it out unto the Lord."

Naturally considered, David evidently regarded this daring feat as

an act of courage, but not of prudence; the risk was too great for the object. His will and judgment were not in it, but were against it; and had he been previously consulted he would have condemned and prohibited the attempt. Thus in spiritual things do we sometimes act from the ardour of zeal untempered by discretion, and afterwards find, in the moments of cool reflection, that the understanding does not approve the deed, however generous and well intentioned it may have been.

In the operations of the mind and thence of the life there is a continual action and reaction of the inner and outer man. The inner man occupies a higher and more peaceful region of the mind; the outer man treads the earth, and has to engage in the toils, share in the excitements, and endure the storms of life. The inner man is the seat of our principles, our conscience, our essential and ruling life. The outer man has more to do with ways and means than with principles and ends. The inner man may be considered as the legislative, the outer man as the executive, branch of the government of the soul. From the inner man come forth the laws of life, but the outer man is left to interpret and to execute them. The outer man is not a passive instrument, but an intelligent and reactive agent. Our inner man expresses his desires or enunciates his laws, our outer man has to interpret and execute them. But he does not always interpret them rightly, nor execute them faithfully. Indeed it is sometimes extremely difficult to do so. As the popular will may be so strong as to impede or defy the law, so may our natural man greatly modify or entirely resist the will of our inner man. This kind of action and reaction between the inner and outer man goes on continually. Great must be the difference in the character and results of this reciprocal action in the different stages of the regenerate life—in the early stages when the natural mind is yet turbulent, passionate, impatient, and in the later stages when it has become reconciled and accustomed to the mild and easy yoke of heavenly love and truth. In this case the inner and outer man act as one; and this unity of action constitutes regeneration, producing true peace and solid happiness. This unity of action does not imply a blending of the agents and reagent. On the contrary, as the inner and outer man, the spiritual mind and the natural, become more harmonized and united, they acquire a more distinctive character and action. The line between them becomes more distinct, and so do their functions. The inner man retires more within himself, and yet acts more powerfully upon the outer. He is more remote from the turmoil and more secure from the dangers and the conflicts of life. And so, the more any one is a Christian the more he enjoys the tranquillity of inward peace, however his natural man may be suffering from outward tribulation. When the life of David had been endangered in

the encounter with one of the sons of the giants, the men of David sware unto him, "Thou shalt go no more out to battle, that thou quench not the light of Israel."

During the progress of the regenerate life much of the reaction of the natural mind must imperfectly represent the action of the spiritual. The desires of the mind may be carried out with zeal and energy, but not always with wisdom. And when this is the case, that which had been the object of the desire, though it may be secured, cannot be appropriated; for nothing can enter into the inner life which does not unite in itself, or is not the result of, both love and wisdom, zeal and prudence.

Although David refused to drink the water of the well of Bethlehem, for which he had longed, he "poured it out unto the Lord. And he said, Be it far from me, O Lord, that I should do this: is not this the blood of the men that went in jeopardy of their lives?" To have drunk of the water thus procured would have been equivalent to accepting the blood of a human sacrifice, since the water was regarded as the blood of these men. However such sacrifice may be the fruit of religious zeal, it is greatly deficient in religious wisdom. In one sense human sacrifice is too great an offering. God's acceptance of human sacrifice, and especially of voluntary human sacrifice, would represent the absorption of the human soul into the Divine essence—a notion which, being a corruption of one of the highest truths, is itself one of the greatest errors. Christianity requires us indeed to offer ourselves as sacrifices unto God; but it requires us to offer ourselves living sacrifices—to devote the affections of our hearts and the labour of our lives to His service; and to strive to attain conjunction with the Lord, which enables us to feel, that the more fully we are His the more distinctly we are our own.

To pour out unto the Lord the water of the well of Bethlehem, as the blood of those who obtained it, is to acknowledge that life, which is the gift of God, is His, and is to be ascribed to Him alone, and to look to Him to sanctify it, and render it fit for His sacred service. This pouring out of the water reminds us of the truth that "we must needs die, and are as water spilt on the ground, which cannot be gathered up again." Man cannot give life, neither can he restore it. This is true of spiritual and eternal, as well as of natural and temporal life. The breath of natural life and the spirit of regenerating life are equally the gift of God. To Him should they be poured out, in the spirit of devout acknowledgment, that every good and every perfect gift cometh from above. And where we have erred in the right employment of the powers which the Lord confers upon us, or of the graces which He bestows, when zeal may have carried us where wisdom would have forbidden us to venture, may we listen to the dictates of that

Divine voice, which never fails to speak out clearly and distinctly when even the generous impulses of the mind have carried us beyond the bounds of prudence.

CHAPTER XXVII.

DAVID'S SIN IN NUMBERING THE PEOPLE, AND ITS PUNISHMENT.

2 *Samuel* xxiv. 1-15.

IT is impossible to form a right judgment respecting the character of the Jewish history, unless we consider it with reference to the Jewish dispensation. That dispensation was not only suited to the people and to the age for whose benefit it was established; it was also representative of a dispensation which was yet to come, being the shadow, but having little or nothing of the substance, of a real Church. In consequence of this all things that existed amongst the Jews, and happened to them, were representative of the spiritual states and their consequences, as characteristic of a higher and purer dispensation.

To understand the crime of David we must know what was represented by the people and by numbering them.

The people of Israel represented the spiritual Church. The twelve tribes of Israel, like the twelve apostles of the Lamb, represented all the graces and virtues, or all the principles of goodness and truth, which constitute the Church, considered under a spiritual idea; from which circumstance it was that the names of both were engraven on the walls and gates of the New Jerusalem. As the Church may exist in one individual mind as well as of an innumerable multitude, the people of Israel denote the numerous goods and truths which constitute the kingdom of the Lord in the regenerate mind.

To number, in the Word, signifies to know the nature and quality of the several parts and numerous particulars of which anything consists, and to dispose those parts and their particulars in just order, so as to form one perfect whole. The numbering of the sons of Israel, when done by Divine command, represented the disposition or arrangement of all the principles of goodness and truth in the regenerate mind, so that such a mind may be a form of heaven. This spiritual meaning of numbering, and the nature of the arrangement which it represents, are treated of frequently in the Scriptures. In the 40th of Isaiah it is said that the Lord numbereth the stars and calleth them all by names. Numbering in this case means that He who created the host of heaven has disposed them in that perfect order which makes up the grandeur and beauty of the whole astral heavens, which are

upheld by His power and directed in their courses by His wisdom. But when we regard the stars, which nightly declare the glory of God, as symbolizing the pure truths of His Word, which He sets in the heaven of a regenerate mind, and which spiritually declare His glory and manifest His power and goodness, the arrangement of these truths, and their preservation in a state of harmony and order, must be regarded as a result of Divine power, if not greater in itself, at least more important and beneficial to us, than the numbering and ordinating of the stars. The truths of the Word are themselves the subjects of a Divine arrangement, by which their harmonious and united testimony to the love and wisdom of God is obtained, and by which their combined operation in the mind and life of the regenerate man is secured. Another instance of the spiritual sense of numbering occurs in the New Testament, where the Lord, speaking of the minuteness of the Divine circumspection, assures us that the very hairs of our heads are all numbered. This implies not only that the Divine knowledge, but also that the Divine circumspection, extends to the least of our states and circumstances, thoughts and affections. And it further teaches that in the mind of every true disciple the principles of goodness and truth are so arranged or ordinated, that the Divine government is exercised in a way which is adapted most fully to promote the soul's spiritual welfare.

The numbering of the children of Israel represented, therefore, the arrangement or ordination of all the principles of goodness and truth in the minds of the regenerate, by which the Lord is present with them and operates savingly in and by them.

Such a spiritual arrangement may be illustrated by the works as well as by the Word of God. In all the Divine works we find an arrangement existing according to certain laws, by which the Divine power is exercised and the Divine purpose is accomplished. Our planetary system is held together, and the motions of the planetary bodies are regulated, by certain fixed laws. The perfection of the human body, as an instrument of the soul and mind, and as capable of sensation and motion, is the result of the arrangement of its parts in such an order of mutual dependence and relation as fits them for united and harmonious action. Nor is the mind itself to be conceived of as existing and acting except as an organized form, constituted in an order suitable to its nature and necessary for the exercise of its faculties. The natural mind of man is formed to the image of the world; but the spiritual mind is formed to the image of heaven, and by re-creation, or regeneration, becomes a heaven. All the affections of good and perceptions of truth are arranged into such a form, or according to such an order, as makes the regenerate mind a heaven in miniature. For the heaven of angels is as one man, of which all

the inhabitants are members, each occupying a place and exercising a function agreeable to his quality and his capacity for use; and it is in virtue of this perfect arrangement, which is produced and preserved by the laws of order, resulting from the Divine perfection, which is order itself, that heaven is under the perfect government of the Divine love and wisdom, and is preserved in a state of unity, harmony, and blessedness. In proportion as heavenly order is introduced into the regenerate mind the same happy results are experienced.

The particulars of that order which is introduced into the mind by regeneration cannot be fully comprehended by the regenerate themselves, because its particulars do not come to their perception. It is possible, however, and even necessary for them to know the general spiritual arrangements of which they themselves are the subjects. To compare the mind with the body, the regenerate are in the order of heaven when love to the Lord constitutes the head, love to the neighbour the breast, the love of the world the lower extremities, and the self-love the feet. When this order exists, love to God and love to the neighbour rule, and the loves of self and of the world serve. This is heavenly order; for when the love of self and the love of the world are subordinated to the love of God and the neighbour, neither honour nor gain will be sought, nor even accepted, without the sanction of the laws of justice and equity, which are the laws of love and charity.

This order of the principles of the Church and of heaven in the human mind cannot be introduced at once, but is the work of time. Every unregenerate man is in a state of inverted order. In natural men the loves of self and of the world constitute the head, and love to God and love to the neighbour constitute the feet—for even natural men can be moral and religious when morality and religion serve to promote their natural ends. Man cannot be restored to the order of heaven but by degrees. He must first be brought to love his neighbour whom he hath seen, before he can be brought to love God whom he hath not seen. The first general effect of the order which is introduced into the minds of those who have entered on the regenerate life, is to exalt the love of the neighbour above the love of the world. The supremacy in the mind of love to God is a higher degree of order and of spiritual life. These two different ordinations of which the regenerate mind is the subject, were represented in two distinct numberings of the people of Israel by express Divine command. The first took place not long after the people had left Egypt, the second took place immediately previous to their entering the Promised Land. The desert in which the Israelites wandered forty years represented self-denial and spiritual temptation, taking up the cross daily. The numbering of the people at the beginning of their journey represented the institu-

tion of that spiritual order which prepares the mind for undergoing temptation, which is intellectual, or the arrangement of truths in the understanding; the second numbering represented that more perfect ordination which follows as the result of temptation, and which prepares the regenerate for entrance into heaven. This is that perfect order which relates more to the will, and in which love and charity rule. No one can undergo spiritual temptations while self-love and the love of the world have the dominion; for no one can resist evil from the love of evil. Satan cannot cast out Satan. Something of Divine order must be introduced to enable the mind to undergo temptation; and that order must consist in the love of the neighbour or the love of God being exalted above the love of self or of the world, if not in the will at least in the understanding.

But this is not all that is required for success in the spiritual life. It must be seen and acknowledged that all goodness and truth, and the true order in which they exist in the mind, are from the Lord alone. The necessity of this acknowledgment was represented in the law, delivered by the Lord to Moses, that in taking the sum of the children of Israel they should give every man a ransom for his soul unto the Lord, half a shekel, after the shekel of the sanctuary, lest there should be a plague in numbering them (Exod. xxx. 12, 13). The giving of this piece of silver represented the acknowledgment that all the good of charity and all the truths of faith, and their ordination and disposition in the mind, are from the Lord alone.

It will be seen, then, what was involved and represented in David's numbering the people. This numbering He did, not only without any Divine command or authority, but in compliance with a temptation to commit the crime of numbering Israel and Judah. The temptation is said to have come from God Himself—a form of expression which occurs in the Word, as being agreeable to appearance, the real truth being that God tempts no man, but that every man is tempted when he is drawn aside by his own lusts and enticed. In the First Book of Chronicles (xxi. 1) it is said that Satan stood up against Israel, and provoked David to number the people. David's numbering the people, regardless of the warning of Joab, represented the sin of which man is guilty when he claims for himself the authorship or the merit of the goodness and truth which he knows or possesses, and makes them subject to his own will and wisdom; in which case they cease to be good and true, for perverted order perverts those things whose order is perverted. And as the natural will and wisdom of man are opposed to the will and wisdom of God, to claim the gifts and assume the prerogative of God is to divide and destroy.

This evil might be illustrated by many examples, but may itself be detected under many different forms. It is this very principle which

prompts the unbeliever daringly to impeach the moral government of God, as if it had imperfections which the wisdom of man could correct. It is the same principle which has given birth to those numerous and discordant arrangements of the truth of the Word by the authors of the various sectaries, each claiming the possession, in some instances the exclusive possession, of the truth of God, and the keys of the kingdom of heaven. But this evil does not lie at the door of infidelity and heresy only. Selfish and worldly loves are sufficiently powerful in the mind of even the true Christian disciple to lay him open to the temptation, at least, to commit this sin, by giving self-intelligence the right to interfere with the established order of the Divine arrangements and operations for the government of his mind and life. The consequences of yielding to such subtle insinuations are frequently set before us in the Sacred Word, and in a very striking manner in the present historical relation. And no doubt such admonitions and warnings are required, since they are so repeatedly given. No adversaries are so deceitful as those of our own minds. No treasures require more to be guarded than those of love and truth. No degradation is so great as that which is the result of apostasy.

We may, therefore, profitably consider the punishment which was brought upon Israel and Judah by the numbering of the people.

In no cases is it more necessary to consider the events of the Jewish history in connection with the Jewish dispensation, than in the infliction of those terrible punishments which followed their acts of disobedience. As punishments, these seem, in many instances, to bear no very perceptible connection with, or to bear no just proportion to, the sins they committed. Yet we cannot suppose that the Judge of all the earth acted capriciously on any of those occasions, however singular or severe some of His judgments may seem. He who is order itself cannot have acted independently of the law of cause and effect. The difference between the circumstances in which the Jews were placed and those in which we stand consists in this, that the effect followed the cause immediately and visibly; whereas natural effects from spiritual and moral causes are now gradually, and in many cases imperceptibly, developed. Although in the present instance the crime appears to have been David's, while the people only endured the punishment; yet the relation itself states that David's act was the result of an evil which existed amongst the Israelites as a nation. "Again the anger of the Lord was kindled against Israel, and He moved David against them to say, Go, number Israel and Judah." And we may consider the anger of the Lord as having been kindled by their rebellion and insurrection against that authority which He, at their own urgent solicitation, established amongst them.

After the numbering of the people had been completed, Gad was

commissioned to go to David and give him the choice of the punishment which should ensue: he might choose seven years of famine, or three months' flight before his enemies, or three days' pestilence. These punishments signified the effects of the evil which the numbering of the people represented. The three years of famine signifies that those who destroy Divine order, after it has been established in their minds, deprive themselves of all the good of love and the truth of faith; the three months' flight before enemies signifies that evils and falsities continually pursue them; and the three days' pestilence signifies that the remains of truth and goodness received from infancy perish. David chose the last. This undoubtedly was of the Divine Providence, to signify, in the first place, that with the Israelitish and Jewish nation, at the time our Lord came into the world, everything good and true was about to perish; and, secondly, and more interiorly, that the inversion of spiritual order in any human mind results in the total destruction of spiritual life, even of that which is acquired before man acts from liberty according to reason. The nature as well as the extent of the devastation is expressed representatively in the number of persons who died of the pestilence. Seven is a holy number, and seventy is expressive of that of which holiness is predicated. The number ten not only exalts the idea of holiness, meant by the number seven, but is itself expressive of the holy principles that were in this case destroyed. This number, which is that of the commandments, is symbolical of all the principles of goodness and truth, the sum of which are love to God and love to man, on which hang all the law and the prophets. As the ten commandments are the laws of life, and are the duties first impressed upon the minds of the young, they signify also what remains and is preserved in the mind during advancing life. When the new spiritual life begins, these are the rudiments of the new state; and so important are they that no regenerative process could be commenced without them. In proportion to the quality and quantity of these remnants of heavenly things in the mind is the capacity and inclination to receive the principles of goodness and truth, and so to become spiritual.

When, on the other hand, the Church in general, or any of its members in particular, decline or fall away from a state of integrity, and invert the order on which the stability of the Church and the efficacy of religion depend, these remains of what is good and true become fewer and feebler, until they almost cease to exist. They are the first to live and the last to die. Were they entirely to cease, the human race would perish, or cease to exist as rational beings, and the very capacity of becoming spiritual would be destroyed. "Except the Lord of hosts had left unto us a very small remnant, we should have been as Sodom, and we should have been like unto Gomorrah." When, in

a Church or a human being, this remnant becomes so small that no restoration to a state of true spiritual life can be effected, there is a judgment, which brings the Church to an end. Such a state in the Jewish Church is indicated by the Lord's anger being kindled against Israel, and His moving David to number the people. For what is called anger in God is the contrariety of the state of the Church to the Divine character and attributes; His moving David to number the people is the natural effect of this state, in the inversion of order; and the punishment of the crime is the destruction of the holy principles of goodness and truth, even to the very small remnant that would have saved Israel and Judah from becoming as Sodom and like unto Gomorrah. The seventy thousand that fell under the pestilence were taken away for some wise and merciful purpose even towards them; but it was at the same time a representative judgment, and the history of it is written for our admonition, upon whom the ends of the world are come.

CHAPTER XXVIII.

THE DESTROYING ANGEL COMMANDED TO SPARE JERUSALEM.

2 Samuel xxiv. 16-25.

HAVING in the previous chapter considered the two particulars, David's sin in, and his punishment for, numbering the people, it may be useful to follow it up by examining those which relate to the preservation of Jerusalem, and David's building an altar in the threshing-floor of Araunah the Jebusite. The rearing of that altar was indeed the means of staying the plague and preserving the city. For Gad the prophet "came that day to David, and said unto him, Go up, rear an altar unto the Lord in the threshing-floor of Araunah the Jebusite. And David built there an altar unto the Lord, and offered burnt-offerings and peace-offerings. So the Lord was intreated for the land, and the plague was stayed from Israel."

As plagues and calamities of other kinds are attributed in Scripture to the anger of the Lord, their progress is represented as being arrested by the Lord's anger being appeased. A remarkable instance of this occurs in the 16th chapter of Numbers, which contains an account of the rebellion of Korah, Dathan, and Abiram. On the morrow after these men and all their company had been swallowed up of the earth, "all the congregation murmured against Moses and against Aaron, saying, Ye have killed the people of the Lord. . . . And the Lord spake unto Moses, saying, Get you up from among this congregation, that I

may consume them as in a moment." Moses, being aware of the nature of the evil and the means of staying its progress, said to Aaron, "Take a censer, and put fire therein from off the altar, and put on incense, and go quickly unto the congregation, and make an atonement for them: for there is wrath gone out from the Lord; the plague is begun. . . . And he stood between the dead and the living; and the plague was stayed." The wrath of the Lord, as we have seen, is an expression implying the rejection and also the perversion of His love and truth by the Church and by man. For as all protection and blessing are from the Lord, and are experienced by those who love and believe in Him, so all spiritual misfortune and misery are the result of rejecting Him as the Object of love and faith. In His love is life, in the refusal or rejection of His love is death. Spiritual rebellion—the renouncing of His authority, the presumptuous violation of His commands—makes us the subjects of wrath, because it brings us into communion with that kingdom which is opposite in its nature and experience to the kingdom of God. Thence come all the spiritual plagues that afflict the human race. And when the mind admits into itself the influence of evil, and adopts evil as a ruling principle, disease and death invade the whole of the will and understanding. There are no means of arresting the plague of the soul but by seeking reconciliation and conjunction with the Lord. These are signified in the Word by atonement; and atonement is made or effected by true spiritual worship. In the merely natural, or what may be called the Jewish sense, atonement seems to man the appeasing of Divine wrath, and the reconciliation of God to man; for since to God is attributed wrath, to Him must also be attributed reconciliation. But the Christian or spiritual sense teaches that there is no wrath in God, and that as the anger is on the part of man, on man's part must also be the reconciliation. The doctrine of the New Testament is, that "God was in Christ reconciling the world unto Himself, not imputing their trespasses unto them." "Now then," says the apostle, "we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God did beseech you by us: we pray you in Christ's stead, be ye reconciled to God." How is this reconciliation to be effected but by repenting of our evils, acknowledging with David that we have sinned and done very foolishly; or by turning in sincere worship to the Lord as our preserver and restorer; like Aaron with his censer containing fire from off the altar. In the highest sense, Aaron, as the high priest, represented the Lord Himself; and it is still true spiritually that the Lord Himself, as our great High Priest, stands between the living and the dead. He is present with every human soul, ready to save, by sanctifying the heart with the holy fire of His Divine love, infusing life into every affection and thought of the mind. And when the Divine love is received and acknowledged the soul is preserved.

It was therefore when David had acknowledged his sin, and, in obedience to the command of the Lord by the prophet, had reared an altar, and had offered burnt-offerings and peace-offerings, that "the Lord repented Him of the evil, and said to the angel that destroyed the people, It is enough: stay now thine hand." We may here pause to inquire why an angel was the destroyer. But we need not marvel at this when we find that God Himself is represented as acting the part of a destroyer. The death of the first-born of the Egyptians is spoken of as having been effected by Jehovah Himself. And yet neither God nor His holy angels can destroy either the bodies or the souls of men. Plagues, and pestilences, and wars are the results of evil, and are effected by the agency, not of good but of evil angels. Why, then, it may be inquired, should they be ascribed to God and His angelic ministers? In the letter of the Word, all things and events, even evil things and calamitous events, are ascribed to God, in accordance with the general truth that God is the Creator and Governor of the world. But under this general truth there are particular truths, which reveal distinctions. It is true that God creates both good and evil things, for nothing exists which did not originally, and does not now, derive its life from Him; but good things were created and are sustained through heaven, and evil things through hell. God is the sole Governor of the world, but He governs by the laws of permission as well as by the laws of provision. Good He provides, evil He permits. Calamities come through evil, and are permitted for the purpose of restraining or correcting it. But calamities do not come through the agency of good but of evil spirits. In all permissions which are granted to evil spirits, angels are present to moderate or arrest the hands of the destroyers. Evil spirits do not need to be employed to do these direful works. Hell is in the continual effort to rush forth to the work of destruction; and it is only by the controlling power of the Lord that they are prevented from coming in like a flood, to carry the inhabitants of the world away into the gulf of perdition. The Divine wisdom measures the extent of the Divine permission, and says to the demoniac power, "Thus far shalt thou go and no further, and here shall thy proud waves be stayed." When the angel stretched out his hand upon Jerusalem to destroy it, the Lord is said to have repented Him of the evil. The Lord is not a man that He should lie, nor a son of man that He should repent; and yet there is a Divine meaning in His recorded repentance. That which is repentance in man is mercy in God; and that in man which obtains forgiveness is that in God which grants it. There is this essential difference between man and God. The finite changes, the Infinite is the same yesterday, to-day, and for ever. He does not change from severity to mercy. He never becomes merciful. He is mercy itself, and His mercy is

ever the same. But as, when men sin, He *seems* to be angry, so, when men repent, He *seems* to be merciful. Men's changed states towards Him produce seemingly changed states in Him towards men. All that is necessary to make God merciful and forgiving is to remove the evil and impenitence that prevent His mercy and forgiveness from finding their way into the hearts and lives of men. It was when the angel stretched out his hand upon Jerusalem that the Lord repented Him of the evil, and said to the angel that destroyed the people, "Stay thy hand: it is enough." Jerusalem was the holy city, the place where the tabernacle containing the ark of the testimony was reared; and it represented, in the general sense, the Church, and, in the particular sense, the interiors of the mind. In the devastation of the Church, the Lord never permits a full end, for in that case there could not be a new beginning; and in the devastations of those who endure temptation, the Lord preserves the inner man from the power of evil spirits, for if the destroying angel were allowed to enter there, the capacity as well as the means of salvation would be destroyed.

We shall now speak of these circumstances in their general and particular sense. The numbering of the people and destruction that followed, represented, as we have seen, the perversion and consummation of the Jewish Church. This completeness of the consummation of that Church is signified by the number of people who died of the plague. The preservation effected by the offerings made on the altar does not denote the preservation or restoration of the Jewish Church, but the raising up of a new Church in its place. The altar was raised by Divine direction in the threshing-floor of Araunah the Jebusite.

The Jebusites were one of the nations of Canaan whom the Israelites were commanded to disinherit; and Jerusalem was their stronghold. When Jerusalem was taken by David, the Jebusites were not entirely extirpated; but a remnant continued to live with the Jews. There were indeed two of the nations who were permitted to live with, though in subjection to, the Israelites—the Hivites, with whom Joshua made a covenant, and whom he made hewers of wood and drawers of water; and the Jebusites, who dwelt in Jerusalem. These two nations were preserved, because they represented those in whose idolatry there was something of good and something of truth. They were Gentiles in whom some of the principles of true religion could be implanted. David was required to rear an altar in the threshing-floor of Araunah the Jebusite, to represent that the Church which had become consummated amongst the Jews was to be transferred to the Gentiles. The pestilence continuing till the altar had been raised and offerings made in the floor of Araunah, describes representatively the continuance of the decline of the Church in the world, till the wasting corruption was arrested by the commencement of the Christian dispensation. It is

therefore recorded that the angel of the Lord was by the threshing-place of Araunah when his hand was stayed. It was upon the spot where the angel stood and on which the altar was reared that the temple of Solomon was afterwards built, as recorded in the Second Book of Chronicles. "Then Solomon began to build the house of the Lord at Jerusalem in mount Moriah, where the Lord appeared unto David his father, in the place that David had prepared in the threshing-floor of Ornan the Jebusite" (iii. 1). The temple was a representation of the Lord's Humanity, the temple of His body. The altar indeed had the same representation, with this difference, that the temple represented the Lord's Humanity as to Divine truth, and the altar represented the Humanity as to Divine goodness. When the temple was built, the altar of burnt-offerings was placed within the court to the east of the temple itself, the altar of incense being in the sanctuary, near the table on which was placed the shewbread. Indeed, one principal use of the tabernacle and temple was that the Lord might be worshipped according to the rites of the Mosaic law, and the altar was an essential part of the means by which that worship was performed, it being that on which the offerings were laid, and by which they were sanctified. The Lord therefore says in the Gospel, "Whether is greater the gift, or the altar that sanctifieth the gift?" Not only does the Divinity of the Lord dwell in His Humanity, as the ark of the testimony did in the holy of holies, but the Humanity, like the altar of the temple, is that through which our offerings of worship are presented to the essential Divinity, and by which they are sanctified, and made acceptable to the Lord. When this representative character of the altar and temple is known, it may be understood why the altar was raised, and the hand of the angel was stayed, at the floor of Araunah the Jebusite. Jerusalem itself was preserved. The reason of this is, as we have remarked, that in all the dispensations of His Providence the Lord so orders that there shall not be a full end; for however the Church may be corrupted and consummated, a remnant is saved, to form the commencement of a new Church. Unless this were the case, no new dispensation could be commenced after a former one had come to its end. No Church or dispensation is therefore permitted to expire, or to close by an entire cessation of life; but is brought to an end by a judgment upon it while it yet contains some vitality, so that out of the remnant of the old Church a new Church may be established. The Lord teaches this when He says, speaking of the darkness and corruption which were to precede His Second Coming, "Except those days should be shortened, there should no flesh be saved; but for the elect's sake they shall be shortened." The shortening of the days is the bringing of the Church to its end, before it utterly expire by its own inherent

decay. It was from the remnant of the Jewish Church that the Lord formed the beginning of the Christian Church; His apostles and first disciples being from the Jewish nation.

A similar Providence presides over the individuals of the human race as over the general Church. The numbering of the people and the pestilence which followed denote the entire perversion and destruction of the Church in those who fall away and terminate their life in a state of confirmed evil. With such there is a destruction of all goodness and truth, even of such as had been acquired from the period of childhood. Yet even in those cases some small remnant is preserved, for so much of the life or vitality of goodness and truth is preserved as is necessary to the existence of the faculties of liberty and rationality, without which nothing of humanity would exist. Something therefore remains which the worst can never utterly destroy, however much they may desire to do so; it is therefore said of such, that they "shall seek death, and shall not find it; and shall desire to die, and death shall flee from them" (Rev. ix. 6). The destroying angel therefore ever stays his hand before there is an entire end. But in this world man, however far he may have departed from the way of truth and goodness, is never without the power to return. And all the judgments of the Lord are intended to bring him by correction to a state of humiliation and repentance, and thus to the true worship of the Lord. The repentance and worship by which the sinner turns to the Lord are signified by those of David. The altar was set in the threshing-floor of Araunah, because a threshing-floor signifies where there is the good of truth. Jerusalem signifies the Church as to doctrine or the doctrine of the Church, and corn signifies the good which is the chief support of spiritual life. By a corn-floor is also signified the separation of what is evil and false from what is good and true, for there the wheat is separated from the chaff. It also signifies temptation, for spiritual temptations are the means by which there is a separation of good and evil in the mind and life. The altar of true worship, by which there is conjunction with the Lord, and thence all the benefits of His redemption and salvation, as they are dispensed by Himself in His Divine Humanity, must be built and established in the good of truth, or in the charity which is acquired by a true and sincere faith—a principle of good and charity which can only be acquired by self-denial, as the means of separating all the evil of self-love and the love of the world from love to the Lord and the neighbour. In the monarch of Israel, humble and repentant, seeking to stay the destructive pestilence by building an altar in the threshing-floor of the Jebusite, we may see the penitent worshipping the Lord in simple holiness from the principle of sincere good, chastened and purified by spiritual trial and temptation.

We may observe in conclusion that in the individual sense David signifies the human intellect. In his numbering the people we see the intellect acting under the influence of the natural will, or the self-hood; but in his penitential worship we see the intellect acting under the influence of a will brought into a state of humble submission to the Divine will. Whenever the understanding acts from self-will, evil consequences ensue; when it acts in union with a humble heart, goodness and blessing are the result.

CHAPTER XXIX.

ABISHAG THE SHUNAMMITE NOURISHES DAVID.

1 *Kings* i. 1-5.

THE subject of this chapter may seem to some to be of too delicate a nature to be brought under notice. Let us reflect on the words of David himself, that to the pure all things are pure. We have already, in treating of Amnon and Tamar, partly stated our views upon this point. The present subject differs widely indeed from that which we then considered. This relation, in its literal sense, supplies no moral lesson sufficient to justify us in making it a subject of reflection. It is because it contains a higher and more instructive sense that it is brought under consideration. Yet it may be well to observe that neither in this nor in any other part of the inspired Word is there anything, however delicate, that is really impure. It is a just remark of our Expositor, in speaking of the difference between the Song of Solomon and the books of the Divine Word itself, that "in the literal sense of the Canticles many indecent things occur, which is not the case with the books which are called Moses and the prophets." But whatever may be our views respecting the literal sense of some parts of even Moses and the prophets, we know that their inner sense, of which the letter is but the vehicle, is pure and holy; and one advantage of being aware, not only that they contain a spiritual sense, but of what that sense is, has a tendency to withdraw the mind from the mere natural image, and fix it on the higher reality, which it was designed to be the means of bringing down to our apprehension.

The active and eventful life of David, through which we have followed him, now draws near its close. Youthful and ruddy, brave and powerful as he was when we first beheld him, he is now old and stricken in years, and his natural warmth has almost departed with his vital energy. Life has ebbed so low that the common artificial means for retaining the warmth of the body are found unavailing: "they covered

him with clothes, but he gat no heat." In this extremity his servants suggested a means, frequently adopted in ancient times, to impart both warmth and vigour to his now enfeebled and aged frame. There is however something in the tenor of this suggestion sufficient to awaken our attention to the circumstances, recorded as they are in a book written by Divine inspiration, as certainly including more than appears on the surface of the narrative. Why was it necessary that the cherisher of the king should be a young virgin? And why, if the fire of life was sinking so fast, should all the coasts of Israel be sought to find a fair vestal who might watch it and exert herself to keep it alive? If to cherish and minister to the king were all that was required, the royal harem might have supplied abundant means for that purpose.

The truth is, the whole circumstances were typical or representative. David represented the Lord, and Abishag the Shunammite represented the Church. David was about to die, to be succeeded by his son Solomon. A life and a reign of warfare, in which the enemies of Israel had been subdued, are to be followed by a life and reign of settled peace and unexampled prosperity. In the first we may see a type of the life of our Lord in the flesh, when, by His conflicts with the spiritual enemies of His Church, He made His foes His footstool; in the second we may see a type of the life of the Lord in His risen humanity, when He truly reigns as the Prince of Peace, and His kingdom is enriched with the spoil of His enemies and the treasures of redeeming love. One of the objects to be accomplished by our Lord's coming into the world was the raising up of a new Church, and this new Church, in its youthfulness, purity, and beauty, was represented by the young and fair Abishag; the reciprocation of the Divine love and truth, which is one of the highest functions and one of the most distinctive characteristics of the true Church, being, with equal fidelity, represented by her cherishing the king and ministering unto him.

Under this general view of the subject there are several particulars which serve for confirmation and illustration.

Death, literally the end of our existence in this world and the beginning of our existence in another, is spiritually the close of one state of regeneration and the commencement of another. "Old and stricken in years" expresses the ripeness of the voluntary and intellectual life for the approaching change; for then vitality begins to recede from the external, that this may be laid aside, to be succeeded by another life, of greater purity, sensibility, and energy. This is the Divine law of progression. And that event which we call death is only one of the effects of a law which is universal and constant, and the more striking because to us it is more distinctly marked. Death is a less important

change than many others that we pass through, which make much less impression upon us. Death changes the scene of our existence, but does not alter the state of our life. It clothes us with a spiritual body in place of the material one that is left behind; but the soul is the same in the one as it was in the other. The changes that are effected by progressive regeneration are changes of state. They are the putting off of old principles and the putting on of new. When those which served the purposes of a body, as being instrumental means for the manifestation of the powers of the mind, have performed their use, they fall like leaves from the tree in autumn, not however without having first shown signs of decay. The diminution of heat causes the sap to recede from the extreme parts, and the chilling frosts complete the work of temporary destruction.

In all such changes there are two forces at work, one acting from within and the other acting from without. Apparently there is but one. It appears as if the vernal and summer heat were the cause of vegetation, and as if the vital heat of the body were the cause of life. But the primary cause of both vegetable and animal life is that one universal life which enters from God into all created things. The heat of the sun of nature only acts upon the external of things, and disposes it to yield to the influence of the sun of heaven, which constantly operates from within; and it is this truly and only vital force which causes all things to live and grow. In spring and summer nature reacts *with* this vital force, and hence all things bud and blossom, and rejoice; in autumn and especially winter nature reacts *against* this force, and therefore all things languish, and wither, and die. In man's case it is similar; nor was it different with the Lord Himself when in the flesh. The Divine acted from within, the human reacted from without. In the spring and summer of the Church, the love of the human race re-acted with the active love of God, and the Church enjoyed prosperity and brought forth fruits of holiness. But when the love of men waxed cold, the Divine love, though still acting from within, could no longer bring itself into outward manifestation in the affections and lives of men.

This state is described in the letter of the Word as if God Himself had withdrawn His love from the Church; for when the Church has driven away the love of God from herself, she imagines that God has ceased to love her. Natural heat is the emblem of love. And when David, in his old age, even when they covered him with clothes, gat no heat, he but represented the state of the Lord in the world when there was no true love in the Church to re-act with, or to reciprocate, His own Divine love. Clothes, or coverings for the body, are emblematical of truths for the mind; for truths clothe good as garments cover the body. But the clothes with which they covered David

represented truths without good, or faith without love. In these there is no virtue, no power of calling forth the Divine love into vital action in the Church or in the human mind. And such was the state of the Jewish Church when the Lord was in the world, and especially when He was about to pass out of the world. The Jews possessed the Word, and were acquainted and conversant with the truths which it contained; but they had not the love of God in them. The truths with which they were acquainted availed them nothing. These truths were like the leaves upon the fig-tree, which was yet cursed for its barrenness; or like the purple and fine linen upon the rich man, which served but to make his degradation the greater.

When the Lord could get no love from the Jewish Church He turned to the Gentiles; and He found among them what no longer existed amongst the Jews—sincerity, simplicity, and affection. The Christian Church which the Lord raised up among the Gentiles was represented by Abishag the Shunammite. The Jewish Church, even in its best state, had never been more than a representative Church, which, compared with a real spiritual Church, is little more than the garments or clothes that cover the body compared to the living body itself. But when that Church became corrupted, it was like a filthy garment, to which in the prophets it is compared. The Church, in its true state, is compared to a woman, the bride and wife of the Lord. The youth, the virginity, the beauty of Abishag make her a fit representative of the Christian Church, which was new, and pure, and fair; differing not only from the Jewish Church, but from all previous Churches, in its having a principle of youthfulness, purity, and moral beauty, derived from that new fountain of all spiritual life, the Humanity of the Lord, the Saviour and Redeemer, of a different character and of a more enduring kind than either the ancient or the most ancient Church possessed.

They sought a fair damsel throughout all the coasts of Israel, and found Abishag, a Shunammite, and brought her to the king.

This is not the only instance in which a Shunammite ministered to the Lord's representatives during the Old Testament dispensation. It was a Shunammite woman who constrained Elisha, on a day that he passed to Shunem, to eat bread; and who with her husband made for him a little chamber in the wall, and set for him a bed, and a table, and a candlestick. It was to this hospitable Shunammite that the prophet, for all her care, gave the promise of a son, and whose son he restored to life, when he had been struck down while he was with his father's reapers in the field. In this instance also the Shunammitish woman typified the Church among the Gentiles, her barrenness representing that state in which the nations were before the Lord came into the world and brought them to the knowledge of the

truth, and entered into a covenant with them. Then was the barren woman made to keep house, and to become a joyful mother of children. And when the manchild of true doctrine, which had been born of and gladdened the Church, died in the harvest—the consummation of the age, when the angels were sent forth as reapers—the Lord restored it to life again, inspiring the Church with still purer joy and more profound reverence and gratitude (2 Kings iv.).

Although David no doubt took Abishag to him as a wife, yet she became, as a virgin, really the wife of Solomon, no doubt to represent that it was not till the Lord had died and risen again, and had been fully glorified, that the Church really became the wife of the Lamb. It was not indeed till the day of Pentecost that the covenant of the Lord with His Church was fully ratified. Hitherto, as the Lord Himself had taught His disciples, He, as the Spirit of light and life, had dwelt *with* them; it was only now that He was *in* them. It was expedient for them that He should go away, that He might send them another Comforter that should abide with them for ever. This Spirit was poured out upon them when they were assembled together with one accord in one place. And then was the marriage of the Lord and His Church consummated; and the apostles went forth in the power of the Spirit to carry the Gospel to them that sat in darkness and in the shadow of death.

There was another reason for this circumstance. Abishag the Shunammite represented the celestial Church. And as Solomon represented the Lord as to the celestial principle, and, in the secondary sense, the celestial man, therefore she could not be actually united to David, and become united to Solomon.

The history of David and the Shunammite, like every other part of the Word, treats of the Church in particular as well as of the Church in general. The Lord is in every true member of His Church as well as among the whole body of the faithful. And in every regenerate mind those changes take place which passed upon the Lord and the Church while He was engaged in working out the great deliverance of mankind in human redemption. Without entering into the particulars of this remarkable, and, we may justly assert, mystical narrative, we may learn from it that it is not by faith and truth only, but by love and goodness, that we can preserve the Lord's life in our souls. The warmth of heavenly and Divine love cannot be supported within us without our cherishing it and ministering unto it. The Divine love as it is in itself is ever the same. Widely different is it in us, according as, with different degrees of faithfulness, we cherish and reciprocate it; or make it the object of a formal faith or verbal exaltation. We must search through all the coasts of Israel, through the whole spiritual mind, till we find a spiritual affection so tender, so pure, so

fair as to be fit to be brought to the king—the Divine truth in the mind—that it may nourish and minister unto it, so as to make it in us the truth of love—the power of God unto salvation.

CHAPTER XXX.

ADONIJAH'S REBELLION.

1 *Kings* i. 5-31.

THE near prospect of David's death gave rise to that serious calamity which is incident to kingdoms in certain conditions—a disputed succession. Absalom had attempted to dethrone his father during his lifetime, and Adonijah, anticipating the time of his father's death, now endeavours to secure the throne, which he knew was designed for Solomon. This act of Adonijah not only divides the house of David, but ranges the leading men of the kingdom into two parties hostile to each other, and leads to the death of some of the most eminent and active of David's servants and supporters, and among them of the renowned general of his army, Joab the son of Zeruiah. These fatal and fearful results of their rising in favour of Adonijah are mentioned, not simply as the reward of their present crime, but as a retribution for deeds long past, but neither forgotten nor forgiven. This subject, almost too large in itself and too multifarious in its particulars to be taken in at one view, must yet, to prevent our exceeding reasonable limits, be compressed if possible into one chapter.

Regarding the kingdom of Israel as representative of the kingdom of the Lord—of that kingdom especially as spoken of by the Lord Himself when He said, "Behold, the kingdom of God is within you"—we are led at once to place the present history before us as containing some spiritual instruction interesting and useful to us as beings whose chief business it is to live for eternity. Considered apart from revelation, the principles of a sound, though not necessarily of a profound philosophy, enable us to see that history is a projection of the state of human nature. In the conduct and economy of men in their collective capacity, we can read with some degree of certainty the state of the human heart, without presuming to decide on individual states and eternal consequences, which are known to God only. There are, no doubt, important differences between profane and sacred history. Sacred history equally with secular exhibits the state of human nature; and displays, often in painful and humiliating lessons, the corruptions of the human heart. But it shows us these

in a way which not only fits us to judge of the general state of the human mind, but which directs us to look, and enables us to see, into our own hearts individually, and to learn how they may be changed from their natural and worldly to a spiritual and heavenly state. The natural events which are recorded actually correspond to spiritual events in the history of our own inward spiritual experience. And yet those outward events themselves were not determined by any arbitrary decree or compulsory control. They were in harmony with the invariable laws and operations of Divine Providence, which leave the freedom of the human will untouched. Yet volition and action are acted upon providentially in a thousand ways, which leads men themselves freely to choose what they resolve and do. The inspired record also is so framed, and the incidents are so selected, as to form the receptacle of spiritual truth, which may be derived from it by the law of analogy or correspondence.

In treating of David and Abishag the Shunammite, we endeavoured to trace the analogy principally in relation to the Lord and His Church, whom David and Abishag represented. The present subject equally relates to the Lord and to His Church or kingdom. As in the case of Absalom's rebellion, which has already been considered, so in the case of Adonijah's revolt, we see the nature of the temptations which the Lord suffered in working out the redemption of His creatures. These temptations arose immediately out of the frailty of the humanity which He took upon Him, and which He took for the very purpose of being tempted, that He might overcome the tempter—the tempter being Satan and the devil, or the whole powers of darkness. But the ultimate end of our Lord in suffering and overcoming was to succour those who suffer, that they also may overcome. To us, therefore, and to all who enter on the life of heaven do these historical circumstances refer; for the servant is not greater than his lord, neither is he that is sent greater than him that sent him. "If they have called the master of the house Beelzebub, much more shall they call them of his household."

Our Lord, in speaking of the necessary effects of the principles of the Gospel, declared that He came not to send peace on earth, but a sword; for He had come to set a man at variance against his father, and the daughter against the mother, and the daughter-in-law against the mother-in-law; and that a man's foes should be they of his own household. When the Lord told His disciples and the people that He came to sow division and to make a man's household his foes, He pointed out the spiritual results of the reception of the principles of Christianity in creating division in the mind between the old man with his carnal lusts and the new man with his spiritual affections. When the Lord said that He came not to send peace on earth He alluded to the effect

which would be produced in the natural mind, which is meant by the earth, in stirring up that conflict between good and evil, truth and error, by which evil and error are cast out, and good and truth are confirmed; and the Lord's kingdom comes, and His will is done on earth as it is in heaven.

The type or ensample of this condition of the Christian mind which is presented in the present conduct of Adonijah is to be considered as part of the realization of the judgment pronounced on David for his sin in the matter of Bathsheba, the mother of Solomon, that the sword should never depart from his house, and that out of his own house the Lord would raise up enmity against him. These foes of his own household are the principles of the natural mind that are indisposed to submit to the rule of those of the spiritual, and are ever ready to usurp the authority which Divine truth and Divine order award to the higher and purer principles that belong to the new kingdom which the Lord establishes in the souls of the faithful. Adonijah, who attempted to usurp the power which he knew was intended for Solomon, must be considered as representing a principle in the mind which is the opposite of that which Solomon himself represented. As however Adonijah and Absalom are mentioned in connection in the sacred history, and as their crimes were of a somewhat similar character, the one having rebelled against his father and the other against his brother, though Solomon was not yet king, the nature of the evil which the attempt of the second son of David represented may be more clearly seen by comparing it with that which was made by the first.

In the beginning of this chapter, in describing Adonijah and his attempt to seize the throne, it is said at the 6th verse that "he was a very goodly man; and his mother bare him after Absalom." Of the six sons born unto David in Hebron, "the third was Absalom the son of Maacah the daughter of Talmai king of Geshur; and the fourth, Adonijah the son of Haggith." From these particulars and from their general history we learn, that they were both born while David remained in Hebron; that they were both beautiful in person; that they were born in nearest succession; that they were both fondly loved by their father; and that they both rose up against him, the one against his person, the other against his sovereign will. The sons born to David in Hebron represented the principles that are produced while the regenerating man is in an external state, and which have their residence in the external or natural mind. And as Solomon was born unto David after his removal to Jerusalem, he represented a principle produced in the mind when the regenerating man has advanced to an internal state, and having its residence in the internal man. These sons born in Hebron being six in number,

represent also, like the six days of labour that precede the seventh of rest, states of temptation and conflict, while Solomon, the seventh son, represents that state of rest and peace which exists when the warfare of the spiritual life is accomplished. Now as the natural mind is opposed to the spiritual mind, and is not only impatient of its rule but is desirous to rule over it, this is the general ground and reason of the attempted usurpation both of Absalom and Adonijah. The rebellions of Absalom and Adonijah, while they have the same general representative character—both representing the rebellion of the external man against the government and dominion of the internal—yet have that difference which is always involved in two acts that have the same general character. One represents opposition to the government of truth, the other opposition to the government of goodness. This is further indicated by the representative character of the distinct government of those against whom Absalom and Adonijah rebelled. The kingdom under David represented the government of truth in the mind, and the kingdom under Solomon represented the government of good in the mind. The rebellion of Absalom represented, therefore, opposition and hostility to the government of Divine truth, and that of Adonijah represented opposition and hostility to the government of Divine goodness.

In the economy of salvation and in the order of the Divine government this principle is ever operating either potentially or actually, that the first shall be last and the last first. The principles that are first acquired, and which have at first the ascendancy, are designed and destined, if regeneration proceeds, to become the last, and yield to the ascendancy of principles acquired in a more perfect state of the religious life. This inversion of state is not effected without internal conflict; and often does it require a long and painful struggle in the mind, and with ourselves, before it is accomplished. How long and tenaciously do we often cling to early impressions and opinions, prejudices and habits, even after we have formed inward principles that are subversive of them. In every state, too, when a change is to take place in our habits and pursuits and our very enjoyments, there is always time spent and difficulty experienced in obtaining emancipation from the dominion of the one, and bringing ourselves quietly and happily to submit to the government of the other. We have an early example in the weaned child, so expressively used in Scripture to describe the experience of the child of God becoming weaned from self and the world. How passionately does young and tender nature rebel against the power that remove it from under the dominion of one set of tastes and habits and enjoyments to another. Another trial and sometimes another conflict awaits the young denizen of this changing but progressive life in the transition from amusement to

study, from the dominion of the parent to that of the teacher. In every transition period and state of life it is the same. There are always difficulties and repugnances to be overcome—always a tendency to carry the old feelings and habits into the new sphere of action, and not unfrequently a conflict ensues between the old and the new. The difference of the two is sometimes so great that the result is opposite in different persons. Some, for example, who enter on the business of life, seem to find it so difficult to change the habit and the mode to which they have been accustomed, that they fail of success for want of application, while others, who overcome them and enter with delight and industry into their new duties, go forward with satisfaction and profit. If this is the case in natural life, much more must it be the case in spiritual life. These changes are of such a nature that they bring into conflict principles and feelings and thoughts and habits that are as opposite to each other as time and eternity, the world and heaven, the flesh and the spirit. These in fallen man are opposite and conflicting; and the lower are desirous to have dominion over the higher. Their influence over us is naturally great. The world seems to us to be beautiful, and everything connected with its enjoyments and its prospects seems fair, before any spiritual affections have been awakened in the mind. This is the case not only generally, but particularly. In every particular state on which we enter in passing through the regenerate life, there are opposite affections and thoughts brought into action that have never been active in relation to each other before. There are natural tendencies that come into actual development that have never before been subjected to the scrutiny, and have never been opposed by the principles, of the spiritual mind. Adonijah had never been displeased by his father at any time, by his saying to him, Why hast thou done so? Naturally, this does not bespeak wisdom, though it indicates tenderness, or rather fondness, in the father, and may help to account for the son's want of respect for his father's will. Spiritually it signifies that, during the previous states of regeneration, the principle represented by Adonijah had never come under the scrutiny of the internal man, as a principle having in it anything in opposition to himself. And now it comes into manifestation, and shows itself in acts of open hostility. It draws also into connection with itself principles which had previously been active on the side of order. Joab went after Adonijah, though he had not gone after Absalom. Absalom's rebellion was opposition offered to the rule of truth; Adonijah's was opposition offered to the rule of good. That which submits to the rule of one may not submit to that of the other. And whenever the rule of love, which is the rule of goodness, is in its commencement, there must be resistance from affections and thoughts, and therefore also from lower and apparent goods and truths, which, though suited

to the wants and conditions of a spiritual, are not suited to those of a celestial state.

We may learn, then, from the history of Adonijah that in the regeneration there are changes of state which act upon the inmost principles of our spiritual life; but are so overruled by a wise and merciful God as to bring everlasting benefit to those who love and serve Him.